

**SPHS 102**

**POSTGRADUATE COURSE  
M.A - HISTORICAL STUDIES**

**FIRST YEAR**

**FIRST SEMESTER**

**PAPER - II**

**SOCIAL AND CULTURAL HISTORY OF  
TAMIL NADU UPTO A.D. 1565**



**INSTITUTE OF DISTANCE EDUCATION  
UNIVERSITY OF MADRAS**

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**SYLLABUS**

**UNIT I**

Ancient Tamil Civilization – Sangam and Post Sangam Age: Social Institutions -Customs and Practices – Economic Life – Trade – Religion – Literature – Art and Architecture – Status of Women.

**UNIT II**

Age of the Pallavas: Society – Economic Life – Religion – Bhakti Movement – Literature and Education – Art and Architecture.

**UNIT III**

Age of the Cholas: Society – Economic Life – Religion – Role of the Temples – Literature and Education – Art and Architecture – Status of Women.

**UNIT IV**

Age of the Pandyas: Society – Economic Life – Religion – Foreign Accounts - Literature – Art and Architecture.

**UNIT V**

Tamil Nadu under Vijayanagar and Nayak rule: Society – Economic Life – Religion – Literature – Arts.



**Books for Reference:**

1. K.A. Nilakanta Sastri - Sangam Age
2. N. Subramanian – Sangam Polity
3. K.K. Pillai – Social History of the Tamil
4. N.K. Mangalamurugesan – Sangam Age
5. C. Meenakshi – Social and Administration of Pallavas
6. A.K. Gopalan – Pallavas of Kanchi
7. T.V. Mahalingam - History of Pallavas
8. Rajamanikar – History of Pallavas
9. Nilakanta Sastri – History of Cholas
10. Sadasiva Pandaratar – Pirkala Chola Varalaru (Tamil)
11. K.A. Nilakanta Sastri - History of South India
12. K.A. Nilakanta Sastri - History of Pandyas
13. Sadasiva Pandarata – Pandiyar Varalaru (Tamil)
14. H.G. Sewell – The Forgotten Empire
15. V.M. Krishnamoorthy – Topics in South Indian History
16. Dr. K.V. Raman – The Pandyas

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**SCHEME OF LESSONS**

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# **LESSON – 1**

## **GEOGRAPHICAL FEATURES AND SOURCES OF TAMIL NADU**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Understand the physical features of Tamil Nadu
- ❖ Learn about the classification of the land and
- ❖ Know the sources for the study of Tamil Nadu History.

### **Structure**

- 1.1 Introduction**
- 1.2 Geography and History**
- 1.3 Frontiers of Tamilagam**
- 1.4. Classification of the land**
  - 1.4.1 The mountainous region**
  - 1.4.2 Rainfall**
  - 1.4.3 Rivers**
  - 1.4.4 Flora and Fauna**
  - 1.4.5 Minerals**
- 1.5 Sources**
  - 1.5.1 Literary Sources**
  - 1.5.2 Archaeological Sources**
- 1.6 Summary**
- 1.7 Check Review Questions**
- 1.8 Answers to Check Review Questions**
- 1.9 Further References**

## 1.1 Introduction

The general description of the Geography of Tamil Nadu, the land lying between Tirupati-hill and the cape- comerin are explained. In Tamil Nadu, the land is traditionally divided into five geographical regions (tinai): they are the mountainous regions (kurinchi) which include the forest areas, fertile plains (marudam), coastal region (neidhal), pastoral region (mullai) and arid region (palai). The history of the past can be written only on the basis of relevant and reliable sources available; the sources may be grouped into inscriptions, numismatics, archaeology and literature.

### Tamilagam

Tamilagam is named after the name of the people who speak Tamil Language. The southern most part of Tamilagam called kumara-kandam or lemuria was devoured by the Indian Ocean. Tamil Nadu is bound by the Western Ghats on one side, and the Coromandel Coast on the other. The Western and Eastern Ghats bind the Deccan Plateau in Tamil Nadu. While the Western Ghats tend to be steep and high, the Eastern Ghats are lower and their slopes gentler.

## 1.2 Geography and History

It is true to say that “Geography governs History”. The geographical features of a country like its mountains and rivers, its climate and natural resources determine in a large measure the nature of the social and economic life of its people. The people’s standard of life as well as their social customs and institutions bear the imprint of the geographical features of the land in which they live. It is obvious that in moulding the human factor itself, the influence of the geographical features has a vital share.

Generally speaking, it may be said that the geographical, no less than the human factor has an important part to play in moulding history. For instance, the long history of the commercial relations of South India with countries on either side of the ocean was primarily the result of South India’s geographical position. Geography and human history thus shape each other, and their relationship is complex.

## 1.3 Frontiers of Tamilagam

Naturally, therefore a history of the early Tamils has to be preceded by a consideration of the principal geographical features of Tamilagam. The exact extent of Tamilagam has varied from age to age. A legendary account states that in the age of the so-called First Tamil Sangam, extended farther into the south and the east than the present confines of Tamil Nadu and that it comprised forty nine major divisions. The traditional conception during the age of this Sangam was that Tamilagam comprised that part of Peninsular India, which stretched south from Venkadam (Thirupati) to Kanyakumari. The land stretching south from the Konkan along the west coast, now comprising the Kerala state was a part of Tamillaagam throughout the early period of South Indian History. Tolkappiyanar explains about Sen Tamil Chernta Pannirunilam. But he does not specify the twelve units of Sen Tamil Nadu, there is an old venba which says that Sen Tamil Nadu consists of Twelve regions.

It is beyond dispute that Tamilagam of Historical times extended southwards from the Tirupati hill down to Kanyakumari, surrounded by sea on the three other sides. Thus it formed the southernmost part of the South Indian Peninsula.

## 1.4 Classification of the land

To understand the subject the following divisions are made namely the mountainous region, Rainfall, Rivers, Flora and Fauna and Minerals.

### 1.4.1 The mountainous region

The mountainous regions lie in the western part of Tamil Nadu. The western Ghat and the Eastern ghats run parallel to the West and East coasts of Peninsula. Both the Ghats meet at Doddabedda and the continuation of these Ghats goes up to Cape Comerin. The Palghat gap connects the highlands of Kerala and Coimbatore.

#### **Western Ghats:**

All the rivers that flow towards Tamil Nadu, originate from the Western Ghats. Ooty, Kunoor, Kotagiri, Erkad and Kodaikkanal are some of the important hill stations existing on these hills. They are summer resorts. The Palani, Anaimalai, Kodai, Sabari, Podiyil etc. are

important places on the southern part of this Ghat. Western Ghats offer access between the Carnatic, the Deccan Plateau, and the Malabar Coast.

### **Eastern Ghats:**

The Eastern Ghats running by the side of the East coast are different from the Western Ghats in their nature and formation, particularly in respect of height, productivity and scenery. They possess little of the magnificence of the Western Ghats; the Eastern Ghats are scattered, broken and of much lower altitude. But they are older than the Western Ghats. They are running southwards from Orissa along the coast and then near about Madras they take a south-westerly direction meeting the Western Ghats at the Nilgiris. Isolated masses of hills like the Palani and the Shevroy hills, in and near the Salem district, branch off from the main range.

#### **1.4.2 Rainfall**

Tamilagam has depended largely on rainfall for the successful pursuit of agriculture. The South-West monsoon gives scanty rain to the eastern side, because the South West monsoon winds do not blow across this region. On the whole, the South-West monsoon is the heaviest in the northern region of Tamil Nadu, and generally it decreases towards the south.

The North-East monsoon starting from October to mid-December provides the heaviest rainfall for Tamil Nadu, the average rising from 40" to 50". Generally the maximum rainfall of the year in Tamil Nadu occurs in the period from mid-October to mid- November

Generally the total rainfall is more inadequate, and hence artificial irrigation is employed especially in regions which are far removed from the major river systems of the country.

#### **1.4.3 Rivers**

Fortunately, the rivers, though small in number, supply a substantial amount of water needed for cultivation. The Kaveri, the Palar, the river Vellar, the Vaigai and Tamiraparani are some of the important rivers which rise in the Western Hills and irrigate the eastern slopes and later merge in the Bay of Bengal.

## **The Kaveri:**

The most prominent river of Tamilagam is unquestionably Kaveri, celebrated in Tamil literature and history. It is said that Karikalan constructed a dam across the river kaveri. The Cauvery River, originating in the Coorg district of the neighboring state of Karnataka, is the lifeline of the state. The lush Coromandal plains are irrigated by the Cauvery and its Thanjavur-Nagapattinam delta is called the granary of Tamil Nadu. It bifurcates into two branches called Kollidam and Kaveri

## **Palar**

The river Palar originates from Nandidrug in Karnataka, and running through the North Arcot District, falls into the Bay of Bengal near Sadras in the Chengleput district. It helps the irrigation of some areas of Chengleput district.

## **Vellar**

This river draining the southern slopes of the Shevaroy's and Kalrayans and the northern slopes of the Pachamalais enters the sea just north of the Kaveri delta. It flows through Bangalore, Salem and Cuddalore.

## **Vaigai**

The Vaigai raises from the Palani hills and flows through the town of Madurai. Due to the construction of certain dams in modern times, water from the Western ghats has been diverted into the Vaigai, and as a result the volume of water flowing through this river has been augmented.

## **Tambraparani**

The Tambraparani is the biggest of the rivers in the southernmost region. It flows through the Tirunelveli district. It derives directly the benefit of the South-west monsoon and it irrigates a large part of the Tirunelveli district.

All these rivers fall into the Bay of Bengal. All the rivers have been used for irrigation. The Gulf of Mannar is famous for pearl fisheries.

Rivers were used for commerce and trade. Dams have been constructed across the rivers and they are also used for hydro-electric utility. Rivers are sacred and people worshipped them. They also formed the backbone of the Dravidian civilization.

## **The coastal region**

The coastal regions of Tamil Nadu (the 'Coromandal' coast) have a few natural harbours, and these areas have had links with the Romans, Arabs, and the Chinese since ancient times. Their port cities are scattered along the coastline. The Satavahanas, the Pallavas and the Cholas had strong navies, and for a time the Cholas colonized nations east of the Bay of Bengal.

### **1.4.4 Flora and Fauna**

Agriculture has been the main occupation of Tamil Nadu. The total cropped area of present Tamil Nadu is about 16 million acres. Out of the 16 million acres under cultivation in the present Tamil Nadu 38% is devoted for the cultivation of rice, other crops cultivated consisted of Cholan (11%) Kambu (9%), Ragi (5%), Varagu (4%) and 13 % consisted of commercial crops such as groundnut and cotton. A small percentage of land is devoted for the cultivation of tobacco, sugarcane and vegetables.

On the western slopes of Western Ghats are found a number of flora and fauna. Tea, coffee, Cardamom, Cinchona, Bamboos, Rose-wood etc are found. A variety of fruits are also cultivated and they are exported. Many wild animals are living in the Ghats. Vedanthangal nearer to Madras is noted for its bird sanctuary with thousands of aquatic birds.

### **1.4.5 Minerals**

Tamil Nadu has a fair distribution of certain minerals. Lignite, Iron, Chromite, Aluminium, Bauxite, Copper, Graphite etc are some of the resources of Tamil Nadu. Lignite is found in Neyveli. Iron, Chromite, Aluminium etc are found in Salem district. Pearl fishing is popular in Tuticorin. Salt is also taken from Tuticorin and Marakkanam. Recently petroleum is found in Tanjavur district.



## **Special features of Tamilagham**

Varieties of beautiful sculptures are found in the temples. Bronze images of Tamil Nadu are world famous. People of different races and communities are living in this land. The situation of Tamilnad is the extreme south of peninsula has saved it from the cultural and political influences brought by Kushans, Afghans, Turks, Mughals etc in the north; with the exception of the Muslim invasions in the 14<sup>th</sup> century and a brief Government of Madurai Sultanate, Tamil Nadu successfully retained the essentials of ancient culture of Tamil Nadu. The fertility of the soil, the regularity of the monsoons, the never failing rivers like kaveri, the rich quality of minerals and the excellent flora and fauna lead the land to great prosperity

## **1.5 Sources**

The history of any country can be reconstructed only on the basis of relevant source material. The sources for the study of History of Tamil Nadu may be grouped into epigraphical data, numismatics, archaeology and literature.

### **1.5.1 Literary Sources**

The literary sources can be divided into Indigenous literature and foreign literature. The Indigenous literature can be divided further into Tamil literature and Non-Tamil literature.

### **Tamil Literature**

Literary sources include books written in the past, religious literature, poetry, travelogues, biographies, and other kinds of literature. From these, historians can learn about the social, economic and religious conditions of their times. Literary sources thus supplement the archaeological sources of knowledge about the past.

Books were written on palm-leaves before paper became common. Palm leaf manuscripts are collected in places like the Sarasvathi Mahal Library at Thanjavur, established by Nayak Kings in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries.

The following are some of the main literary sources of the history of Tamil Nadu.

The oldest Tamil literature belongs to the first and second centuries CE. Sangam literature may be considered as the more valuable and most reliable source of history of Sangam Age. The whole of Sangam literature Consisted of Tolkaippiyam, Pattupattu, Ettutokai, Patheninkilkanakku, Twin Epics namely Silapathikaram and Manimegalai and Perundevanar Bharatham are of most useful for the purpose.

For the study of the Pallava period the Hymns of the Devaram written by Appar, Sambandar and Sundarar explains about the Socio-economic and Religious conditions of the Pallava age. The religious conflict, the great famine, and the Pallava chalukya conflict can be studied through these works. The Naliyira Divya Pravandam of the Alvars is a religious work. We infer information about the war materials used by the Pallavas and Rashtrakutas from Nandikkalambatgam, a work dedicated to Nandivarman III, and the pandikkovai. The Bharatha Venba mentions about the battle of Tellaru. Thus these literary works serve as the useful source material for the study of the Pallava History.

In the Chola period many Tamil works were written. Periyapuram of sekkilar, Kalingathuparani of Jayamkondar, Ottakkuttar's Muvarula, Kulothungan chola Pillai Tamil were some of the literary works which serve as a source material for the study of the cholas

The pandikkovai and Periyapuram throw light for the study of the Pandyas, The Divya suri-Charitha and the Guruparamparai are other contemporary Vaishnavite works. Thiruvilaiyadal Puranam of Paranjothi also gives some historical information.

### **The Non- Tamil literature**

The Ramayana and Mahabharatha explain about the society of the Pandyas. Avanthi sundari kathasara of Bharavi and Matavilasaprahasana of Mahendravarman are some of the Sanskrit works which explains about the Pallava History. Gangadevi's Madura Vijayam or Kambana Raja Vijayam is the Sanskrit works. A detailed description of Kumarakumban's expedition is narrated in the Madura Vijayam.

### **Foreign Literary works**

Among the foreign writers Megasthenese, Strabo, Pliny and Ptolemy of the west and Pan Kou, Fahien, Hiuen Tsang of the East are prominent and their accounts besides Periplus and Peutingerian Tables are very useful.

The earliest direct notice of south India is probably found in the work of Megasthenes, the Greek who visited the Magadhan Empire. Megasthenes mentions about the Pandya kingdom. Another Greek historian, Strabo, explains about trade between southern India and Europe via Egypt. Periplus of the Erythraean Sea is a book on trade between India and Rome in the ancient period. The author is unknown. He describes about the western coast of India and trading conditions here. After this period, Chinese travelers, Fahien and Hiuen Tsang describes about southern India.

From the ninth century onwards, there were Arab travelers and geographers who refer to the southern India. Ibn Batuta, the Moroccan traveller of the fourteenth century, wrote of his travels in South India and describes about the religion and society of the Tamils. .

From the fourteenth century, there are many European accounts. Some of these writers were Benjamin of Tuleda and Marco Polo. Marco Polo travelled through southern India on his way back from China to Europe in the late thirteenth century.

The rise of Vijayanagar in the fourteenth century is mentioned by many European writers. The Italian Nicolo Conti and Portuguese Duarte Barbosa visited Vijayanagar in the fifteenth century and wrote about their experiences. Several other traders and missionaries left records of their travels in India.

Many of the Arabic and Persian historical works were written under the patronage of Muslim rulers of the Deccan. Ferishta, who lived in 16th- and early 17th century, wrote a comprehensive history of Islamic rule in India, and touched upon the extreme south also. Abdul Razzak, a Persian ambassador in the Vijayanagar court, wrote down his observations of the administration and society of that time.

### **1.5.2 Archaeological Sources**

The archaeological sources can be classified into three divisions namely Epigraphy and Copper plate, Numismatics and Monuments.

## **Epigraphy**

Epigraphy is the study of inscriptions on rocks, pillars, temple walls and copper plates. Inscriptions are the main source for reconstructing the history and culture of ancient civilizations.

### **The Rocks**

Inscriptions of Ashoka, Hathikumpha inscription of King Kharavela of Kalinga etc are found outside the Tamil country, these inscriptions mentions about the Tamil rulers.

### **The Pillars**

Allahabad Pillar inscription of Samudragupta refers to 12 rulers of South India which mentions about the ruler Vishnugopa of Kanchi.

### **The Caves**

Tiruppargundram, Nagamalai, Anaimalai, Kilkuyilkudi, Tirukkoyalur Kudimiyamalai etc are some of the places where inscriptions are found and they give reference about the Sangam period.

During the Pallava and the Pandya period number of caves were carved out throughout their empire. Mandagapattu, Mahendravadi, Trichy, Sittannaval, Mamalapuram are some of the caves of the Pallavas. From Mandagapattu inscription we come to know that prior to the Pallava period temples were constructed with the help of the perishable materials like timber, Marter, wood etc. The Rathas of the Mamalapuram also bear inscriptions of the Pallava and the chola period.

### **Temples**

Kanchi, Mamalapuram, Tanjavur, Gangaikonda Cholapuram , Darasuram, Madurai , Tanjavur etc. are the places where big and small temples are found with plenty of valuable historical inscriptions. They give information about the expeditions, method of administration (Uttiramerur), and the social and economic life of the people.

### **Copper Plates**

The Copper plate was used for inscribing matters. They are found in Prakrit, Sanskrit languages. Hirahadahalli, Gunapadeya, Mayidavelu are some of the Pallava copper plates:

Velvikudi, Talavoypuram, Sinnamannur, Sivakasi copper plates describe about the Pandyas. Thiruvallangadu, Karanthai, Anbil, Largent Leydon are some of the Chola copper plates.

## **Numismatics**

It is a study of coins. During the Sangam period, the Romans settled here and issued coins. The coins of this age are found in Arikkamedu, Madurai and other places. The coins of Vijayanagara rulers, the Nayaks, the Sultanate etc. give information about their social and economic conditions.

## **Monuments**

From the temples we infer their architecture style. The Kailasanatha temple, Vaikundaperumal temple etc reveal the Pallava's style. The descriptions of various Gods are also identified from the sculptures of these temples. Different poses of the dancing girls are found on the eastern gopura of the Chidambaram temple.

The excavations at Arikkamedu, Poompuhar, Kodumanal and other places reveal the overseas commercial activities of the Tamils. Thus the archaeological monuments give more information for reconstructing the history of Tamil Nadu.

## **1.6 Summary**

To understand the history of Tamil Nadu we use literature, Inscriptions, Numismatics and Monuments as source material. The fertility of the soil, the regularity of the monsoons, the never failing rivers like kaveri, the rich quality of minerals and the excellent flora and fauna lead the land to great prosperity

## **1.7 Review Questions**

1. Describe about the classification of the land.
2. Narrate the literary sources for the history of Tamil Nadu.
3. Explain about the archaeological sources for the history of Tamil Nadu.

## **1.8 Answers to check Review Questions**

1. See the section 1.4
2. See the sub-section 1.5.1
3. See the sub-section 1.5.2

## **1.9 Further References**

1. A.K.Gopalan, Pallavas of Kanchi
2. K.K.Pillay, Social History of the Tamils
3. K.A.Neelakanda Sastri, History of South India
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## **LESSON - 2**

# **SOCIAL ORGANISATIONS, CUSTOMS AND PRACTICES IN THE SANGAM AGE**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Understand the ancient Tamil Civilization
- ❖ Learn about the fivefold divisions of the land
- ❖ Know the caste system, family life, shelter during the Sangam age

### **Structure**

#### **2.1 Introduction**

#### **2.2 Division of Lands**

#### **2.3 Caste system**

#### **2.4 Occupations**

##### **2.4.1. Slavery**

##### **2.4.2 Dwellings**

##### **2.4.3 Food**

##### **2.4.4 Dress**

##### **2.4.5 Ornaments**

##### **2.4.6 Amusements, Pastimes and Games**

##### **2.4.7 Festivals**

##### **2.4.8 Marriage**

##### **2.4.9 The Courtesans (Parathaiyar)**

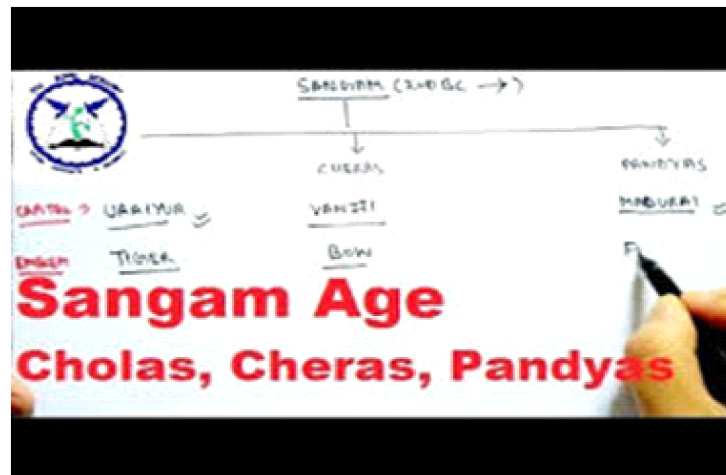
##### **2.4.10 Hospitality**

**2.4.11 Funeral Practices****2.4.12 Customs and Habits****2.5 Beliefs and Superstitions****2.5.1 Status of women****2.5.2 Sati****2.5.3 Family****2.5.4 Widowhood****2.6 Education****2.7 Fine Arts****2.8 Summary****2.9 Answers to Review Questions****2.1 Introduction**

Scholars regard the Sangam period as the “Classical Age” of the Tamils. Some scholars consider the sangam age as the “Golden Age” of the Tamils, which marked a unique epoch in the history of Tamilaham. The physical features of ancient Tamilaham landscape with its mountains and rivers have induced the ancient Tamils to divide the landscape on the basis of







geographical set up. The hilly regions were called Kurinchi, the forest area was known as Mullai, the fertile regions of river-valleys are called as Marutham, the seashore is known as Neithal and the waste land and the sandy desert are called as Palai. These fivefold divisions of the land gave an impetus to the development of culture. Sangam literature reflects the matter of great historical importance.

### **Ancient Tamil Civilization**

The term “Tamilakam” appears to be the most ancient term used for designating the Tamil territory. According to the Tolkappiyam “the virtuous land in which Tamil is spoken as the mother tongue lies between the northern Venkata hill and the southern Kumari. The Silappadikkaram defines the Tamilakam as “The Tamil region extends from the hills of Vishnu (Tirupati) in the north to the oceans at the cape in the south. In this region of cool waters were the four great cities of Madurai, Uraiyur, kanchi and Puhar with the roaring waters (of Kaveri and the ocean)”. These ancient texts do not clearly define the eastern and western boundaries of the Tamilakam. Scholars assume that these boundaries were the seas, which may explain their omission from their ancient definitions. The ancient Tamilakam thus included the present Kerala.

While excavating a site linked to the Sangam period, archaeologists have unearthed remnants of a civilization in Tamil Nadu whose drainage system resembles that of the Indus Valley Civilization. Around 3000 ancient artefacts have been found from Keezhadi Pallai sandhaipudur village in the Shivaganga district. The artefacts include swords, arrows, other

iron and copper weapons. Further a particular note about the drainage system which is underground and lay with “baked clay pipe lines” similar to those of Harappan civilization.

According to Archaeological Survey of India, the site is over 2500 years old, (more than 500 BC) and belongs to the ancient Pandyan era. This means that there was a flourishing Dravidian civilization was in existence.

### **Ancient brick Structure**



## **2.2 Division of Lands**

The Sangam Age in Tamil Nadu witnessed prosperity in all spheres of life. The Tamil people had a common language and culture in the Sangam Age. But they lived in five different Natural landscapes. These natural landscapes or geographical regions were called as Thinais. Sangam literature referred about the fivefold division of land and they were known as Kurinji, Mullai, Marudham, Neydal and Palai. Each Thinais was geographically distinct from the other. Moreover each thinais region reflected their social characteristics. The life of the people in these divisions differed according to their regions.

**Kurinji** - It refers to the hilly region. The people in this region were known as Vettuvar (Hunter) and Kuravar. Their main occupation was hunting. Occasionally they also cultivated vegetables and fruits and gathered honey. Their deity was Murugan or Seyon.

**Mullai-** It is the pastoral area. They domesticated animals. The people of this region were known as kovalar or Ayar. They produced dairy products like milk, curd and Ghee. They worshipped Thirumal or Mayon.

**Marudham-** This region refers to fertile and agricultural lands. People in this region were referred as Vellalars because their profession was agriculture. They were familiar with the Irrigation methods also. They worshipped Indra or Rain God.

**Neidal-** Coastal area is the region of Neidal. People were called as Meenavar or Parathavar. (Fisherman) Their main occupation was fishing. Their chief deity was varunan or the sea God

**Palai-** refers to Desert region. Among these five regions the first four regions are of permanent nature and the fifth region cannot be considered to be so. The Mullai and kurinchi regions by nature's blessings are of interchangeable into palai region and vice versa. The people of this region were known as Maravar of Kallar. Highway robbery and warfare were their occupations. Korravai or Kali was the chief Goddess worshipped by them.

## 2.3 Caste system

The Tamil society during the Sangam period was broadly divided into several groups. In the beginning of the Sangam Age, the Tamil society was not organized on the basis of the Vedic caste system, namely Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, vaisyas and Sudras. However, the earliest of the Sangam literature, Tolkappiyam mentions about the fourfold divisions were prevalent in the Sangam society namely, Anthanar, Arasar, Vaislyar and Vellalar, it may be said that this classification roughly corresponds to the Vedic Social division. Arasar were the ruling class. . Anthanars played a significant role in the Sangam polity and religion. Vanigar's profession was trade and commerce. And the vellalas were agriculturists. Another Sangam work, Purananuru mentions the names of ancient Tamil tribes such as Thudiyar, Pannan, and Kadamban. Other tribal groups like Parathavar, Panar, Eyinar, Kadambar, Maravar and Pulaiyar were also found in the Sangam society. Ancient primitive tribes like Thodas, Irulas, Nagas and Vedars lived in this period. These divisions indicate the complex social structure prevalent in the Sangam Age. The social order of the people was based on the region in which they lived or on the occupation which they had adopted

The four-fold division was known to them and this was mentioned in the poem Purananuru. V.Kanakasabai has a classification of caste. Ulavar, Ayar artisans like goldsmiths etc., Padai-Achis (armed men), Valaiyar (fishermen), pulaiyar (official slaughters). There is no warrant for such a division in society.

The concept of upper classes was quite well established in the days of Silappadikaram where it is said that the Goldsmith being a kamala walked at a distance from the higher class people walking along the street among whom Kovalan the vaisya, was one.

## **The Brahmins**

Brahmins played a prominent role in the Tamil society ever since the coming of the Aryans into South India. They are mentioned in practically in every text in sangam literature i.e., Tolkappiyam, the Ten Idyls, the Eight Anthology and the Eighteen Minor Works. Brahmins had composed major and minor poems: they had played the role of patrons also. They had been ambassadors, priests, ascetics, householders, merchants and judicial advisors. Thus they have contributed to the enrichment of Tamil Culture.

The Brahmins are called Andanar or Parppar or Maraiyavar. According to Thiruvalluvar Andhanar is otherwise called Aravar, because they assume justice and kindness towards all creatures. Parppar means a 'seer': "Maraiyavar" means those who study and teach the Marais or the Vedas. Tolkappiam mentioned the duties of Parppar and they were Learning, Teaching, Performing sacrifices, giving presents and Receiving presents.

Tolkappiyar also speaks of the Arivar. They are the wise men who know the past, the present and the future, i.e. are omniscient. Agastya, the famous sage is included among these ascetics by Nachchinarkkiniyar.

The Andanar were recruited for service in the royal court as purohiths and probably as astrologers. Some of them served as judicial advisers, and were employed as ambassadors.

The Andanar lived in particular parts of the town or village. Their quarters were called Parppana Cheri. They were famous for their clean surroundings and hygienic environment. Their residential area could be easily recognized. The housewife in the Andanar family was a dutiful and industrious lady whose charity was proverbial like that of Arundadi.

It is strange that couple of references in the whole of the sangam literature has led many scholars to conclude that the Tamil Brahmin of the sangam Age was a meat-eater and a wine drinker, The sources which are supposed to support them are poems 113 and 119 of Purananuru and Kapilar's Inna Narpadu one of the eighteen minor works of the sangam literature. According to K.A.N.Sastry 'Apparently Brahmins ate meat and drank toddy without incurring reproach'. Scholars have come to a conclusion that the Brahmins after their Gurukulam's education neglected non-vegetarian food.

In all walks of life the Brahmins had high respect and reward. The Brahmins helped the kings for performing the sacrifices and the conduct of state affairs, particularly in the administration of justice. The kings treated them with great courtesy. Thus the Tamil Brahmins of the Sangam Age enjoyed considerable respect in the society.

### **Other Communities**

The kings of Sangam Age were the natives of Tamilaham in every sense. The Tamil kingdoms were founded by Dravidian immigrants. It is clear that they were not Aryan immigrants. The king's duties were well recognized. The occupational or professional order in the long -run became birth based. Among these, Vellala the agriculturist were highly respected by all other communities, as the daughters of Velir, the Vellala chiefs were given in marriage to the Tamil Kings i.e. the celebrated Pari, Anji, Kari, Or Pehan etc. The vellalars are introduced as Ulavar (Cultivator) who owned the curved plough and led a virtuous life. They condemn killing and abhor stealing; perform their duties to the heavenly Gods and offer oblations.

Tolkappiar calls the commercial community as Vaisyas. The merchant community was the backbone of national economy. Basically they were traders dealing in the eight varieties of grams, dhal, millets. According to Thirukural the merchant community had a high standard of honesty. They won't take anything more than what should they get, and won't give anything less than what they should give and thus they regard the goods of others equal to that of their own. They have developed the foreign trade during the sangam age. They were the owners of the big vessels which were used for their trade. They lived in luxurious houses and led a high life.

The natural occupation of the coastal region was fishing and the people who had adopted fishing as their occupation was called 'Minavar' after the Tamil word "Min" that is the people who lived on fishing. They were also called as "Paradavar". They were also mentioned in the sangam literature as "Valainar" and "Nuliyar". According to Pattinappalai they built boats small and big and carried on their trade along the sea coasts. Gradually they became sailors, who took their trade to Arabia and Africa in the west, and Burma and China in the east. Perumpanarrupatai speaks about their large houses in the broad streets approaching the sea shore.

There were other innumerable communities. The Umanar were the manufacturers and sellers of salt. Blacksmith rendered their effective service for the heroic society. He was known as Kollan with the famous title Karungaikkollan (meaning the strong armed smith). The goldsmith, were called as Porkollan. Silapathikaram mentions about Porkollar for Goldsmith. He was the dealer in gold and manufacturer of jewels and ornaments. They were treated as low-born persons.

The Carpenter was a busy craftsman. The art of building was known to them. Wood carvings and wood works were in their houses. Purananuru explains about their skill. The carpenters made vehicles and bedsteads, planks and doors, chariots and boats. The weavers were the next importance to the agriculturist and they were famous in foreign countries for their fine production of textile goods. The tailors were known as Tumiyaakarar. The shepherds and cowherds were a very important and large community: They represented the pastoral regions in the land and cattle were their wealth.

The vedars were the hunters and they accompanied the king on the hunting expedition. The cobbler who was treated as a "low born" not only made and mended shoes but he manufactured the "Pari" the large leather can be used for drawing water for irrigation. Such was the Tamil Sangam social structure.

## 2.4 Occupations

Agriculture was the main occupation of the sangam people. It was considered to be a noble profession. Tirukural says that agriculture alone provides the means of catering to the

elementary needs of mankind and other professions depend directly or indirectly on agriculture. Apart from Varagu, Tinai were also cultivated.

Cattle breeding were another important occupation of the Sangam age. Milk and Milk products were used by the Tamil people hence they showed keen interest in cattle rearing. Milk, curd, ghee, butter were taken to the nearby region for sale. The women folks were the vendors of milk products.

Weaving was a prominent occupation of the Sangam people. They developed great skill in manufacture nice variety of cotton and silk clothes. Silappadikkaram refers about 32 varieties of cotton cloth. Dyeing of the cloth was skillfully done. Well designed bordered silk cloth was a common feature.

The skill of blacksmith was also very much in demand in the Sangam Age in making toys, utensils, agricultural implements, weapons of warfare and all the construction of buildings and ships.

During the Sangam age the Toddy Tapping was also an important occupation. Pattinapalai mentions various kinds of toddy namely pilimattu, matu, and naravu and it explains that 'pili' was tapped from the spathe of palmyra tree. Toddy was generally known as 'kal'. The term 'teral' which denoted money, also was used as the synonym for toddy. It is also offered to 'natukal', the memorial stone, during worship. Hence the toddy tapping also was an important and profitable occupation of those days.

The natural occupation of the coastal region was fishing and the people who had adopted fishing as their occupation was called 'Minavar' after the Tamil word "Min" that is the people who lived on fishing.

The Brahmins discharged their six fold functions. These were the study of the Vedas, conducting Vedic sacrifices, officiating priests in sacrifices giving gifts to others and receiving gifts. They were highly respected by the rulers and also by the rich and the poor people. They were liberally donated by the kings. Some Brahmins took secular functions also. Thus they had been ambassadors, priests, ascetics, householders, merchants and judicial advisors

There were other occupational groups also. The Umanar were the manufactures and sellers of salt. Blacksmith, the goldsmith, the cobbler and the carpenter were treated as low-born persons.

#### **2.4.1 Slavery**

There was no trace of the existence of slavery in the Sangam age. Megasthenes said that slavery as an institution was never known to India: as he had never seen an open market for the sale of slaves. V.Kanakasabai says “slavery was ever unknown amongst the Tamils and this is strong evidence of their superior civilization in the early period”. V.A.Smith also remarks “Slavery is said to have been unknown amongst the Tamils”.

But N.Subramaniam concludes in a reasonable way that there might have been slavery but in disguise. He puts forth the following in support of his view: Purananuru mentions the term “Adiyurai” which means “Adimai” Silappathikaram mentions the term ‘Urimai Surram’ which means “Adimai” since the foot note says “Adimaittirli” Thiruttondar Purnam mentions directly the word “Adimai”.

These evidences seem to proper and appropriate. He also says that unconditional submission of a subject to the king, of a disciple to his guru and of the wife to her husband also indicates the slavery in a philosophical way.

In addition to these things the system of bonded labour that is “Pannaiyal” system which existed till recently may be considered as evidence.

However we have to give margin that there is no direct evidence in the Sangam classics to show that there existed the institution of slavery .

#### **2.4.2 Dwellings**

Primitive men lived in the natural caves and worshipped Nature via Sun, Moon, cloud and even Lightening. But in course of time people felt the need of a dwelling place, and gradually he began to build houses so as to protect himself from the horrors of the Sun, Rain and even cruel animals etc.



No doubt the Sangam classics reveal that the ancient Tamils were far advanced in this aspect also. They were well trained in the art of brick and mortar. We hear about the cloud capped storied buildings of Pukar from Pattinappalai

People lived in two kinds of houses-those built of mud and others built of bricks. According to the literary evidence the second category of houses were built of Suduman, which means burnt mud. The poor lived in thatched houses covered with leaves of gross of the coconut or Palmyra.

A Sangam classic speaks of the large houses with spacious front-yards. They used to have double doors. Invariably the royal buildings had the tiger mark, the royal emblem of the Chola kings. There were small tanks and cattle sheds in the spacious front yard of the large houses.

There were huge and lofty storied buildings with many halls big and small

With a narrow passage between the main entrance and the next inside door: and there were much elevated piles around the buildings which were provided with long ladders with close set rungs. There were windows to allow the breeze in .Literary work speaks about the storied buildings with huge circular pillars, where numerous guests were fed in the spacious kitchen halls and the surplus was kept ready for the newcomers. It is also said that there were grain stores in the interior parts of the houses.

### **2.4.3 Food and drink**

The diet system of the ancient Tamils was not much different from that of the present days. Primarily it may depend upon the flora and fauna of the land. The diet of the Tamils was simple but a great importance was attached to it, as it is the life sustainer. The sangam people ate both vegetarian and non vegetarian food. Cooked rice was the staple food of the ancient tamils and it continued through the ages without much change.

There are vast paddy fields with one crop or the other always. The land is cultivated throughout the year with alternative crop plants. There is ample evidence from sangam classics to show that milk was in use, and sometimes the rice was cooked with milk. Curd and buttermilk

also had their due places in the meals and they were popular in those days too. Ghee was used invariably by the middle and high class people. Ghee was used in the performance of sacrifices.

Eating of mutton was always accompanied by drinking of Toddy and ginger. The king ate and drank in the company of his guests and relatives. The sangam people used betel leaves also. In addition to this they used slaked lime and areca nut.

#### **2.4.4 Dress**

A variety of clothing was used by the people during this age, including those made of cotton and silk. People living in hilly and deserted areas wore dresses made of foliage and flowers. Sheaths of grassy weeds (Korai) were used for making dress by the hill and forest area people. Skins of animals and barks of trees were also used. Men of the poorer classes wore only one piece of cloth around the waist. Women covered their upper body with a kind of dress called kachchu. Among the higher classes, men wore two pieces; one around the waist and the other, the upper cloth, thrown over the shoulders. Women of sophisticated society wore half sari, made of the finest cotton and silk fabrics, with embroidery.

The cotton dress was more popular among all Tamils and the silk also was in use, perhaps by the rich. A sangam literary work mentions about the dress of those days. It speaks about the cotton, silk and foliage dresses. It says that the ladies by mistake wore the cotton, cloth of their husband instead of their own silk sarees. It shows that the silk was used invariably by ladies and the ancient Tamils were well trained in fine cotton weaving and in silk too. Pattinappalai mentions also about the use of foliage dress by the paratavar women. This is clear evidence to show that in ancient times the foliage dress was in use among the maids and ladies on festive and ceremonial occasions.

#### **2.4.5 Ornaments**

Ornaments were very popular among the ancient Tamils and there were numerous varieties of them and especially the married women were crazy for such ornaments. But one should not think that all the maids and ladies wore all kinds of ornaments mentioned in Sangam classics.

Particular ornament worn by particular individual depended on the social and economical conditions of the person concerned. Pattinapalai provides details of ornaments worn by ancient Tamils, and it refers wherever necessary by the common term *ilai* (ornaments), such as *nerilai* (proper ornament), *pasilai* (special or gold ornament) and *murrilai* (complete set of ornaments). *Ilai* is a common name for the ornaments as they are made of gold and studded with diamonds. However mention is made about two particular ornaments namely *kulai* and *toti*. *Kulai* means an ear ring but here the 'kotunkulai' may be said as an ear ornament such as modern 'jimikki' and 'pontoti' means in this context may mean the goldern bracelet as it is worn by putalvar (son). From the above mentioned information we come to know that the Sangam people lead a civilized life.

#### **2.4.6 Amusements, Pastimes and Games**

The amusements, pastimes and games of the ancient Tamils varied from place to place. In the towns the people had less time for leisure due to their social activities whereas the rural people had spent their leisure time in many ways. In the Mullai region, the bull fighting was very common. In villages cock-fighting and goat-fighting were popular. Wrestling was also known to the Sangam Tamils.

Kuravar boys used to make bows and arrows with twigs and thorns. Horse and elephant riding was the pastime of few people. On the full moon day, which is specially intended for Varunan the sea-god, the dark skinned paratavar folk, neglected their usual work of fishing in the wide cold sea, ate and drank, and enjoyed playing with their black mates, who wore garments of green leaves

To train the youngsters in warfare the villages had organizations, called Paravai and Muranakalari, Porvila Pundodai Vilavu were celebrated in honour of the distinguished youngsters.

Panar and Viraliyae, skilled in Music and dance respectively provided entertainment to the kings chieftains and the public.

Youngsters took the game of football. Kalangadudal was a favorite game of the girls. Swinging on a pole-suspended by ropes was another pastime of the girls. Boys and girls delight in erecting fancy structures and dolls with sand imitating the cries and pranks of birds was one of the amusements. Tiny carts and toys were also used.

This reminds us in the ancient days, women used to wear around their waist green leaves plaited with colorful flowers. This kind of fanciful attire was considered a decorative garment, and was used by maids, on extraordinary occasions such as festivals. And it is evident that the full moon day was set apart for offering prayers to Varunan the sea-God by the Paradavar folk; hence their womenfolk presented with garment of foliage

It is evident, in those days both men and women used to drink but the drinks were quite different from each other; the women used to wear silk, but the men were contented with cotton.

### **2.4.7 Festivals**

There were many festivals celebrated in the Sangam age and references can be found in the sangam classics. Marudam region Tamils used to worship Indra as their God. Hence they celebrated a festival known as “Indra Vizha”. We are able to get detailed information about this festival from the Tamil epics Silappadkkaram and Manimekalai and it says how the chola rulers celebrated this festival in a grand manner. There was a belief that if they celebrate a festival to Lord Indra they will have a good rain and also their difficulties and dangers are removed

Lord Murugan is the favourite God of the Sangam Tamils. The sangam Tamils used to celebrate Kartigai festival. There was a reference in the literary work about this festival. The literary work Ahananuru says that the Kartigai festival is celebrated during the full moon day of the Tamil month of Karthigai. The literary works Thirumurugatrupadai and Purananuru explains about the khandashati vizha. Accordingly the legend says that the lord Murukan destroyed kadamba Asura king Sruabadma.

We have a reference about the festival of Pongal. It is known as harvest festival and they used to celebrate this festival in order to thank the God Sun. They used to celebrate this festival in the month of Thai.

Maduraikanchi speaks about the Thiruvonam festival. According to that on Thiruvonam the birth star of Lord Vishnu, a group of stars which are bright together and resemble like an eagle. Hence this incident was celebrated for ten days by the Pandya rulers.

Thus we can say many festivals which were celebrated by the Sangam Tamils even now we follow in Tamil Nadu

### **2.4.8 Marriage**

During the Sangam age, marriage was very simple and natural. The coming together of man and woman constituted marriage. “Manam” means in Tamil marriage.

There was not a much difference in the system of ritualistic marriage what we follow now to the Sangam age marriage rituals. Silappadikaram gives a graphic picture of the marriage between Kovalan and Kannagi. The bride was on the eve of completing 12 years and the bridegroom 16 years. This was an arranged marriage by their parents. The sacred “Tali” (which the bride was to wear around her neck throughout her wedded life) was taken round for all to bless it: the grand old Brahmins conducted the marriage of Kovalan and Kannagi (as chaste as Arundhati). The system of wearing Tali is a peculiarly non-Aryan practice. It is indigenous to Tamilaham. Later on it was incorporated by the Brahmins into their ritualistic pattern.

In those days early marriage was practiced. After ritualistic marriage became fully established the practice of arranged marriage automatically followed.

### **2.4.9 The Courtesans (Parathaiyar)**

The courtesans are mentioned in many places in the Sangam literature especially in the Aham literature. They were known as “Parattaiyar or Kanigaiyar”. During the Sangam age, a courtesan was a woman who had sexual relationships with rich and powerful men for money. Their profession was prostitution. They were of two kinds. The professional prostitutes were who earned a living by the profession and did not get attached to any particular customer. They were known as Cheri parattaiyar.

There were others who though belonging to that community set their heart upon a particular person and lived in love with him but were not married at any time. They were known as Kadar parattaiyar and they were just unmarried spouses. Kovalan lived with Madhavi on those terms only.

These courtesans found in large numbers in the palace of the king. They were the king's body-guards and servants. They served as maids of the queen. They accompanied the king even to the battlefield; these courtesans lived in a separate suburb called "Parattaiyar Cheri".

These courtesans were greatly accomplished in fine arts especially in the art of dancing, music and drama. Prizes were given to the best dances. Madhavi won the prize from the king, and that started the affair between Kovalan and Madhavi.

The favourite courtesans of the kings received special honours and treatment. During the Sangam age it was considered necessary that this class of persons should not be discouraged from their ancestral profession.

#### **2.4.10 Hospitality**

Thiruvalluvar wrote much about hospitality in his Thirukkural. Hospitality was considered as an essential duty of a house – holder, and hence they gave a warm welcome to their guests and provided delicious food. Cordiality to neighbours also was considered as a duty of a house – holder.

Malaipatukadam narrates how sangam Tamils invited their guests warmly and used to share their food with the guests. Even if the guests came late at night they were sure to get food and shelter. Charity was an allied virtue of the ancient Tamils: feeding the poor was believed to be sacred duty. Hence the ancient Tamils were more hospitable and charitable. Pattinappalai explains that there were public feeding houses in Pukar and the large quantity of "Kanchi" the rice water drained from the cooked rice was flowing through the street like a rivulet. Besides all these, the foreigners who had diverse tongues, stayed in Pukar on trade purposes, led a free and happy life as they received kind hospitality from the Tamils.

Thus the hospitality of the ancient Tamils is proverbial. It was in high order and the tradition is continuing even today.

#### **2.4.11 Funeral practices**

During the Sangam age the Tamils followed four methods to dispose the dead. The methods were Cremation, Urn Burial, Exposing for vultures and jackals to eat and simple

burial. The cremation ground or the burning ghat was Sudukadu, while the rest were known as Idukadu. Of these cremation seems to have been the most usual practice and this we inferred from Naladiyar.

The urn burial was done by putting the dead body in a large pot and burying the pot deep in the ground upside down. The urn was called “Mudumakkal tali”- meaning “the urn of the departed ones”. Sati was practiced during this period.

Epic Silappadikaram mentions about the customary for certain post-mortem rites to be performed.

After cremation, brick tombs of various shapes were raised by the relatives of the dead. Epic Manimekallai mentions about such construction of tombs. It is different from “Nadukal” which was raised for the warriors who had fallen in battle.

#### **2.4.12 Customs and Practices**

The sangam literature gives a detailed description about the various customs and practices of the people of the Sangam Age. In the Sangam Age people lived mostly in villages, leading a simple and contented life. The ideal of the house holder was to sustain society by feeding the ascetics and bachelors. Thiruvalluvar wrote much about hospitality in his Thirukkural.

During festival time they used to organize feeding the public and they used to distribute good and tasty food. Every person was to take care of the parents, the elder brother, the teacher and the king as the “Five Great Ones” to be primarily respected. Tirukural says that it was a Duty of a father “to make the son take the first seat in the assembly of the wise ones” In turn it was the duty of the son to conduct himself as to earn a very good name and fame for his father. Pisir Andaiyar says that the main reason why .hair on his head not turned grey in spite of his old age was that the youngsters in his house never crossed him. For a wife, the husband was more worthy of worship than anybody else,

Guests were treated well and while the guests were leaving the inmates used to walk along with them “Seven Steps”. Another custom was that the practice of setting apart some food for the crow before one began to eat. The shepherdess lighted the fire at home with a

stick which was violently rubbed against a wooden frame: this was the only way they know to make fire. The practice of scrubbing the floor with cow dung paste was quite common in those days. In course of time it acquired the religious significance.

The young girls were entrusted with watching the drying grains in front of their houses as they were not engaged otherwise. Perhaps this may remind us that the young maids were sent to the tinai (millet) field for watching the ear of corn (katir).

Another practice was the determination of the hour of the day. It was determined by them in a variety of ways. One such way was to find out the position of the sun. Another way was by observing the dropping away of water from the water basin set up for the purpose. Another way was by observing the blossoming of flowers. The dawn was no doubt announced by the unfailing cock. Many of the traditions of the Sangam age continued and survived in the later periods and some exist even today.

## **2.5 Beliefs and Superstitions**

The Tamils had many beliefs and like most ancients were to a great measure Superstitious. They believed in the significance of dreams which they thought would always come true. They felt that the exact time when a dream would be realized depended on the Jamam (the quarter of the night) in which it occurred. A dream of the first quarter of the night was expected to be effective in a year: that of the second quarter in eight months: that of the third quarter in three months and that of the last quarter in ten days. For instance the dreams of Kannagi and Kooperundevi become true very early. The following were considered as bad Omens by the Sangam Tamils and it was referred in Purananuru; i.e. the hooting of birds as bad omen, the falling of burning logs in all directions, riding a pig, seeing oneself naked and oneself taking oil-bath.

According to Ahananuru, the Tamils had profound faith in certain other omens also. The lizard creeping along the steep wall was watched for the direction from which it hooted. It was known as "Asariri. Kalithogai says that in those days journeys were undertaken on auspicious days. The same literature mentions that it was considered lucky if the left eye of a girl or the right one of a man quivered violently. According to Silappadikaram if the planet "Velli" (Venus)



appeared in the south it was a bad omen. The cawing of a crow was taken to portend the arrival of guests,

The Sangam Tamils believed in ghosts and spirits and feared. Kuruntogai speaks that Tamils believed that the nature of next birth of a man was decided by the thoughts of his last moments in this birth. Untouchability prevailed during this time. They believed in the efficacy of Margosa leaves and white mustard as protective against the influence of ghosts-Pey: women applied ney and white mustard to the hair on heads of children to protect them from evil influences

Left was inauspicious during this period. The bride after her marriage entered the mother-in-law's house placing her right foot on it. The dancer ascended the placing her right foot first on it.

The husband must not leave the company of his wife for fifteen days after the start of menstrual flow for her: but is not to seek union with her during the menses period. Scientific enquiry would show that this was not mere belief but the result of careful observation. It was customary for the women, after the child-birth to go to the public tank for bathing. During the period of "impurity", they were "unapproachable" and must not touch the domestic utensils.

### **2.5.1 Status of women**

#### **Status of Women**

The Sangam literature describes the position of women in ancient Tamil Society. In the Sangam Age women were treated with respectable position. However, male chauvinism prevailed. The natural feminine qualities such as Achacham, Madam and Naanam were insisted in the Sangam literature. Tolkappiyar credits the womanhood with the virtues of self-restraint, mental peace, uprightness, uttering only purposeful words, and discrimination between good and evil. These qualities made it clear that woman were expected to occupy a more passive role in the society. Chastity was the most important virtue of Tamil women. They considered Karpu much more important for them than life itself. They were highly devoted towards their husbands. Chaste women were greatly respected in the society. The women were given freedom to choose their life partners during the Sangam period.

According to the Sangam literature, a woman had to play different roles in the family such as a dutiful wife, responsible mother and an ideal hostess to guest.

Women had no rights on property and, in general, were subordinate to men. However, women mixed freely in the business and amusements of social life. In towns and cities, women of lower classes were employed as hawkers, vendors, shopkeepers or servants in rich households and in the villages; they worked in the fields and gardens along with men and shared their hardships. The ladies of the higher classes were more confined to their homes, but they were not secluded from society. The treatment of women in Pattinappalai is highly commendable. In the text we find references to the young maids with shining forehead and guiltless look are entrusted to watch the drying grains in front of the spacious houses. They unmindingly scare away the guilt fowls by throwing away their golden ear-ring. This shows clearly the gold ornaments were in much use among the Tamils during the Sangam age and also they were very rich.

Women's education was also insisted during the Sangam Age. We come to know a few women like Avvaiyar, Ponmudiar, Kakkaipattiniyar and Nachchellaiyar, whose verses are found in the Sangam literature. The most exquisite and soul-stirring pieces contributed by the Tamil poetesses of Sangam period have been praised as the repositories of poetic excellence and fertile wisdom.

### **2.5.2 Sati**

The loving wife was a lucky one if she predeceased her husband: but if she had the misfortune to survive him, her position become miserable. She could either perish with him on the funeral pyre or survive to lead the humiliating life of a widow.

The practice of Sati was there in the sangam age: but this term Sati is not used in the sangam age. Tolkappiam speaks about "Tippaidal" (falling into flames) this means that "Tippaidal" was the most usual form of self-immolation. It must be said that there is no instance of compelling the widow to perform sati. Sangam literature including Tirukural does not mention about the practice of Sati.

In some cases women commits Sati on the death of their husbands. Kopperundevi, who died the moment she saw her husband roll to his death, belongs to the first category. Peunkoppendu, the wife of Bhuda-p-pandiyan, who died on the funeral pyre of her husband, falls into the second category. Women who live widowed life relate to the lowest category of women. Kopperundevi left the mundane world along with her lord. The ancient Tamils raised monuments over the remains of women who committed sati. Sensitive women tried to avoid the degraded life after the husband's death. Hence they followed self immolation. Moreover, for those women life had lost all meaning with the death of her husband.

### **2.5.3 Family**

The basic unit of the ancient Tamil society was the family. A group of families constituted the different strata of the Tamil society. Hence, the household life of the Tamil people played an important role in the development of Tamil culture. Domestic life has been patronized as a supreme state in the life of every human-being. Love and virtue are the important qualities of the householders and they are considered as the symbol of the family life.

An excellent wife is a blessing to the family and that has bearing the good children are considered as a precious ornament. The wife is known as the "illuminator" of the family. There are number of pictures of the sweet home in the sangam literature which bear ample testimony to the significance attached to the family life.

One could not find a parallel to this type of reverence and respect shown to the family life in any other ancient civilizations of the world.

### **2.5.4 Widowhood**

From the epic Manimekalai we understand that it was not every woman whose husband predeceased her followed self immolation. The life of a widow was to be that of an ascetic. It was a life of Nonbu (Penance). It was a degraded life: for a woman life was not worthwhile after her husband's demise. It was known as Kaimmai, the condition of being reduced or bereaved: and a woman so bereaved was a Kaimpen.

She was prescribed a kind of diet to follow. The widow had to serve symbolic, sacrificial food for the departed soul of her husband and she was to clean, scrub and wash the floor of the house. The Tamil literary work says that “the weeping widow washed the ground with her tears”. Naturally the rigours of a widowed life drove a few loving and sensitive women to prefer to death to a life of such humiliation.

## **2.6 Education**

The value and importance of education were fully realized by the Tamils of the sangam age. Tirukkural provides an elaborate exposition of the value of learning. The sangam classics show that education was popular among all classes of people as the poets invariably belong to different classes. The patinenkil kanakku works indicate that educational activities had continued to be steady even after the Sangam age. Parents were keen in the education of their children. Ponmutiyar a sangam poetess says that it is the duty of the father to educate his son. Pattinappalai reveals that in Pukar, there were many eminent scholars who had hoisted flags so as to invite other great scholars for debate. This shows that education was much appreciated by all classes and hence there were many scholars and poets

The student began their education in the young age. They were the personal disciples of the teacher. The students wrote on dried and cut palm leaf bits. The leaves are called “Olai” and the bundle of leaves was a “Suvadi”. The teacher was paid either in cash or in kind by the students. The students gave their manual labour and wealth to the teacher. During the Sangam age much of the teaching was oral. The teacher was given great respect. In view of the above facts, it is clear that education was popular among all people and poets represented all communities.

## **2.7 Fine Arts**

### **Painting**

Fine arts took fine shape during the sangam age. The Tamils of the Sangam age paid proper attention for the painting. Sangam classics reveal that the figures of Gods and natural sceneries were painted on the walls as well as on canvas. Pattinappalai refers to the paintings

of Goddess Tirumakal on the wall, and the tiger, the royal emblem on the doors. It also hints about various figures painted on the walls. It is sure that there might have been literature on painting. Manimekalai mentions about “Oviyac cennul”. It says that the painter will create the figure to draw in his mind first then draw it and finally paint it. The unpainted drawing was called “Punaiya Oviyam”. The painting in Tamil was called “Oviyam” and the painter was called “Oviyan”.

## **Sculpture**

Sculpture was a familiar plastic art for the Sangam Tamils. The artists were called “Mannittaral”, experts in stucco work. The sculptors were called “Sirpasarigal. Since they have used perishable material for making sculptures, there is no concrete evidence about the Sangam paintings and sculptures. We have reference from the literary work Silappadikkaram which speaks about the dolls and images as Pavai. These images were worshipped in the temple of those days.

## **Dance and Drama**

Dance and Drama could not function without music. It was the soul of the other two fine arts. Dance was performed by both men and women. Attan Atti was a dancer. He was the celebrated husband of Adi Mandi, a daughter of karikal chola. Natanam was the term used for dance in Sanskrit, and Natakam was the term used for drama. . A Kuttan was a male dancer, and a Kutti was a female dancer.

In the sangam period the dancing had attained a high degree of excellence and was cultivated with great enthusiasm. There were many kinds of dances such as Vallikkuttu, Kuravaikkuttu and so on. This art was well developed during the sangam age and the dance performance exhibited by Matavi was quite different from those of Vallikkuttu, etc., and far advanced. She received the Royal Award of 1008 kalanchu pon which was the custom of those days.

Drama was an “attempt to represent on the stage a story” of course to the accompaniment of Music. It was otherwise called Natakam. Among the dramas Kuravai Kuttu, Kumarikkuttu and Tunangai kuttu were famous during this period.

## Music

The Tamils of the Sangam age had acquired a remarkable skill in Music. They took great delight in enjoying music both vocal and instrumental. They were very much interested to witness either a dance performance or a play. This can be ascertained from the concept of “Muttamil” that is Iyal, Isai and Natakam.

Pattinappalai shows that the citizens of Pukar were used to gather at a common place to enjoy music and witness dramas. The term “isai” itself denotes that the music melt the minds of the people. Whenever we think of Tamil music we have to think about the “pan” the melody of Tamil isai. The Tamils of the sangam age were far advanced in Music. They had separate pan for every region, namely kurincippam for kurinci region, pancuram for palai region, marutappan for marudham region and cevvalippan for neytal region. In the same way they had separate yal (string instrument) for the five regions and they were called with the names of the respective regions, but vilari Yal for neytal region. There were seven tunes called Kura, tutarn, kaikkoli, ulal, Ili, vilari and taram, each representing the seven strings of Yal. It was also restricted that a particular pan should be sung only in a particular time and there were appropriately adjusted musical tunes suited to various occasions such as marriage, religious functions, coronation or war.

## Musical Instruments

There were numerous musical instruments in Tamilakam. A sangam literature mentions about the Kulal, yal, Mulavu and Murasu. The most prominent Kulal of the Sangam age is identified with the present flute. There were various types of Yal. The Mulavu (tabor) and the mulavu (drum) are the leather instruments. The mracu had played a prominent part in the royal activities.

Thus these evidences show clearly that the Tamils of the sangam age acquainted a remarkable skill in the field of music.

In view of the facts we have seen so far, it is clear that the fine arts such as Music, Dance and Drama as well as Painting and Sculpture were well developed during the Sangam age.

## 2.8 Summary

Thus the social order of the people was based either on the region in which they lived or on the occupation which they had adopted. The occupational or professional order in the long run became birth-based. Sangam Age people had a well- organized social life. They lived in both towns and rural areas.

## 2.9 Review Questions

1. Write a short note on Marudham region.
2. Explain about the caste system during the Sangam Age.
3. Write short note on a) Slavery b) Festivals. c) Hospitality.
4. Describe the customs and habits of the Sangam people.
5. Narrate the status of women during the Sangam age.
6. Discuss the growth of Fine arts during the Sangam age.

## 2.10 Answers to Review Questions

1. See the section 2.2
2. See the section 2.3
3. a) See the subsection 2.4.1  
b) See the subsection 2.4.7  
c) See the subsection 2.4.10
4. See the subsection 2.4.12
5. See the subsection 2.5.1
6. See the section 2.7

## **LESSON – 3**

# **ECONOMIC CONDITIONS –FOREIGN TRADE, ART AND CRAFTS, DURING THE SANGAM PERIOD**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Analyse the different kind of professions of the five regions of Ancient Tamils during the sangam age.
- ❖ Recall the port towns of the Sangam age.
- ❖ Examine the growth of both inland and foreign trade of the sangam age and
- ❖ Discuss the arts and crafts of the Sangam age.

### **Structure**

#### **3.1 Introduction**

#### **3.2 Agriculture**

##### **3.2.1 Cattle Breeding**

##### **3.2.2 Hunting**

##### **3.2.3 Fishing**

##### **3.2.4 Salt Manufacture**

##### **3.2.5 Textile industry**

##### **3.2.6 Sugarcane Industry**

##### **3.2.7 Pottery**

##### **3.2.8 Metal Carving and Cutting**

##### **3.2.9 Stone Cutting and Carving**

##### **3.2.10 Beads and Bangle-making Industry**

#### **3.3 Trade**

##### **3.3.1 Inland Trade**

##### **3.3.2 Foreign Trade**



### 3.3.3 Tamilaham and Rome

### 3.3.4 Coinage

## 3.4 Summary

## 3.5 Answers to Review Questions

## 3.1 Introduction

The Sangam economy was very simple. The Tamil society had enjoyed an affluent economy during the Sangam Age. Agriculture, industry, trade and commerce made the Sangam Tamils almost self-sufficient. Exports were also made to the other parts of the world.

## 3.2 Agriculture

### Agriculture

During the Sangam age and even afterwards agriculture was the main occupation of the Tamils. In the beginning the people cultivated some coarse varieties of paddy and other grains such as millets. Gradually the methods of cultivation had improved and during the sangam age, it had become well developed. The agriculturists in Sangam Age had maintained a respectable status among the people. Tirukkural, the scripture of the Tamils, praises the nature and importance of agriculture in an entire chapter.

Agriculture alone can save the mankind from the pangs of hunger and hence almost all the people have to depend either directly or indirectly on agriculturists. They alone can be generous as they have a good stock of grains always with them and the word “Velanmai” which denoted agriculture first, later denoted the hospitality. Pattinappalai speaks in detail about the public feeding twice. Ilango adigal says that the appeasement of the man’s appetite and the sustenance of the king’s prowess depend on the agriculture.

The Palar, the Pennar, the Kaveri, the Vaigai and the Tamraparani – to mention only the larger among the Tamil rivers sustained the fertility of the land. The delta region was very fertile. Pattinappalai says that cultivation was going on throughout the year without any interval, and hence the fields were always with one crop or the other. Paddy cultivation yielded an

enormous and surplus return. This helped the people to be self-sufficient in food, their vital need: and the surplus grains helped them to get sufficient money for their other necessary expenses and also improved their economic condition to some extent, besides improving the economic condition of the country also.

### **3.2.1 Cattle Rearing**

Cattle are closely connected with agriculture. Bulls and Buffaloes are much needed for agriculture. Besides this the milk and the milk-products are used as food. In those days there was a separate class of people set apart for the purpose. They were called ayar, Itaiyar, koval and Potuvar. Their main occupation was dairy farming and other allied works which provided their livelihood. The sale of milk and milk-products helped the people to improve their economic condition.

### **3.2.2 Hunting**

Hunting was the profession for the people who lived in the hilly tract and forest areas. It was also treated as a sport by the rich living in other parts of the country. Meat formed part of the daily food of the majority of the people and hunters had a good earning in those days. Besides, they had extract honey and ivory.

### **3.2.3 Fishing**

Fishing was an important occupation as it yielded much profit. The people who were engaged in fishing were called as 'minavar' and 'valaiyari'. They engaged themselves in pearl-fishing and collecting conch-shells, which fetched a fair fortune. They earned much by fishing and it was also an important occupation.

### **3.2.4 Salt Manufacture**

Salt was manufactured in coastal areas. Pattinappalai explains that salt was sold in exchange of paddy which was used as a measure of value then and the boats were used for the purpose. The people engaged in the salt trade were called "umanar". Building of boats and other industries flourished during the sangam age.

### **3.2.5 Textile industry**

Apart from agriculture, spinning and weaving were the most important and widely practiced crafts. Spinning was done by patient women in spare time. Uraiyur and Madurai were famous for weaving. The Periplus mentions the fineness of Tamil Textile Fabrics especially those of Uraiyur. We have abundant references in contemporary Tamil literature about the beauty and fitness of the textile products. The art of weaving attained a high degree of perfection. Weaving of complex patterns on both cotton and silk are mentioned in the Tamil Literature.

#### **1) Cotton Clothes**

There were varieties and grades with regard to cotton fabrics.

The cotton clothes were so nicely woven which looked like the slough of the snake or a cloud or smoke or stream. There were important centers of cotton textiles and saris. Uraiyur deserves special mention in this regard. Even today it ranks as the foremost centre of cotton saris.

#### **2) Silk Industry**

Silk Industry was also flourished and foreigners were interested in buying silk clothes. Silk clothes were variously known as Kosikam, Pithakam, Sunnam, Pedakam, Panakam, Vanadai, Ponnelluttu, Kaththulam etc. Kanchipuram was a popular centre of silk clothes and saris. Even today it is famous for silk. Pattukkottai was yet another center which seems to have attracted the Chinese traders. Embroidery cloth was used by them during the Sangam period.

#### **3) Dyeing**

Dyeing was a widespread ancillary industry to weaving: and the blue dye for the lenon cloth was a favourite colour with the consumers. The excavations conducted at places like Arikamedu and Uraiyur and from that they found about dyeing vats built with several course of bricks.

Thus we can conclude that next to Agriculture Textile industry provided employment opportunities and also developed the foreign trade.

### **3.2.6 Sugarcane Industry**

Pattinappalai reveals that there were sugarcane presses, where the juice was boiled and jaggery and sugar were prepared. The fragrant smoke coming out of the boiling juice made the lily flowers grown in the nearby fields, to grow pale and fade. This shows that the ancient Tamils were carrying on this industry as one of the main cottage industries which yielded them much profit.

### **3.2.7 Pottery**

Potters and their produce are mentioned in the Sangam literature. The art of making pottery was flourished as a cottage industry in the Sangam period. There were different ceramic industries prevalent and the techniques and methods employed in the industry were perfectly in tune with the demands of the people. Majority of the people commonly used these vessels. Due to demand supply has become more. Hence many people engaged in this profession. The art has reached perfection during the Sangam Age. But in the post sangam period these vessels slowly and steadily replaced by those made of metals like iron, copper, tin, lead etc. However, they continued to be used by the poor and in the rural even today.

### **3.2.8 Metal Carving and Cutting**

The Tamils developed advanced techniques in the field of metal carving and cutting. Metals like gold, silver, copper and iron were used in this industry. Ornaments were made out of both gold and silver. Bangles, beads and vessels were made out of copper. Iron was the most popular and common metal and was used for making objects of many kind. Agricultural equipment and articles of warfare were made out of iron. Iron was available in plenty in the country at that time. In the same manner gold mines were reported to have been identified in the Nilgris and the adjoining areas

Blacksmith rendered their effective service for the society. He was known as Kollan with the famous title Karungaikkollan (meaning the strong armed smith). The goldsmith, were called as Porkollan. Silapathikaram mentions about Porkollar for Goldsmith. He was the dealer in gold and manufacturer of jewels and ornaments. They have organized themselves into occupational group and lived in a separate block of quarters. . They were treated as low-born persons.

### 3.2.9 Stone Cutting and Carving

Stone Cutting and Carving was a yet another cottage industry and provided employment opportunity to the people. The semi-precious stones like Quartz, Jasper, beryl, crystal etc: where used for making beads and studs. We are able to get their beads and semi-precious stones from the excavation sites. From literary source we come to know that these ornaments were sent to North India.

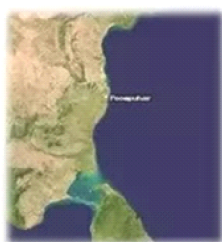
### 3.2.10 Beads and Bangle-making Industry

Beads and bangles were manufactured in a large scale out of gold, copper, glass, ivory and terracota. Shells beads and bangles were popular with women folk of the Sangam age, Bangles reached beyond seas and thus it led to the development of trade contacts.

## 3.3 Trade

Literature provides information about the extensive trade carried on those days in Tamilakam. It explains about the articles imported or exported at the Pukar port. Further in those days they had the trade with barter system.

### 3.3.1 Inland Trade



PAST - Remains Of The City Found Under The Sea !!!

#### THE LOST CITY - POOMPUHAR

(Also known as Puhar, Kaveripoompatinam )

❖ Located in the mouth of Kaveri , the city was washed by sea in 500BC

❖ Flourishing port city of the early Chola kingdom.

❖ Had 2 districts :Maruvurpakkam and Pattinapakkam

❖ Scientists believe the city was being washed out by

Tsunami caused by Krakatoa 416 AD.



PRESENT - PUHAR BEACH

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The inland trade was in a flourishing condition in the sangam age. Most of the trade was carried on by barter. Paddy got in barter of salt. Other commodities were also sold in barter. Peddlers used to sell paddy, millets, vegetables, liquor, etc. and occasionally clothes and ornaments also. The exchange of essential commodities such as paddy, salt, vegetable, etc. on a barter basis was Common in those days, especially in villages. Side by side there were bazaars and markets in towns and cities, where the monetary system was prevalent. We learn from sangam classics that the indigenous coins of Tamils were in use. Sangam classics reveal that paddy and salt were used as a measure of value. In early days, paddy and salt were given as wages.

There were bazaars markets in town. The bazaar or market is mentioned as “Angadi”. There were Nalangadi (day bazaar) and Allangadi (evening or night bazaar). In these markets such large varieties and large quantities of goods were sold and purchased. Crowds thronged into the markets for busy transactions. Silappadikaram gives a detailed description of the markets in the city of Puhar.

In Madurai people of many countries speaking many languages crowded for busy transactions. Especially foreigners who had come from outside Tamilaham made wholesale purchase of TAMILIAN goods for sale elsewhere. In the Allangadi or evening bazaar in Madurai the following people were busy in selling and buying; Namely the grocers, the sellers of couch-bangles, goldsmiths, appraisers of gold articles, sellers in foreign cloth, other textile dealers, sellers of copper wares, painters, and dealers in perfumes , flowers and sandal paste.

The following commodities were sold in the bazaar of Puhar: i.e. dyes, Scented powder, sandal paste, flowers and aromatic wood like ahil were sold in abundance .Silapathikaram reveals that flowers were greatly in demand especially during festivals and more particularly during the festival of Indra.

Normally textile dealers, sellers of perfumes, flowers sandal paste, scented-powder, sellers of salt, oil mongers, dealers in bronze and copper wares, carpenters, goldsmiths, artists like painters and sculptors, dealer in dolls, lapidaries, those that sold false hair or fashionable wigs, traders in sheep, fish and mutton and sellers of cakes and vegetable edibles thronged the

bazaar. Pattinappalai mentions the market place as 'avanam' and flags were flying in front of the shops indicating the sale of particular commodities and the poem also mentions the sale of salt, tasty victuals, fried fish and meat and toddy. The traders lived in separate streets. There were warehouses near the bazaar.

The merchants functioned often in a body. Apart from the tendency to associate as 'guilds' and 'chambers of commerce' the wandering hawkers literally went about in large numbers together. Such merchant bodies were called "Vanikachchattu" Such caravan of traders moved from place to place for business. They were escorted by the warriors. In spite of these protective measures, they were not free from danger from robber gangs.

The pearl of the Pandya kingdom has been a much desired article in the kingdoms of the Gangetic Valley. The Arthasastra of Kautilya mentions few commodities as coming from the land of the Pandyas namely Pearl and cotton fabric from Madurai.

Thus the Sangam people had brisk internal trade. The wholesalers, retailers and hawkers had indulged themselves in brisk trade. Barter system prevailed in internal trade. The business people sold their goods by openly announcing the profits that they were aiming at. Honest trade led to increased trade and the increased trade led to the increased prosperity. Integrity in trade was accepted as a general principle.

### **3.3.2 Foreign Trade**

From early times Tamilaham carried on an extensive trade with foreign countries. The great secret of her foreign trade is her possession of certain commodities which have always been in great demand in foreign markets: pepper, ginger and rice among food products: sandal wood, almug among trees: cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric among stimulating spices: Ivory and pearls for luxurious ornaments: cotton fabrics for dress: monkeys, deer and peacocks among favourite domesticated animals and birds, cheetahs, and tigers and elephants among the wild animals. These articles were in great demand in the crowded bazaars of foreign lands. It is certain that there was a well –developed maritime trade in Tamilaham during the Sangam age.

## 1) Hebrews

The most ancient trade contact Tamilaham had was with the ancient land of Hebrews. The Hebrew Bible mentions two important objects. They are “kapin” and “tukim”. Clearly Kapim is Kapi which is easily in Tamil Kavi i.e. Monkey and Tukim is the Tamil “togai” i.e. peacock.

## 2) Greece:

Tamil trade with Greece is amply borne out by the existence in Greek vocabulary of Tamil names of many objects: the Greeks have Oriza for “rice” from the Tamil arisi. Tamil “Chiruttai” became “cheetah” in English. “Corrundun” is clear transliteration of the Tamil “Kurundam”, Sandalwood was derived straight from “sandana” or “sandu”.

The pearl of the Pandya kingdom was a great attraction to foreigners in those days. Pliny mentions about cottonara as a centre of pepper trade. The place Cottanera is identified with kuttanad

## 3) Light House

Perumpanatrupadai mentions about the light houses in order to direct the ships. The light house was known as Kalangarai Illangusudar.

## 4) Harbour

Sangam literature and notes of foreigners refer to the harbours where foreign ships anchored. Puhar (Chola kingdom) alias Kaveripoompattinam, Musiri (Chera Kingdom) and Korkai (Pandya kingdom) were some of the noteworthy harbours of the sangam age.

## 5) Puhar (Kaveripoompattinam)

Puhar was a remarkable harbor of chola kingdom. Pattinappalai presents a vivid picture of the pukar port with the articles either imported or exported. Black pepper was brought by carts. Sandal and fragrant incense obtained from the eagle wood came from the western ranges. Pearl and red coral came from the southern and eastern seas respectively. Precious things from Ceylon and rare manufactured things from Burma also arrived. We learn from Purananuru that Mavilankai, Puraiyaru or Purunthai and Pokar were the important chola ports of those days.



## 6) Musiri

It was the gateway of western India on those days. Musiri was a busy harbor of chera kingdom. Purananuru mentions that several ships of Tamil Nadu were anchored there. Paddy (received in exchange of fish), pepper, golden articles, ivory, silk and pearls etc. were found in this harbor. Periplus states that these articles were exported.

## 7) Korkai

Korkai harbor was famous for its beautiful pearls. Periplus states that prisoners were employed to collect pearls and Korkai harbor belonged to the Pandya kingdom. Madurai Kanchi was all in praise for Korkai harbor. Korkai was also known for its Valamburi Sangu. Thus from the above account it is very obvious that the foreign trade of Sangam Tamilaham was very brisk and extensive.

The people of the Sangam age traded with Rome, Greece, Africa, Sri Lanka and South East Asia. The Romans liked the pearls of the Pandya kingdom. Gemstones, ivory, sandalwood, peacock, cotton and silks, textiles and spices were exported to Greece and Rome. Many gold and silver coins that were issued by the Roman Emperors like Augustus, Tiberius and Nero have been found in all parts of Tamil Nadu indicating flourishing trade. Major exports of the Sangam age were cotton fabrics and spices like pepper, ginger, cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric along with ivory products, pearls and precious stones. Major imports for the traders were horses, gold, and sweet wine.

Thus Trade was a great source of income to the Government by way of duties and tolls and hence it was the main source of country's economy. Considering all these above mentioned facts, it may be said that the economic condition of the country was sound.

### 3.3.3 Tamilaham and Rome

We find large hoards of Roman Gold coins of the Augustan Age in many parts of South India. This shows that the Sangam people had brisk trade with Rome which resulted in the inflow of considerable gold into Tamilaham. Periplus says that Tamilaham had a direct trade route to Arabia, Egypt and Rome. One of the most important articles which came from India was cotton and perhaps silk.

The eastern trade beyond **Tamilaham** with Burma, Malaya, Java, Sumatra and china was mostly in the hands of the Tamils. Strabo says that 120 ships sailed to South India from Harmuz and he saw a Pandiyan embassy at the Royal Court of Augustus. There was a brisk trade in silk with China besides sugar. Greeks and Romans came to Tamilaham as traders but soon arose many commercial colonies in **Tamilaham**. Greek merchants were called “Yavanas” first, subsequently it was applied to Romans, still later to all foreigners including the Arabs. The foreign merchants moved about the bazaars freely and transacted business. There might have been translators to help them in their transactions.

### 3.3.4. Coinage

Apart from the barter system coins were also used as medium of exchange in Trade. The local coins were known as “punch mark coins” and were made out of silver, copper and lead. They bear punch marks or symbols such as sun, moon, river, tree in railing, mountain etc. Besides these gold coins, known as Kalanju and Pon were also used by the Sangam Tamils. In Puhar and in Madurai mints were situated

## 3.4 Summary

The Sangam people had brisk trade. The wholesalers, retailers and hawkers had indulged themselves in brisk trade. Barter system prevailed in internal trade. The business people sold their goods by openly announcing the profits that they were aiming at. Honest trade led to increased trade and the increased trade led to the increased prosperity. Integrity in trade was accepted as a general principle.

## 3.5 Review Questions

1. Write a short note on
  - a) Cattle Breeding
  - b) Fishing and Salt manufacture of Neidal region
  - c) Metal carving and cutting industry
2. Explain about the importance of agriculture of the Sangam Age

3. Trace the growth of Textile industry in the Sangam Age
4. Write a short note on
  - a) Puhar
  - b) Musiri
  - c) Tamilakam and Rome
5. Explain about the importance of internal trade of the sangam age.
6. Describe the foreign trade in the Sangam Age

### **3.6 Answers to Review Questions**

1.
  - a) See the subsection 3.2.1
  - b) See the subsections 3.2.3 & 3.2.4
  - c) See the subsection 3.2.7
2. See the section 3.2
3. See the subsection 3.2.5
4.
  - a) See the subsection 3.3.2 (5)
  - b) See the subsection 3.3.2 (6)
  - c) See the subsection 3.3.3
5. See the subsection 3.3.1
6. See the subsections 3.3.2 and 3.3.2(1) to (7)

## **LESSON – 4**

# **LITERATURE, RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY IN THE SANGAM PERIOD**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Highlight the importance of Sangam literature
- ❖ Explain the religious condition of the ancient Tamils during the sangam age
- ❖ Analyze the beliefs of Ancient Tamils on superstitions, the cult of spirits, ghosts and demons

### **Structure**

#### **4.1 Introduction**

#### **4.2 Literature**

##### **4.2.1 Tolkappiam**

##### **4.2.2 Eight Anthology**

##### **4.2.3 Pattupattu**

##### **4.2.4 Eighteen Minor works**

##### **4.2.5 Post-Sangam Works**

#### **4.3 Religion and Philosophy**

##### **4.3.1 Method of worship**

##### **4.3.2 Temples**

##### **4.3.3 Supernatural Elements**

##### **4.3.4 Beliefs and Superstitions**

##### **4.3.5 Jainism**

##### **4.3.6 Ajivikas**

##### **4.3.7 Buddhism**

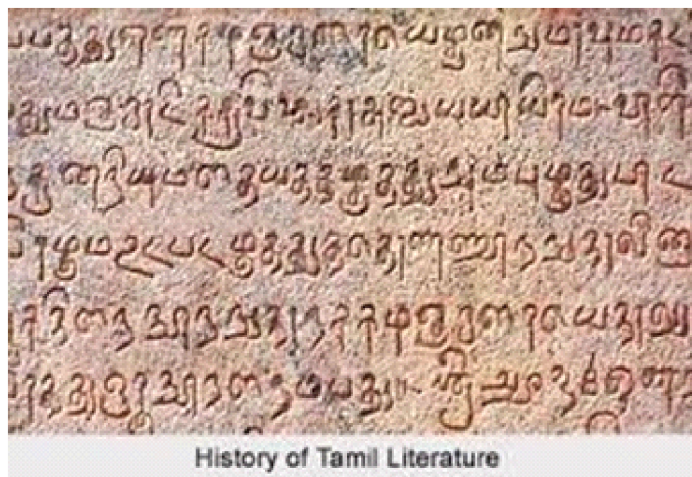
#### **4.4 Summary**

#### **4.5 Answers to Review Questions**

## 4.1 Introduction

Sangam literature can be considered as the more valuable and most reliable source for the study of the Sangam Age. Sangam poets were not inhibited by excessively religious or any other extraneous sentiments. The verses of Sangam poets belonged to a spontaneous and natural type of poetry which is free from exaggeration and unnatural hyperbole, and by the simplicity and directness, of smiles they serve as a useful and dependable source of history of Tamil Nadu. The Tamil Sangam period has been truly called the “Augustan age” of Tamil literature.

## 4.2. Literature



The Sangam literature consists of Tolkappiam, the Pattuppattu (the ten Idylls), the Ettuttokai (the Eight Anthologies) and the Patintnkilkanakku (Eighteen minor works) and the Twin epics namely Silappadikaram and Manimegalai.

The subject matter of Sangam literature is divided into two broad divisions namely Akam and Puram and they are called as Akattinai and Purattinai. Akam speaks about love whereas Puram deals with other worldly affairs such as war, Government, society, etc.

### 4.2.1 Tolkappiam

Tolkappiam is the oldest Tamil Grammar. In fact it is the oldest extant Tamil Work .Its author was Tolkappier. It is divided into three major parts called Eluttu Adikaram, Sol Adikaram,

and Porul Adikaram. Each Adikaram consists of 9 Iyals and in all 1612 Sutrās. It is the traditional method of expounding Tamil Grammar. Porul Adikaram reveals to us the Sangam Tamils concept and practice of warfare in an elaborate manner.

#### **4.2.2. Eight Anthologies**

Of the eight Anthologies Narrinai, Kuruntogai, Ainkurunuru, Ahananuru and Kalitogai belonged to the Aham group. Purananuru, Padirrupattu and Paripadal belonged to the Puram group

##### **(1) Narrinai**

It consists of 400 stanzas: which explains about all the five Tināis. 275 poets wrote these poems. The important name of the sea ports and other big towns are found in this work. Tondi, Korkai, Kunrur etc. are some of them. This work was compiled by Pannadu Tanta Maran Valuti.

##### **(2) Kurunthogai**

205 poets composed all the 402 poems of this work. Purikko Patronised and Purikkudi Kilar compiled these songs. The poems of Atimantiyar, Iraiyanar, and Velliivitiyar are found in the Kuruntogai. The names of the rulers like Ori, Pari, Nalli etc., and Places like Srimallur, Urantai, and Mantari are found. The social life of the Sangam Age is beautifully described in this work.

##### **(3) Ainkurunuru**

The poets Orampogiyar, Ammuvar, kapilar, Otalantaiyar and Peyanar composed 500 poems, in five divisions of 100 poems each, describing the five Tināis. These poems were compiled by Pulatturai Murriya Kudalur Kilar. The characters of the three rulers were described in these poems. The socio-economic lives of the people are narrated in this work.

##### **(4) Ahananuru**

It deals with all the five Tināis. It consists of 400 poems. Otherwise Ahananuru is known as Neduntogai. This work was written by 145 poets and was compiled by Ukkirapperuvaluti. Mauryan invasion of South India is referred in this work by Mamulanar.

### **(5) Kalithogai**

It consists of 250 poems dealing with five Tinais. There are different views about the author of the poem.. Some of the social customs and practices were depicted in this work. References to the worship of Tirumal, Balaraman, Siva and Murugan are found in Kalithogai.

### **(6) Padirrupattu**

It is a quasi-historical collection of Ten Ten of verses composed by the different poets. Each poem depicts about a chera monarch. Karur, Musiri, Tondi are some of the important places of Cheras, Utiyam Cheral, Imayavaramban, Nedunchelyan Cheran Senguttuvan etc., are some of the Chera Kings. Further it speaks about the rulers patronization of the Tamil poets.

### **(7) Purunanuru**

Each of 400 stanzas of Purananuru contains between 4 and 40 lines. 160 poets composed these songs. These poems were composed in honour of 18 Chera rulers, 18 Chola rulers, 15 Pandiya rulers and a number of Chieftains of Tamilaham. This work serves as an important source material to trace the History of Sangam rulers namely chera, chola and Pandiya

### **(8) Paripadal**

It deals with both Aham and Puram. Though it consists of 70 poems we were able to get only 22 poems. This literary work helps us to trace the socio-religious life of the Sangam Tamils. The worship of Tirumal, Murugan, and Korravai were described in this work.

### **4.2.3 Pattupattu**

Pathupattu is an anthology of ten mid-length books and one of the oldest surviving works of Tamil poetry. They are Thirumurukarruppadai, Porunararruppadai, Sirupanarruppadai, Perumpanarruppadai, Mullaippattu, Maduraikkanchi, Nedulvadai, Kurinjippattu, Pattinappalai and Malaipadukadam.

These works are composed in aciriyam or akarvapa which has three lines as minimum and thousand lines as maximum. Among the Ten Idyls, five belongs to Aaturpadai.

Aatrupadai means a literary device by which a bard or a minstrel who has received gifts from some wealthy patron is supposed to direct another to the same patron. This gives the occasion to the poet, among other topics, to describe in great detail the natural beauty, fertility, and resources of the territory that has to be traversed to reach the palace of the patron

### **(1) Thirumurukarruppadai:**

*This work contains 317 lines, composed by Nakkirar, is a devotional song on Lord Murugan. The author depicts the way to a devotee to attain the supreme bliss of Lord Murugan at the six places called Arupadaividu. Six Abodes of Muruga are: Thirupparamkunram Thiruverakam (Swamimalai), Thiruaavinankudi (Palani), Thirucheeralaivaai (Thiruchendur), Kundruthoraadal (Tiruttani) and Pazhamudircholai.*

### **(2) Porunararruppadai**

Porunararruppadai, with 248 lines praising the famous chola king Karikal Valavan was composed by Mutattamak kanniyar.

Porunaraatruppadai contains 250 lines of poems in the Achiriyappa meter. The poems were written by the poet Mutathaamakkanniyaar in praise of the Chola king KarikalaChola. Porunaraatruppadai belongs to the Ten Idyls collection and follows the Arrupadai style, a device used by most of the books in the Pattupattu collection

### **(3) Sirupanarruppadai**

Sirupanarruppadai, with 269 lines praising Nalliyak Kotan, a chieftain under the chola king was composed by Nallur Nattattanar. The poverty life of Paradavar, the virali and her dance are given.

### **(4) Perumpanarruppadai**

Perumpanarruppadai contains 500 lines of poetry in the Achiriyappa meter. The poems were written by the poet Uruttirankannanar in praise of King Tondaiman Ilandiraiyan. Perumpanarruppadai belongs to the Ten Idyls collection and follows the Arrupadai style, a device used by most of the books in the Pattupattu collection. The work mentions how a brother of an ancient Chola king met with a Naga princess and had by him a son. The son was affectionately called Ilam Tiraiyan or literally the Young Tiraiyan by the family. Tiraiyar was the name of the



naga tribe to which his mother belonged. Over the course of time he went on to rise to the position of the Lord of Thondaimandalam and took on the title Tondaiman.

### **(5) Mullaippattu**

*Mullaippattu, with 103 lines, the shortest among the verses of Ten Idyls, is based on the subjective element of Mullaittinai.* The composer is Nappoothanaar. It speaks about the mental condition of a separated wife from her husband who was away in the battlefield. Mullaippattu is a pure love poem, and talks about the heroine longing for the hero who had left her to fight a war. In the olden days, the soldiers use to come back to their home country during the rainy season to look after their primary profession of agriculture. The heroine laments that although the rainy season had already started, that her lover had not returned from battle. The description of the country in the rainy season is particularly enjoyable in this book.

### **(6) Maduraikkanchi**

*Maduraikkanchi, with 782 lines, is the longest among the ten idylls based on the subjective element of Kanchittinai, which belongs to Puram.* Kanchittinai indicates the mortality of human beings. The poems were written by the poet Mangudi Maruthanaar in praise of the Pandya king Nedunjeliyan II on the occasion of his victory at the battle of Talayanankanam. The author by way of praising the Pandyan king presents a detailed description of his kingdom, his administration and his capital Madurai.

### **(7) Nedulvadai**

*Nedulvadai* is a part of the Ten Idyls collection, which is the oldest available collection of long poems in Sangam Tamils. *Nedulvadai*, with 188 lines, was composed by the poet Nakkirar is based on the subject element of Mullaittinai, which belongs to Aham. But it contains an indirect reference to Pandiyan king who was away in the war front and hence it is considered to be of Vakaittinai, which is part of Purattinai.

### **(8) Kurincippattu**

Kurinippattu with 262 lines is based on the subjective element of Kurunchit tinai that is pre-marital love or love at first sight. This contains a fine description of mountain scenery and

speaks about as many as ninety nine flowers including Kurinchi flower which will blossom once in twelve years and they are found largely on the Western Ghats especially on the Nilgris. This was composed by Kapilar in order to impart Tamil knowledge to Prakattan, an Aryan king.

### **(9) Pattinappalai**

This love poem was composed by Uruthirankannanar. Pattinappalai with 301 lines, a fairly long verse, has a fine picture of Kaveripumpattinam and its suburbs, which was then Chola capital and the main sea-port: it also gives a detailed account of the destruction caused by Tirumavalavan the pattutai talavan to his enemy's countries. The splendor of river Kaveri, the rich seaborne trade and the flags flying aloft over the city are vividly described.

### **(10) Malaipatukadam**

It is also known as Kuttarruppadai. Malaipatukadam with 583 lines, the second longest among the Ten Idylls is composed on the lines of Arruppadai style. It was sung by Perunkunur Perunkausikar. In this poem a bard who received gifts from Nanan directs a dancer and his group to the same patron for the purpose of receiving gifts. It also describes the lifestyle of the folk dancers of the ancient Tamil country.

#### **4.2.4 Patinenkilkanakku**

Patinenkilkanakku is a collection of eighteen poetic works created during the Sangam period. The poems are written in the Venba meter and are relatively short in length. Most of the books deal with morals and ethics. Patinenkilkanakku contains the following books: Nalatiyar, Nanmanikkadigai, Inna Narpadu, Iniyavi Narpadu, Kar Narpadu, Kalavali Narpadu, Ainthinai Aimpadu, Thinaimoli Aimpadu, Ainthinai Elupadu, Tinaimalai Nurrumbadu, Tirukkural, Tirukadigam, Achara kovai, Palamoli, Sirupanchamulam, Mutumolikanchi, Elathi and Kainnilai.

### **(1) Nalatiyar**

It was composed by padumanar. It consists of 40 chapters. Each chapter contains ten stanzas. It also deals with Aram, Porul and Inbam. Certain social customs of the people regarding wedding, serving food to the poor in the backyard, disposal of the dead are described in this work.

## **(2) Nanmanikkadigai**

Nanmanikkadigai is a Tamil poetic work belonging to the Eighteen minor works anthology of Tamil literature contains one hundred songs written by the poet Vilambi Naganaar. Since this poem is famous and easy to understand, this work is included in the school Tamil Nadu text books. Each poem of Nanmanikkadigai contains four different ideas. The name Nanmanikkadigai denotes the fact that comparing of the four ideas to four well-chosen gems adorning each poem.

## **(3) Inna Narpadu**

This poem comes under eighteen minor works. It was authored by Kapilar. It is a collection of 40 poems describing the most undesirable things one should avoid. One of the meanings of the Tamil word Inna is one that brings displeasure. This poem indicates about four harmful things one has to avoid in their life namely a beautiful and disloyal wife, the wealth of a miser, a life under tyrant and a beauty of a flower without fragrance.

## **(4) Iniyavi Narpadu**

Iniyavi Narpadu is a Tamil poetic work belonging to Patinenkilkanakku work. . This poem belongs to sangam period. It is a collection of forty poems written by the poet Putham Sernthanar. It describes the most desirable things in life. They have adopted the Venba meter for their poems. This collection is very similar to Inna Narpadu. This work says that four categories of things one should have in life for example: learning even at the time of begging, to listen to the advice of learned persons, healthy children and strength to not covet other's spouse.

Thus both Iniyavi Narpadu, and Inna Narpadu explains in concise and simple manner narrates about the moral codes essential for an individual as well as to the society. Further these works insisting about the importance of education and individual responsibility in society.

## **(5) Kar Narpadu**

This work comes under the eighteen minor works of the sangam age and it contains forty poems written by the poet Kannankoothanaar .The poet belonged to Madurai region. The

poem deals with Ahattinnai and it narrates about the subjects like the intangibles of life such as human emotions, love, separation, lover's quarrels, etc. Many poems explain about how the heroine was consoled by her friend by way of describing the beauties of the rainy season. Here we should know the meaning of Kar namely rain in Tamil.

### **(6) Kalavazhi Narpathu**

Kalavazhi Narpathu work belongs to Sangam age. This work contains forty poems and the author of this work was the poet Poigayaar. The poem deals with Purattinnai. It deals with the subjects like war, politics, wealth, etc.

### **(7) Ainthinai Aimpathu**

Ainthinai Aimpathu contains fifty poems written by the poet Kannankoothanaar who was from Madurai. The poems of, Ainthinai Aimpathu, deal with the agam (internal) subjects. Agam denotes the subject matters that deal with the intangibles of life such as human emotions, love, separation, lovers' quarrels, etc. The poems of Ainthinai Aimpathu are divided into ten poems for each of the five thinai, of Sangam poetry and describe in detail the situation and emotions specific to each division of the land.

### **(8) Tinamalai Aimpathu**

Tinamalai Aimpathu contains fifty poems. This work was written by the poet Kannan Chenthanaar. The poem deals with Ahattinnai namely internal subjects of human beings. This was divided into ten poems for each of five thinai of Sangam age namely Kurinji, Mullai, Marudham, Neydal and Palai.

### **(9) Ainthinai Elupadu**

This work contains seventy poems written by the poet Muvathiyaar. This work deals with Ahattinnai of sangam age. Aham denotes the subject matters that deal with the intangibles of life such as human emotions, love, separation, lovers' quarrels, etc. The poems of Ainthinai Elupatu are divided into fourteen poems for each of the five thinai, of Sangam poetry and describe in detail the situation and emotions specific to each division of the land . They are mullai, kurinji, marutham, paalai and neithal.

### **(10) Thinaimalai Nurru Aimpathu**

This work contains 154 poems. This poem was authored by the poet Kanimeythaviyaar. These poems dealt with Ahattinnai of sangam Tamils. Tilaimalai NurruAimpatu poems are categorized into 30 poems for each of the five Tinnai. It explains in detail about the situation and emotion specific to each thinnai.

### **(11) Tirukkural**

**Thirukkural** poem consists of 1330 couplets divided into 133 chapters. This work was divided into three broad divisions namely Aram, Porul and Inbam. . It deals with everyday virtues of an individual. It is considered as one of the best Secular work in Tamil literature. Thiruvalluvar was the author of this work. More than hundred scholars have written the summary for this work. It has been translated into nearly forty languages. The Kural has influenced many scholars across the ethical, social, political, economical, religious, philosophical, and spiritual spheres. In order to honour the author recently the Tamil Nadu Government erected a 133 feet statue in the Kanyakumari sea shore.

### **(12) Tirukadugam**

This poem contains 100 poems. The author of this work was Nallathanaar. The poems of Tirukadugam are written in Venba meter. Tirukadugam uses the analogy of the traditional herbal medicine, which uses the three herbs namely sukku, milaku, and thippili to cure diseases of the stomach. Tirukadugam similarly uses three different varieties to explain the correct behaviour.

### **(13) Acharakkovai**

Acharakkovai contains 100 poems written by the poet Peruvaayin Mulliyaar. The poems of Acharakkovai are written in the Venba meter. . Acharakkovai shows the influence of Sanskrit literature and hence believed to be of a later period than the other poems in the Pathinenkilkanakku works. The instructions in Acharakkovai are concerned with personal ritual and the correct method to follow. Acharakkovai has 100 stanzas in venba meter

### **(14) Palamoli**

It consists of 400 verses each of which embodies a proverb. The author of this work was Munrurayanar. There are incidental references to the chera, chola and Pandya kings and some of the important customs of the Sangam Tamils.

### **(15) Sirupanchamulam**

Kaniyasan composed 97 stanzas which insist the codes of moral conduct, truth, honesty, vegetarianism and non-injury to animals are some of the important virtues emphasized in this work. The value of education, the qualities expected of an ideal teacher, the pupil of the housewife are described in this poem.

### **(16) Mudumozhikkanchi**

Mudumozhikkanchi belongs to the post sangam period. This work contains 100 poems. The author of this work was the poet Mathuraikkoodalur Kilaar. From this title we infer that he would have lived in Madurai. Mudumozhikkanchi was divided into ten groups of ten poems each. Further this work followed a simple poetic style to enable the lay person to understand the messages,

### **(17) Elathi**

Elathi contains 80 poems. This poem was written by the poet Kani Methaviyar. Elathi emphasizes the use of the traditional herbal medicine known as elathi which uses six herbs such as elam ,ilavanka pattai , milagu , thippili , and sukku . It also instruct us about six values of every aspects of life in every poem in four lines. The six values are fame, wealth, integrity, courage, education and philanthropy.

### **(18) Kainnilai**

Kainnilai is the last work in Pathinenkilkanakku. It contains 60 poems and the author of this work was the poet Pullangkaathanaar. Unfortunately this work is available in a damaged condition with many of its poems only partially available. This work deals with Ahattinnai. The poems are divided into twelve poems for each of the five thinnai namely Kurinchi, Mullai, Marudham, Neydal and Palai.

#### **4.2.5 Post-Sangam works**

Next important works in the sangam age are the twin epics. Silappathikaram and Manimegalai are known as Twin epics.

#### **Silappathikaram**

The author of this work was Elango Adigal, brother of chera king Senguttuvan, The reason for writing this epic is mentioned by the author in the following lines: The theme of the epic is based on Silambu (anklet). It is woven around Kovalan a rich merchant of Puhar, Kannagi his wife, and Madhavi, a dancing girl.

Silappathikaram as a literary work is held in high regard by the Tamil people. This work was divided into three divisions namely Puharkantam, Maduraikantam and Vanchikantam and has a total of 5270 lines of poetry. The story of this work involves the three Tamil kingdoms of the sangam age which were ruled by the Chola, Pandiya and Chera dynasties.

This epic explains in detail about Tamil culture and their religion the town planning and city types and the arts of dance and Music. Thus Silappathikaram serves us as a useful source material to study about the socio-economic conditions and political conditions of the Sangam age.

#### **Manimegalai**

Manimegalai is one of the Twin epics. Its author was Chithalai Chathanar. This epic contains 30 cantons. Its story is a sequel of Silappathikaram. . This epic narrates the story of Manimegalai. She was the daughter of Kovalan and Madhavi. She was a devotee of Buddhism and hence naturally this work provides a vivid exposition of the Philosophical doctrines of Buddhism. It also contains an exposition of logical fallacies.

### **4.3 Religion and Philosophy**

Religion played a predominant role in the Sangam society. Sangam literature provides a perfect conception of the various faiths followed in the Sangam age. It speaks about the rustic form of Varunan worship by the fishermanfolk as well as the civilized form of Murugan worship

by the citizens of Puhar. Sangam classics present a vivid picture of the primitive form of kantu worship of linga worship of the early Tamils. Beyond all these we see Pallis or the hermitages of the Jains and Buddhists.

Tolkappiyar makes a reference to Kadavul means “He that transcends thought, word, and deed” He makes a reference in another place about four Gods namely Mayon (Thirumal) the God of the Mullai region, Seyon (Murugan) of Kurinji God, Vendan (Indra) the deity of Marudham and Varunan (rain God) the deity of Neydal. Murugan was considered as the God of Kurinji region, but at the same time, he was considered as a favourite God of Tiruchendur located in Neydal region. Though Korravai the Goddess of Palai or the desert region has no mention in Tolkaippiyam, she is accepted as the goddess of war and victory by literature.

### **(1) Murugan**

Kurinji people worshipped Murugan or Seyon. The term Murugan means beauty, youth and charm. He was worshipped as a war God. Nallantuvanar a Sangam poet says that Murukan is the lord of the seven worlds. The “vel” (spear) is his favourite weapon, and from its name he is called as “Velan”. Undoubtedly Murugan was the favourite God of the Tamils. The worship of Murugan was done in the entire Sangam period Korravai is often mentioned as the mother of Murugan. In Thirumurgarruppadai he has been referred as Muruku and explained as a God of beauty and youth with phrases such as “the body glows like the sun rising from the emerald sea”. Further this text explains him with six faces each with a function, twelve arms, his victory over evil, and the temples dedicated to him in the hilly region. For example Thirumurgarruppadai states that Murugan resides in the six sacred military camps of Tirupparankunram, Tiruchchiralaivai, Tiruvavinankudi, Tiruveragam, Pazhamudirsolai and Kunrutordal Muruga’s vehicle is pea-cock, which is associated with snake. Lord Murugan wears Kadamba garland. According to Sangam classics, the Murukan worship was predominant in almost all the regions.

### **2) Mayon (Tirumal)**

Mayon was known as Mal or Tirumal. There are six verses in Paripadal exclusively intended for Tirumal. The term “mal” means great and hence Tirumal may mean the great God. He is also known as Vishnu from which the term Vaishnavism was derived. This deity is referred to in



Sangam classics such as Purananuru, Paripadal, Kalittokai and Mullaippattu as well as Silappatikaram. He was the prominent God of the Idaiyars of Mullai region. His vehicle is Eagle.

Various incarnations of Vishnu were known to the Sangam Tamils. Varaha, Narasimha, Vamana, Balarama, Krishna, Rama, Parasurama are mentioned in the Sangam literature. Rama was the great hero who defeated Ravana. Parasurama was the one who had a battle axe in his hand. Balarama was the elder brother of Krishna. Krishna saved the people from a severe downpour. Krishna the incarnation of Vishnu is worshipped by all people who had accepted Vaishnavism.

### **3) Indran**

Indra was the deity of fertile soil. In some of the Sangam literary works, the name of Indra is mentioned. Silappatikaram describes Indran as "Maalai venkudai mannavan, literally meaning Indra with pearl garland and white umbrella. His vehicle was the elegant white elephant (Airavatha). Puhar, the coastal city celebrated a festival for Indra. This festival is mentioned in Silappatikaram as Indhira vizha in detail. This festival was celebrated for want of rain.

### **4) Varunan**

Neithal thinnai is known for its seashore place occupied by fishermen, with God of Sea and rain known as Varunan or Kadalon. Pattinappalai narrates about the pen-picture of the Varuna worship offered by the fishermen folk. The full moon day was an auspicious day to worship Varuna, the sea God. On that day the fishermen neglected fishing in the dark wide sea and erected a horn or sword of a gravid shark as a symbol of Varuna and worshipped with offerings of food (meat and Fish) and drink (toddy).

### **5) Sivan**

Siva is one of the great Gods of Tamils and some uphold that he is the supreme among them. The Tamils of the Sangam age considered Siva as one of the four supreme deities, others being Murugan, Tirumal and Valiyon. It is said that Murugan is son of Siva, hence he is called as Cey or Ceyon but he held primordial position among other deities. During the Sangam age

no doubt Siva held a secondary position to Murukan. Nakkirar describes these four as the props of universe. It is said that Siva has an eye on his forehead and hence he is known as Nerrikkannan or Mukkannan- the God of three eyes. His favourite weapon is Trident. Siva is also known as Nataraja on account of his dances which are called kotukotti, Kapali and Pantarankan. Although these dances belong to the Tamil conception they flourished only after the sangam age. Invariably no temple of Siva will be without a Linga at the sanctum sanctorum of the temple and the Linga itself is called "Sivalingam".

## **6) Korravai**

Korravai was the Goddess of Palai region. She was known as Palaivol {AncientGoddess}. She was the presiding deity of the Palai region and was worshipped by the hunters. She was worshipped by the Tamils for achieving victory in battles and for fulfilling their wishes. She was surrounded by ghosts which perform the Tunankai dance. She was also believed to be residing in the weapons of war belonging to the warriors. She is mentioned as the mother of Murukan. Veriyadal was performed before her. Sacrifices were performed.

## **7) Thirumakal**

Pattinappalai refers to Goddess Tirumakal. In sangam classics they refer the term "tiru" means Tirumakal (Lakshmi), wealth and beauty. Manimekalai mentions about the Goddess as Ilakkumi. She is said to be the wife of Mayon and goddess of wealth, prosperity, good fortunes as well as beauty. Kapilar the sangam poet describes that Tirumakal seated on a lotus flower had been worshipped by elephants with water and flowers.

## **8) Brahman**

Brahma is described as a four-headed God. He is also called Mamudu Mudiycvan and so on. It is mentioned that Brahma himself emerged from the lotus which sprouted from the navel Tirumal. Saraswathi, the consort of Brahma is not mentioned in any work.

## **9) Kaman**

Kaman or Manmatha is the Hindu God of human love or desire, often portrayed along with his female counterpart Rathi. His parents were Lord Vishnu and Goddess Lakshmi. Sugarcane, bow and floral arrow are his weapons.

## **10) Yaman**

Yamaraja is a God of death, the south direction is His place. According to Vishnu purana Yama is the son of Sun God –Surya.

## **11) Balaraman**

Balarama otherwise called Valiyon was the elder brother of lord Krishna.. Ploughshare is mentioned as his weapon. . Silappadikaram refers to a temple for Valiyon.

## **12) Sun and Moon**

Sun who was considered to be the greatest of the Devas, was also worshipped like all other Gods. Worship of crescent moon was common. Sun was first worshipped before doing any offering to God or Goddesses. Silappadikaram begins with a prayer to Sun God.

## **13) Ancestor Worship**

Ancestor worship in some form or the other seems to be flourished in the early days and this might have been emerged as the hero-worship that is the worship of “natukal” or the memorial stone which is also known as “virakkal” or hero stone.

## **14) Sadukkabudam and Sattan**

The early Tamils believed that Sadukkabudam resided on the cross roads in Kaviripumpattinam. This deity is known from Silappadikaram and Muchukunda brought the Sadukkabudam from heaven and installed in Manimegalai. The Sangam people believed that this deity would kill bad people like an unchast woman, a liar and a disloyal minister. Maduraipatti was the guardian of the city of Madurai. In Silappadikaram this deity appears and tells Kannagi the events of her previous births. The Koillppavai was a very ferocious deity resided in the Kolli hills.

Sattan was another local deity worshipped by the Sangam people. . He was also known as Sasta, Aiyandar, Aiyappa or Hariharaputra, the sons of Siva and Vishnu. Sattan was one of the names associated with the lord Buddha. It is known that the Vaishnavites treated the Lord Buddha as one of the avatars of Vishnu himself.

## **15) Kandu and Linga**

The early Tamils planted a big stump of wood and made offerings to that. This stump of wood was known as Kandu and the Tamils believe that God resided in it. Some scholars are of the opinion that Siva in the form of Linga was worshipped by the Tamils. Some other scholars do not accept this phallic form of Siva as there is no reference in Sangam literature to Linga.

## **16) Nature Worship**

Apart from sun and moon, Sangam Tamils worshipped Rivers, Mountains and Stars. It was believed that the trees were the abodes of some deities. Banyan tree was associated with Lord Siva and Vishnu. Kadamba tree was connected with Murugan and Korravai with Siva. Elephants and bulls were animals of worship as they were the vahanas of Gods. They also worshipped snake. They made offerings to the snake pits and these offerings by the Tamilians are following even today.

### **4.3.1 Method of Worship**

Lamps were lighted during the time of worship Flowers and Garlands were offered and this was known as Puppali. Food was also offered to the deity.

Nadukal worship was common in the Sangam age. The Tamils bathed the deity, offered peacock feathers and flowers. Toddy and rice balls sprinkled with blood of sacrificed animals were also offered. The drum used in the battlefield was also worshipped. The devotees bowed down in reverence before the deity.

People kept images of Gods in their houses and worshipped them. The images were known as Paai. The deities were worshipped during sunset. Lamps were lit at dusk and prayers were offered. Invocation to God at the beginning of all important ceremonies, praying for their successful completion was the common practice of the time.

The Brahmins followed slightly a different practice. They chanted the Vedas and Mantras. At the time of prayer, the adult Brahmins were found with their sacred thread. They performed sacrifices to ensure prosperity to the people. The Tamil rulers were also performed many yagas. For example Palyagasalai Mudukudumi Peruvalusi set up numerous sacrificial places.

. Animals were also offered for sacrifices. The construction of pillars in the yagasala and the chanting of mantras by the Brahmins are explained in the sangam Tamil works.

### **4.3.2 Temples**

Tamil literary works mentions temple as Kovil or Kottam From silappadikaram we come to know that there were temples dedicated to Airavata, baladeva, Surya, Siva, Murukan, Kaman, yaman, Sattan and so on. Manimekalai mentions about Durga temple. It also mentions about Jaina Pallis and Buddhist Viharas. Both the epics Silappadikaram and Manimekalai mentions about the temple for Indra. Senguttuvan is said to have constructed a temple for Kannagi, the chaste Goddess.

For the construction of the temples they used perishable materials hence we are not able to have these temples in Tamil Nadu. Reference to brick temple with gopuras is found in Manimekalai. Flags were waving on temple tops. The place where the offerings were placed was called Balipidhai.

### **4.3.3 Supernatural Elements**

Animism is essentially the cult of spirits which are believed to exist in the shape of demons, Ghosts and souls which are not visible to the human eye. The ancient Tamils believed that ghosts with disheveled hair wandered about. They hunted the battle fields and reveled in playing with the corpses of the dead soldiers. It is believed that ghosts were connected with the life after death because ghosts were imagined to see the living spirits of dead persons.

The Sangam Tamils believed in the heaven and hell. They also believed that by performing penance one could attain heaven. Siva, the God of destruction in the Hindu trinity was the God of controlling death. The early Tamils believed that the infants could easily affected by the ghosts. In order to safe guard from the ghosts the people used to worship village deities. They also used white mustard in order to protect them against ghosts.

### **4.3.4 Superstitious Beliefs**

The Tamils had many beliefs and like most ancients were to a great measure Superstitious. They believed in the significance of dreams which they thought would always come true. They

felt that the exact time when a dream would be realized depended on the Jamam (the quarter of the night) in which it occurred. A dream of the first quarter of the night was expected to be effective in a year: that of the second quarter in eight months: that of the third quarter in three months and that of the last quarter in ten days. For instance the dreams of Kannagi and Kooperundevi become true very early. The following were considered as bad Omens by the Sangam Tamils and it was referred in Purananuru; i.e. the hooting of birds as bad omen, the falling of burning logs in all directions, riding a pig, seeing one naked and oneself taking oil-bath.

According to Ahananuru, the Tamils had profound faith in certain other omens also. The lizard creeping along the steep wall was watched for the direction from which it hooted. It was known as "Asariri. Kalithogai says that in those days journeys were undertaken on auspicious days. The same literature mentions that it was considered lucky if the left eye of a girl or the right one of a man quivered violently. According to Silappadikaram if the planet "Velli" (Venus) appeared in the south it was a bad omen. The cawing of a crow was taken to portend the arrival of guests,

The Sangam Tamils believed in ghosts and spirits and feared. Kuruntogai speaks that Tamils believed that the nature of next birth of a man was decided by the thoughts of his last moments in this birth. Untouchability prevailed during this time.

They believed in the efficacy of Margosa leaves and white mustard as protective against the influence of ghosts-Pey: women applied ney and white mustard to the hair on heads of children to protect them from evil influences

Left was inauspicious during this period. The bride after her marriage entered the mother-in-law's house placing her right foot on it. The dancer ascended the placing her right foot first on it. The husband must not leave the company of his wife for fifteen days after the start of menstrual flow for her: but is not to seek union with her during the menses period. Scientific enquiry would show that this was not mere belief but the result of careful observation. It was customary for the women, after the child-birth to go to the public tank for bathing. During the period of "impurity", they were "unapproachable" and must not touch the domestic utensils.

### 4.3.5 Jainism

It is well known fact that both Jainism and Buddhism sprang up simultaneously into prominence and that while Buddhism received royal patronage while Jainism lacked these advantages. According to K.A.N. Sastri “Jainism was the more persistent religion in its influence on Tamil literature”. Jains had produced Jivaka Chinthamani, Chulamani, NilakesiNannul, Yapparungala Virutti etc Thus they were intellectual giants who had made remarkable contribution to Tamil literature. The tradition says that Badrabahu, the Jaina ascetic accompanied by Chandra gupta maurya, led his followers to Sravanabelgola. From there they reached the nearest place Kanchipuram. Hence it has been a strong hold of Jainism.

In the city of Puhar Jains were known as Samanas and their places of stay were called Samanapalli or Amanapalli. The lay Jains were called “Ulaga Nonbigal”. At Uraiyur there was an Aruhan temple called “Sri Kandappalli”.

The Amanappallis were retiring and resting places of the Jaina monastriesand these places were surrounded by gardens full of flowering plants. Jainism became popular during the time of Kalabharas.

### 4.3.6 Ajivikas

Ajivikas were another sect of Jains. Kannagi’s father Manaikkan was reported to have joined this order and became a Jaina monk. The founder of this order was Mamballiputta Markhali gosala. He established Ajivikism, which had a component of Jaina doctrine and his own independent views. Kaundi Adigal was a Jaina ascetic who is said to have escorted Kovalan and Kannagi.

### 4.3.7 Buddhism

Buddhism sprang up in Tamil Nadu during the SangamAge. Buddhism received royal patronage, and their influence is clearly indicated in the Tamil Literature. The authors of Manimekalai, Virasoliam, and the Kundalakesi were great Buddhists.

Buddhists learned Tamil like the Jains in order to spread their religion in Tamil Nadu. Unlike Jainism Buddhism spread in various parts of ancient Tamilaham. Vjharas and Chaityas

were the Buddhist religious establishments. Manimekalai refers to a big Chaityas in kavereipumpattinam. Manimekalai gives detailed account of the doctrines of Buddhism. The important centers of Buddhism were Kaveripumpattinam, Karur, Uraiyur, Madurai and Kanchipuram.. Maduraikanchi refers to a monastery in Madurai. The Buddhist monks preached the virtues of self-control and non-violence. Women were also admitted with the Buddhist order. Flower and incense were offered. The Kalabhara rulers were the followers of Buddhism.

From the available evidences we can say that to an certain extent Sangam society was influenced both by Jainism and Buddhism. Some Tamils abstained from meat eating. The Hindus adopted a few legends of the Buddhists.

#### **4.4 Summary**

In general there was a religious tolerance prevailed among the sangam rulers. People worshipped according to their living thinnai but lord Murukan worship was famous among the Tamils. Nature worship was also prevalent in the sangam age. Apart from Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism were also in existence. Sangam rulers donated liberally for the construction of temples, monasteries, Pallis and Chaityas.

#### **4.5 Review Questions**

1. Write short notes
  - (a) Tolkappiam
  - (b) Narrinai
  - (c) Purananuru
  - (d) Thirukural
2. Explain about Ten Idylls
3. Describe about the post-Sangam works
4. Write about the religion and Philosophy of the Sangam age
5. Describe about the method of worship during the Sangam age
6. Discuss the existence of Buddhism during the sangam age



## 4.6 Answers to Review Questions

1.    a. see the subsection    4.2.1  
       b. see the subsection    4.2. 2 (1)  
       c. see the subsection    4.2. 2 (7)  
       d. see the subsection    4.2. 2 (11)
2.    See the subsections    4.2.3 &4.2.3 (1) to (12)
3.    See the subsection    4.2. 5
4.    See the subsections    4.3 &4.2.3 (1) to (12)
5.    See the subsection    4.3.1
6.    See the subsection    4.3.7

## 4.7 Further References

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2.    Jesudasan    C            :    History of Tamil Literature
3.    Kanagasabhi    V        :    Tamils Eighteen Hundred Years ago
4.    Subtamanian N            :    Sangam Polity
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7.    www wikipedia

## **LESSON – 5**

# **KALABHRA INTERREGNUM, PALLAVAS’ ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL CONDITIONS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Understand the History of the Kalabhras
- ❖ Explain the existence of industries, trade and commerce, merchant guilds during the Pallava period
- ❖ Narrate the position of women and the existence of caste system under the Pallavas.
- ❖ Reviewing the existence of temples, educational institutions such as Ghatikas and temples, food habits, dress and ornaments during the pallava period.

### **Structure**

#### **5.1 Introduction**

#### **5.2 Kalabhras**

#### **5.2 Agriculture**

#### **5.3 Industries**

##### **5.3.1 Land Revenue**

##### **5.3.2 Land Tenure**

#### **5.4 Trade and Commerce**

#### **5.5 Weights and measures**

#### **5.6 Social conditions**

##### **5.6.1 Brahmanas**

##### **5.6.2 Kshatriyas**

##### **5.6.3 Vaisyas**

##### **5.6.4 Sudras**

## 5.7 Position of women

### 5.7.1 Marriage

### 5.7.2 Dress and Decorations

### 5.7.3 Food and Sports

## 5.8 Education

### 5.8.1 Ghatika

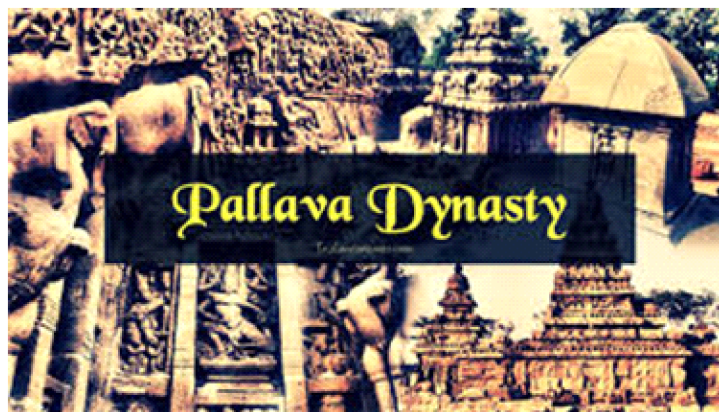
## 5.9 Summary

## 5.10 Answers to Review Questions

# 5.1 Introduction

The age of the great Pallavas of Simhavishnu line was perhaps the most formative period of South Indian Culture. The administrative system of the Pallavas is considered as one of the most important feature of society. The Pallavas had developed a very well organized and efficient system of administration. The Pallava period witnessed excellent economic progress. The revenue of the Government increased due to taxation and the economy of the country also witnessed rapid progress.

They had introduced the beginnings of an elaborate local administration. Dry lands were brought under cultivation. Lakes and canals were widened for irrigational purposes. Villages were self-contained and enjoyed a semi-autonomous like status. Hence there was an industrial freedom and economic progress in the villages. In short the villages played an important role in developing the economy of the country and they are very often known in the contemporary literature as the centers of socio-economic activities.



The history of any period can be reconstructed only on the basis of relevant source material. Epigraphy assumes greater importance with the emergence of the Pallavas. The economic life of the village during the Pallava period is derived from the different copper-plate charters namely Pallankovil, Kurram, Kasakudi and Tandantottam as well as the glimpses obtained in Tevaram and Nalayira divyaprabandam, hymns of Nayanmars and Alvars. We infer from the inscriptions about land survey, land tenure, land tax etc. The villages and their boundaries, private land, and Government land settlement in the villages, the different industries or occupation followed are being mentioned. We are also able to form an idea about the size of each village and the population. Thus these sources help us to learn about the economic history of the Pallavas.

## **5.2 Kalabharas**

Historians call the Kalabhara period as the Interregnum or interlude in the History of Tamil Nadu. After the decline of the Sangam age they ruled over Tamil Nadu up to the Pallava period. The Historians call this period as the Dark Age.

According to Dr N.Subramanian, there is a dark political pall descending over and enshrouding the history of the Tamils for a period of three centuries namely 300 A.D to 600 A.D. Through this historical mist we get merely glimpses of the nature and activities of a people called the Kalabhras who ruled the whole or considerable parts of the Tamil country having captured power from the three traditional crowned monarchs of Tamilaham.

### **Who were the Kalabhras?**

There is a mystery shrouded about the Kalabhara's origin. According to Krishnaswamy Iyengar, Kalabhras could be related to the Kalvar of the Venkatam origin. According to Dr.T.V.Mahalingam the Kalabhras were oliyars. According to literary source Periyapuranam Kalabhras were the Kannadians. According to Dr M.S.Govindaswamy Kalabhras ruled over the Chola territory in the name of Muttaraiyar. Further he says that they patronized Jain poets who composed Naladiyar. Thus there are various theories about them and we don't have reliable sources to study about them.

## **Religion of the Kalabhras**

Kalabhras were Jains. Kalabhras suppressed other religions and promoted the religion of Jainism. Jainism became a dominating force of the Pallava and Pandya rulers.

## **Decline of the Kalabhras**

By the end of the Sixth century Kadungon of Pandya ruler defeated the kalabhras. Since they are mentioned in the Kurram copper plate we assume that they would have lived up to 8<sup>th</sup> Century A.D. without holding any political importance.

Thus after the Kalabhra period we have the Pallava rule in Tamil Nadu.

## **Agriculture**

Agriculture is the cultivation of land and breeding of animals and plants to provide food, medicinal plants and other products to sustain and enhance life. The land was classified as dry and wet lands and taxes were collected accordingly. The entire lands of the kingdom were measured. Every village was measured and sketch was drawn. There were two kinds of lands viz., Puyal and Adai. The income of the former was shared by land owners and cultivators, and the latter lands were crown lands.

The rulers took all possible steps to increase the area of cultivation as well as to increase the yielding capacity of the lands. Dry lands and waste lands were brought under cultivation. For these purpose lakes, canals and wells were used by the people. The lakes depended mainly on rains. A large number of wells were constructed for drinking and irrigational purposes. Agricultural lands were used for the cultivation of rice which was one of the staple food crops of the country. Rice was one of the main items of barter. Apart from paddy, groundnut and cashew nut were cultivated in large tracts of land. They used get wood from forest areas. In the coastal belt cashew nut and coconut grooves were cultivated on a large scale. But unfortunately due to the failure of monsoon (that is lack of rainfall) farmers were not able to get benefited out of the yield from their lands. The region was not so fertile like cholamandalam.

Agriculture was the main occupation for the majority of the people. There were big and small landlords as well as ordinary labourers who were paid wages either in cash or kind.

Through Forest and mines Government were able to get the good revenue. Lakes, tanks, wells, rivers and even trees were counted and registered for purposes of tax assessment.

In the coastal areas salt was manufactured.

### **5.3 Industries**

Apart from Agriculture there were other industries like weaving and dyeing, Stone cutting and shell cutting, bead and bangle –making, pottery and terracotta works carried on throughout the country.

#### **(1) Weaving and Dyeing**

Both cotton and silk clothes were produced. . Silk was an important item of export and was very popular in countries like China. China imported silk clothes and saris in large quantity from the pallava kingdom. Even today Kanchipuram was a flourishing trade centre of silk saris and these saris are very popular in the international market. Majority of the people in this area was engaged in this profession.

#### **(2) Stone Cutting and Carving**

Cottage industry was existed in the Pallava period. Semi-precious stones were used for making beads of various size and shape. The art of cutting and polishing the stone were very famous during this period. The excavations were conducted in places like Kanchipuram and they founded numerous such beads. Stone studs were also made.

#### **(3) Bangle Making**

Shell and glass bangles were very popular during this period. People were able to get employment through this industry.

#### **(4) Pottery**

Pottery or ceramic industries made rapid progress and the industry was spread all over the kingdom. This industry provided vessels for domestic use to all sorts of people. The potters organized themselves into guilds or corporations. They enjoyed a high status in the society.

Women folk were also engaged in this industry. Thus many people followed pottery as their profession.

Besides the above, there were also other industries like sugarcane, oil pressing, carpentry, ivory working, cattle breeding etc., which provided the village population to earn their livelihood. The members of the village community maintained themselves by many of these organized industries or industrial crafts. The village population included these industrial workers besides Goldsmith, Traders, Merchants and Brahmins.

### **5.3.1 Land Revenue**

We come to know that there were many kinds of lands from the copper plates from Kuram, Kasakudi and Bahur. Land Revenue was the main source of income. Land was owned both by the king and by the individuals. Land was classified into cultivable and non-cultivable besides forests, pastures etc. The term Puravupon figuring in the Pallava records refers to the tax in money on cultivable lands paid to the Government by the land owners. The kings owned personal lands and hence they were able to donate tax free lands to the Brahmanas and temples.

Lands donated to Brahmins were called Brahmadeya lands. These lands were exempted from tax. More over these lands were not to be sold out. The Brahmins who mastered four Vedas were lived in Chaturvedimangalam. Lands donated to the temples were known as Devadhana. The revenue from the lands were spent for temples. The temples extended loans to the people during the time of famine or drought. Lands given to Jain monasteries were known as Pallichandam.

### **5.3.2 Land Tenure**

The cultivable lands in the villages were held under different tenures. There were lands whose produce was shared equally by the land owner and the tenant. There were also lands, wherein 1/6 of the produce was to be given to the king. There were also instances where in the tenants of the Government lands were changed periodically. Details were worked out to compensate and reemploy the old tenants.

## 5.4 Trade and Commerce

The Pallava period witnessed a considerable development in the field of trade and commerce.

### 5.4.1 Inland Trade

Regarding inland trade, every village had shops in those days. River transportation was also restored under the pallava rule.

Each village had their shops and some inscriptions speak of the commercial activities of these shops. Commodities like rice, salt, cotton, toddy, sugarcane, jiggery, pots, oil, coconut, Palmyra and areca nuts, clothes, fish, milk and milk products .Ulagalantha Perumal temple of Kanchi states that licenses were issued. Barter system was generally followed in the business transactions.

### 5.4.2 Taxes

The main source of income to the Government was from taxes. The Inscriptions speak of land revenue and the following professional taxes, namely **IlamPutchi** was levied who drew toddy, **Kussakkanam** was levied on those who made pottery, **Tattukkanam** was levied on Goldsmith, **Paraikkanam** was levied on the Washer man, **Padamkalai** was levied on Spinners, **Tharikkurai** was levied on Weavers, **Ndumparai** was paid to those who beat drums, **Sungavari** was the excise duty, **Manrupadu** was levied in courts etc.

### 5.4.3 Foreign Trade

Mahabalipuram was an important port during the Pallava period. It is often mentioned by Thirumangai Alwar and Chinese traveler Hiuen Tsang in their masterpieces. In addition to Mahabalipuram, Nagapattinam was also a remarkable port. There was trade relationship between Kanchipuram and China and South West Asia. Nandikalambagam gives an account of the trade was going between Kanchipuram and China.



#### **5.4.4 Trade Guilds**

The various artisans and traders and craftsmen organized themselves into Guilds or Corporations. They took care of the welfare of these people and at the same time made gifts to religious institutions and public welfare activities.

### **5.5 Weights and Measures**

As several of the Pallava inscriptions relate to gifts of land Gold and other articles of produce, a scrutiny of these records reveals to us a number of weights and measures that were current in the country. Most of these continued to be in use even during the post-Pallava period. A few of them are still in vogue in southern Tamil districts.

#### **5.5.1 Measures**

The early Sanskrit inscriptions mention the extent of land measured by “plough”. There were also other kinds of measures like Pattika, Nivartana, and Padagam etc. Veli and Kuli were the most common land measures. There were other numerous measures with different names and each denoted a different standard.

In the Pallava age rice and paddy were measured by the nali, marakkal, kuruni, and Kalam. Ghee, oil, milk and curd were measured by the Alakku, Ulakku, Uri and nail. Padi was also a measure and that is still in practice in our country.

#### **5.5.2 Weights**

Gold weights such as Kalanju and Manjadi were prevalent in the Pallava age.

#### **5.5.3 Coinage**

Coins were used as medium of exchange besides Barter system. Many coins of Pallava rulers are available to us. Wheel, Swastik, Umbrella, Sangu, Arrow, Fish, Crab, lion, Horse etc., were found on the obverse of coins. Coins bearing the emblem of Nandhi and two ships are also available to us. Coins were made out of Gold, silver and copper.

## 5.6 Social Conditions

The four fold division of society into Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, Vaisyas and Sudras continued during the Pallava period in a modified form. They followed the principles of Hindu Dharma and Varnashramadharma. Kasakudi plates explain about the significance of observing the principles of Varnashramadharma by all castes during this period. Besides there were artisans, goldsmiths, carpenters, Idaiyars and farmers.

### 5.6.1 Brahmins

Though numerically in a minority, they were at the head of the society. In general Brahmins were educated people in the society. During the Pallava period many Brahmins were migrated from the Andhra to Tamil Nadu. They were respected and honoured by the rulers by grant of Brahmadeya land gifts. These Brahmins found employment in the temples for reciting Vedas during services and also during the various royal sacrifices, such as Agni stoma, Vajapeya and Asvamedha.

Brahmins were found employment as officers in the Pallava Royal court and Government Departments. They were also serving as accountants in village assemblies. The Brahmins were polygamous and married more than one wife. The Brahman girls married Kshatriya, Vysia, and sudra men too. This was called Pratiloma marriage while the members of non-Brahman communities married Brahman girls under Anuloma marriage practice. This led to numerous mixed castes.

### 5.6.2 Kshatriyas

The Talagunda inscription refers to the Pallava rulers as Kshatriyas. The kings were pious and God fearing. They were interested in the welfare of the people and promoting dharma. They made liberal grants and gifts to the Brahmanas and scholars. They performed Vedic sacrifices. They were fond of war. The queens were also equally pious and took pride in making gifts and endowments to temples and other religious and educational institutions.

### **5.6.3. Vaisyas**

Vaisyas were the business community during this period. There were also a few Nayanmars who belonged to the community. The rich among them made grants of lands to establish educational institutions, Hospitals, feeding houses and both construction and renovation works of the temples. They provided large funds for these public welfare activities.

They organized themselves into a number of guilds and corporations. These guilds took care of the welfare of the trading community and also for their business transactions. They were able to influence the ruling family. They were associated with the administrative work both at the centre and village levels.

### **5.6.4 Sudras**

The lowest strata of society were the Sudras. They were followed different kinds of professions apart from serving as agricultural labourers. The hymn of Alvars refers to a few of them as Pulayas and Chandelas. as socially down caste people. There were great men like Tiruppanalvar and Tandanar who belonged to this community. They were allowed to enter into the temples and offer worship.

Besides there were Vellalas, Dhobis, shepherds, fishermen, hunters, Parayas, Panars and Pulayars. They were identified by their professions.

## **5.7 Position of women**

Women were highly respected in the society. They showed keen interest in religious and temple affairs. Women enjoyed right to own property during this period and they have donated liberally to the temples. Women had donated gold coins through Hiranyagarbha and Tulabhara ceremonies.

Monogamy was in existence. Certain kings had two wives. Women were educated, intelligent, beautiful and skilled in various arts and crafts. Besides serving in temples, women indulged in spinning, weaving and selling of milk from door to door. The inscription of Mukteswara temple state that there were many dancing girls. They enjoyed high reputation and influence in kings' court and in society.

During this period Queen enjoyed special concessions and privileges. They gave gifts liberally to temples. The kings had matrimonial alliances with Rashtrakutas, Kadambaras and Gangas in order to gain political advantages. Queens like Charudevi and others patronized religion. They donated lands to temples and they celebrated festivals. They had valuable jewels. Women were fond of wearing numerous ornaments and garments. The Pallava sculpture representing the queens and dancer bear testimony to this fact.

The Aryan culture had a great impact on Tamil culture. This we infer from the works of Andal and Sundaramurthy Nayanar. Thiruppavai Nonbu i.e., fasting was observed by women folk during the Pallava period.

There were no evidences either in literature or in the inscriptions about the practice of Sati. Hence we come to the conclusion that Sati was not known to them.

### **5.7.1 Marriage**

During this period marriage was conducted with the consent of the parents, However love marriages were also permitted and received encouragement. Many rituals and ceremonies were observed during the marriage. Homam was performed. The holy thread (Thali) was tied to the neck of the bride with the instrumental music and in the presence of relatives and friends.

Inter-caste marriages were also existed. The Brahmana girls married the Kshatriya, Vaisya and Sudra men. Similarly the non-Brahmin men married the Brahmana girls. From this we infer that the caste was not a hindrance to enter into marriage at all levels of society.

### **5.7.2 Dress and Decorations**

Both men and women wore costly dresses. Particularly members of the royal families and ministers wore rich and beautiful dresses. The term Kalingam was used to indicate silk clothing. Sirradai and Meladai (lower and upper garments) were used by the ladies. Jains wore washed cloth during the pallava period. The ascetics wore yellow garments. Special types of dresses were used by the Warrior class.

## **(1) Ornaments**

Both the Pallava kings and the queens wore different types of ornaments. From the inscriptions we come to know that they use the following ornaments: The crown-chains, Thodu, Kundalam, Marakkuli, Anklets, Rings, padagam, Pathakkam, Valayal and Ottiyanam. They also adorned their shoulder with with pearl strings known as Veerachangili. . The ornaments were made of either Gold, silver or copper. Palm- leaves were also used as ear-rings by some ladies.

## **(2) Foot Wears**

People wore chapel made out of leather, wood and skins. Umbrellas of different types were common in those days.

## **(3) Head Dress**

Royal family members both men and women wore crowns to adorn their heads. They tied their hair into knots of different fashions: combing the hair was a common scene. Both men and women decorated their body from head to foot. They took bath in scented waters and applied sandal powder for their body. They wore flowers over the hair. It was also a customary to wear flower on the right ear by young men. It was known as tonrippu.

### **5.7.3 Food and Drinks**

Inscriptions explain that the people of this age consumed red paddy (sennel). Cooked rice was their staple food. Apart from this they cooked Appam, Sweet Pongal, curd-rice, ghee-rice, milk, dhal and butter. These food items were used by the royal family members also. Special diets were provided for soldiers. They consumed non vegetarian food: grains like ragi, cholam etc were also used for preparing food. Meat eating was very common. Betel and nuts were served after the meals. Toddy was consumed by large sections of people. The rich people drank wine and toddy of high quality.

## **Sports**

Hunting, elephant riding, horse riding, Swimming, sword fighting and wrestling were the favorite games for men. Dice was a favourite indoor game. The womenfolk spent their leisure time in swimming, taming parrots in cages and Gardening.

## **5.8. Education**

During the age of the Pallavas Hindu, Buddhist and Jaina educational institutions flourished at Kanchipuram. Hindu educational institution received a patronage from the rulers and attracted scholars from different parts of India. The language of the court and also the medium of instruction was Sanskrit. The ruler Mahendravarman I was a very great scholar. Educational institutions were patronized by the rulers. But there was no evidence regarding their educational centers or their curriculum. One of these institutions must have been the Ghatika.

### **5.8.1 Ghatika**

Ghatika was an educational institution. It consisted of a group of holy and learned Brahmanas. There were many branches of study. The center of Ghatika was Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram. The study of Veda, Angas, Mimamsa and the like were practiced in the Ghatika.

The other centers of learning were Bahur, Bahur Palampathi and Sholingar. The Pallava kings supported those educational institutions. The numerical strength of Ghatika varied from place to place. It was a residential institution offering free boarding and lodging to the teachers and taught.

### **(1) Agraharas**

The Brahmadeya village and Agraharas undertook the teaching of the people. It provided opportunities for the people to study Vedic literature and other subjects. The Pallava rulers founded numerous agraharas for the Brahmanas which helped in spreading literacy among the people. They were named after the rulers or their queens.

### **(2) Temple as an Educational Institution**

Temples served as centers of learning and provided free boarding and lodging to the scholars. They provided courses for the architect, sculptor and the painter. They also employed the musicians, dancers and actors. It is said that the Kailasanatha temple was fostering higher studies in Vedic lore and philosophy. Provisions were also made for reciting Mahabharata and Devaram hymns. Debates and discussions were held in the mandapas of the temples.

### **(3) Mathas**

Both Saiva and Vaishnava Mathas encouraged the educational activities. The inmates of the Mathas were all highly qualified persons and taught subjects of various interests to local students. Secular subjects like astrology, medicine etc., was also taught to the students.

### **(4) Buddhist and Jain centers of Education**

The viharas and Jaina Pallis functioned as centers of education for Buddhist and Jain systems of philosophy. Hiuen-Tsang gives a graphic picture about the popular Buddhist University at Kanchipuram, Many scholars came to this university both from other parts of India and abroad similarly there were Jaina Pallis encouraged the study of Jaina philosophy. Jina Kanchi was considered as the main center of learning for Jains.

## **5.9 Summary**

The dark period of Kalabhara rule came to an end and the Greater Pallava dynasty started to rule Tamilaham with Kanchi as their capital. Pallavas established their political stability and supremacy in the Tamil Country. The economic condition of the country was stabilized and the development of education was patronized by the rulers. Thus there was an all round development in the Pallava territory. Though there were frequent wars, there was peace and progress.

## **5.10 Review Questions**

1. Explain about the four fold divisions in the society under the pallavas.
2. Discuss the position of Women during the pallava period.
3. Describe about the agriculture under the Pallavas.
4. Explain about the industries in the Pallava period.
5. Write Short Notes on
  - a. Land revenue system of the Pallavas
  - b. Inland trade under the Pallavas
  - c. Weights and measures during the Pallava period

6. Explain about the four fold divisions in the society under the pallavas.
7. Discuss the position of Women during the pallava period.
8. Discuss the education system existed under the Pallavas.

### **5.10 Answers to Review Questions**

1. See the subsection 5.2
2. See the subsections 5.3 and 5.3(1) to (4)
3.
  - a. See the subsection 5.3.1
  - b. See the subsection 5.4.(1)
  - c. See the subsections 5.5.(1) and (2)
4. See the subsections 5.6 and 5.6.1 to 5.6.4
5. See the Section 5.7
6. See the subsections 5.8 and 5.8.1 and 5.8.1 (1)to (4)



## **LESSON - 6**

# **RELIGION, BHAKTI MOVEMENT AND LITERATURE UNDER THE PALLAVAS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Highlight the importance of religious faith in Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism and their temples in the Pallava period.
- ❖ Discuss the development of Bhakti movement, contributions of Nayanmars and Alvars to the growth of Saivism and Vaishnavism during the Pallava period.
- ❖ Explain the growth of Tamil and Sanskrit literature during the period of the Pallavas.

### **Structure**

- 6.1 Introduction**
- 6.2 Hindu Religion**
  - 6.2.1 Vaishnavism**
  - 6.2.2 Saivism**
  - 6.2.3 Buddhism**
  - 6.2.4 Jainism**
- 6.3 Temples**
  - 6.3.1 Religious Tolerance**
- 6.4 Bhakti Movement**
  - 6.4.1 Saivism**
  - 6.4.2 Vaishnavism**
- 6.5 Literature**
  - 6.5.1 Saiva works**
  - 6.5.2 Vaishnava works**
  - 6.5.3 Tamil Works**
- 6.6 Summary**
- 6.7 Answers to Review Questions**

## 6.1 Introduction

A unique feature of the Pallava period was that people belonging to different religious followers lived together in the capital of the Pallava dynasty. The Pallava rulers followed religious tolerance policy. The spread of Bhakti movement had provided stimulus to them. Both Sanskrit and Tamil religious literary works came. We can see the decline of Jainism and Buddhism in this period.

## 6.2 Hindu Religion

“The very soul of India, the very life blood of her civilization and culture is found not so much in the palaces but in temples, not in politics but in philosophy” Religious philosophy is the fundamental keynote in Indian History. It cannot be denied that the age of the Pallavas occupies an immortal place in the religious history of India. The early Pallava rulers were the followers of Vedic religion. The rulers performed many sacrifices like Aswamedha, vajapeya, Somayaga and Agnishtoma. Simhavarman was credited with the performance of 100 Yagas. .Simhavarman and Paramesvaravarman have performed Aswamedha sacrifices. Almost all the early Pallava rulers had a great faith in the Vedic sacrifices. Pallava rulers constructed many Hindu temples.

### 6.2.1 Vaishnavism

The devotees of Lord Vishnu were called Vaishnavites. Alvars preached Vaishnavism during the Pallava period. There were twelve Alvars. Those who lived in the Pallava kingdom were Poigai Alwar, Pey Alwar, Bhudhathalwar, and Tirumangai Alwar. Early pallava rulers were staunch followers of vaishnavism. From the inscriptions we come to know that rulers were great worshippers of Vishnu feet. Sometimes the king and queen are compared to Vishnu and Lakshmi respectively. Simhavarman was portrayed as the incarnation of lord Vishnu and the queen of Dantivarman as an incarnation of Goddess Lakshmi.

Lord Vishnu was worshipped in three postures: i.e. Reclining, Standing and Seated. The ten avatars of Lord Vishnu were worshipped. Among the ten Avatars, Varaha and Srivikrama Avatars were the famous in the early pallava period. The advent of Narashima form was not found prior to Narashimhavarman-I. Vishnu temples are found in Kanchipuram, Mamalapuram,

and Mahendravadi etc. Sacred food and flowers were offered to the deities. Vishnusarashranamam were chanted in the temples. Rulers donated lands to the temples and they made as an endowment to the temples in order to do puja daily in the temples. Festivals were also celebrated in the temples.

### **6.2.2 Saivism**

The followers of Lord Shiva were known as Saivites. During the Pallava period, Nayanmars the Saiva saints had preached Saivism. There were sixty-three Nayanmars. Only in the later pallava period Saivism flourished due to the patronage of the rulers like Narasimhavarman-II. Many Shiva temples were constructed at Kanchipuram, Panamalai, and Mamalapuram. In the early part of the pallava period Shiva was not worshipped in the form of a Linga. The main object of worship in a temple was panel of Somaskanda- Shiva with his son Kumara and his consort Parvathi. This panel was either painted or sculptured on the rear wall of the central shrine. It was during the time of Rajasimha-II that the worship of Linga became popular. Other forms of Shiva were also worshipped. He was worshipped as Gangadharamurthy, Tirupuantaka, and Kailasanatha.

In those days they have offered flowers and mantras were chanted for worship. The ritual of abhisheka was not in vogue and the main ritual at the time of early pallavas was only nivedhana. From the Kurram records we come to know that the ruler Paramesvaravarman was the one who introduced the puja to Lord Shiva with a sacred bath, to be followed by offering flowers, sandal and incense to the deity. Hence we can say that he was the one who introduced the Abhisheka ritual in the temples.

### **(1) Saiva Sects**

In the early centuries of Pallava rule there were certain religious sects like Kapalika, Kalamuka and Pasupatha etc., as also the kaumaras, the Sastas etc. These were splinter group of original Saivism. Their religious rituals included the offering of wine and Blood to Bhairava and Kali, ferocious aspects of Shiva and his consort Parvathi. According to Chinese pilgrim Hiuen Tsang "the kapalikas lived in the holes and crevices of the rocks, like Yaaksa who haunt the place of Tombs".

## **Bhairava and Kali worship**

The chief centers of Kapalika, Kalamuka and Pasupata sects which flourished in the Pallava Kingdom were Kanchipuram, Thirvorriyur, Mayilappur and Kodumbalur and certain places in Tanjavour and Tiruchchirappalli districts. The prevalence of Kali, Durga and Mahisasura-mardhini is clear from the sculptures in the shrines of Mamallapuram. The worship of Bhairava can be seen from the sculptures of the terrible form of Siva Bhairavamurthi in the Kailasanatha temple at kanchipuram.

## **Bhairava episode in Siruttondarpuranam**

The Siruttondarpuranam explains in a detailed manner about how the Bhairava took the form of a Kapalika and entered Saint Siruttondar's house on invitation for a repast in his house on condition that he was provided for food cooked flesh of a five year old boy. The request was met in full by sacrificing his only son, five year old. The devotion of Saint Siruttondar having been proved, the life of the boy was given back by the Bhairava, who then mysteriously disappeared.

A Saiva math for the Kalamuka sect was located at Kodumbalur .They took to penance and reciting of sacred hymns. The Pasupatas were also known as Maheswaras. They considered Siva in the form of Pasupata as their chief deity and worshipped in the form of Linga. They went about sparsely clad wearing the sacred ashes all over the body. They had great faith in sacrifices. An offering of flesh to the deity was considered as an important form of worship

The Kapalikas were worshippers of Siva in the form of Bhairava. They adorned themselves with a garland of skulls. Animals and human sacrifices were given to Bhairava. The Kapalikas took flesh, intoxicant drinks and worshipped their deity. They considered women a Sakthi. A Kapalika Math was established at Kanchi. Kapalikas were also popular in Mayilappur. The decline of the Kapalika sect in the Pallava Kingdom is brought out in Mattavilasaprahasana.

## **(2) Shanmatha**

The Pallava period saw the rise of six creeds (Shanmatha) in the Hindu pantheon. There is some evidence that the six creeds were introduced by Sankaracharya. The six creeds are

(a) Ganapatyam (worship of Ganapati), (b) Kumaran (Shanmuga), (c) Sauram (sun), (d) Saktam (Sakthi), (e) Saivam (Siva), (f) Vaishnavam (Vishnu), Images of Ganapathi and Shanmuga (Kumaran) are represented in the Pallava sculptures. Ganapathi worship was introduced during the Pallava days. Temples of Ganapathi were constructed. A Brahmana lady Devachchani set up an image of Ganapati in the Kailasanathar temple at Paramesvaramangalam and endowed a perpetual lamp. In the later Pallava times Ganesa appears in the group of Saptamatri (seven mothers).

The popularity of worship of Durga and Mahisasuramardini ferocious aspects of Sakthi is clear from the sculptures found at Mahabalipuram. The cults of Saptamatri and Jyeshtha were famous during the Pallava times. The cult was popular from the reign of Dantivarman. Temples of Saptamatri were constructed at Tiruttani, Velacheri and Alampakkam during the period. Jyeshtha, the eldest sister of Lakshmi, was another popular deity worshipped in this period. Kailasanathar temple has the first representation of this goddess. She was considered as a goddess of evil and was propitiated by devotees forwarding of evil. Brahma, Vishnu, Siva the Trimurtis were also worshipped collectively. Temples for Trinity are found at Mandagapattu and Mahabalipuram. Hari Hara (Siva-Vishnu synthesis) and Surya were also worshipped.

### **(3) Hero Stones**

The ancient form of hero worship was also popular. For those heroes who fell in the battlefield a memorial was erected and worshipped. Such memorial stones are sculptured with the figure of the hero and the deed would be engraved. Such hero stones are available in all parts of the Pallava kingdom.

### **6.2.3 Buddhism**

Buddhism was patronized by the Pallava kings from very early times. They were followers of Mahayana form of Buddhism. Two of the early Pallava Kings-Buddhavarman and Buddhyankura-were believed to be patrons of Buddhism. According to the Chinese Buddhist scholar Hiuen Tsang who had visited India in the 7<sup>th</sup> century explains about the condition of Buddhism. He says that Kanchipuram was a flourishing city and most of its population was Buddhist. Further he mentions that there were over 100 Buddhist monasteries and over a

thousand monks. Mahendravarman's work *Mattavilasa prahasana* mentions about the existence of viharas. Raja Vihara was the chief vihara.

Among the notable scholars Dharmapala of the Nalanda university belonged to the resident of the city Kanchipuram. The material prosperity of the Vihara is explained in the words of Devasoma. Urugapura (identified with Uraiyur) was the seat of the famous monk Buddhadatta, who composed his *Ahbidummavatara* there. Kaviripumpaatinam was another Buddhist centre having a big monastery. Bhutamangalam and Nagapattinam had also monasteries. In the days of the Pallavas there existed different schools of Buddhist philosophy and logic. One of the most popular schools of philosophy flourished was the Sthvira School. Another school of philosophy was the Dhyna School. However there seems to be a decline in the morals. This is indicated in the *Matavilasaprhhasana*. To revive Buddhism steps were taken. Vajrabodhi, the Buddhist monk visited the Pallava kingdom during rule of Narasimhavarman-II (A.D. 690) and exhibited his miraculous power to relieve the people from the famine.

The religious condition of Tamil Nadu began to change after the 7<sup>th</sup> century due to the advent of Saivism and Vaishnavism. Pallava rulers did not patronize Buddhism hence it led to the decline gradually. We can conclude about Buddhism in the words of Pandit Hisselle Dharmaratana Maha Thera "Although Buddhism declined in the Tamil country from the 7<sup>th</sup> century onwards it was by no means eradicated"

#### **6.2.4. Jainism**

Jainism was another important religion that flourished in the Pallava kingdom from very early times. Jainism seems to have more followers than Buddhism. Unlike Buddhism, Jainism received more royal patronage during the time of Mahendravarman I. A tradition over that Mahendravarman was a Jain later converted to Saivism by the preaching's of Appar. Jainism became an important religion in the life of the people when Vajranandhi, founded the *DravidaSangha* in A.D. 470. The famous Prakrit writer KundaKunda a Digrambara Jain is related to Sivakumaramaharaja, identified with one of the Pallava kings of the Prakrit charters. It is also during the time of Simhavaraman, Sarvanandhi, completed the copying of the Jaina work *Lokavibhaga* in Prakrit. With the reconversion of Mahendravarman to the Saiva fold, Jainism lost the royal support.

Kanchipuram was an important Jaina centre. Other Jaina centres are located at Tiruppanmalai, Tirupparuttikkunram, Vallimalai and Ponvilaindapatti. It received royal patronage

of the Pallava king Simhavarman. The Pallankoil copper plates record the functioning of the famous Nadisanga at the place Amanserkkai, and the patronage received from the Pallava king Simhavarman. At Venkunram, Perumandur, Malaiyadippatti, Kilsatamangalam and Pachapandavamalai, Jain Pallis functioned. At Vedal there was a nunnery with strength about 500 members. Jains were divided into monastic order and lay following with further subdivisions. The worship of prophets and celebration of great public festivals was the feature of the normal religious life of the people. Trilokyanatha Temple in Kanchipuram and Chitharal Jain temple were constructed during the Pallava time. Royal patronage played a vital role both for the growth as well as for the decline of Jainism for example Mahendravarman I's period

Trilokyanatha/Chandraprabha temple is a twin Jain temple that has inscriptions from Pallava king, Narasimhavarman II and the Chola kings Rajendra Chola I, Kulothunga Chola I and Vikrama Chola, and the Kanarese inscriptions of Krishnadevaraya. The temple is maintained by Tamil Nadu archaeological department. This temple comes under the Archaeological Survey of India.

#### **Trilokyanatha Jain temple at Kanchipuram**



## 6.3 Temples

Temples were known by the great name Devakula during Pallava times. The Vishnu temple was name Vishnugraha or Vinnagaram. The temples of the Buddhist and Jain were known by the term Palli. The Hindu temples were generally located near the village settlements whereas the Pallis of the Buddhists and Jains were situated far away from the village settlements. In the early days of the Pallavas temples were constructed out of bricks, wood or perishable materials. From the days of Mahendravarman temple were carved into rocks. They are of simple type with one Garbagriha preceded by a pillared Mandapa. Shrines for other deities were also provided on the sides. In the cave temple Pradakshina was not provided. From the time of Pramesvaravarman-I temples were constructed out of huge stone blocks. They were big structures provided with a PradakshinaPatha and shrines for other smaller deities. Pallava kings constructed many such temples. A temple for Trinity was scooped out at Mandagapattu by Mahendravarman. At Vallam his chieftain Kandasena excavated a temple for Siva. A temple for durga was carved at Mahabalipuram. Paramesvara-I and Rajasimha-II built temples of Siva at Kuram and Kanchipuram respectively. Nadivarman-II built the famous Vaikuntaperumal temple at Kanchipuram.

### (1) Offerings

The deity was worshipped with the grunt of an endowment. Endowments of perpetual lamps were popular form of worship provisions were made to freed the deity and Brahmanas in the temple on various occasions. Flowers were also offered as a token of their love and affection. In later Pallava times the deities were bathed first and flowers, sandal paste and incense were offered. While puja is performed musical instruments were sounded. An offering of the head to Durga was another kind of sacrifice popular during the Pallava times. Sculptures in Mamallapuram portray a few instances of head offerings to Durga. Another kind of sacrifice, Navakandam was also practiced. In this case the warrior would offer flesh taken from nine parts of his body as a price for the victory vouchsafed by the goddess Durga. An instance of offerings of Navakandam is known from Mallam epigraph.

### (2) Philosophy



The religious Philosophy was shaped by Sankara and Kumarilbhatta. Kumariala elucidated the philosophy of ritualism. Sankara preached by Advaita Philosophy. The Nayanmars preached Bhakti and it is only with Bhakti a man can become god. It was preached that no amount of penance and self-torture or asceticism will be any use if it is not accompanied with Bhakti or love. The rebirth was realised and cessation from rebirth could be achieved only by uttering the name of god.

### **6.3.1. Religious Tolerance**

It is generally believed that the various religious group followed a safe path of tolerance. Pallava kings have endowed to the heretical sects Jainism and Buddhism. A village was endowed to Jainasangha at Pallava kingdom without any difficulty.

The devotional literature furnished an entirely different view. They provide some evidence for the religious rivalry that took shape during this period. The quarrels with other religious groups are known and to gain superiority with the other people they have viewed with each other. The hymns of Gnanasambandar and Appar, invariably the tenth verse of every hymns contains a thorough denunciation of the Buddhists and Jains. In pursuance of these aims to wipe out Buddhism and Jainism they carried out a vigorous propaganda condemning the Buddhist and Jains and upholding the Saiva faith. These saints engaged in religious disputations with several sects and on numerous instances the saints emerged successful and established the cause of their religion. Gnanasambandar came into conflict with Jains at Madurai and proved the superiority of Saivism over Jainism to the Pandya king and converted him to Saiva fold. By conducting some miracles the jains were defeated. At Podimangai and Tirvottur also, the Buddhist and Jains were defeated. Tirunavukkarasar, experienced the healing power of Siva, when he was relieved of the intense pain latter he was put to torture by the Jains, but he established the supremacy of Saivism by performing some miracles.

Among the Vaishnava saints, TirumangaiAlwar exhibits his rivalry towards Buddhist and Jains. At one instance he robbed the golden image of Buddha from the NagapattinamVihara, and melted and used gold for constructing the 4<sup>th</sup> prakara of the Siranganatha temple. Mahendra destroyed Jain Pallis at Tiruppadirippuliyur and built a Saiva temple at Tiruvadigal. On the basis of a representation of two men, being impaled sculptured in a panel in the historical

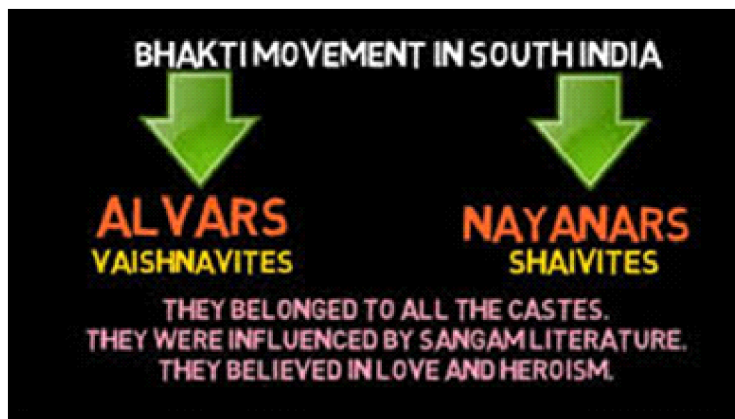
sculptures of Valikuntaperumal temple at Kanchipuram, it was suggested that members of the heretical sects like Buddhists and Jains were impaled. However, in the panel there is no evidence to suggest that the persons impaled were Buddhists and Jains. The confiscation of the wealth in respect of few temples of the Buddhists and Jains could not be taken as an uniform policy followed in the Pallava kingdom. In the Kanchipuram the capital city of Pallavas, no damage was done to any of the temples of Buddhists and Jains. This could indicate that the people largely practiced religious tolerance.

## Review Questions – 1

1. Write short notes
  - a. Saiva Sects
  - b. Shanmatha
2. Describe the condition of Buddhism and Jainism under the Pallavas
3. Write about the temples under the Pallavas

## 6.4 Bhakti Movement

-The Pallava period is considered as “The Age of Bhakti” par excellence in the Tamil country. It is also considered as Hindu religious revival successfully led by the Alvars and Nayanmars. The revivalist movement was started to stop the vigorous spread of the heterodox religious-Jainism and Buddhism in the Tamil country. The revivalists visited innumerable temple centers and gathered strength to their movement by their soul string devotional songs. These songs were set to easy music tunes which attracted worshippers to this movement.



### 6.4.1. Saivism

Nayanmars played a significant role in the Bhakti movement. They were very pious and orthodox men. The Periyapuranam of Sekkilar is a compilation of the biographies of the sixty-three Saiva saints. Appar, Tirugnanasambandar, Sundarar and Manikavasakar are prominent among them. The Bhakti movement was stimulated initially by the 63 Nayanmars and it was first started by KaraikkalAmmaiyar.

The episodes in the life of the Nayanmars created awareness among the people. KaraikkalAmmaiyar was the wife a merchant at Karaikkal. When her husband understood her bhakti towards God, he left her. She, denounced her young body and attained the form of aged women to serve Lord Siva. There upon she stayed at Tiruvalangadu and sang hymns in praise of the deity at Tiruvalangadu, Later she witnessed the dance of Siva at Tiruvalangadu. She believed that there is only one God-Siva. Further she gave importance in her songs about the uncertainty of life.



Among the 63 SaivaNayanmars the most important are Tirunavakkarasar, Gananasambandar and Sundramurthy. They visited various temples in the country and sang verses in praise of Siva. Their hymns were collected in the Saiva canonical work called Devaram by Nambi Andar Nambi.. Their hymns portray a varied religious experience. Devaram hymnists have visited a total of 429 shirnes.

#### (1) Appar

**Appar (Thirunavukkarasar)** was the holiest among the Saiva Saints. His original name was Marulneekkiyar. . He was by birth a Vellala born at Tiruvamur (South Arcot district) and he

was a Jain at first and became a Jaina monk. At an early age he lost his parents. Sometime later Thirunavukkarasar was infested with a severe fever. He could not be cured. Ultimately he approached his sister Thilagavathi and was cured after offering prayers to Lord Siva. After this incident Thirunavukkarasar became a Saivite. One hearing the conversion from Jainism to Saivism the Pallava king Mahendravarman tortured Thirunavukkarasar. He was poisoned and dropped into the sea with big stone, but he survived. These miracles convinced the Pallava king Mahendravarman and he also converted to Saivism. Thirunavukkarasar toured many places and began singing Sivan's praise. Thiru GnaanaSambandar respectfully addressed Navukkarasar as Appar (father) and he and Appar travelled together singing hymns. Appar is said to have travelled to about a hundred and twenty-five temples in different cities or villages in Tamil Nadu. He composed 3<sup>rd</sup>, 4<sup>th</sup> and 5<sup>th</sup> Tirumurais. His approach to God is known as Chariya marga or Dasa Marga, where the relationship between God and devotee is that of a master to slave. In his 81<sup>st</sup> year he attained the heavenly abode at Tiruppugalur.

## (2) Tirugnanasambandar



Tirugnanasambandar was born in the family of Anthanar (Brahmana) in the first half of the 7<sup>th</sup> century at Sirkali (Thanjavur District). At the age of 3 he was offered the divine milk from Goddess Parvathi. . His parents took him to the shiva temple where Lord Shiva and his

consort Parvathi appeared before the child. His father saw drops of milk on the child's mouth and enquired who had fed him whereupon Tirugnanasambandar showed the sky and responded with the song "Todudaya Seviyan" which happens to be the first verse of Devaram. Since then he became a devoted servant of Siva. His hymns form the first three parts of Tirumurais. He toured the Tamil country singing in praise of Siva from the very early age. With the attraction of Jainism the pandyan king Koon Pandiyan became a Jaina but this was not liked by Tirugnanasambandar. In the mean time the Pandiyan queen mangaikkarasiyar invited him after the ruler fell ill. According to a Saiva legend Tirugnanasambandar performed music for the king, which cured the king's disease. Later with influence of Tirugnanasambandar the pandiya ruler was reconverted to Saivism.

According to some Saiva legends he performed many miracles. He defeated Jains at Madurai. He cured some persons of their diseases on his tour. The ancient text says that Tirugnanasambandar brought two people back to life by singing hymns to them. One of those resurrected was the daughter of a business man, who offered her to Sambandar in marriage. He declined due to knowledge that he would soon die. He is said to have attained salvation along with his bride during the marriage ceremony at the age of 16.

Tirugnanasambandar followed the kriya marga or sat-putra marga where the relationship between the God and devotee is that of a father to a son.

### **(3) Sundramurthy Nayanar (Nambiyarurar)**

Sundramurthy Nayanar was born at Navalur (South Arcot district) in a poor Brahmin family. He was brought up by the local chieftain NarasingaMunaiyadavriyar. When his marriage was about to take place, it was stopped by the intervention of Siva, in the guise of a Brahmin, who claimed him (Sundarar) as his slave. Sundramurthy Nayanar was taken to Tiruvennainallur where the Brahmin disappeared into the temple. Thereupon Sundramurthy Nayanar became a staunch devotee of Siva and praised him with his hymns. He was the author of the 7<sup>th</sup> Thirumarai. Like the other Nayanmars, Sundramurthy Nayanar is also credited with many miracles. Sundramurthy Nayanar became the friend of God and was known as Tambiran Tholan (friend of God). Sundramurthy Nayanar's approach to God is known as yoga marga or sakha Marga, where the relationship between God and devotee is that of a friend to friend.

#### (4) Manickavasagar

Manikkavasagar was born at Vadhavoor in Madurai district. Manikkavasagar was a minister to the Varagunavarman II of the Pandya king. He was sent to purchase horse for the Pandiya army by the ruler. He spent the money in building temples of Siva. When the Pandya king heard of this, Lord Siva sent horses to the Pandya court. However these horses turned to be jackals. Thereupon the king realized his mistake and approved Manikkavasagar's devotion to god. His approach to God is a famous one in the Tiruvilayadal Puranam. His approach to God is called Gnanamarga or Sanmarga. He has made an excellent contribution Saivite literature. His masterpieces are Tiruvasagam and Tiruchirrambalakovai.

Manikkavasagar's work Tiruvembavai is a collection of 20 hymns and in that he has praised the importance of Paavai Nonbu and praising Lord Shiva. These 20 songs and 10 songs of Tiruppalliezhuchi are sung all over Tamil Nadu in the month of Margazhi. Manikkavasagar's work Tiruvasagam was translated into English in the year 1921 by Francis Kingsbury and C.E. Philips and Oxford University Press published this work

#### 6.4.2 Vaishnavism

Vaishnavism is also known as Vishnuism and its followere are known as Vaishnavas. They considered Vishnu as the supreme Lord. Alwars played a significant role in the Bhakti movement. They were very pious and orthodox menthe Alwars are twelve in numbers.

#### (1) (a) Alwars

##### 12 Alwars



Among the 12 Alwars the first three Alwars were contemporary to the early Pallava rulers. The first three Alwars (Mudalawars) – Poyggaialwar, Puddattalwar and Peyalwar and Tirumaisaialwar have spread the tenets of Bhakti movement in the Pallava country. The **DiyyasuriCharitam** records the life history of these Alwars. All the Alwars were not normal children born in the ordinary way and bear names commemorating some occurrence in the lives. Tondinadu was their birth place. **Poykkaialwar** is said to have been born out of a lotus in Kanchi, **Pudattalwar**, of the Madhavi flower in Mallapuram and **Peyalwar** of Kairava flower at Mylapore. **Tirumalisai**, the fourth Alwar (7-8 A.D.) was a deformed child of a sage of the village Tirumalisai, which took shape only after it was abandoned on the roadside and was later brought by a Sudra.

The first three Alwars spent their early life in search of God. All the three wanderers met accidentally in a Vishnu temple at Tirukkovalur on a rainy day. While sleeping they felt the divine presence of Lord Vishnu on their mortal bodies who commanded them to sing His praise. Hence they composed Nalayira Divyaprabandam. Their works are free from sectarian bias.

**(b) ThirumalisaiAlwar** was a follower of Vaishnavism. He visited important Vaishnava shrines. He was a monotheist and preached that there is only one god Vishnu and that Brahma and Siva were created by him.

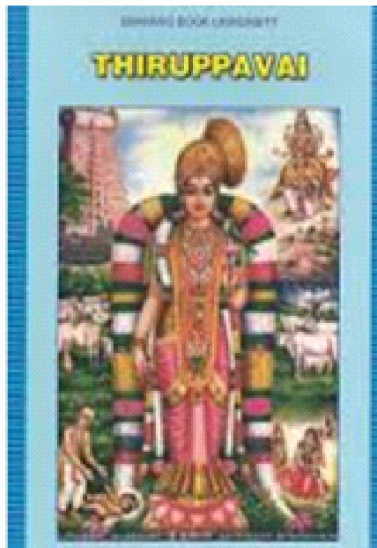
### **(c) TirumangaiAlwar**

TirumangaiAlwar was a kallar by birth. He resorted to robbery to renovate Srirangam temple. Lord Vishnu came in person in the guise of a bridegroom and uttered the eight syllable mantra “Om Na Mo Na Ra Ya Na Ya” into the ears of the belligerent devotee and converted him into a benevolent one.

## **3. Other Saints**

The Bhakti movement in the Pallava country was influenced by Nayanmars and Alwars of the neighbouring areas, particularly from the Pandya country.

The contributions of **Periyalwar** and **Andal** to Vaishnava Bhakti movement are significant. He was a Brahmin of Srivilliputtur in the Pandya country. He was the foster father of Andal. He converted Srimara Srivallabha to Vaishnavism.



Sri Andal or Kothai was the greatest among the women mystics of India. Her Thiruppavai contains 30 poems are very famous one. Even today in the Vishnu temples they recite Thiruppavai in the morning time in the month of Margai. Tiruppan Alwar, a minstrel of low caste was another important alwar, with his intense devotion acquired a place in the Bhakti movement. Tondoraidippodi alias Vipranarayana Alwar, a Brahmin by birth was another great devotee of Vishnu. Namalwar was a great mystic. His tiruvaymoli is supreme among the philosophical literature of the world.

Thus the devotion and intense love of these saints have supported the Bhakti movement from 6<sup>th</sup> to 10<sup>th</sup> centuries. Though these saints were born in Pandya country, they offered their devotion, and love to the religious centers situated well within the rule of the Pallava territory.

#### 4. Principles of Bhakti

**Saivism:** Bhakti is devotion to god. Devotion to God can be expressed in many ways. Bhakti can be expressed in its full form in the temples. Visiting to the temple, the abode of Siva, was considered as one of the chief virtues of the Bhakti. Worshipping Siva or participating in the pujas of Siva was considered as an important aspect of Bhakti. Reciting devotional songs to the accompaniments of musical instruments was also favoured. Taking the deities on processions and conducting regular festivals in the temples, were also recognized as a form of worship. The Bhakti movement stressed the supremacy of God Siva, love to God was manifested in the hymns of Nayanmars. The significance of five letters **Panchakshara-Namasivya** was



explained. Reciting the life stories of Nayanmars was considered as a way to attain moksha. Temple construction, repairing the existing temples, and even cleaning the premises of a temple were a means of showing Bhakti. These activities will ultimately lead to moksha. Similarly, granting donations to temples for feeding Saiva devotees was also a way of showing one's devotion to god. Sincere devotion of the devotees to God was also treated as Bhakti.

**Vaishnavism:** One of the basic tenants of the teachings of Alwar is the social and spiritual equality of the devotees, irrespective of their birth and economic status. Alvars laid emphasis on the aspect of social equality among the worshippers of Vishnu. They preached that those engaged in the service of Vishnu are all members of one society irrespective of their caste and creed. The Bhakti in Vaishnavism is influenced by the spirit of service to Vishnu. The service is explained in the Vaishnava phraseology as Kainkarya. It is an attitude in which the individual considers himself as a servant (dasa) of god. The servant is longing always for doing service to God. Another aspect of Vaishnava Bhakti is propounded in the attitude known as Nayaka Nayakibhava. In this attitude, the Lord Vishnu is considered as the holiest of all beings (Purushothaman) and the worshipper considering himself as a passionate woman entirely dependent on Vishnu. Another important aspect of Bhakti was the total surrender to Vishnu, great God. It is the prapattimarga, (complete surrender) an effective means of recurring salvation. In worshipping the supreme God, the practice of severe austerities was discouraged. More emphasis was laid on the repeated utterances of the thousand names of Vishnu than performing elaborate sacrifices.

## **The movement**

The Bhakti movement started in South India by spreading the life stories of 63 Nayanmars. The life histories of these saints were summarized by Sundarar in his Tiruttodattogai. Together with, the miracles of the Gananasambandar and Tirunavukarasar were also spread among the people. These miracles induced some sort of confidence among the way worshippers in the Hindu fold. The SaivaNayanmars expressed some sort of cosmopolitan outlook, in which, devotion of god was considered as supreme virtue and all other caste differences were not merited. In this the people of higher castes dining with the people of lower castes. The hunter Kannappar and Pulaiya were taken into Saiva fold. On the Vaishnava side also caste distinctions

were not shown. Tirumalisai and Tirumangai were taken into Vaishnava fold. These instances quickened the Bhakti movement in the Tamil country.

The conversions of Mahendravarman by Appar in the Hindu fold acted as an important event which prepared a favourable ground for further conversions. These disputations between the Hindus and Buddhists, as well as with Jains and the victory gained by the Hindu saints are other reason for the success of the Bhakti movement. The Royal patronage to construct the temples may be considered as another important reason for the spread of Bhakti cult in Tamilnadu.

### **Check your Progress – 2**

1. Describe the role of Nayanmars for the growth of Saivism
2. Analyse the part played by the Alwars for the growth of Vaishnavism.

## **6.5 Literature**

The Pallava rulers were great patrons of both Tamil and Sanskrit languages. Their capital Kanchi had remained a great centre of Sanskrit learning. Most of the Tamil woks were religious compositions. There are a few secular compositions also. Among the Sanskrit works mention may be made to two works authored by the king poet Mahendravarman. They are of the force style. Buddhists composed few religious works in Prakrit. The Tamils adopted a kind of literary style known as andadi in this period. An andadi is a composition in which the last word or phrase of the preceding verse is taken as the first word or phrase of the following verse. Such andadi works are numerous in this period. Another style of works was popular in this period was Prabhandam, Padigam, another style of poetry was also employed mostly in the devotional literature. The use of Venba meter was popular in this period. Other methods followed in this period are viruttam and Kattalaikkaliturai.

In the Tamil literary works Religious literary works are in prominent position. Let us analyse their works. First we are dealing with Saiva works.

### 6.5.1. Saiva works

#### 1. Devotional Literature:

According to A.L.Basham, “the hymns of the Nayanmars and Alvars are among the greatest contribution to the world’s religious literature”. To prove to his words we have great literary works of KaraikkalAmmaiyar

#### KaraikkalAmmaiyar



#### Works of KaraikkalAmmaiyar:

KaraikkalAmmaiyar's original name was Punithavathy. She wrote many Tamil literary works. Among the Tamil devotional literature works of KaraikkalAmmaiyar can be considered as first work. She was a woman saint who sang two padigams of 22 verses on the Lord Shiva of Tiruvalangadu (Tiruvalangadu Mutta-tirupptigam). In it she portrays in detail about the divine dance of Siva in the cremation ground along with the ghost of that place. Two other works, Thiruvirattainmanimalai and Arpudattiruvandadi were composed by her in the Andaldi style. The first work consisted of 20 verses composed in Venba and Kattalaikkalitturai meters. The later work consists of 100 verses and in this work she adores the God in various manifestations.

2. **The Kshetrat-Tiruvenba** of AiyadigalKadavarkon was another work of 24 verses of Venba meter written in Andadi style. In this work the author lists 22 Saiva shrines including Ujjain (Makkalam) which were held in high esteem in his day. Though the author hailed from Tondainadu, most of the shrines praised by him are located in the Chola country. The author

gave importance to a few religious centres and they are Kumbakonam, Chidambaram, Tiruvarur, Tiruvanaikkal, Tirumalapadi, Mylapore and Tiruvotriyur.

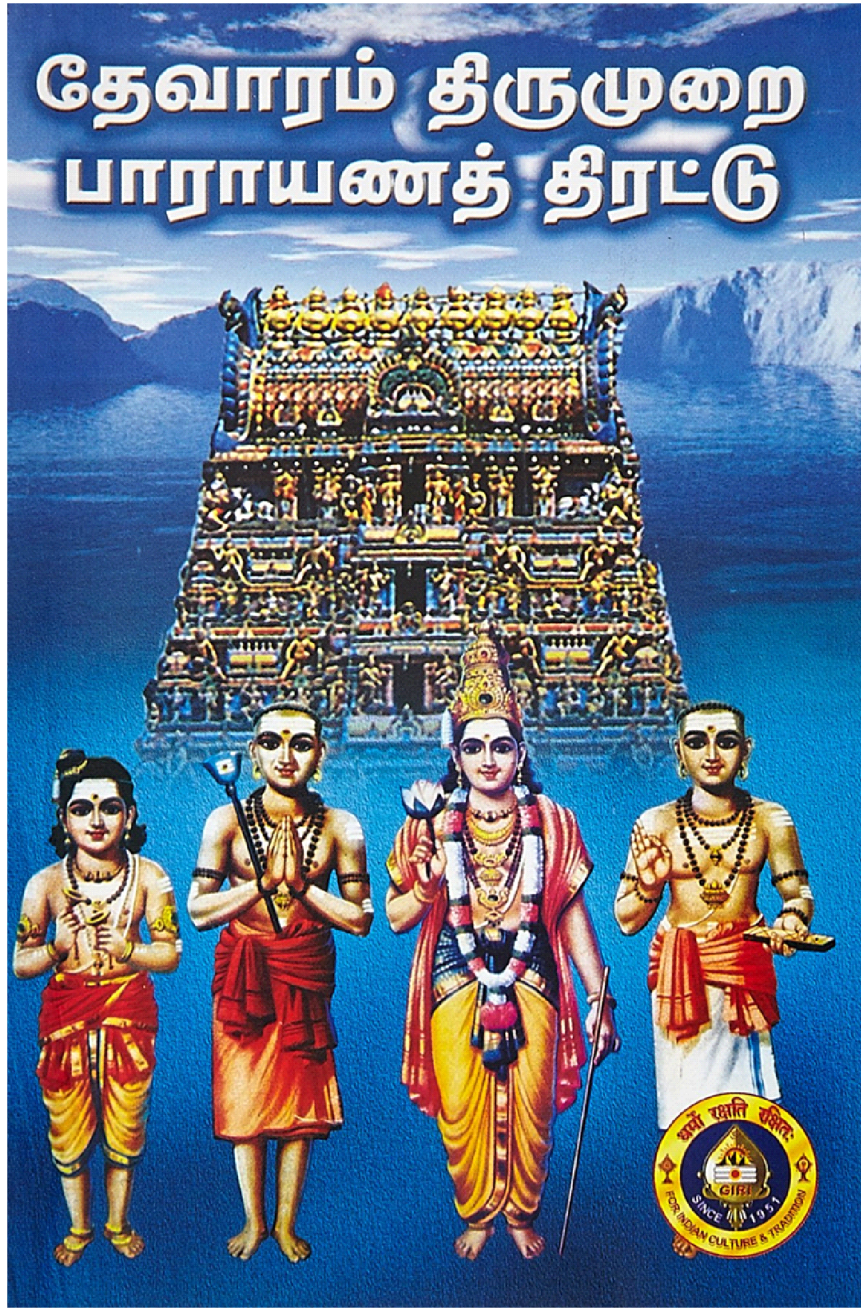
### **3.Tirumular's Tirumandiram**

The Tirumandiram is a Tamil poetic work written by Tirumular and is the 10<sup>th</sup> Tirumarai which uses the texts of Saiva Siddhanta and this is first Tamil work to use this term. In Tamil the Tirumandiram is the earliest exposition of the Shiva Agamas. It consists of over 3000 verses dealing with various aspects of spirituality, ethics and praise of Lord Shiva. This work is more spiritual than religious and one can see the difference between Vedanta and Siddhanta from his interpretation of "Mahavakavyas".

This work is considered as a manual of Saiva mysticism. Tirumular was a Brahman yogi from Kailasa, migrated to the south to meet the Agastyar. At Tiruvaduturai he entered the dead body of a shepherd out of pity for the herd which had just lost him. He led the herd back home in the evening and then abandoned the shepherd's family. Then he meditated upon God and wrote out the doctrines of Siva Philosophy in 3000 verses at the rate of one verse in one year. All the 3000 verses of the tirumandiram are divided into 9 tantras (section) and each tantra deals with one separate topic. Of the 9 tantras the second tantra, explains about Sivapuranas, the third and fourth on yoga and the mantropasana, the fifth about the different forms of Saivism and the sixth on the Sivagurudarsavas. This work was written in a simple language. He convinced that mortal body was not a hindrance for the attainment of salvation. According to Venkataraman a historian Tirumular's Tirumandiram covers the entire feature of Siddhar cult of the Tamils.

### **4. Thevaram:**

Thevaram indicates the first seven volumes of Tirumurai. All seven volumes are dedicated to the works of the three most prominent Tamil poets of the 7<sup>th</sup> century namely Saiva Saints Gnanasambandar, Tiruavukkarasar and Sundarar. During the reign of Raja Raja Chola I collection of these songs were found in Chidambaram temple and it was compiled by NamiyandarNambi.



The songs were originally recited by these saints in the temples in praise of the presiding deity, they have visited. All the three saints have collectively visited 429 temples in the entire Tamil country and have sung more than hymns divided into 797 padigams, each padigam containing approximately 10 verses and more. These 8000 hymns were divided into seven books (Tirumurai). The first three books consisting 384 padigams were sung by Gnanasambandar, the most celebrated Saiva hymnist. The next three books consisting of 313



padigams were sung by Appar and the rest was by Sundarar, which consisted the 7<sup>th</sup> book of the Saiva canon.

Devaram hymns contain many allusions to the saivasiddhantha philosophical system. The hymns of Smabandar are well known for their youthful vigor and imagination. The Spontaneous outpourings of devotion can also be witnessed in his hymns. In every one of his padigams he condemns the Jains. In the hymns Appar condemns caste and conceit of learning. He was preached equality of human beings and condemns orthodoxy and blind in the sastras. The hymns of devaram are marked by an exceptional high literary quality. The practice of singing Devaram is continuing in many Siva temples in Tamil Nadu even today.

## 6.5.2 Vaishnava Works

### 1. Nalayira Diva Prabhandam :

| Sl no | Name of the prabandham   | Starting from | Number of pasurams | Sung by                  | Sl no | Name of the prabandham   | Starting from | Number of pasurams | Sung by                   |
|-------|--------------------------|---------------|--------------------|--------------------------|-------|--------------------------|---------------|--------------------|---------------------------|
| 1     | Periazhvar Thirumozhi    | 1             | 473                | PeriyAZHVAR              | 13    | Mudhal Thiruvandhadhi    | 2082          | 100                | Poigai AZHVAR             |
| 2     | Thiruppavai              | 474           | 30                 | Aandaal                  | 14    | Irاندam Thiruvandhadhi   | 2182          | 100                | BhoothathAZHVAR           |
| 3     | Nachiar Thirumozhi       | 504           | 143                | Aandaal                  | 15    | Moonram Thiruvandhadhi   | 2282          | 100                | PeyAZHVAR                 |
| 4     | Perumal Thirumozhi       | 647           | 105                | Kulasekara AZHVAR        | 16    | Naanmugan Thiruvandhadhi | 2382          | 98                 | Thirumalaisai AZHVAR      |
| 5     | Thiruchchanda Viruththam | 752           | 120                | Thirumalaisai AZHVAR     | 17    | Thiruviruththam          | 2478          | 100                | NammAZHVAR                |
| 6     | Thirumalai               | 872           | 45                 | Thondaradippodi AZHVAR   | 18    | Thiruvasiriyam           | 2578          | 7                  | NammAZHVAR                |
| 7     | Thiruppalliyezhu chchi   | 917           | 10                 | Thondaradippodi AZHVAR   | 19    | Peria Thiruvandhadhi     | 2585          | 87                 | NammAZHVAR                |
| 8     | Amalanadhi piran         | 927           | 10                 | Thiruppaan AZHVAR        | 20    | Thiruvezhukkurrirkkai    | 2672          | 1                  | Thirumangai AZHVAR        |
| 9     | Kanni Nun Siruththambu   | 937           | 11                 | Madhurakavi AZHVAR       | 21    | Siriyai Thirumadal       | 2673          | 40                 | Thirumangai AZHVAR        |
| 10    | Peria Thirumozhi         | 948           | 1084               | Thirumangai AZHVAR       | 22    | Peria Thirumadal         | 2713          | 78                 | Thirumangai AZHVAR        |
| 11    | Kurun Thandagam          | 2032          | 20                 | Thirumangai AZHVAR       | 23    | Thiruvay Mozhi           | 2791          | 1102               | NammAZHVAR                |
| 12    | Nedum Thandagam          | 2052          | 30                 | Thirumangai AZHVAR       | 24    | Ramanuja Nootrandhadhi   | 3893          | 108                | Thiruvarangaththamudanaar |
|       |                          |               |                    | Total number of pasurams |       |                          |               | 4000               |                           |

| பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை |
|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|
| பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை |
| பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை | பொருத்தொருமை |

The contributions of the Alvars for the spread of religion are remarkable. The first three Alvars belonged to the Tondianadu and have contributed to the devotional literature in a big

way. The other Vaishnava saints had also contributed to the enrichment of literature. The hymns of the Alvars were compiled by Nathamuni Acharya and it was known as Nalayira Divya Prabhandam in the 10<sup>th</sup> century. The work contains 4000 hymns of the Alvars. It is divided into four books and each book containing one thousand verses. The contribution of the first three Alvars **namely Poyagai Alwar, Pey Alwar and Pudattalwar** are known as 'Tiruvandadi.' This work is included in this fourth book 'Iyarpa'. Each Tiruvandadi contains 100 pasurams (hymns) composed in the Andadi style of Venba meter. The compositions are regarded as unequalled for their simplicity and lyrical beauty. The main subject of the andadis narrates about the Miracles and the Incarnations of Vishnu.

## 2. The TiruchchandaviruttamandNanmuganTiruvandadi

These two works were composed by Tirumalisai Alwar. The first work contains 120 pasurams and included in the first book (Mudalayiram) of the Divya Prabhandam. It explains about the Vaishnava philosophy which is beyond the comprehension of an ordinary person. The latter work contains 96 pasurams in viva meter and included in the last book (Iyarpa) of the Divya Prabhandam. The theme of this work is give importance of the supremacy of Narayana and Lakshmi. The greatness of devotees is also explained.

## 3. Periyathirumoli,

It is a work of Tirumangai Alwar consists of 1084 pasurams. The work is dedicated to numerous Vaishnava shrines in the Tamil country as well as those in North India. It contains valuable historical data on the different battles fought by Nandivarman-II against the Chalukya, Pandya rulers. The flourishing condition of towns and temples and brisk overseas trade are vividly portrayed in this work. Tirumangai Alwar's other works are **Tirukkuruntandagam, Tirunedutandagam, Tiruvelukkurikkai, Siriyirumedal** and **Periya Tirumedal**. The above works consisted of 169 pasurams. They are included in the 2<sup>nd</sup> thousand (Periyathirumoli) of the Divya Prabhandam collection. In the Vaishnav canon the contributions of Tirumangai (1253 pasurams) is one of the largest.

## 4. Other works

The saints of the Saiva and Vaishnava sect from the neighboring areas have also contributed to the enrichment of the devotional literature. Though their works do not have any

direct bearing on the Pallava literature, they are referred here. Manikkavasagar's Tiruvasagam form the 8<sup>th</sup> book of the Saiva canon. It contains 51 hymns. His Tiruttondartogai, sung at Tiruvarur narrates the life stories of the 52 Nayanmars. The Tiruvasagam is the epitome of the philosophic mysteries of Tamil Saivism. Tiruvarur Mummaikkovai and Ponvannattu Andadi are the other works of importance.

Though a few Alvars come from outside the Pallava country they have praised the Lord of Srirangam and Tiruvengadam, Kulasekhara has sung three decades in Periyatirumoli a work consisting of 105 verses. Tiruppanalwar and Tondaraidippodi Alwar have sung poems in praise of Sriranganatha.

## **5. Prakrit and Sanskrit Works**

Prakrit and Sanskrit literary works were flourished in the Pallava kingdom. The Pallava royal family patronized Sanskrit poets. Prakrit language was encouraged by the Buddhists and they authored few books. The Abhidammavataara of Buddhadhotta (5<sup>th</sup> A.D.) explains the importance of dharma of Buddha. It further narrates about the flourishing status of trade in the famous port city of Kaveripumpattinam. The life of the rich merchants and their political abodes and five parts in the city are also explained. The other work, Vinayavinichchayam also written at Kaveripumpattinam refers to the condition of Buddhism in the southern part of India. This work serves us a useful source material to study about the social life of the people in the cities.

## **6. Works of Bharavi**

The scholars praise the rule between Simhavishnu to Narashimavarman as the golden age of the Sanskrit literature in the Pallava kingdom. Scholars from distinct regions have enriched the Sanskrit literature. Bharavi's Kiratarguniya, describes in 18 sections the penance of Arjuna to obtain the Pasupatastra. Bharavi's story is narrated in the Dandin's Avantisundarikatasara. Domodara, was the son of Narayansvamin, a Brahmin migrated from Anandapura and settled at Achalapura (near Nasik). He secured the friendship of Vishnuvardhana (King Eastern Chalukya) and in course of hunting expedition consumed animal flesh. To exonerate the sin he started on a pilgrimage to holy places in the courses of which he stayed for sometime in the court of Durvinita. In order to patronize Sanskrit scholars



the pallava ruler Simhavishnu invited Bharavi to his court. Bharavi composed the literary work in praise of the pallava ruler Simhavishnu.

## 7. Works of Mahendravarman

**Mattavilasaprahasana** was composed by Mahendra-I. It is a one act force in which the play centres round the frolics of drunken kapalin, Sathysoma and his wife Devasoma. At one state Satyasoma discovers that his skull bowl is missing and accuses a Buddhist monk. They both find a Pasupata monk, as their mediator. Finally the problem was settled with the entry of a lunatic with the skull bowl which he had taken from the dog of a chandela. The play is mixed with fun, humor and wit. From this work we come to know about the social life and religious conditions of the Pallava period.

### Bhagavadgiugam

This is another work also written by Mahendravarman I. However the anonymous commentator of the work assigned this work to Bodhayana. The name of the work is mentioned in the Mamandur inscription along with Mattavilasa prahasana and hence the scholars have come to a conclusion that this work was written by Mahendravarman I.

### Avantisundarikatasara

Dandin was the court poet of the Pallava King Rajasimha-II. and he wrote Avantisundarikatasara. The historical introduction of Avantisundarikatasara mentions that the Chalukya king Vishnuvardhana and the western Ganga ruler Durnimita and Simhavishnu are contemporaries. Kavyadarsha is the other work written by Dandin both the works are considered as the most important Sanskrit Literary works.

### 6.5.3. Tamil Works

Though the Pallava rulers patronised Sanskrit scholars few Tamil literary works are also available. Few works of the eighteen minor works (**Padinenkikkanakku**) are included in this period. The Jains were patronised by the Muttaraiyars the feudatories of the Pallava rulers

## Nandikkalambakkam

It is a secular work. It gives a clear picture of the history and achievements of Nandivaraman-III. This was an important work composed during the days of Nandivaraman-III. The author of this work is not known. It is a quasi-historical work of about 80 verses in various meters. It describes the various events of the region of the Nandivarman-III. Traditionally it is believed that the work was composed by the brother of Nandivarman-III, in order to kill Nandivarman-III to get the throne. These poems were sung with the mystical vengeance and finally Nandivarman-III was burnt alive when last verse was recited. The work refers to the military victories of Nandivarman-III in several battle fields like Tellaru, Kadambar, Palaiyaru and Kurukkotai. Few titles of the Nandivarman, like Avaninaranam, Todaivamdham, and Desabhandari are mentioned in this literary work. Nandivarman-III is described as a great lover of Tamil and Perundevanar (the author of Bhaatavemba) adorned his court.

Another important Tamil work was that of Bharatavemba of Perundevanar, described the story of Mahabharata in Tamil Muthollayiram was written during this period. It deals with the three great kings. The author of this work is not known. A Jaina work Sulamani was written by Tolamoli Tevar also belonged to the Pallava period.

Among the works of grammar and lexicography are the Kalladam of Kalladanar, Pingalam of Pingalanar, Purapporu Nenbamalai of Aiyam-artinae (editor) , Iraiyanar Ahapporul Urai etc.

## Review Questions – 3

1. Write about the Sanskrit literatures of the Pallava Period.
2. Discuss the growth of Tamil literature during the Pallava period.

## 6.6 Summary

The Pallava rule in the Tamil country witnessed the movements of different religions. Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism were the three major religious prospered in this period. The kings and people have patronised all the three religions in various order of preference. It was generally suggested that there was religious tolerance in the Pallava Kingdom.

## **6.7 Answers to Review Questions**

### **Review Questions – 1**

1.   a. see the subsection 6.2.2 (1)  
      b. see the subsection 6.2.2 (2)
2.   see the subsections 6.2.3 and 6.2.4
3.   see the subsections 6.3 and 6.3. (1) & (2)

### **Review Questions – 2**

1.   see the subsections 6.4.1 (1) to (3)
2.   see the subsections 6.4.2. and 6.4.2(1) to (3)

### **Review Questions – 3**

1.   see the subsections 6.5.2. (5) to (7)
2.   see the subsection 6.5.3

## **LESSON - 7**

# **THE ART AND ARCHITECTURE OF THE PALLAVAS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After having gone through this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Recall the features of the Pallava's temple art and architecture.
- ❖ Analyse the structural temples under the Pallavas
- ❖ Discuss the development of sculpture and paintings during the reign of the Pallavas.

### **Structure**

#### **7.1 Introduction**

#### **7.2 Architecture**

##### **7.2.1 Cave Temples**

##### **7.2.2 Monolithic Rathas**

##### **7.2.3 Structural Temples**

#### **7.3 Sculpture**

##### **7.3.1 Sculptures at Mamallapuram**

##### **7.3.2 Paintings**

#### **7.4 Summary**

#### **7.5 Answers to Review Questions**

### **7.1 Introduction**

The history and development of Pallava art and architecture constitutes a fascinating chapter in the annals of Indian History says Dr C. Minakshi. The Pallavas began the great age of temple building. Percy Brown says that if all the great powers that together made the history of Southern India, none had a more marked effect on the architecture of the region than the earliest of all, that of the Pallavas, "whose productions provided the foundations of the Dravidian style".

They were the pioneers in the history of the Dravidian architecture which constituted a brilliant chapter in South Indian History.

The Pallava architecture shows the transition from the rock-cut temples to the stone built temples. The earliest examples of the Pallava art are the rock –cut temples of the 7<sup>th</sup> century A.D. The latest examples are of structural temples built in 8<sup>th</sup> and 9<sup>th</sup> century. The lasting monolithic temples are known as Rathas and Mandapas. From this we can understand the skill of the sculptors of the Pallava period. The shore temple in Mahabalipuram is the best example for their excellence in the structural temples.

## 7.2 Art and Architecture



In the Pallava period there was a great encouragement to art and architecture. The Pallava architecture is confined only to the religious architecture and not on secular buildings like palaces which are not in existence today. In the Managapattu cave temple inscription Mahendravarman I say that he completely avoided the use of bricks, lime and wood for the construction of the temple for the first time. Nearly twenty cave temples were excavated during the Mahendra period in different places. These temples dedicated to Vishnu, Siva and Tirmurthi

From Mahendravarman I to the end of the Pallava period we have two broad divisions of architectural style. They are (1) rock cut temples and (2) structural temples

## 1. Rock-cut Temples



The Rock Cut Temples of Mahabalipuram

Mahendravarman I was the beginner of the rock-cut pattern. According to Dr. T.V.Mahalingam, "it was Mahendravarman who handled hard rock's perhaps for the first time after Asoka and achieved a success that has earned for him a niche in the temple of Indian art." In the pre-pallavan period, only brick structures were built. Stone was not used for the construction of temples. This is one of the reasons that we do not get any religious structure of the Sangam Age. Therefore the introduction of stone masonry in the construction of temples was considered to be a novel idea of the pallava ruler. The mandagapattu inscription says that "This brick less timber less, metalless and amortaarless temple which is a mansion for Brahma, Eswara and Vishnu was caused to be created by the king Vichitra- Chitta". According to J.Dubrenil "Mahendravarman imported the rock-cut pattern from the Vishnukundins."

The Mandagapattu temple with three garbha grahas is dedicated to the Lords of Hindu Trinity. The Pancha-Pandava temple at Mamandur, the Mahendra-vishnugraham at Mahendravadi, Malleswara temple at Dalavanur etc., are important specimen of this type. Most walls of these temples are adorned with plastic arts of incomparable quality.

## 2. Rock-cut Architecture

The technique of scooping out a cave or a mandapa is very interesting. The work will start from the top portion and gradually the middle and lower parts of the cave will be cut out. Therefore the first portion scooped out will be the roof and its superstructure then comes the body-walls and lastly the basement. This method is evidently seen, as there caves the Vimana and the Garbhagraha scooped out and finished. But the basement is left untouched and stands as rock portion. The same method was followed in the case of Ajanta and Ellora caves.

The caves of the pallavas seen in the Tondaimandalam are covering the modern districts of Chingleput, North Arcot, Tiruchirapalli and parts of Andhra Pradesh. The cave is nothing but a mandapa either square or rectangular in plan with one more cells on the interior of the back wall. The mandapa bears one or two rows pillars – each row having more the 4 pillars. It is sometimes shown projecting with short pillars and looking like a shrine or niche. The caves have flat roofs in most cases and there are a few with two or three storeys.

We may also notice some evolution or stages of progress in the cave architecture. There are a number of caves which bear beautiful sculptures and carving on the interior walls and pillars. The Mamallapuram caves can be suggested as best examples. They contain the figures of Vishnu Sive, Brahma, Durga, Lakshmi, Sarasvati and numerous other forms of Siva and avatars of Vishnu. There are Sculptured panels depicting scenes from Ramayana. Mahabharata and Puranas. We can see the pallava caves in the following places namely Mamallapuram, Mandagapattu, Tiruchirapalli Rock for (foot of the fort) Mahendravadi etc.

### **3. Mamallapuram**

Mamallapuram is a great centre of art and architecture of the pallavas and attracts tourists and art lovers from all over the world. It has more than 14 cave -temples, 9 monolithic shrines, 3 structural stone temples and 4 relief sculptured rock panels. It has the earliest datable rock-cut mandapas, rathas and structure temples of the Dravidian style. The monuments seem to have been originally decorated with paintings, traces of which are noticed even today in the Adi-varaha cave temple. These caves and rathas bear inscriptions in Pallava grantha characters and from this we can assign their date.

### **4. Authorship**

The authorship of the monuments at mamallapuram is controversial issue. There are two theories (1) the monuments are dated according to their architectural styles; (2) according to the palaeography of the inscriptions on the wall of the monuments. The first theory was put forth by K.R. Srinivasan and according to him most of the monuments belong to Narasimha Varman-1. He classified them as belonging to different styles such as Mahendra's style, Mamalla's style etc. The Mahendra's style was followed by Narasimhavarman-(Mamalla). The style was continued under the successors of Mamalla like Mahendra-II or Paramesvaram.

The structural temple was first introduced by Narasimhavarman-II (Rajasimha). The second theory was postulated on the basis of the study of the inscriptions. The inscriptions on the rathas contain a number of titles borne by Rajasimha and therefore they were described to him. Further he is believed to have excavated the mandapas also as the ruler has immense interest to create varieties of monuments at the same place.

The Mamallapuram monuments may be studied under three categories namely (1) Cave temple, (2) Monolithic rathas, (3) Structural temples.

### **7.2.1 Cave Temples**

There has been difference of opinion about the authorship of the group of cave temples, penance panels and the Five Rathas. R. Nagaswamy expressed the view that Rajasimha (Narasimhavarman II) was the sole author of all the Mamallapuram monuments and inscriptions. They are about a dozen cave temples. To name a few Dharamaraja Mandapa, Kotikal Mandapa, Tirumurthi Cave, Varaha Cave, Adivaraha temple Ramanuja Mandapa, Panchapandava mandapa and Mahishamardhani cave etc. There are few more caves but they do not exhibit workmanship or sculptures. Among the above mentioned caves, the following deserves detailed discussion.

#### **1. Trimurthi cave**

It is triple-celled dedicated to the trinity namely Siva, Vishnu and Brahma. The three cells are guarded by door keepers in bas-reliefs. The figure of the god is carved in bas-relief on the back wall of the cells.

#### **2. Varaha Mandapa**

The cave is noted for its beautiful sculptures on the interior walls of the porch. The sculptures represent Vishnu in the Varaha and Tiruvikrama avatars and also Goddess Gajalakshmi and Durga.

#### **3. Adivaraha Temple**

It is one of the biggest caves with rich sculptures. Here again the Varaha avatars of Vishnu are sculptured inside the shrine chamber. There are portrait sculptures representing the



rulers Narasimhavarman-I and his father Mahendravarman-I and their queens. This is an interesting feature of this cave.

#### **4. Mahishasuramardhani Cave**

This is yet another triple-celled mandapa. The central shrine contains the figure of Somaskanda in bas-relief. They are also sculptured panels depicting Durga fighting with the demon and Vishnu as Sesgasatyin. These two panels are remarkable for their artistic merit originally of treatment and skilful execution.

### **7.2.2 Monolithic Rathas**

There are 9 rathas of which 6 are almost finished and the other 3 are unfinished and incomplete at their bottom. Of these, 5 caves are found in one area and named after the pancha pandavas in the later period. Each ratha is carved out of a single rock and it is cut model of a structural temple of timber construction of the earliest period. They contain a garbha and a verandah.

#### **1. Five Rathas**

They are named after Draupati, Arjuna, Bhima, Dharmaraja and Sahadeva

#### **2. Draupati Ratha**

It is but shaped and dedicated to Durga. It shares its platform with Arjuna ratha. There is a huge sculpture of Durga on the inner wall of the shrine.

#### **3. Arjuna Ratha**

It is dedicated to Siva. It is square in share and single storied; and adorned at the top up an octagonal dome. Chatiya motifs and string courses of miniature shrine motifs run around the storeys.

#### **4. Bhima Ratha**

It is rectangular in plan with wagon topped or Sikhara having gable ends on either side. The porch has rows of pillar with lion base. It is incomplete. This plan and shape served as prototype for the Gopurams of South Indian temples in the subsequent periods.

## 5. Dharmaraja Ratha

It is dedicated to Siva and three storied and square in plan. The ground floor is unfinished and the first floor houses the sanctum with pradakshina patha. The walls of the upper storey contain small niches with sculptures representing various aspects of Siva and Vishnu. There are inscriptions on the walls declaring its date of construction and author.

## 6. Sahadeva Ratha

It is unique in its ground plan because it has an apsidal ground plan and elephant back top. It is known as Gajaprishta shrine in Sanskrit. This may be called a representative type of the Vesara style of architecture prevalent in the Karnataka area.

## 7. Ganesa Ratha

It is also an apsidal shrine but with wagon top roof and gable ends. The above mentioned rathas thus represent different shapes and style in the temples architecture of Tamil nadu. The pallavas created these rathas to serve them as models for the future guidance. That is why they present varieties. Further, they were no meant for offering worship as suggested by their unfinished characters. It may be stressed here that these rathas with different ground plan and Vimana served as prototypes for the storied temples and gopurams of the later period. Thus this is an important contribution of the pallavas to Dravidian architecture.

### Review Questions -1

1. Write short note on Mamallapuram
2. Examine the cave architecture introduced by the Pallavas
- 3 Describe the monolithic rathas of the Pallavas.

### 7.2.3 Structural Temples

#### Importance of Shore Temple, Mahabalipuram

From Kuram records we get information about Structural temples. Shore Temple is granite made temple at Mahabalipuram built during the period of Narsimhavarman. This group of temples is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and is oldest structural temple in India. There is only



one temple i.e. the famous shore temple. It is one of the few earliest structural temples of the pallavas. It is in a most dilapidated condition and its prakaras and frontal portions had been ruined by Nature's fury. However a conjectural restoration suggests that the temple had originally two small concentric outer Prakaras with entrance at the western side. Now the temple is rueing most, while its eastern wing abutting into the sea waters almost. The cell measures 12 square and 11 heights. There is circumambulatory passage around it. The vimana is three storied. Inside the cell a Somaskanda panel is seen on the wall. On the western side, there is third shrine of Vishnu in a recumbent position. This is later addition. As said earlier there was originally one or two outer prakaras for the temples. But at present they are razed to the ground.

The wall of the eastern shrine is decorated with rampant lion shaped pilasters at regular intervals. It is an excellent temple, which is a combined complex of 3 shines, one dedicated to Vishnu and the remaining two dedicated to Shiva. This temple indicates the culmination of the architectural efforts that began with the cave temples and monolithic rathas. 7 Pagodas is a

term associated this temple. It is said that the 6 more temples were associated with it, all now submerged in water.

### **TIGER CAVE AT SALUVANKUPPAM**



#### **1. Tiger Cave at Saluvankuppam**

Besides the above monuments, there is yet another unique cave at Saluvankuppam about 5 K.M. north of Mamallapuram. It is large mass of rock 60' length and 2'-height. A shrine is excavated at the central portion. The facade is shaped like the mark of a tiger with griffin heads in relief and hence it is called tiger cave. It is said that the animal depicted is the mythological Yali and hence it is also known as Yali Mandapam.

It is also said that the shrine was used as a stage to render musical concerts and excavated according to the principles of acoustics of buildings. The mandapam is like an open air theatre and even today some cultural events are held here. Small hillocks, big boulders set amidst casuarinas' trees and the sandy shores make this place as a great heaven for birds and a picnic spot.

## 2. Pillars

The pillars show evolutionary stages. The pillars in the beginning are very simple. They are very short, bulky and plain. They have a square base and bracket capital. In the next stage they have become taller exhibiting more workmanship. The body is faced and fluted and the capital is shaped like an inverted lotus flower and above it is placed a broad abacus (Palakai). The base bears a squatting lion or yali. In the final stage, the lower portion of the pillar is shaped like a rampant lion or yali. This type of pillar has become a permanent feature of the later. Pallavan pillars and they may be considered as a criterion to identify Pallava monuments. Plasters of this shape are being used as a decorative motif to adorn the outer walls of the sanctum and prakaras as seen in the shore temples at Mamallapuram and Kailasanatha and other temples at Kanchipuram.

These types of pillars were also adopted by the early Cholas in areas like Tondaimandalam which marked the transitional stage from the Pallavas to the early Cholas.

## 3. Kanchipuram

Kanchipuram was the capital of the Pallavas. It is one of the oldest and sacred cities in India. It was flourishing as a centre of all the four major religions in India namely Saivism, Vaishnavism, Buddhism and Jainism. It served as a meeting place for different religious sects and cultures. Most of the Pallava temples are located at Kanchipuram and they are considered to be the earliest datable structural temples of the Dravida style. The following are the Pallava temples which are in existence today at Kanchipuram (1) Kailasanatha Temple 2. Vaikunthaperumal Temple 3. Mukteswara Temple 4. Matangesvara Temple 5. Amaresvara Temple 6. Airavarisvara Temple 7. Piravatisvara temple and 8. Ravanatisvara Temple.

## 4. Kailasanatha Temple

It was built by Rajasimha. It is called Rajasimhesvara after him. This temple is the “greatest architectural masterpiece”. It is an art gallery with innumerable minor shrines, considered to be “apogee of the Pallava style”. It is famous for its architectural designs and sculptural wealth. It is well proportioned, Substantial and rhythmic in its mass and elegant in its outlines.

The temple has three components 1. The main shrine with its vimana and the separate pillar mandapa in front 2 Prakara and a separate shrine known as mahendravarmanvara in front of the pillard mandapa and 3. Outer courtyard

### **5. Main shrine (Sanctum)**

The main shrine is square sub-shrines attached at its three sides and corners. These sub-shrines are projecting outside and thus give a star-shape outline of the sanctum.

The vimana has three storeys adorned at the top by an octagonal stone. The base of the temple bears ornamental moulding and relief sculptures.

### **6. Prakara**

The prakara wall bears as many as 58 niches with sculptures representing various aspects of Siva etc. They were originally painted and traces of such paintings are visible even today. They may be called replica of main shrine but in miniature forms. The prakara wall carries at its centre on all the four sides a rectangular sala (wagon Topped roof) and this structural motif at the top of the main entrance on the western side is imposing and suggests the Pallava's sincere attempt to design a pattern (rectangular as in the case of the gopuras) for the main entrance to a Hindu temple. Further, the Mahendravarmanvara shrine has also a rectangular ground plan and occupies the frontal portion near the entrance. This structure and its disposition are marvellous and really a subsequent periods the Cholas and the Pandyas, picked up this idea and also adopted this structural design while shaping the gopuras. The idea of providing entrances in all the four directions is also evident from the distribution of the Salas at the top of the midprakara walls of this temple.

### **7. Outer Courtyard**

The entrance to the temple is provided in the outer courtyard on the western side and the entry in to the prakara is provided by a narrow opening on both sides (southern and northern sides)

### **8. Nandi Mandapa**

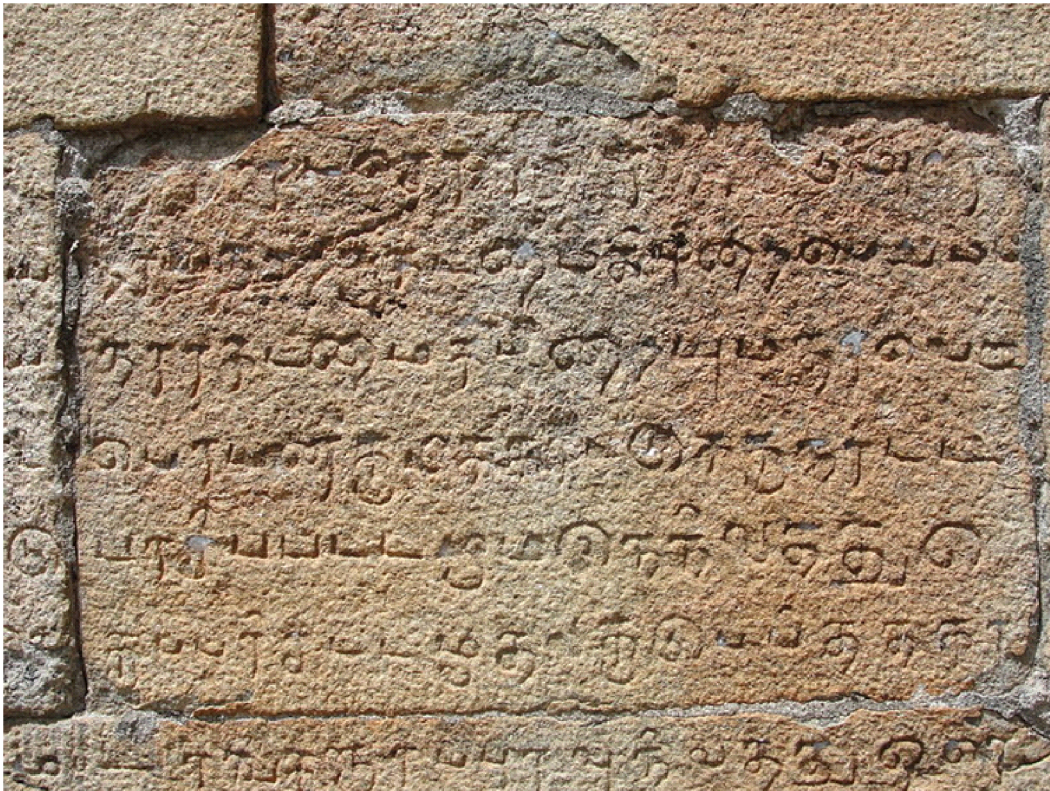
In front of the temple at a distance, a huge monolithic Nandi is seen within a shelter. It may be called as Nandi Mandapa.



## 9. Sculptures

The sub-shrines around the sanctum carry sculpture representing Siva, Vishnu, Brahma, Somaskanda, Nandi etc. The well known aspects of Siva such as Bhikshatana Gangadhara and Tripurantaka are also depicted. Similarly, as said earlier, the various cells on the inner walls of the prakara bear beautiful sculptures in relief exhibition the Hindu gods and mythological scenes. Since Kailasantha temple is the earliest of a series of pallava temple at Kanchipuram, the sculptures there in represent the earliest phase of plastic art in Tamilnadu. They also exhibit the scholarship of the master craftsmen in the execution of art specimens and sculptured panels. They are narrative to some extent and informative to a large extent.

## 10. Inscriptions



There are a number of inscriptions noticed in the temple which help us to date the style and the various temple complexes. The inscription belongs to both the Pallavas and Western Chalukyas. The Chalukya king Vikramaditya-IV admired the architectural beauty of this temple and made gold gifts to the temple. He was impressed with this style of architecture. Hence on the same style he constructed the Virupaksha Temple at Pattadakalis

## 11. Vaikunthaperumal Temple

This temple is famous for its historical sculptures. It is yet another wonderful product of the pallavas times. It was built by parameswara alias Nandivarman Pallavamalla. It is a Vaishnavite temple and is called paramessvara Vishnugriham in an inscription of the temple.

The plan of the sanctum is square and it has a pyramidal tower with three storeys and the top is adorned by an octagon stone. The first two storeys are functional as they contain the sitting and reclining form of Vishnu within the shrine chambers while the ground floor has the standing figure of Vishnu. All the three chambers are alike in plan and size with a circumbulatory passage around the sanctum. The Vimana bears the various forms of Vishnu including a few of his avatars such as trivikrama, Narasimha etc. There are scenes from Bhagavata and puranas. The walls of the sanctum in the ground floor also contain the avatars of Vishnu and Krishna as gopuradharis.

In front of the shrine chamber is a pillared mandapa and a cloister (pillared verandah) running round the inner prakara. There is also an outer prakara with a ruined gopura of the period.

These panels are narrative in character and tell us the history of the pallava dynasty from beginning. The events that lead to the election of Nandivarman to the pallava throne are clearly portrayed in successive panels in a Chronological order. Further as many as 14 panels bear labels with description of the scenes. These historical panels are unique in the annals of South Indian sculpture and are considered to be an important source for writing the history of the pallavas upto the time of Nandivarman. These sculptured panels hide many important historical and political events of the contemporary period and they are yet to be properly identified and interpreted. It remains to be done.

## 12. Other Temples

The Kesava Perumal temple at Kurram is the master piece of the Pallava art. The other temple at Kancheepuram namely is Mukteswarar temple. This temple is the "Zenith of Pallava Art". Are very small ones with a sanctum and a pillared porch. The sanctum is located on a high plinth of about 10 feet high. Steep steps lead to the porch. An enclosure is also noticed in

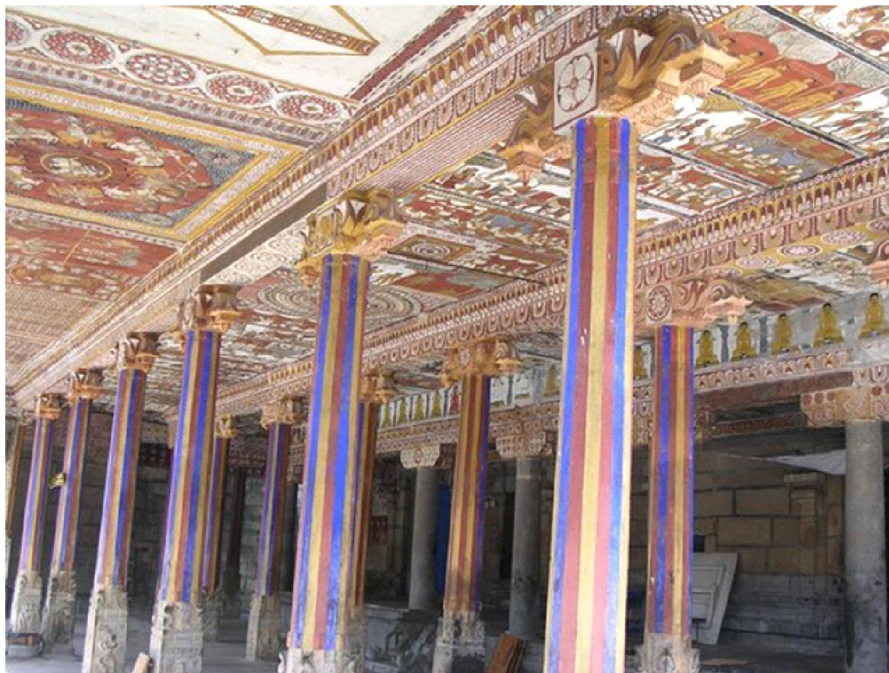


a few temples. They are belonged to the later pallava period, i.e., after Naddivarman's time. The dimensions of these structures suggest that the pallava resources were drained on account of frequent wars with the chalukyas and consequently they did not have sufficient funds to be diverted to the construction of temples on large dimensions.

### **Muktheswarar Temple at Kanchipuram**



### **13.JainKanchi**



Jain kanchi forms part of kanchipuram but it is familiar with this term mainly on account of its association with jainism and jain temples. A regular colony of jains was in existence in those days at this place. It is also known as Tiruparuttikunram. There are two jain temples at this place – one is dedicated to Vardhamana the 24<sup>th</sup> Tirthankara and Chandra Prabha, the 8<sup>th</sup> Tirthankara. According to local traditions, these temples were built by a pallava king at the instance of 2 jain teachers who were residing at this place. Both the temples are located very near to one another. These temples have been renovated during the Chola and later periods and at a time of renovation work the temples lost their original architecture features

#### **14. Panamalai Temple (Near Villupuram, S.A. District)**

The temple is known as Talagirisvara temple. It is built by Rajasimha. In plan and design it resembles the kailasanatha temple. It has a square sanctum preceded by a vestibule (narrow passage) and an ardhamandapa. The sanctum has projecting miniature cells at the centre cells of its three sides and this arrangement give star shaped outer design for temple. The northern cell contains painted figures of a dancing Siva and Parvathi. The traces of paintings are still visible.

#### **15. Tiruvatikal Temple**

It is situated at about 45 miles South East of Villupuram. It is a famous Siva temple known as Tiruvirattanesvara temple and it is sung by Appar. It was built by Parmesvaravarman-II. But during the time of Nirapatunga and Nandivarman, the temple received additional changes.

The Vimana has 5 storeys and much of its original structural portions are hidden under the thick coat colouring material recently applied during renovation.

### **Review Questions -2**

1. Discuss the features of the structural temples under the pallavas.

### **7.3 Sculpture**

The sculptus of this period are the earliest in Tamil Nadu and hence they constitute the earliest art in the history of the Tamils. Though there are references to making stone images and sculptures in the Sangam works, we do not have any specimens on hand for study.

The materials used in making sculpture are (1) granite and (2) sand stone. The latter variety was used more frequently as it was easy to chisel and carve on the stone. But the granite is a hard stone and it may crack while chiselling and the Pallava sculptors voluntarily picked up this stone to exhibit their skill in the art of sculpting.

The sculptures are found scattered over the entire Thondaimandala area, adorning the walls, pillars, storeys, basement and balustrades of the caves, rathas and the structural temples. The sculptures in the temples at Kailasanatha and Vaikunthaperumal are covered with thick coating of plasters (stucco) this is a special feature of sculptural art of the later pallavas.

Though there are the different types of sculptures and panels it is very difficult to trace any stages of evolution. However, the lengthy panels and massive sculptures and figures of this period may represent the initial stage and later gradually they were reduced in size and proportions suggesting improvement and advancement in the subject.

The following are the salient features of the pallava art and sculpture.

Namely the theme in most cases is religious but secular and social scenes are also portrayed and the contemporary society is vividly depicted. The flora and fauna are also represented. The fauna is represented by both wild and domestic animals. Birds are also included in the panels. The everyday life has also been chiselled. For instance, marriage scene, milking the cow, processions, festivals, selling, markets etc deserve special mention. The stories from ancient puranas even from Mahabharata and Ramayana are shown in narrative panels. War scenes are not known to the Pallava artisans. Buddhist and Jaina sculptures are also seen.

There are sculptured panels depicting the contemporary political events. For instance, the sculptured panels of the vaikunthaperumal temple are considered to be master pieces in the whole history of South Indian art. The election of Nandivarman Pallavamala, to the throne and his coronation was attended by the nobles and ministers.

The various figures like men and women, gods and goddess, different garments numerous ornaments from head to foot and present varieties of hair dressing and crowns, however, garments and ornaments are fewer in number they are not lavishly executed.

The figures are represented in a related position but in different places to suggest depth and perspectiveness. Light and shade are effectively exhibited. Dynamism and naturalism are explicitly noticed. But sometimes, anatomical details of human figures are not faithfully brought to surface. However attempts have been made to represent life size figures in a natural way.

Prominence is being given to human figures as well as animal's kingdom.

### **7.3.1 Sculptures at Mamallapuram**

Among the sculptures at Mamallapuram, the following deserve special mention.

#### **1. Krishna as Govardhana**

The Panchapandava Mandapa, contains very lengthy panel, measuring about 50' x 8 running over the entire back wall of the mandapa. This is one of the biggest sculptured panels (bas-relief) seen in South India. Here Krishna's youthful exploits and adventures among cowherds and in Brindavan are being narrated. The panel shows Krishna holding up the Govardhana hill in his left arm in order to shelter a group of men, women and children of the cowherd community.

#### **2. Arjuna's Penance**

This is the biggest bas-relief sculpture in the history of the Indian art and as you all know, it provides a rare and unique feat to the eyes of the visitors – particularly the foreigners. This sculptured panel is said to represent the "Arjuna's Penance". The story is that Siva appeared before Arjuna in the Guise of a wild kirata (hunter) Arjuna was doing penance to invoke the blessings of Siva and accordingly, this scene is represented on the rock surface. But apart from Arjuna and Siva, there are some other features which suggest that the scene may be interpreted as depicting the Bhagiratha's penance and descent of the river Gangas. This explanation is offered on the rock which is supposed to represent the descent of the river Gangas and a Naga and Nagini are offering worship to the goddess with their folded hands from the banks of the river. It is well known fact that the Nagas are water spirits.

There are figures of other deities like the sun and the moon and Devas and Gandharvas. Siva represented with four arms attended by his little ganas or attendants. A small shrine is

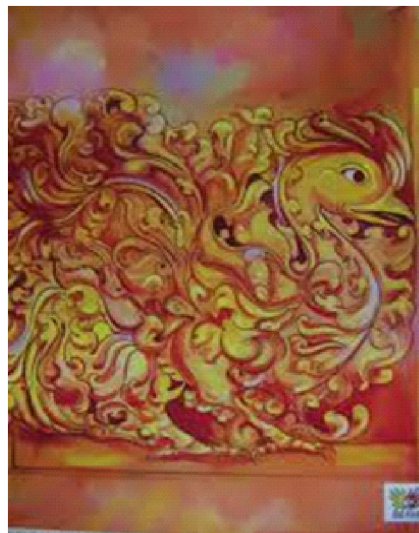
shown and in front of it is seen Arjuna or Bhagiratha doing Penance. The entire rock which measures about 60' x 30'm stands for the mount Himalayas. It is interesting to note that the scent exhibits a variety of animals like lion, elephant, and monkey etc. are moving towards the river. A monkey family is also vividly chiselled. Further it is amusing that cat is also doing penance on the other bank of the river opposite to Arjuna surrounded by mice looking at the cat with awe and wonder.

Therefore this panel represents and only the religious scene from the ancient literature, but also the wild animal life and the forestry in the contemporary period. The technique and style and superb and the animal representations are realistic and conform to the norms of anatomy. The various figures have been arranged and displayed in a fantastic way that the story hidden is readable and brought to surface. The above mentioned pieces of sculptures and panels speak the high scholarship of the sculptors of the pallava period and the plastic art has reached a high water mark during the period.

### 7.3.2 Paintings

Great impetus was given to paintings during the pallava period. It is amply seen in the inscriptions of Mamandur. Mahendravarman took steps for the compilation of a commentary called Dakshina Chitra (South Indian Painting). He followed the rules and regulations suggested for this work.

**Sittanavasal Painting**



Sittanavasal is an important centre of the paintings of the age. The walls were first coated with lime paste to cause even surface. Then paints of natural herbs were used to colour the sketches. The south Indian School of painting seem to have flourished reaching its apogee under the pallavas

Mahendravarman was called “Chitrakarapuli” due to his contributions to the paintings.

The paintings on the roof of Kudimiyamalai, on the walls of Kailasanatha temple, Adivaraha and Mamandur cave have clearly shows their interest in the field of paintings.

### **Music:**

Under the pallavas music seems to have developed well. The Mamandur inscription contains a note on the notation of vocal music. The Sanskrit inscription of Kudimiyamalai is famous for its reference to musical sounds and instruments. Mahendravarman himself was an expert in Music. The Alvars and Nayanmars composed their hymns in various musical notes.

### **Dancing:**

Dancing was developed during this period to a greater extent. The various poses of the Nataraja at Kailasanatha temple indicate their interest over dance. There were dancing girls in the temples during in this period.

### **Drama:**

The Pallava rulers showed great interest in the field of drama. Mahendravarman wrote a beautiful social drama Mattavilasaprahasanam in Sanskrit. From Penenkattai we know the importance of drama. There is reference about dance group in the Vaikundaperumal temple. From these references we get a fair idea about the Pallava’s interest towards Drama.

### **Review Questions-3**

1. Examine the features of the sculptures during the rule of the pallavas.
2. Write a note on the paintings of the pallavas.

## 7.4. Summary

The Dravidian style of architecture started with the Pallava rule. It was a gradual evolution starting from the rockcut-cave temples to monolithic rathas which finally concluded with the structural temples. Architecture reached its zenith under the Pallava rule. . The period is also called as the age of “poetry in stone”. The magnificent Kailashnatha temple is carved out in stone, bears the testimony of the period. The monolithic seven Pagodas or rathas named after Pandavas are architectural wonders, though sea-erosion has taken its toll.

Therefore, it may be said that pallava period witnessed the emergence of stone masonry, the introduction of rock cut techniques, the construction of structural buildings for the first time in Tamil Nadu. Further, they were responsible for the introduction of Dravidian style of architecture in South India. This style gained momentum in the subsequent periods and reached its zenith of power during the later Chola and Vijayanagar periods.

## 7.5 Answers to Review Questions

### Review Questions -1

1. See the subsection 7.2. (3)
2. See the subsections 7.2. & 7.2. (1)
3. See the subsections 7.2.2 & 7.2.2 (1) to (7)

### Review Questions -2

1. See the subsections 7.2.3 & 7.2.3 (1) to (11)

### Review Questions – 3

1. See the section 7.3
2. See the subsection 7.3.2

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## **LESSON - 8**

# **SOCIO - ECONOMIC CONDITIONS UNDER THE IMPERIAL CHOLAS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After having gone through this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the existence of different kind of castes based on their profession and the right hand and left hand communities during the Chola period.
- ❖ Examine the life conditions, customs and behaviour of the people and status of women during the period of the Cholas.
- ❖ Recall the various kinds of taxes collected during the Chola period
- ❖ Examine the inland and foreign trade carried on during the administration of the Cholas and
- ❖ Discuss the transaction of coins and the usage of weights and measures under the Cholas.

### **Structure**

#### **8.1 Introduction**

#### **8.2 Population**

##### **8.2.1 Caste system**

##### **8.2.2 Communities**

##### **8.2.3 Slavery**

##### **8.2.4 Women**

#### **8.3 Buildings**

##### **8.3.1 Dress**

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## **8.1 Introduction**

The Chola dynasty was one of the longest ruling dynasties in the History of South India. From the various sources we get a detailed description about the administration, society and economic conditions of the Imperial Cholas. The Cholas had a fertile valley of the Kaveri River and they also ruled a larger area from half of the 9<sup>th</sup> century till the beginning of the 13<sup>th</sup> century. The Chola period was a well-advanced period in all spheres. Caste system was prevalent during the chola period. Brahmanas and Kshatriyas enjoyed special privileges. The inscriptions of the later period of the Chola rule mentions about two major divisions namely Valangai and Idangai castes. The cholas had a good economic condition. Reclamation of forest lands and the construction and the maintenance of irrigation tanks led to agricultural prosperity. They have issued Gold, Silver and copper coins. Reclamation of forest lands and the construction and maintenance of irrigation tanks led to agricultural prosperity.

## **8.2 Population**

The exact numbers of the population during this period is not known, periodical survey was not conducted. The ports, important cities and towns were thickly populated because of busy activities. There cannot be the slightest doubt that under the cholas of the Vijalaya line, Southern India was vastly more populous and that social life had become far more complex than in the Sangam Age.

### **8.2.1 Caste System**

Caste was the basis of social organisation. Each caste was more or less a hereditary occupational group with an active organization for the regulation and protection of its economic and social interests. Though there were various sections in the society, it is interesting to note that there was practically no evidence of ugly social conflicts or jealousies. The general impression derived is one of social harmony in the chola period. The upper classes enjoyed high privileges in the society. Heredity was not always a bar to a person changing his occupation and his group- relations with it.

## 8.2.2 Communities

### Brahmanas

Though learning and teaching the Vedic literature, performing rituals and officiating ceremonies were considered as the main duties of the Brahmins, the inscriptions of the Chola period throw light on the other occupations in which the Brahmanas engaged themselves. They played the part of chief priests of the temple, Gurunatha of the emperors, ministers, royal officials, general, poets, arbitrators, administrators etc. They occupied high positions during this period. A large number of Brahmins were invited from North India and were given Brahmadeya for their comfortable life. Higher education was in the hands of the Brahmin teachers. The vedapatasalas were under their control.

The Brahmanas had knowledge in Vedas, Puranas, Upanishads and other spiritual and religious matters. They helped the common people to understand the great principles underlying the epic stories. The Brahmanas acted as Rajagurus to the chola kings. They served in the temples. Some served as ministers and commander-in-chief. They were given many grants like Veda vritti, Bharatha vritti and Bhata vritti for such services.

The administration of Brahmadeyas and Chaturvedimangalams were left under the control of the Brahmins. The assembly was known as Sabha. The qualification required to become a member of the Sabhas were prescribed. They assisted the local court in deciding cases as they were well versed in Nitisastras.

The administration wheeled around the king during the time of the Cholas, very little is known about the ministers who assisted the king. But some were very powerful and treated well by the monarch. Anirudda Brahmarayan was the Brahmin minister of Sundara Chola, father of Rajaraja-I. The king granted him a village as Ekabuga, Brahmadeya. Anirudda's father was a teacher and grandfather was a priest. Krishnan Raman a general of Rajaraja-I served as Olainayakam in the reign of Rajaraja-I. He built compound wall of the Brahadesvara temple. His son also served as general under Rajendra-I. A Brahmin served as a revenue official under Rajadhiraja-I.

Though the administration of the area was left under the control of the government officials and local authorities, in importing justice they used to consult the Brahmins of the locality as they were the masters of Nitisastras. When the Kammala's claims the rights of performing

Vedic sacrifices the Brahmins made it very clear to the king that Kammalas should not be given such rights as it was the privilege of the Brahmins.

The Brahmins were engaged in trade also. The Brahmins were very much devoted to their spiritual ideals and culture and simple living and commanded the respect of the other classes. Many grants were made in their favour in almost all parts of the Chola country by all classes of people without any distinction. Both Siva brahmanas and Vaishnava brahmanas lived during this period. Both were patronized equally. Thus the Brahmins enjoyed special privileges in all spheres.

### **Vellalas**

The vellalas were a powerful community of people. They owned lands and they were in position to donate lands to the temples. The vellalas had their own flag. They had separate army for their safety and security. The vellala ladies had high respect in the society. This we infer from the Kaveripakkam inscriptions. Certain inscriptions of Rajaraja I refer to the appointment of Vellalas in the Siva temples to recite Tiruppadiyam.

### **Kammalas**

They enjoyed special privileges which were given by a chola monarch. The privileges were: the blowing of two conches, the beating drums and so on at domestic occurrences, good or bad: the use of sandals when they went out of their houses: and the plastering of the walls of their residences with lime plaster. The construction of houses with two storeys and with double doors is also mentioned together with the right to decorate the front of their houses with garlands of water-lilies.

### **Other Communities**

There were other groups of people who lived in the chola dynasty. One among them was the Kaikolar community. They were weavers and merchants but they also maintained armies. Their main roles were trading and military. Another section of the society was Rathakaras. It means chariot maker. There were also Shepherds, Paraiyas and Puliyas.

### **Right and Left hand classes:**

No picture of social divisions in South India under the cholas will be complete without a reference to the broad division of the industrial population of the country into Right-Hand and Left-Hand, Valangai and Idangai divisions. These two divisions were never friendly and there were various instances to prove their enmity between each other. During the time of Kulonthunga Chola-I a clash between the right and left hand castes resulted in the burning of the village and the destruction of its sacred places. There were many divisions on each side. It is said that there were 98 sub-divisions in the left hand classes. Their primary occupation was agriculture. Both Idangai and Valangai sects had separate temples for their worship. They used separate pavilion for religious purposes.

Thus in the chola period we can come across the importance of the Brahmins in the society. They followed the Arya fourfold divisions in the society. There were other communities also lived without any quarrels.

### **8.2.3 Slavery**

From the literary evidence we come to know that a considerable number of the population especially among the agricultural labourers lived in a condition of slavery. Like any other property, the rich had the right to buy human beings also. Free men and women were made slaves for various reasons, and it would appear that there were several grades among the slaves. Most of the sales are recorded in the inscriptions are sales of persons to temples. Sometimes they were voluntary: two ladies sold themselves and their dependants and relatives to a temple in the Tanjore district: in these instances, the religious motive must have been more dominant than economic. But in another case when six persons were sold to the same temple in the same year for 13 kassu by another person, neither the voluntary nor the religious character of the transaction is so apparent. Similarly many were sold to the temples. It is interesting to note that women were presented to a temple to sing Tirupadiyam and to serve as chauri bearers to God.

Though they were presented they had to be under the custody of the temple authorities and they had to serve in the temples as slaves. It was also a practice that some facilities were

dedicated for temple service by officials. The dedicated families were not ill-treated by the local authorities. Instead they were enjoyed some privileges on the festival days though they had to work hard. Anyhow as they were compelled to discharge their duties assigned by the officials and the local assembly they were identified with slaves. Devaradiyar were dedicated to the temple and they were assigned to work of singing and dancing in the temple. Some women were also appropriated to the place service.. As sridhana or dowry, wives brought slaves to their husbands. If he wanted so sell the slaves, he had to get the consent of his wife. Sometimes that temple after having purchased the slave employed them as slave's mutt. They were marked with the trident mark and assigned specific duties to them. If they failed to do their duty, they were punished.

Slavery was also due to poverty. In times of famine, destitute persons escaped death by selling themselves and sometimes their unborn descendants for their keep. When the husband died the wife became the legal owner of his slaves and property. The labourers were not permitted to own slaves.

Though the basic necessities of life were enjoyed by the slaves of the Chola time, the owners were very strict about the slaves. It is clear from various records that the slaves were owned by the temples and mutts, sole to them voluntarily, or compulsorily. There is no direct evidence to show that the rich people owned slaves. But as the rich had sold the slaves to the mutt and the temples, it could be presumed that the wealthy people also owned slaves during the Chola time.

Thus during the Chola period there were two kinds of slaves viz., temple slaves and household slaves. Some slaves were purchases: some were given as presentation to temples: some were sold during the time of famine and drought. Slaves in the temples considered themselves as slaves to God but not to human beings. This fact is greatly accepted even today. .

## **Review Questions – 1**

1. Examine the existence of various communities during the Chola period.

### 8.2.4 Women

During the Chola period it was generally felt that the women were well treated and they were not placed under any restraints in their social life activities though modesty was considered the highest among their graces.. It is clear from various records that the women of the royal family and upper classes owned property and had the right to dispose of it as they wanted. Members of the royal family like sembiyanmadevi, Vannavin Maadevi and kundavi were the great patrons of religion and temple building. Many Chola queens and princesses donated freely to the temples, schools and hospitals. They were instrumental to build several temples also. Polygamy was prevalent amongst kings and the rich people had more than one wife.

Women were interested in music and dance and instruments of various kinds were known to them. Some women attached themselves to the temples and the palaces. They served the kings and the royal ladies. Though women were respected they did not have equal right. Wife was expected to look after the household affairs. Chaste women were respected. The employment of female labour in the less skilled occupations was perhaps quite as common as at present.

## 1. Marriage

Marriage is considered as an important stage in a woman's life in society. It binds together two individuals as husband and wife. Marriage leads to life, which is considered to be the basic unit of society. Kings and rich men married more than one wife. Common men had only one wife. Marriage was celebrated according to Vedic rites. Apart from ornaments and jewels, rich women were given slaves also when they left for their husband's house. Married women have high status in the society. The bridegroom had to pay a certain amount to the girl's parents before marriage. Dowry system was unknown to the people of the. Girls were named at the age of twelve. The tying of tali was in vogue in the Chola period.

## 2. Sati

Sati or self-immolation of a woman on the funeral pyre of her husband is occasionally mentioned in the inscriptions, but the reference is so few that it can be hardly regarded as a common practice in the Tamil country under the cholas. Gangamadeviyar, the wife of Vira-sola



Ilangovalar, is said to have endowed a lamp before she entered the fire: this was perhaps early in the reign of Parantaka I. The Tiruvalngadu plates mentions about the Vanavan-mahadevi, the queen of sundara Chola. Viramadevi, the queen of Rajendra-1 who committed sati; some of the wives of chieftains also committed sati.. A man who killed a relative of the Chola king in a wrestling match was sentenced to death. His wife followed him in spite of opposition from the parents. In most of the cases, women lived after the death of her husband and did service for the promotion of Saivism. Sembiyan Mahadevi's services are remarkable. Endowments were made by descendants for the spiritual benefit of the deceased. Some women took to sati to escape cruel treatment of the hands of the relatives especially the other wives of their husbands.

### **3. Widows**

The condition of the widows from time immemorial was very pathetic. They were symbols of misfortune and their presence was inauspicious. They lost their identity as the light of the homes. They had to lead simple life renouncing the joys of life, only very few widows followed sati. Others were at the mercy of the male members of the house. The condition of the king's wife and noble's wife were slightly better. So they owned property, they had their own entity and they had the right to lead life of their own. But there also they seemed to dedicate their life in religious activities. Rich women endowed grants to temples and schools. Sembiyanmadevi, the widow of gandaraditya engaged herself in building many Siva temples and granted lands.

### **4. Courtesans**

The class of courtesans has always held a considerable place in Indian society. The courtesans had their own place in history from very early times. They were known as kanikaiyar or parathiyar in the sangam society. They had separate streets for themselves. There were different varieties in them. Similarly the Chola society also witnessed a separate community of people known as courtesans. Usually they were attached to temples participating in religious festivals. They were experts in music and dance. She mixed freely with men and was under no obligation to observe the restraints imposed on matrons in their social intercourse. Her private company was given to select friends, and her choice was guided by sentimental and aesthetic as by mercenary motives. The courtesan led a life of cultured ease and pleasure provided amusement and intellectual companionship to those who could afford the luxury.

During the reign of Rajaraja-1 there were several dancing girls attached to the Brahadeesvara temple. They were known as talicheripendir. They were housed near the temple and grants were made by king for their maintenance. They had to participate in the festivals and daily activities of the temple. They were well versed in music and dancing. Some were good actresses enacting dramas. As this group of women dedicated themselves to temple activities and festivals and lived near the temples, they were known as Devaradiyar or Talicheripendir and natakakaiyar. Usually these women never married. But there were a few exceptions that were married. Most of courtesans were rich and pious women. They also made many endowments for various public benefactions.

The dancing girls were given all facilities during the chola period. The title of 'Talaikkol' was given to a girl who excelled in dance and Music. The courtesans who were very well versed in music and dance were given the title as talaikadi by the Chola rulers. The way in which they were treated by the monarchs and chieftains gave them a good status.

This system of Devaradiyar was abolished in British times but its rudiments are still found in isolated areas.

### **8.3 Buildings**

During the Chola period many palaces, big houses and public buildings were constructed. The people had a good knowledge and technique of building big and small houses. The rulers lived in big palaces. The Cholas had palaces in Tanjore, Kumbakonam, Palayarai, Gangaikondacholapuram and Madurai. Recently excavated palace at Gangaikondacholapuram indicates the maganificent craftsmanship in temple construction. The important cities were well planned. There were multi storied buildings with all facilities. Burnt bricks were used for the construction of the building. Stones were used for foundation.. Separate areas were allotted to various occupational groups. Streets or areas were named after them. Market places were well planned. The soldiers lived in areas allotted to them in the capital. Royal women were living in separate palaces. Around the fort moats were dug to safeguard the same. Chola emblems were kept in the front. Beautiful gardens were found in the palaces. Painting was lavishly used in temples and houses. The decoration was fantastic in many buildings.

### 8.3.1 Dress

The people of Chola period used both cotton and silk dresses. From the existing sculptures we know the various types of dresses of the people. Women covered their breast by a piece of cloth called “kachchai”. They also used blouses. Women folded the sari and inserted the frills on the left side of the hip. The people used bed sheets. Special type of dress was used by the soliders. Tailoring was known to them. Every temple had its own tailor. The tailor stitched clothes for Gods and Goddesses. Comb was used by the ladies .Cosmetics was used by them. The ladies applied turmeric powder: they also used flower: kumkum. Kings and queens wore silk dresses. Costly stones and pearls were also used in making the royal dresses.

### 8.3.2 Food

Rice was the staple food of the people. Various kinds of rice were used like Tuvellarasi, Hilly rice etc. Tamarind, pepper and salt were added in preparing various dishes. Milk, curd, buttermilk, and ghee were also used. Vegetables formed a part of the food. Meat and fish were eaten by the non-vegetarians. Mango, plantain, jackfruits, etc., were available. Root crops and honey were also taken by them. Guests were treated very well. Toddy and wine were taken by the poor and rich respectively.

Many inscriptions give a detailed picture of the food given to the Brahmins in temples and mutts, of they were not given prepared food, they were eligible to get rice, vegetables, salt, pepper, ghee, curd, earthenware pots, fuel, areca nuts and betel leaves. Though the poor were not in a position to have rice and vegetables they consumed rice mixed with water. Rice flakes were also eaten. Oil was used to prepare food.

### 8.3.3 Ornaments

Various kinds of jewellery were known to the people of the chola period. Queens and royal women wore ornaments from head to foot. Ornaments were made of gold and silver. Precious stones, pearl and coral were used in making jewels. Ring, bangles, chains, necklaces, armlets, girdles etc., were some of the common ornaments. Tali was worn by the women. Grants were made to the goddesses in various temples for ornaments especially tali. Chola inscriptions give a list of ornaments donated to temples, and poor people wore jewellery according to their status.

People were fond of perfumes. Women used delicate perfumes on their dresses. Ahil smoke was spread on the hair. Women painted their hands and feet with reddish paste. Sweet smelling ointments were used by women to their bodies. Betel leaves were used to colour the lips of women.

## **Review Questions – 2**

1. Discuss the position of women under the Cholas.
2. Write a note on houses built during the time of the Cholas.
3. Mention about the food habits of the people under the Cholas.

### **8.3.4 Funeral practices**

The people of the Chola times disposed of the dead in two important ways. They either buried or cremated the dead. Weeping and wailing were the common actions when the rituals followed. Drums were beaten and conch was blown. When the husband died, very few wives followed the system of Sati and most of them remained as widows. The relatives carried the dead body to the burial ground.

Cremation was done by placing the dead body on the funeral pyre. There are references to hero stones in the Chola inscriptions. Nadukal or hero stone was erected for the warrior who had fallen in the battle. The hero stones were worshipped by the relatives of the dead warrior.

### **8.3.5 Customs and Manners**

The people believed in starting a new work on an auspicious day. For marriages and other ceremonies also they choose good day and good time. They believed in the significance of dreams and thoughts they would come true. It was considered lucky if the left eye lash of a girl or the right one of the man quivered. If the right eye lash of a girl quivered, it was unlucky for her.

The karthigai day in the month of Karthigai was celebrated. By beating the drums the arrival of flood was announced to the people. The child birth was followed by certain ceremonies. Casting of horoscope was practiced. Naming ceremony and thread economy were conducted. The male child was permitted to go to the teacher after performing some rituals.

The guests were respected and given good feast. Betal leaves were given to them. During ceremonies and feasts drinks were served. Chappals made of wood were used by the people. Rich people used golden screws in the sandals. The practice of setting apart some food to crows before one began eating was in practice. They had their own significance for the cry of the crow and the noise of the lizard. They believed in the existence of spirits and ghosts. They believed in undoing their crimes by donating money or land to the temples.

### **8.3.6 Pastimes**

People of the Chola time had enough pastime and entertainments, in towns and villages the people spent their leisure hours in various activities. In villages cock fighting was popular. Hunting, chess playing, wrestling, bull fighting, etc., were also practiced. They showed keen interest in music and dance drama, Rajarajanatakam, sakkikuthu, Aryakuttu and many other kutus, were enacted by them. Women were keeping pet animals and birds. They also played balls, ammanai and kalang.

### **Review Questions – 3**

2. Discuss the customs and manners of the Chola period.
3. Write a shot note on pastimes under the Cholas

## **8.4 Income**

A sound system of finance is the back bone of any Government. The Cholas had a very good system of economy. Land Revenue and trade Tax were the main source of income to the cholas. The king needed income to protect his people, to establish his status and power of wage war with his enemies and to give many facilities to his subjects. Hence the Government levied taxes on land, trade etc.

### **8.4.1 Land Tax**

Land tax was collected according to the produce of the land. It was given in cash or kind. The Panchavaravariyam and the Sabha of the village were entrusted with the duty of collection of land tax. They collected money and grains were sent to the central treasury. As 1/6 of the

produce was given to the Government, the rest went to the peasants who owned the lands. The land tax was known Puravuvvari, Puruvu denoting the cultivable land. The puravubarithinaikkalam was the committee, which was in charge of collection the land tax in each reign. Granaries were kept in each village to store the grains collected from the peasants.

## **1. Other taxes**

Apart from the land tax, many other taxes were levied. Angadippattam was levied on the shop keepers. Idaippattm was a levy collected from the shepherd who owned sheep and cattle. Kannalakknam was a small levy on the couple during their marriage. Odakkuli was collected from boatmen. The tax given by the local people for their safety was known as Nadukaval. Maraviral was a tax on those who enjoy the produce of the trees in public places. Ilaikkulam was a small tax levied in betel leaf cultivators. Ulgu was the customs duty levied on objects of internal and external trade. There was prosperous trade with the eastern countries. Chola kulottunga-1 abolished the customs duty and was called as Sungam Thavirtha Chola, the Chola who abolished the customs duty. The Chola inscriptions give a vivid account of the tax levied on each occupation. Though many taxes were mentioned, the people never felt the burden of taxation.

### **8.4.2 Collection of tax**

The Sabhas of the village assembly was entrusted with the work of collecting the tax from the land owners. Though they were prompt in paying the tax, there were defaulters. When the tax was not paid regularly, the Government gave full right to the Sabha to confiscate the tad was also confiscated. Some such lands were sold to the local temples. Though the Brahmins enjoyed many privileges, if they failed to pay the tax, they were also treated in the similar way.

When the Chola power deteriorated, there were confusion and some of the village assemblies misappropriated the funds. When such cases were found, the defaulters were punished. Similarly, when the Government officials misused the collected tax, the village officials were strict with them and they regulated the entire system.

### 8.4.3 Expenditure

The income they get from the people should be well spent for their welfare. The king and royal members had their own properties. Special officers were appointed to administer the income and expenditure of the state. The state had to spend on various issues. Defence, agriculture, irrigation, police, foreign relationship, law and order, justice, education etc., were some of the heads on which the Government had to spend. As the village assemblies were looking after the administration of the villages, the central Government was free from shouldering big burdens. When the public money was misused by the Government officials or local bodies, the Central Government interfered and set right the entire matters.

## 8.5 Agriculture

Agriculture was the backbone of economy. The heart of the chola country lay in the kaveri delta. Kaveri delta was highly responsible for the progress of the people. The vast majority of the people lived a rustic life in the villages and agriculture was their main occupation. Possessing a strip of land was considered to be prestigious. The village was mainly a settlement of peasants and the village assembly was an association of landlords. Individual ownership and common ownership were known to the people of Chola times. Inheritance of land from father to son and selling and donating the land to others were common features. There were great and small land owners. Many landless labourers cultivated their lord's land and share the proceeds of agriculture according to the labour they had put forth. The distinction between persons paying the land- tax (irai-Kudigal) and those who did not was clearly established, and the former had usually a larger share in the tasks of local government..

From the inscriptions we come to know that, apart from the regular agriculture labourers, there was a class of hired day labourers who worked in the fields for daily wages. The remuneration was given in grain. Those who worked in the flower gardens attached to the temples were also paid in grain. Sometimes when land were donated to temples certain portions of the land was set apart for the residences of the families of the labourers engaged in cultivation. Those labourers were not owned of lands. But they were entitled to the use of a house -site near enough to the place of their work and to get wages fixed in advance, the proceeds of their labour on land being altogether the property of the institution that owned the soil on which they worked.

## 1) Tenancy

Tenancy cultivation was also common, both on private estates and on quasi-public land such as that of a temple: after paying a fixed amount to the land lord in advance the tenant usually kept for himself as his share what remained after payment of the direct expenses of cultivation and any minor dues assessed on the land held by him. He employed labourers to cultivate his land and pay them accordingly.

## 2) Tenures

All cultivable land was held in one of the three broad classes of tenure which may be classified as: peasant proprietorship called vellan-vagai in the inscriptions: service tenure, comprising all the holdings described such as jivita, bhoga, kani, vritti and so on: and eleemosynary tenure such as Brahmadeya, devadana and salabhaoga resulting from charitable gifts and governed by the special terms laid down in each case in a separate document drawn up in set terms and engraved on copper plates or stone.

### 8.5.1 Survey of Lands

During the Chola period lands were surveyed and boundaries of lands were properly marked. Classification of land into different grades, as twelve grades and unclassified lands being alluded to make it clear that the rate of assessment differed with the fertility of the soil. But it is not clearly stated in any of the record about the proportion of the produce that formed the normal share of the state. The revenue from agricultural lands was periodically reassessed. The classification of the lands was revised from time to time in accordance with the changes in cropping, fertility and so on.

If in each village there were some lands which were exempted from all taxes, they were used for residential purposes, the temples, tanks, the channels passing through the village, the area occupied by the pariahs, the quarters of the artisans and the cremation ground.

### 8.5.2 Peasant Proprietors

The ordinary ryotwari village as we now call it was the Vellan- Vagai, having direct relations with the Government and paying a land-tax liable to revision from time to time. . If a man



owned long stretch of land he could employ peasants and pay them their wages and after paying the tax to the Government own the rest of the produce.

The conversion of Vellan Vagai into Brahmadeya and Brahmadeya into Vellan Vagai was common. The Vellan Vagai into at least two broad classes – one directly remitting a variable annual revenue, to the state and the other paying dues of a more or less fixed and standardized character to the public institutions like temples to which they were assigned.

### **8.5.3 Service Tenure**

Service-tenures were of various types. The assignments in favour of public servants as remuneration for their official work under the Government have already been noticed: these assignments were, however only of certain rights to taxes and dues from land. Some servants paid the tax to the Government. But if the lands were given to the servants as tax free, they enjoyed the whole produce. Lands of such kinds were referred to as Irai Nelngal and Irai Irangal in the Government record books. The temples often parcelled out their lands and assigned them as Jivita Bhoga, Kani, all terms are used indifferently, for persons who fetched water for bathing the deity, kept watch over the temple premises and so on.

Individual donors often earmarked their gifts of land to temples for particular purposes. Lands were given for maintaining rest houses, lakes, maintenance of teachers in schools and for the village physician etc.

The charitable lands could be divided into three main divisions. They were Brahmadeya, Devadana and salabhoga. When the lands were donated to the Brahmins, those lands are known as Brahmadeva. Sometimes such lands were made tax free too. Devadana was the land donated to the temples. Sometimes both Brahmadaya and devadana were combined in a village (i.e) Devadana Brahmadeya. A devadana was different from Tiruvidaiyattam and Tirunamattukani which were lands held in absolute ownership by the temples like any other land owner.

When land already owned and cultivated formed the subject of gift after purchases, the question was to deal with the occupancy right of the actual cultivators of the land. They had to decide the rights of the cultivator and the landlord. Often these lands were made tax free either

by total remission by the taxing authorities, central or local or both or by the tax being secured by a lump sum payment made in advance as Irai -Kaval. In the absence of clear statement to such effect, the lands were liable to the usual taxes.

The Anbil plates of Sundara Chola mentions about ekabhoga brahmadeya .If a village donated to single Brahmin, it was known as ekabhoga brahmadeya. To maintain the homogeneity of the Brahmadeya villages by excluding, all other classes from owning land in them. In large villages where such homogeneity could not be attained, two types of village assemblies (i.e) Sabha and Ur were administrating the villages.

In case of unsettlement of the boundaries between the lands held by two temples due to erosion by the river, king officials fixed the new boundaries in consultation with representatives of both the temples of the Sabha of both the villages.

Land register was maintained by the village assemblies. When the register was lost the village authorities, with the sanction of the central Government took steps prepare a fresh register.

The Devadana lands were marked off by means of boundary stones bearing the emblems of the diety. Devadana lands were managed by the authorities of the temples subject to supervision and control of the village assembly on the one side and the Central Government on the other. The authorities of the temple acted in accordance with the local assemblies in paying the remuneration to the servants for the performance of services or supply of articles required for use in the temple. The local people willingly worked even in the unfertile land owned by the temple than before. When lands were donated to the temples, the donor wanted to secure the maximum benefit to the temple of its tenants from his gift. The tenants also readily helped to attain that object. The officers of the Central Government audited the temple accounts periodically. Prior sanction of the king was necessary to change the tenants of the Devadana lands. In some villages, a portion was donated to Brahmins and the rest to the temple. Similarly a village was divided into devadana and vellan-vagai lands.

The lands donated to the Vishnu temple were known as Tiruvudaiyattam. Pathandam was name given to the lands gifted to jain and Buddhist temples. Madappuram were the lands

given to the mutts. The lands given to feed the Brahmins, Sivayogis etc., were known as salabhoga.

Most of these lands were exempted from taxation. But still these donees had to pay a small amount known as Iraiylikkanam to the Government.

#### **8.5.4 Irrigation**

The prosperity of an agricultural country depends to a large extent on the facilities provided for irrigation and the importance of securing an adequate water supply was recognised in South India from the Sangam age. As agriculture was the main occupation of the people, facilities were provided for irrigation, rivers, streams and dependable channels leading off from them were the main source of water supply. The areas in which there were no rivers and streams, the people resorted to use water from tanks and lakes. The Chola-varidhi of Sholingur the Kaliyaneri near Anaimalai in Madurai, Kallinangaikulam at Solapuram, the Vairamegha-tataka of Uttiramerur dating from pallava times, the “big tank” of Bahur, Madurantakaperieri in Madurantakkam, Sembiam Madevipperi near Tirumalapadi, Gandaradittappereri in Ulagapuram, Sundaracholappereri and Kundavaipereri in Brahmadesam and the Rahjendrasolap-periya-eri at Punganur were some of the tanks mentioned in chola records. Rajendra-1 founded the new city of Gangaikondacholapuram and dug a very big lake and named it as cholagankam. This action of Rajendra was very helpful to the people of that area in irrigating their lands. These tanks were used for irrigational purposes.

The village assemblies maintained the lakes in their area every year before the rains set in, they got the silt removed from the tanks to secure the proper depth needed to store the full supply for the next year. Endowments were also made to safeguard this important work from the neglect of the penury of village authorities. Donations were made for annual repairs, in some villages' eriyam. A special cess was collected for the purpose from the peasants in the village.

The water rights attaching to particular plots of land were often enumerated on the occasion when they changed hands by sale or gift. The water in the tank was to be distributed between the villagers and temple in that area in the ratio of their holdings. Some follow common

land of the village was converted into a bund and a channel was dug for irrigation to the cultivable land of the village.

Another aspect of agriculture that deserves special mention is the steady progress of reclamation of forest and waste land that was being brought under the plough. No direct statement on the gross yield of land can be traced. On fertile paddy lands the number of crops raised each year was two or three. Nothing definite is known about the share of the landlord. It differed from land to land according to the fertility of the soil similarly the value of land also differed from place to place.

### **Review Questions – 4**

1. Write about the collection of taxes under the Cholas.
2. Describe the agricultural life during the Chola period.

## **8.6 Industry**

During the chola rule, the Tamil society showed improvement in the field of industry. Though there were no large scale industries as in the modern times, there was a good sign of all round activity that resulted in industrial growth too. In most of the industries, the rule was production for the local market. There was brisk internal trade in many articles. The merchant had highly organized mercantile corporations in various parts of the country.

The Chola society was based on caste cum occupational groups. Various occupation lists concentrated on producing various products needed for the people. Descriptions of various kinds of occupations were given in the social conditions under the cholas. Here mention could be made about metal industries.

### **Metal Industry**

The metal industries and the Jewellers' art had reached a high state of perfection. Household utensils made of metal were confined to the rich, especially they used vessels made of costly metals like gold and silver. The temples were the store houses of treasure during Chola period. Various types of vessels were in use in temples for many purposes. They

were donated by the king and the rich people. Similar images of gods and goddesses were made of costly metals. The Tanjore inscriptions give a detailed account of the vessels and images donated to the Tanjore temple by various people. The Chola bronzes are good proofs of the mastery attained by the braziers of the time in the art of manipulating alloys of metals and casting them into very graceful and beautiful forms. Copper, bronze and brass were used in such work besides gold and silver.

## **Jewellery**

The chola inscriptions are rich with information regarding the jewellery used by people of that period. Gold, pearls and precious stones were used in making jewels and ornaments. The records give the names of the ornaments used by the people to beautify them from top to bottom. Some of the ornaments of the chola time have gone out of use. The jewellery mentioned in Tanjore inscriptions alone give us an idea of the amount of the wealth held in the form of jewels and of the flourishing state of goldsmith's trade.

## **Salt**

The manufacture of sea-salt was carried on under Government supervision and control and subject to considerable imposts in kind and money, local and central. The salt-pans of Marakanam, Kanyakumari, Vaiyur and Ayturai were important centres of salt manufacture, which was a widespread industry all along the sea coast.

## **Building**

The cholas were great builders. Many places, buildings and temples were constructed by them on a grand scale. Brahadeeswara temple in Tanjore is a living example of the engineering skill of the cholas. The materials used for the construction were manufactured in large quantity providing job opportunities, to many people.

## **Weaving industry**

Weaving industry was given special attention during the chola period. The weavers of Kanchipuram were well recognised by the kings and the rich people. Some were appointed as

weavers of royal Government. Some were given the management of the financial affairs of the temples. The temple accounts were periodically audited by the weavers who managed the temples.

### **8.6.1 Transport**

There were big and small roads connecting important cities, towns and villages. The local authorities and the Government maintained the roads. The villagers gave free labour required for it. The vali was slightly better than footpaths and not suited to wheeled traffic. The big and better class of road was known as Peruvali, the great road. There were truck roads leading from one part of the country to another. Such roads were Tanjavurperuvali, Vdugapperuvali, and Kongappervali. There were choultries on the way so that the travellers and traders proceeded after taking some rest. Though waterways were not much used in South India, water transport was not unknown to the people of the chola times. Boats were used to carry men and foods from one side to the other. Beasts of burden and carts were made use of to transport the goods from one part to the other.

## **8.7 Trade**

The chief articles of merchandise that entered into long distance trade were goods of great value. The important goods imported were wood, amber, camphor, precious gems, bamboos, ivory, ebony, paper sandalwood, perfumes, drugs and condiments. Important things exported were spices, drugs, fine variety of textile, jewels, semi-precious stones, ivory, ebony, amber, coral, perfumes etc.

There was a great demand for horses and the Arabs involved themselves in horse trade. The cholas had a good cavalry. The kudirai chehettis mentioned in chola inscription were the dealers of horses who imported horses from Arabia and sold them to many monarchs and chieftains.

### **8.7.1 Merchant guilds**

The Chola society saw powerful trade guilds and corporations. They were Manigramam, Valanjiyar, Chithrameli, Periyannattar, Tisalayirattu Ainurruvar, Anjuvannathar and many others.

Nadadesa Tisaiaiyinattu Ainurruvar formed the most important of all these guilds. They got the name as they were five hundred traders who went to thousand directions in all countries. This guild was very popular and powerful.

They conducted extensive overseas trade. Because of their trade contacts and prosperity they were well respected by the monarchs and the rich people. They formed their administrative body and passed resolutions. By a resolution of their body, the Nanadesis and their followers resolved to convert the village of Siravalli into nanadesivadasamadi Erivirappattinam and confer certain privileges on its residents. The nanadesis were served by regiments of foot soldiers and swords men. The nanadesis visited all countries in the course of their trade. The Central Government and the village sabhas respected the Nanadesis. They had their own mercenary army for the protection of the goods in their storehouses and in transit. They were involved in local administration. Their success and prosperity were to some extent independent of the changes of war and peace among the status in which they carried on trade. They built a Vishnu temple at Pagan in Burma. They donated gifts also for the maintenance of the same.

Manugramam was another guild which carried about inland trade. They granted devadana villages to temples. Temple walls were also built by them. They dominated in important towns. There were Uraiur manigarramam, Kodumbalur manigramam, Ilangopattinattu manigramam etc. The Manigramattar were mentioned in the records of Nandivarman-III himself. They had commercial contacts with foreign countries also.

Similarly, the valanjiyars were also a guild of merchants who were considered to be powerful in some important towns like tirupurambiyam and Tinneveli. They donated lands to local temples and Brahmins. They maintained some mutts also. The Brahmins of Ennayiram also joined with the valanjiyar in south Bazaar of Ennayiram. The valanjiyars were considered to be merchants from Ceylon who traded in many towns in Tamilnadu. A Ceylonese inscription mentions them as Ceylonese and followed Buddhism. Though they were Buddhists, they donated to other religious institution and temples also.

The Anjuvabbathar had extensive overseas trade of the time. They are said to have belonged to the race of vasudeva kandali and Mulabhadra. There were many sub-divisions among them. They visited many countries in north India and South India and the foreign countries

also. . They penetrated into many countries by land and water routes. They trade in elephants, horses, precious stones spices, perfumes and drugs. They carried the merchandise on the backs of asses and buffaloes. They were referred to in some copper plates and inscriptions.

Palchandamalai, an old literary work is quoted Kalaviyarkarigal. In that there is a mention of Anjuvannathar who were supposed to be the Muslim traders in tamilnadu having good internal and external commercial contacts. An inscription in Thittandathanapuram in Pandya country mentions about Anjuvannathar. Similarly they were popular in Nagapattinam also.

Sugam was levied on the good imported in ships and carts from across the seas or the interior. This formed an important part of the income to the government. But Kulottunga-1 abolished sungam and was celebrated as Sungam Tavirtha Chola (the chola who abolished customs). This practice was continued by his successors also. Though a portion of income was reduced, the introduction of free trade allowed the flow of foreign goods into the country.

The merchants had full freedom and scope for initiative and capacity for voluntary organizations. The guilds carried on trade when the conditions were favourable and they paved the way for the economic prosperity of the country.

There was local organization of merchants called Nagaram in big trading centres like Kanchipuram and Mamallapuram. The members were known as Nagaratter. The Nagarams raised voluntary contribution from their members for specific purposes such as for maintaining perpetual lamps and temples, maintaining temple servants, feeding the Brahmins, celebrated temple festivals etc. The donation was made either in cash or in kind.

Borrowing on promissory note was known as Kaiyeluttolai was in practice in chola period. Sometimes the local administrative bodies also borrowed money from individuals on promissory notes. Temples which were very rich also lent money in the same way.

### **8.7.2 Foreign Contacts**

Even from the sangam age the Tamils carried on good trade with the foreign countries. During the reign of the Imperial cholas, these contacts were strengthened. The Chinese had trade relations with many countries of the east and west. The Chinese Government itself was



interested in expanding the foreign trade. They sent their missions to various countries expressing their eagerness to have commercial contacts. These missionaries went with government seal and contracts carrying with them gold and rice quality of cloth. Similarly the Chinese Sung Government promised certain rights and safety to the foreign merchants in their land. These developments gave such encouragement to the foreigners to trade with china.

Rajaraja-1 also sent his envoys to china with pearls and precious articles. They started in 1002 A.D. and reached china in 1015 A.D. The Chinese emperor received them with full honour and kept them in a big palace and gave them rice presents. Similarly in the time of ranjendra-1 the contacts continued. He sent a mission to china in 1033 A.D. The trade thus started with China appears to have been carried for a long time The Chinese record also confirms this by stating that during the time of kulottunga-1 around 1077 A.D. an embassy of seventy-two men were sent to china. Further the Chinese record states that the chola ruler sent presents to the Chinese emperor for a long time.

A Tamil inscription in Sumatra dated corresponding to 1088 A.D. which mentions about the Tisai - Ayirattinnurruvar shows that the merchants of South India had settlements outside India especially in Persian Gulf and the China Sea. .. The cholas exported pearls, elephant's tusks, coral , transparent glass, betel nuts, cardamoms, cotton stuffs with coloured silk threads and cotton stuffs.

During the reign of rajendra-1 there was contract between the Tamils and kadaram. Rajendra-1 is said to have undertaken an expedition to kadaram and defeated the ruler and assumed the title as kadaram Kondan. He defeated obstacles were thrown on chola trade with the East, the merchants complained to the chola ruler and hence he undertook a campaign and the chola merchants renewed their trade contracts with the East. Similarly in 1068A.D. Virarajendra invaded kadaram at the request of its ruler and safeguard his position there. This brought in more concessions to the Tamil traders srivijaya.

### **8.7.3 Coins**

The gold, silver and copper coins of the chola monarchs help us to a certain extent to trace the economic history of the time. This is further proved from their inscriptions. . The

earliest chola coin known to us belongs to the period of Uttama Chola. It is a good piece, a unique specimen, once in the possession of Sir Walter Elliot. Its obverse and reverse are identical, the centre occupied by a seated tiger facing a fish to the proper right and separated from it by a line, the legend Uttama Chola in grantha letters along the circular margin and ring of beads at the perimeter. The weight of the coin was between 50 to 60 grains. Though that coin was lost, it gives an idea of the coins of the imperial Cholas.

Kalanju was used in recording payments by weight. There are some mention the Pon and equate it to the Kalanju, implying thereby that the Pon was coined gold of the full weight of one Kalanju. The coin was also called Madurantaka devan- madai and was served as the standard of fitness for testing gold any yielded the same interest as one Kalanju of the fine gold. Madurantaka was the name of Uttama Chola and it could be summarised that this coin must have come into use in his time.

Rajarajan Kasu issued by Rajaraja-I was exactly half of this madai. Twenty kasus were equal to ten Kalanjus. Some of the coins were named as anradunar kasu (good current kasu) and palangasu (old kasu)

The Madurantakan madai was used in the reign of Kulottunga-I: and it is said to have been equivalent to the kalanju of the fineness of 9 and a half karats or two kasus. But this high standard was not maintained at all times. The inscriptions state the change in standard at different times and places.

Some of the gold coins of Rajendra-I bear his regnal years and the title Gangaikondacholan. Similarly his son Rajadhiraja-I issued coins with his regnal year and the title Malainadukonda cholan.

Several other types of madais were in use from the time Kulottunga-I. They were Jayamada, Uttamagandamada, Chamaramada, Birudamada, Bhujabalamada, Palampullimada and Gandagopalamada. The fineness of Madurantakanmadai of 9 1/2 karats was the same as that of sembon. One madai was equal to a kalanju of gold. Two kunrimanis made a manjadi; 20 manjadis made a kalanju. Hence it could be summarised that madai, the gold coin-was equal to four kunrimanis.

The Ilakkusu, Ceylon kasu, which was also half a kalnju of the fineness of mdai, was used in Ceylon even from the 7<sup>th</sup> century A.D. The Ceylon type was with a rude human figure standing in the obverse and seated on the reverse. These type of coins were in gold Ilakarunkasu the black kasu of Ceylon was also in use. It is not known whether it was made of silver or copper. As inscription of Parantaka-I states that the ilakkasu was the equivalent of akkams. It is not clearly known what sort of a coin the akkam was perhaps a twelfth of the kasu and therefore a twentyfourth of the kalanju. It is also presumed from inscription that the Ilakkasu of Parantaka-I's time and kasu of Rajaraja's time were of the some value and fineness. It is also surmised that akkam was equivalent to a gold coin weighing 1213 kunrimani.

From the time of kulottunga, the term kasu was applied to copper coin of very low value and its content varied greatly from place to place with each issue. These copper coins also had the same design as the coins of Rajaraja-1 but the human figure was more degraded and the legend was roughly executed.

#### **8.7.4 Weights and Measures**

Videlvidugukal was used for weighing gold in the time of Aditiya-1. During Rajaraja-1's time the weight adavalan was for weighing gold and dakshinamervitganan for jewels. Other measures mentioned in inscriptions were viyakattarkal, kemponagarasunirai, etc. Though the absolute weight of these different units could not be determined, they all used the same denominations of kalanju divided into 20manjadis, each manjadi being the equivalent of two kunris. The fineness of the gold is explained in terms of touch such as nine mattu by the kasunirakal.

Nilam or veli vatika was the unit measure of land. Lengthy rods were used to measure the lands. They were called the sixteen spans 9kol, the maligaikkot and so on. Ma or seru was one twentieth of the veli though it could not be definitely stated how many kulis made of a ma or seru, it was generally accepted in some places that a ma contained 250 kulis by the 16 span rod and in some other places one hundred kulis by the maligai-kol made up ma. But in some other place 300 kulis by the sixteen span rods were reckoned to the ma. In land measures, as in currency, the same tendency to standardization of the part of the Central government could be traced by the side of the persistence of local usage. Attempts were made to impose a

uniform system on the provinces outside the chola country proper. But those efforts and standardization were not very successful as known from the chola inscriptions.

For measuring liquids and grains, various kinds of nails and marakkals were used. Adavallan, rajakesari, vidividangan komalam, Kanchchippeduninran were some of measures used during chola period. Another standardised unit of value was, strangely was the adu (Sheep)

Thus from the chola inscriptions we come to know about the weights and measures used during the Chola period.

## **Review Questions -5**

### **Write in detail**

1. Describe the growth of industry under the Cholas.
2. Explain about the trade in the Chola period.

## **8.8 Summary**

However, there was cooperation among various castes and sub-castes in social and religious life. The position of women did not improve. The practice of 'sati' was prevalent among the royal families. The devadasi system or dancing girls' attached to temples emerged during this period.

The period of Cholas witnessed economic prosperity and extensive trade and commercial contracts. Agriculture was well taken care of by the digging canals and big lakes. The weaving industry, particularly the silk-weaving at Kanchi flourished. The metal works developed owing to great demand of images for temples and utensils. Commerce and trade were brisk with trunk roads or peruvazhis and merchant guilds. Gold, silver and copper coins were issued in plenty at various denominations. The people of the Chola time were highly civilized. In the fields of art and architecture also they showed their merit. The women were highly esteemed. The Brahmins enjoyed high privileges and favours. People belonging to other castes were respected according to their occupation and financial status. They also contributed to all round developments in their times.

## **8.9 Answers to Review Questions**

### **Review Questions – 1**

1. See the Sub-section 8.2.2

### **Review Questions – 2**

1. See the sub-section 8.2.4
2. See the section 8.3
3. See the sub-section 8.3.2

### **Review Questions – 3**

2. See the sub-section 8.3.5
- 3 See the sub-section 8.3.6

### **Review Questions -4**

1. See the subsection 8.4.1
2. See the section 8.5

### **Review Questions - 5**

1. See the section 8.6
2. See the section 8.7

## **LESSON - 9**

# **RELIGION, RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS AND LITERATURE DURING THE CHOLA PERIOD**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the growth of Saivism, Vaishnavism, Jainism, and Buddhism during the reign of the Cholas
- ❖ Recall the services rendered by the religious institutions under the Cholas
- ❖ Describe the scholars and their works during the time of the Cholas

### **Structure**

#### **9.0 Introduction**

#### **9.1 Learning Objectives**

#### **9.2 Saivism**

#### **9.3 Vaishnavism**

##### **9.3.1 Temples**

##### **9.3.2 Jainism**

##### **9.3.3 Buddhism**

##### **9.3.4 Education through Religious Institutions**

#### **9.4 Literature**

##### **9.4.1 Important works**

##### **9.4.2 Religious Literature**

##### **9.4.3 Commentaries**

##### **9.4.4 Sanskrit Literature**

#### **9.5 Summary**

#### **9.6 Answers to Review Questions**

## 9.1 Introduction

The Cholas were staunch Saivites. But while following Saivism as their parental religion they were not hostile to other religion. Rajaraja I and some of his successors endowed liberally to a Budha vihara at Nagapattinam and even kulottunga II could endow the Srirangam temple liberally. Nambiandar Nambi and Nathamuni compiled the Siva and Vaishnava literature in the Chola period. Prof.K.A.N.Sastri says that the chola period has been called as “the silver age of South Indian Saivism and Vaishnavism”.

## 9.2 Saivism

Saivism is considered as the oldest religion in Tamil Nadu. Saivas adored Siva as the supreme God. . Siva was worshipped both in the human and Linga form .Siva was considered as the God of fertility. Parantaka -1 was a devotee of Siva. The Tiruvalangadu copper plates describe about him as the bee at the lotus feet of Siva and the Larger Leyden grant states that he covered with gold the Siva temple of Chidambaram. Hence he was known as Ponveynda peruman. Gandaraditya and his wife Sembiyanmadevi were staunch Saivites. Gandaraditya was the author of the single hymn called Tiruvisaippa and this is included in the ninth Tirumarai of Saiva Canon. Sembiyanmadevi after the death of her husband devoted all her attention to religious activities. She built many Siva temples in the Chola region and the brick temples were reconstructed with stones. She gave many grants to various temples in the Chola territory. The magnificent Siva temple at Tanjore is the finest monument of a splendid period of south Indian history. Rajaraja-1 built it. Karuvur Devar a contemporary hymnist, celebrated the new temple in his sacred hymn. Rajendra-1 was also a great Siva devotee. He built a big Siva temple in his new capital Gaingaikondascholapuram. Though not in this grand scale, make other Chola rulers also built Siva temples in their realm.

Rajaraja-1 constructed a stone temple of Siva in Polonnaruwa after the annexation of a part of Ceylon. It is one of the important Hindu monuments of Ceylon. The earliest inscription found in this temple is dated early in Rajendra's reign. A Chola officer named tali Kumaran built another temple called Rajarajawara at Mantota which was also named Rajarajapura and endowed the new temple.

The Tanjore temple built by Rajaraja-1 is the finest monument of splendid period of south Indian history and the most beautiful specimen, of Tamil architecture at its best. It has long compound walls beautiful Vimana and numerous inscriptions. The chola ruler was very much interested in painting. They painted the walls and ceiling pradakshina passage round the sanctum of the temple. The theme of the Tanjore chola paintings is religious, drawn mostly from periapuranam. The episode of the title of Sundaramutthi forms the subject of some of the best panels.

The Gangaikondacholapuram temple built by Rajendra-1 described as the feminine counter part of Tanjore lacking the virile qualities mason line vigour of its predecessor, but possessing a rich and voluptuous beauty of its own.

Nambiandar nambi compiled the Devaram songs which were sung in all Siva temples. Many festivals were celebrated in the temples. They celebrated the birthdays of the emperors. Masimaham was grandly celebrated. In the month of Ani, Ani Tirumanjana Vizha was an important festival. The Mahamagam festival at Kumbakonam is known from an inscription. Thaipusam, Sivarathri, Chithirai Vishu, Aipasi Vishu, Karthigai etc. were important days and special grants were made for these celebrations, Parantaka celebrated Indra Vizha at Kalahasti.

Saivism spread all over the Chola County. The great officials, generals of the chola emperors also contributed to the establishment of Siva temples. Lands, jewels, vessels etc., were donated.. Concessions were given to the temple employees, singers, dancers, and servants of the temples were well looked after.

### 9.3 Vaishnavism

The history of Vaishnavism in this period was quite similar. Tradition confers upon nathamuni the honour of having done for Vaishnava lyrics what Nambi Andar Nambi achieved for the Saivism. Worship of Vishnu was also in practice during the chola period. The chola rulers built Vishnu temples and donated for various purposes. **Tiruvoymoli** was sung in all Vishnu temples. Singing of **Tiruvoymoli** during **Tiruppalieluchi** was a common practice. During various festival times also Tiruvoymoli was sung in temples. Endowments were made for maintenance of the singers of **Tiruvoymoli** was **Tirunedundandagam** in Vishnu temples.



Grants were made for singing Tiruppadiyam in Vishnu temples. Food offered to the deity was distributed among the Sri Vaishnavas who recited Tiruppadiyam during worship. The hymn of Kulasekara Alwar beginning Tettarudiral was recited before the deity during worship. The hymn of Kulasekara Alwar beginning tettarudiral was recited before the deity during three nights in the course of a festival in Srirangam.

The record of kulottunga-III mentions the creation at kanchipuram of Bashyavritti for the Ramanuja Bhaya as being regularly expounded by a competent person. **Divyachuri charita** and yathiraja Vaibhavam state that Saint Ramanuja was persecuted by chola rulers and some scholars identified the chola ruler with Virarajendra or Adhirajendra the predecessor of kulottunga-1.

Nathamuni popularised the poems of Alwar by having sung them in temples during this period. The collection of the work is called Nalayira Divya Prabhandam. His grandson Alavandan further elaborated the Visistadvaida philosophy. His grand son was the famous Saint Ramanuja. He has earned a very good name and fame in the history of Vaishnavism.

A chola inscription states the immigration of Bhattas from North Indian to important religious centres in the south. The mutts which maintained these external contacts belonged to the various schools of pasupatas, kapalikas and so on.

In some mutts provision was made for the convenience of pilgrims. The pilgrims were supplied with salt, castor oil and medical aid was to be given for those among the disciples who fell ill and had no one to look after them.

There was a rare incident mentioned in the record of Rajaraja-II as **Gukai-idikalaham**, a revolt in which monasteries were demolished. The cause for the same is not mentioned in the record.

## Review Questions -1

1. Describe the growth of Saivism during the time of the cholas.
2. Discuss the growth of Vaishnavism under the cholas.

### 9.3.1 Temples

The great living chola temples in Tamil Nadu stand testimony to the achievements of the Chola dynasty. Splendid in architecture, sculpture, painting and bronze casting, the magnificent temples are UNESCO World Heritage sites. Temple was the pivot of all activities in the ancient period. The early temples were structure of brick and mortar. The cholas followed the art of erecting structure temples of stone from the 10<sup>th</sup> century onwards. The Anbil copper plates of Sundara chola state that Aditya-1 covered the banks of kaveri along its whole course from the mountain to the sea, with a number of impregnable temples built of stone and dedicated to Siva. The king's relative and officials played a dominant role in temple building activities. Either as renovation old structures or new ones, or more rarely as commemorative monuments of a sculptural, the construction of stone temples continued throughout the chola period.

The chola rulers were not only mighty conquerors and great administrators, but also great builders. They were great patrons of art: during their reign the most magnificent temples and bronze icons were created in the South India. The Great living chola temples comprises of three temples namely the Brihadisvara temple at Tanjore, the temple at Gangaikonda cholapuram and the Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram. The patrons of Lord Siva dedicated magnificent architectural splendours to their beloved God.

Gifts were offered to all temples and administered with great care. Land was a common gift and the lands donated to the temples were made tax free. Each generation handled with caution what was handed down it, and by means of fresh additions, managed to leave a richer heritage to its successor. The vast and growing wealth of the temples brought them into more intimate business relations with the neighbourhood.

### Big Temples

The Brahadeesvara temple in Tanjore was built by the chola king Rajarajal, the king received divine command to build in his dreams. The grand design and magnificence added to architectural splendour of the chola capital. The great temples of Tanjore known as Brahadeesvara temple was the richest temple of the Rajaraja-1. He himself donated to it a vast amount of gold and treasure in the form of ornaments, jewels and vessels. Much of it was

booty that fell to him as a result of his wars. He set apart lands in several villages through his domination including Ceylon yielding good income. 400 dancing girls were there in the big temple.

The singers of Tiruppadiyam with the accompaniment of musical instruments were also gifted. The queens, elder sister and high officials of Rajaraja-1 also donated for various purposes. All the cash endowments amounting to several thousands of kasus were loaned out to numerous village assemblies at rates of interest fixed in kind or money. Camphor, cardamom deeds, champak buds etc., were also provided for the means of each endowments.

The Tanjore temple had played very important role in the country's economy. Employment of many architects and sculptors was made possible because its construction was extended for many years skilled artisans were employed in casting numerous icons. The chola inscriptions state about the minute skill of the goldsmiths in making beautiful ornaments and jewels. The numerous icons of the Big Temple Were decked with varieties of jewellery.

Many men and women were employed for the services of the temples. Hence the temples of chola period proved to be centre of all activities (i.e.) as land holder, employer and consumer of goods and services, as bank, school, museum, hospital and theatre, in short, as a nucleus which gathered round itself all that was best in the arts of civilised existence and regulated them with the humaneness born of the spirit of Dharma. When there were serious problems, the kings officials and king himself interfered and settled the matters.

### **9.3.2 Jainism**

Though the chola rulers were Saivites, they were tolerant towards other religions also. Jainism had a good patronage of the kings and the people. They donated to Siva and Vishnu temples and in the same way gifted to the jain temples also. Such gifts were known as pallichchandam and they were made tax-free. There was a big monastery at vedal. Temples for parsavantha were also found in the chola region. Other important Jaina centres were Rajendrapuram, Sendalai, Tiruppanmalai, Tirunarungonadai, Tirumalai, Tirumalavadi, Tirupparuttikundram and Kuhur.

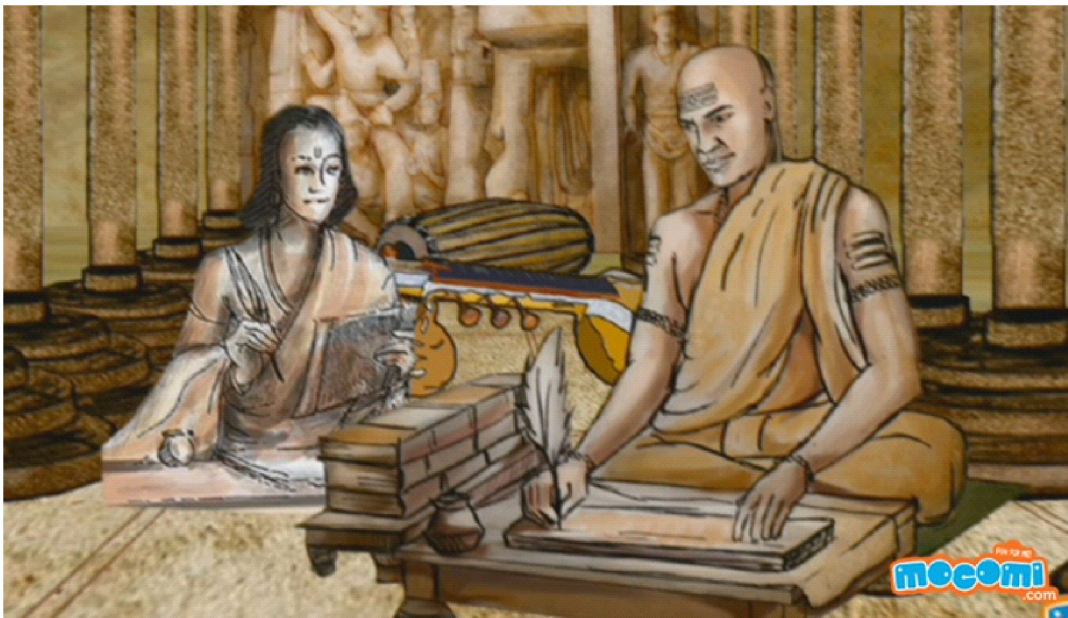
Kundavai the elder sister of Rajaraja-1 built Jain temples at Tirumalai and Tirumalavadi and donated lands for the maintenance. Tirupparuttikunram near Kanchipuram is famous for the Jain shrine and that place was known as Jain Kanchi.

### 9.3.3 Buddhism

Buddhism was not as popular as Jainism in the Chola region. But still a few rulers like Rajaraja-1 were very generous in making grants to the Buddha Viharas. The celebrated Leyden copper plates state the way in which he encouraged the erection of Chudamani Vihara in Nagapattinam by the Sailendra king Sri Mara Vijayottungavarman. The lord of Sri Vijaya Rajaraja donated the village of Anaimangalam to the Chudamani Vihara at Nagapattinam.

Rajendra -1 confirmed this grant after his father's death and caused it to be engraved on copper plates. Kulottunga-1 also supplemented this grant on a representation made by the king of Kadaram through his envoys. Kulottunga-1's copper plates mention about the existence of two viharas namely Rajaraja Perumpalli and Rajendra Solapperumpalli at Chola Kulavallipattinam otherwise known as Nagapattinam. The embassy from Kadaram comprised the king for the issue of the grant while he was in Kanchipuram was a stronghold of Buddhism too,

### 9.3.4 Education through Religious Institutions



The village school was imparting knowledge to the pupils. If the pupils assembled in the temples and mutts, popular education was provided by the recitation and exposition in temples and other public places of the epics like Ramayana, Mahabharata, and puranas. Sometimes the elements of philosophy from the standpoint of particular sects were also similarly expounded, for Sivadhama Somasiddhanta and Ramanujabhasya.

Higher education was pursued in schools and colleges attached to mutts and temples. The mutts, and the pallis, the viharas are centres of learning which often owned large libraries and transmitted by successive copying a vast mass of manuscript literature on a variety of topic which increased in volumes and diversity from generation to generation.. The teacher were also donated with grain etc., for teaching Vedas, grammer, mimamsam, Vedanta etc. similarly to Tribhuvan the students who were learning Manusastra, Bharatam, Ramayanam, were given daily allowance. So also were the teachers. In the Tirumukkudal temple, endowments were made for the teaching of Rig and Yajur Vedas and Vyakarma.

The students who were learning grammer and medicine were provided accommodation in local mutt at Tiruvaduturai. Bhattas and Siva charyas were also granted lands. A thirteenth century inscription mentions the foundation of library (saraswathi Bhandaram) in the srirangam temple. Several endowments were made for rewarding the students who attained merit and distinction in various scholastic pursuits. The numerous mutts the chola period served as more or less important centres for the promotion of learning, religious or secular in Tamil. An important work task of the mutts was to train the hands of choristers who sang the Tiruppadiyamin the temples.

## **Review Questions -2**

1. Write a note on the activities of the temples during the chola period.
2. Describe the salient features of the Tanjore Big Temple
3. Write a short note on Jainism under the Cholas
4. Write about Buddhism under the Cholas
5. Discuss the role of Chola Temples to society

## 9.4 Literature

In literature the age of the imperial cholas constitutes the most creative epoch of south Indian history. During this period, Tamil and Sanskrit literatures were extensively cultivated: there was also some writing in Pali undertaken mainly by the Buddhist divines of the period. Compared to Sanskrit literature, Tamil literature reached its zenith mainly because the Tamil is the language of the people and language of learning. The Prasastis or Meykkirts of the chola rulers from the time of Rajaraja-1 are best examples of the literary growth of the age. The stately diction, the easy flow of the verse and animated narration of historical incidents mark them out as a class by themselves in the literature of Tamil.

In the composition of the prasastis, the various metres are handled with great skill. The complex laws of Tamil prosody are observed with an easy grace which saves the author from the use of obscure words or the adoption of forced constructions. As narrative poetry, these inscriptions share some of the qualities of imperial prasastis.

Some literary works of the cholas period are lost. But their names are mentioned casually in the inscriptions. Rajarajeswara Natyakam, a drama and Rajarajavijayam, a kavya belonging to the reign of Rajaraja-1 are not available. The former was to be enacted in the great Tanjore temple during festivals and the latter was to be read in the temple at Tiruppundurutti. Rajaraja-1 created endowments for both the purposes. Tirunarayana Bhatta wrote kulottunga chola Charitai, a work on kulottunga-1 the poet was granted some land, for the same. Kamalaya Bhatta wrote kannivanpuram and Pumpuliyur Natakam in Tamil. The first one was a sthalapurana and the second one was a drama. The author was given tax free land. Aranilaivaikkan Trialokyamallan Vatsarajan of Arunbakkam rendered Bharata in elegant Tamil. Varadayappulavar of kuratti composed vallaiantadi a poem in praise of the local deity. The titles of the above mentioned works are known only from the records.

### 9.4.1 Important works

In the beginning of the chola period perungadai or udayanan kadai the Tamil version of Brahatagatha was written by a poet named knongu velir. **Tirutakkadevar** wrote **Jivakasinthamani**. The author is said to have been of the race of the cholas. His work was one of Mahakavyas in Tamil. This was known as **Mananul**, book of marriages. In its present form, the poem contains 3145 stanzas, of four lines each.

**Valayapathi and kundalakesi**, two other Mahakavyas in tamil were composed more or less about the same time as sivakasinthamani. They are known by fragments cited in other works. Kundalakesi is a Buddhist work whereas sivakasinthamani is a Jaina work.

Kalladanar wrote **kalladam** which comprises a hundred pieces each purporting to depict a particular mood of life. Kaladanar refers to the miracles wrought by Siva on account of Manickavasagar, Darumi, Idaikkadur and others.

The **kalingattupparani** composed by the poet laureate Jayangondar during the reign of kullotunga-1 the parani is the war poem which depicts not only the pomp and circumstance of war, but all the gruesome details of the battle-field.

Ottakuttar a famous poet of the chola time wrote Nalayirakkovai in praise of his patron Gangeya. . He was patronised by successive chola rulers. beginning with vikramachola: on each of them he composed Ula, besides a parani celebrating Vikrama cola's Kalinga war, and a pillaittamil on kulottunga-II. The last poem is easily among the best among the known compositions of the poet. The stories of the circumstances leading to Kuttan's composition of the Takkayagapparani, Eluppelupadu and the Itti-elupadu being more to Anthropology than History. Itti-elupadu was the poem consisted of seventy verses calculated to bring back to life the 1008 youths whose lives had been sacrificed for the goddess to inspire Ottakkuttar to sing in praise of Sengundar community to which he belonged. Saraswathi Andhai was composed by kuttan in praise of the goddess of learning. Another composition was Arumbaittollayiram. He is said to have set up an image of saraswathi in a temple in his native kuttanur he had the title kavipperumal inscribed in inscription. The village of Kuttanur on the banks of Arsil river in the Tanjore district keeps alive the memory of the poet and the patronage of his talents by the chola rules who gave him the village as a fief.

A greater poet than Ottakkuttan was his junior contemporary Kamban the celebrated author of the Ramayanam. This poem is the greatest epic in Tamil literature. His patron was Sadaiyan of Vennai..He was patronized by the contemporary chola monarch also granted him a field called kambanadu and the title kavichichakravarthi. Besides the Ramayanam, Kamban wrote **Erelupadu**, **sadagoparandhadi** and **Mummanik-kovai**. The Erelupadu, together with

Tirukkai -valakkam is a eulogium on agriculture and the cultivator class, the vellalas. The Venbas composed by kamban are said to have brought back the life of cedirayan, the son of sadaiyan the patron of kamber, kamber composed andhadi to please the god of srirangam before whom approval was sought by the poet for his Ramayanam and who made it a condition that kamban should praise his beloved devotee sadagopan in a centum of verses.

Pugalendi, a contemporary of ottakuttan was renowned poet. He composed a kalambakam on korrandai the chief of Jinji (senjiyarkon). His masterpiece is nalavenba, a poem narrating the story of Nala in about four hundred stanzas in the venba metre.

The kulottunga kovai is a kovai on kumara kultottunga who is identified with kulottunga-III. The kovai like the ula is a peace poem. It purports to deal with the stages in the development of love between a lover and his love from the moment they are thrown together by accident. In portraying each situation, details relating to the birth and achievements of the hero are worked in by the poet. The Tanjaivanan kovai is another secular work of the period was compiled by poyyamolipulavar. Vanan of thanjai, the hero of the kovai was the reputed minister of the pandya king Kulasekhara.

#### 9.4.2 Religious literature

**Periyapuranam** was written by sekkilar. It is also known as Tiruttondapuram. This work in spite of its being a purana is unique for its historical and biographical interests. He was born in Kunrattur in a vellala family. He built a temple of Siva in his native town of kunrattur. The chola king requested him to expound the life-stories of the saints, the ruler desired Sekkilar to write down the lives in a great poem, and gave him much wealth to enable him to undertake the task. Sekkilar then retired to Chidambaram, and with his mind filled with divine grace- there was a voice commanding sekkilar to start the work with the words Ulagelam and he began to compose Tiruttondar-Puranam in the 1000 pillared mandapam in the temple, and the work reached its completion with a total of 4253 stanzas. Then the king himself came to Chidambaram and listened to his work. Periyapuranam was hailed as a veritable fifth Veda in Tamil and took its place as the twelfth book in the Saiva canon. Sekkilar was honoured with the title **Tondar Sirparavuvar** the singer of the glories of saints. The periyapuranam influenced the lives and thoughts of the saivites. It is one of the masterpieces of Tamil literature. Kulottunga-II. was the chola contemporary king of Sekkilar.



The **Tiruvilaiyadal puranam of Perubarrappulyur Nambiperubarrappulyur nambi** compiled the Saiva canon in the form of ten books, the first three comprising padigams of Tirugnansambandar books four to six made up of 307 padigams of Tirunavukkarasu, 100 padigams of Sundarar forming the seventh book Tiruvasagam, of Mannikavasagar being the eighth and number of Tiruvsaippa by nine different authors and the Tirumandiram of Tirumular forming the last two books. Nambi arranged the eleventh book of canon at the request of the chola king. It included the padigams left over and the pasuram uttered by siva himself and the compositions of nambi himself. The periyapuranam is counted as the twelfth book. Among the authors of the ninth book of the canon, Gandaraditya father of uttamachola finds a place.

Karuvur devar who has sung hymns on three chola temples the aditiesvara at kalandia the Rajarajaeswara at Tanjore and the Gangaikonda Cholavara at Gangaikondacholapuram was native of karuvura and the legends centring round his name has found a place in the **karuvurpuranam**, Sivagnanabhodam was written by **Meykkandar** in the first half of the thirteenth century A.D. This is short treatise of dozen sutras which seem to have been translated from a Sanskrit original. Meykkandar explains and illustrates the arguments of each of the sutras and fix their meanings.

**Tiruvundiya and tirukkalirruppandiyu** are written by two authors, teachers, and disciple according to tradition and both known by the name or rather title uyyavandadevar, they are both works meant to present in an easy style the main aspects of Saiva doctrine and practise.

Arunandi wrote **Sivagnanasittiyar**. It is a comprehensive statement of the true doctrine introduced by a critical discussion of rival system of which no fewer than fourteen, including four schools of Buddhism and two Jainism are passed under review. Arunandi also wrote Irupavirupadhu which expounds the doctrine in the form of a dialogue between teacher and pupil.

Umapathi sivacharya was the author of eight works on the doctrine which complete the tale of the saivasiddhanta sastras in Tamil. They are sivaprakasam, Thiruvarutppa, vinavenba, porrip pahrodai kodikkavi, Nejuvidu Dudu, Unmaineri Villakkam and sankarppanikkam.

Very few Tamil works of vaishnavism were written during the chola period. Great Vaishnava Acharyas composed many devotional poems and philosophical works in the Sanskrit languages in this period yamunacharya. Yadavaprakasa and Ramanjua have contributed to the growth of vaishnavite literature during the period.

**Ramanujanurrandhadhi** was written by Thiruvarangattu Amudanar, the disciple of Ramanuja. It is a poem of hundred verses in the kalitturai metre in praise of Ramanuja. The central idea of the poem is that without the grace of the Guru there is no way to salvation.

Striking contributions were made in the fields of grammar, rhetoric and lexicography. The Yapparungalam and **Yapparungalakkarigai** of Amitasagara, a Jaina ascetic composed towards the close of the tenth century. The text and commentary of Virasoliyam belonged to the reign of Virarajendra. The text was written by Buddamitra and its commentary was by Perundevanar. Virarajendra is mentioned as a great scholar in that work. Virasoliyam is written in kaliturai metre and planned on the basis of a synthesis between Tamil and Sanskrit systems of grammar and rhetoric and comprises of five sections sandhi, sol, porul, yappu and Alankara.

The **Dandiyalankaram** is the only work devoted entirely to a discussion of Alankara or Ant as it is called in Tamil. The name of the author and his age are not known. But scholars have assigned him as the grandson of kamban who was the author of Dandiyalankaram. This is composed in sutra style and it treats of the nature of poetry and of figures of speech fewer than two generic head (i.e) **Arthalankara** (porulani) and Subdhalankara (Sollani).

The **Neminadam** of Gunavirapandita is a short work comprising of less than hundred verses in the venba metre and treating of the orthography and parts of speech (eluttu and sol) of the Tamil language. The **Nannul** (god book) written by pavanandi belonged to the reign of kulottunga-III. It treats of elluttu and sol in a simple way. The Nambiyahapporul was written by **Narakavirajanambi**, Lexicography. The **pingalandai** and **chudamani** are two lexicons written during the chola period. Mandala purusha wrote chudamani also known as **Nigantu chudamani**. The payirm of pingalandai states that it was composed by the author of the earliest Tamil nigandu (i.e.) **sendan divakaram**.

### 9.4.3 Commentaries

Though it is difficult to point out the exact age of the early commentators, some of them must have flourished in the centuries of chola rule. Elampuranar was an important commentator. It is commentary on **Tolkappiyam** is a model of verse and critical elucidation of a difficult text. Senavarayar composed a commentary on the solladhigaram of tolkappiyam. Perasiniar wrote commentary for parts of the poruadhigaram. He also wrote on **Tirruchirram-balakkovaiyar**, **adiayrkkunallar** wrote a good commentary on silappadhigaram **parimelegar** wrote beautiful comments on thirukkural and paripadal.

### 9.4.4 Sanskrit Literature

Sanskrit learning and Sanskrit literature flourished during the chola rule. Various endowments were made for colleges where different branches of Vedic and Philosophic study were pursued and to the popularity of the **prabhayakhara Mimamsa** and of the Rupavatara introductory verses in Sanskrit lexicon Nanarthanava samksepa state that a village of Saiva Bhamins learned in Sanskrit lore was established in the chola country by kulottunga-1 and from that village of certain **kesavaswamin** of the Vasta gothra, a member of a family of hereditary grammarians, was in the service of Rajaraja-II and he was commissioned by the king to prepare for the use of young scholars, this Sanskrit lexicon in which the words are arranged in alphabetical order and their various meaning set forth, as directed by the king himself.

Haradatta, a well known commentator on sutra literature, lived in the ninth or tenth century A.D. Bharataswamin commented on the samaeda; **sadgurusishya** composed the commentary on Aitreya Brahamana and aranyanka. He also commended on kaytayan's **saranukramani** and on the **Asvatayana srauta sutra**.

Bhagavata prana which synthesises Bhakti and Adavaita Vedanta is said to have been composed in south India in the tenth century A.D. Vishnu chitta composed commentary on the Vishnu purana in the thirteenth century.

Kulasekhara Alvar wrote **Mukuntamala**, a devotional poem. Saktibhadra composed Ascharyachidamani which deals with an episode in the rama saga. It is believed to have been the first full blown drama to be produced in the south. Unmadavasavadatta written by Sakitbhadra is not available.

Kulasekara, a kerala ruler in the 10<sup>th</sup> century dramatised incidents from the Mahabharata in stage worthy manner in the **Topatisamarana** and **subhadra Dhanamjaya**. He patronised Vasudeva who wrote Nalodaya and Bilomangalaswamin who composed Krishna karnamrita a devotional poem. In the thirteenth century saradatanaya wrote a great work on rhetoric Bhaaprakasa and also a treatise on music called saradiya.

A commentary on the ksumanjali was written by udayana. Varadaraja wrote **Tarkikaraksha**. He was identified as the author of vyavaharanirnaya on work on law and nayavivekadipika; an expose on mimamsa of the prabhakara school.

Saiva philosophy is represented in saskrit by Haradatta charya author of Srutisuktimala also called **chaturedatatparya** sangraha and hariharataratamya a sectarian polemic. Srikanta's bramamimsabashya expounds the sutras of badarayana from the saivas standpoint. Many agorasivacharya and umapatisivacharya wrote many works on Saiva system in Sanskrit. Ganasicacharaya commented on the sivaganaboda section of the rautava ahama.

In lexicography the **vaijayathai of yadavaprakasa** deserves special mention. In grammar Haradatta wrote Padamanjari a commentary on kadika vaman and jayaditya. A commentary called purushakar on the Deiva of Deva was written in thirteenth century by krishnalaisuka.

### Review Questions – 3

1. Describe the literary development during the chola period.
2. Write about the Sanskrit literature of the chola period.

## 9.5 Summary

These temples of Southern India represent an outstanding creative achievement in the architectural conception of the pure form of the Dravida type of temple which is known as the "Great Living Cholas Temples". The Chola style involves use of granite to create design consisting of deities, warriors, kings and dancers. The Dravidian structures reflect the prosperity of the Chola Empire. The glories still live in the wonderful temples.

Devaranayakam was a temple official in charge of singing Devaram songs in temples. Tiruvembavai of Manikkavasakar was also sung in Siva temple. The devaradiyar were also

entrusted with the singing of Tiruvembavai in temples. In literature cholas constitutes the most creative epoch of south Indian history. Thus the Cholas constituted the most creative epoch of South Indian History in the literary period

## **9.6 Answers to Review Questions**

### **Review Questions-1**

1. See the section 9.2
2. See the section 9.3

### **Review Questions-2**

1. See the subsection 9.3.1
2. See the subsection 9.3.1(1)
3. See the subsection 9.3.2
4. See the subsection 9.3.3
5. See the subsection 9.3.4

### **Review Questions – 3**

1. See the subsections 9.4 & 9.4.1
2. See the subsection 9.4.4

## **LESSON - 10**

# **CHOLAS - ART AND ARCHITECTURE**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the features of the temple architecture of the Cholas
- ❖ Describe the growth of sculpture under the Cholas
- ❖ Recall the growth of painting during the Chola period.

### **Structure**

#### **10.1 Introduction**

#### **10.2 Early Chola Architecture**

##### **10.2.1 Vijayalaya Cholesvara**

##### **10.2.2 Balasubramanya Temple**

##### **10.2.3 Koranganatha Temple**

##### **10.2.4 Muvarkoil**

#### **10.3 Later chola Architecture**

##### **10.3.1 Thanjavur Temple (Big Temple)**

##### **10.3.2 Gangaikondacholapuram**

##### **10.3.3 Darasuram Temple**

##### **10.3.4 Tribhuvanam**

#### **10.4 Impact of Chola Art and Architecture**

##### **10.4.1 Sculpture**

##### **10.4.2 Portraits**

##### **10.4.3 Icons**

#### **10.5 Paintings**

##### **10.5.1 Tanjore Paintings**

#### **10.6 Summary**

#### **10.7 Answers to Review Questions**

## 10.1 Introduction

Under the Cholas “art reached and passed its meridian”. According to the historian J. Dubrenil, “the pallavas were excelled in sculpture. The cholas were above all architects. Their style is distinguished by simplicity and grandeur” The temples were the principle nursery of art and architecture. The temples and paintings of the early Cholas are found in larger numbers, in the former Pudukottai state (present Tiruchirappalli district). They are also in good state of preservation. They present us fairly a good idea, how later pallava architecture grew into the chola style proper. As far as the architectural history of Tamil Nadu is concerned it may be said that the early Chola period is the transition period-from the late pallava style into the chola style. There are several stages in the process of evolution, which are well represented by a few early chola temples in the Tiruchirapalli and tanjavur district. The architecture of the cholas can be divided into the early chola temples, and the later chola period.

## 10.2 Early Chola Architecture

The early Chola period may start from the reign of Vijayalaya down to the beginning of the reign of Rajaraja, the Great, and the author of the magnificent Tanjavur temple. Among the early Chola temples, the following deserves mention:

- Vijayalaya Cholesvaram at Narttamalai (Pudukkottai).
- Balasubramanya temple at Kannanur (Pudukkottai).
- Koranganatha temple at Sinivasanallur (Tiruchirappalli).
- Nagesvaraswami temple at Kumbakonam.and
- Muvarkoil at Kodumbalur (Pudukkottai).

The main features of the architectural style of the above temples are as follows: Namely abundant stones were used for the construction of the temples. The temples are not large in dimension. They are small ones which implied limited resources and local developments. The temple complex includes: a pillared mandapa or portico, open courtyard around the temple.

Small sub-shrines are seen in the courtyard lacing inwards resembling the main shrine. They are scattered over the courtyard unlike in the Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram where

they are attached to the main shrine. Vimana consisting of 1 to 5 storey in dimensioning order the plan of the Vimana is either square or circular or combining both patterns. Dome shaped sikhara, Round kalasa, The pillared mandapa is often closed and open as seen in modern days. The external walls of the sanctum and mandapa are decorated with ornamental plasters. "Niches are not seen in the earliest examples while in later ones; there is one on each side of the sanctum. These niches bear sculptures of Brahma, Dakshinamurthi and Vishnu or Lingodbhava or Ardhanari.

Below the cornice at the top of the sanctum wall a frieze of bhutas is seen. The corner of the cornice is shaped into scroll work. Above the cornice is another frieze of lions. The parapet over the ceilings carries miniature shrines (panjarams). The Vimana contains one or more storeys. Each storey is terminated by a roll cornice with kudu motifs. The lower storey carry miniature shrines at intervals. Pillars in the earliest examples are of the pallava order. In the later ones, two changes have been introduced one relating to the capital and the other to the abacus. In the capital a neck moulding has been introduced where it joins on to shaft. To the lower part of the capital is added another member in the form of a vase or pot. The abacus is much expanded.

Let us now see how these features are present in the temples complex of the above mentioned temples.

### **10.2.1 Vijayalaya Cholesvara**

It was built in the time of Vijayalaya as the very name suggests. He is the founder of the early Cholas. It is one of the best preserved examples. The cello is circular and located within a square prakara. This is not usual feature seen in tamilian architecture.

There is a closed pillared mandapa in front of the cella. The vimana has four storeys- the three lower ones are square, while the fourth and the upper most is a circular. The vimana is surmounted by a dome-shaped sikhara and a round kalasa at its top. There are no niches on the external side of the walls. The pillars are of Pallava order. There are two Dwarapalakas, measuring about 5' seen inside niches. They are half-turned towards the entrance and cross-legged. They have only two arms as in the Pallava temples, There are about 7 small shrines in the open around main shrine.



### 10.2.2 Balasubramanya Temple

This temple is also very similar to the former. Aditya-I constructed many Siva temples. Balasubramanya temple is one among them. There are elephant figures introduced in the corners just below the sikhara as also in the four corners of the roof of the shrine.

### 10.2.3 Korangantha Temple

This temple is situated in the town of Srinivasanallur about 59 kilometres from Tiruchirappali. This temple was built in the reign of Parantaka and is dedicated to the God Ranganatha. It consists of a square cella vestibule and rectangular pillared madapa. The height of the vimana is about 50'. This temple represents some development with regard to the pillars. The temple is protected by the Archaeological survey of India

### 10.2.4 Muvarkoyil



**Muvarkoyil**



Moovar Kovil or "The three temples" is situated in Kodumbalur, 36 kilometers from Pudukottai. These temples were constructed by the Chola feudatory and Irukkvel Chieftain of Boothi Vikramakesari as per the inscriptions. The temple is very important as it is a living example of early to medieval Chola architecture. The inscription in the temple also gives us a glimpse of

the political climate of South India between 8<sup>th</sup> to 10<sup>th</sup> centuries as well as the relation between the royal houses of Chola and Irukkuvel.

The temple consists of three shrines separated from one another. They stand on a north-south line and face west. Each of these has an ardhamandapa in front. Proceeding to ardhamandapa is a bigger mandapa common to all three shrines. It measures 91'X41' (north-south & east-west). In front there is a Nandi pavilion. In between the Nandi mandapa and main central shrine is the dhvajasthamba. Around the whole group is a pillared cloister with as many as 15 sub-shrines of varying proportions. They all resemble the main shrines. There is an outer enclosure with a thick massive wall with a gopura entrance at the west. The basement of main shrines contains horizontal mouldings and the lower most moulding consist of lotus petals (padmakosa). There are large number of sculptures on the walls of the sanctum representing Siva as Ardhanari, Vinadhara-Dakshinamurthi, gajari, Samharamurthi, kiratamurthi, Ganadhara, Harihara, Chandrasekhara, Chandra, Surya, Uma, Jeystha and Saptamatrikas. It is one of the best examples of early Chola temples containing elegantly carved sculptures.

### 10.3 Later Chola Architecture

Temple architecture received great impetus from the genius of Rajaraja-I and his son Rajendra, Rararaja built many temples, and they are bigger than those described above. These temples are noted for their sculptures and ornamental work. The plinth portion, the cornice as well as the portion below the same, the different storeys in the vimana and the external wall surface-all have received greater attention and studded with beautiful sculptures, minute carvings and ornamental motifs. The yali frieze was introduced into one of the horizontal mouldings of the plinth-the Ganas in the portion below the cornice are shown in various poses like dancing, they are also shown with pot bellies or with lions or monkey faces. They are very humorously portrayed. The cornice is decorated with creepers in the space between kudus. The kudus are surmounted by lion faces. The lower most storeys of the vimana bear sculptures representing Siva, Brahma, Vishnu and other minor deities. The top most storeys carry elegant bull figures at the corners. The sikkara is ribbed with 8 sides. These are some of the features of the temples architecture during the early years of Rajaraja's reign. Among the temples of the period mention must be made of the following:

Tiruvallisvaram temple at Brahamades (Tiruchirapalli).

Uttarakailasa at Thiruvadi (Tanjavur district).

Vaidyanatha temple at Tirumalavadi (Tiruchirapalli).

2 temples at Dadapuram (North Arcot).and

Sivadevale (Ceylon).

## Gopuras

The cholas had also paid some attention to the development of gopuras. The gopura was considered as an essential adjunct in the sam exil line. We hear of the early Chola gopuras in their inscriptions also. There are also some stray examples surviving still. The temples at Tirukkattalai and Melappaluvur, we find the existence of the gopuras. There seems to have existed a gopura in the temple at Kadambavanesvara at Erumbur (South arcot District) as also other places as evidenced from inscriptions.

The beginning of the eleventh century synchronized with many developments in temple architecture. They are: Elaboration of the vimana-its height was raised to about 200, Elaboration of the gopuras.Greater attention was paid to the embellishment of the internal and external wall surfaces of the mandapas.

Numerous sculptures and carvings were introduced to represent a variety of iconographic forms and sports of many deities.

There are four important temples of the later Cholas which exhibit the maturity of Chola architecture. They are:

- Thanjavur temple built by Rajaraja.
- Temple at Gangaikondacholapuram built by his son Rajendra-I.
- Darasuram temple at Kumbakonam and
- The temple at Tribhuvanam.

### 10.3.1 Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur

The Brihadisvara Temple houses a 3.7 meter tall linga of Lord Shiva and the tallest vimanam in the world. The wonderful designs of the gopurams in the temple are decorated with sculptural depictions of various Gods and Goddesses. The massive proportions and simplicity of design of the temple is believed to have provided inspiration for other buildings. Constructions not only in South India but also were in South-east Asia has been modified from the grand designs.

This temple was completed in 1009 A.D is a fitting memorial to the achievement of Rajaraja I. It is the largest and tallest of all Indian temples. It is a masterpiece reflecting the high watermark of Tamilian architecture. It consists of an ardhamandapa, mahamandapa and a Nadimandapa. They are arranged in the centre of a spacious walled enclosure, with a gopura entrance in the east. There is also the second enclosure with another gopura. There is a pillared corridor running round the temple at the interior of the first enclosed wall. There are a number of sub-shrines built at the cardinal points and at intervals in the corridor.

The main item of attraction in the temple is the Vimana. It is dominating the entire surrounding. The measurements of the Vimana portion are: Base-82' side, Height of the base-50', Vimana total height-200' from the ground and 13-Tiers.

The storeys in the vimana contain beautiful sculptures, miniature shrines, pavilions, arches with sculptures etc. The walls of the base of the vimana contain a number of arches with images, pilasters etc. It is also interesting to note that the monolithic Nandi of this temple is one of the largest monolithic bulls in South India. There are also traces of Chola paintings left on the ceilings and wall of the inner circumambulatory passage found.

### 10.3.2 Gangaikondacholapuram Temple

The Gangaikonda Choleswara temple was constructed by Rajendra I in memory of his victory over northern kingdoms. The city of Gangaikonda cholapuram was erected as the capital of the Cholas by Rajendra Chola I.

The temple houses a four meter height of Shiva lingam. This lingam is the tallest among the other Chola temples. Other attractions of the temple are the colossal representation of

Navagrahas. These auspicious nine deities are placed in a circle. The structure shaped as a Chariot and the sculptures of Chandeswarar and Gnanasaraswathi are other attractions.

It was built about 1030 A.D.-two decades after the erection of Thanjavur temple. It exhibits the same style. It is larger in its plan, but not so tall, the vimana is about 180' height. But its base is about 100' square. Hence the width of the vimana was increased. The vimana contains only 8 tiers. Though the vimana has the same construction as that of the Thanjavur temple, there are some novel features introduced into the elevation of the vimana. For instance, the strong lines in the elevation of the Thanjavur vimana are replaced by elegant curves. The pyramidal body is slightly concave and its angles and the sides slightly curved to effect a sort of convex outline. These curves enhance the shape of the vimana. While comparing the two vimanas, Brown observes: "Each is the final and absolute vision of its creator made manifest through the medium of structural form, the one symbolizing conscious might, the other sub-conscious grace but both dedicated by that divinity which has seized the same".

Besides the main temple, there are also separate shrines for Chandikesvarar and the Goddess. This is one of the largest pillared mandapas that we come across during the Chola period. Pillared mandapa of longer dimensions are the special features of the later period i.e. Vijayanagar. There are also transepts between the sanctum and mahamandapa on the north and south, as in Thanjavur temple. Lastly mention must be made of the embellishment done on the outside of the walls.

The chola style continued to flourish for a century longer. A large number of temples were constructed; it is not possible to mention them here. But temple at Darasuam and Tribhuvanam deserve mention. Darasuram temple was built by Rajaraja-II while Tribhuvanam temple, by Kulottunga-III. The front portion of the Darasuram temple is shaped into a chariot with wheels drawn by mythical animals. The temple contain beautiful sculptures and images besides sculptured panels representing some Nayanmars.. Both these two temples have many features in common with those of two great temples.

### 10.3.3 Darasuram Temple



**Darasuram**



**Airavateshwara temple gopuram**

The Airavateswara temple at Darasuram is smaller than the other great living chola temples. This temple in Darasuram is the third in the list of the great living chola temples. Darasuram is a panchayat town located 3 kilometers from Kumbakonam in Thanjavur District. The town is known for this temple constructed by Rajaraja Chola II in the 12<sup>th</sup> century A.D. This temple is recognised as the UNESCO World Heritage monument along with the Brihadisvara Temple and the Gangaikonda Choleswara temple

This temple is a storehouse of art and architecture. The vimana is 85 feet high. The front mandapam itself is in the form of a huge chariot drawn by horses. The temple has some exquisite stone carvings.

Originally it has a number of enclosures with gopura entrance to each, but only one is in existence. The temple has the same plan and parts as the Tanjore temple, but there is a mahamandapa in front of a pillared agramandapa with porch on the south. This is called “Rajakambirantirumandapam”. It is built like a chariot on wheels drawn by elephants.

This temple bears numerous sculptures and carvings. One of the most fascinating is the series depicting scenes from Periyapuram on the base of the garbhagriha wall. The scenes depict the lives of the Saiva Saints with labels beneath.

Another interesting feature of the sculptural art of this temple is the occurrence of Kumbha panjara motif, on the exterior walls of the sanctum and mandapas at regular intervals. The

vimana has five storeys and the sikhara is of circular shape. There is a shrine for Parvathi to the north of main shrine.

In front of garbhagriha there is a Nandi shrine and balipitha. There is Amman shrine also on the northern side. It is a replica of the main temple but miniature in size. The outer gopura is in ruins. The inner gopura is external and has two storeys.

### 10.3.4 Tribhuvanam Temple

#### Tribhuvanam Kambaheswarartemple



The kambaheswarar temple is dedicated to Siva. It is situated in the town of Tribhuvanam near Kumbakonam. Siva is worshipped as kambaheswarar as he removed the quaking (skt.kampa) of a king who was being haunted by a Brahmarakshasa. According to this temple wall inscription we infer that this temple was constructed by Kulothunga chola III in memory of his victory over North Indian rulers.

The temple follows the Dravidian style of architecture. An unusual feature of the temple is that the vimana is extremely high. The architecture of this temple is similar to other three temples. There is a separate shrine for Sarabeswarar in this temple.

There are shrines for Devi, Somaskanda, chandikesvara etc. The temple as a whole is a vertical sculpture gallery of varied iconography. There are not only scenes depicting stories

from Ramayana, Mahabharata and Puranas but also secular scenes. There are numerous natya poses depicted

## **Review Questions – 1**

### **I Answer the following briefly**

1. Write a note on Vijayalaya Cholesvara
2. Give a brief note on Muvarkoil

### **II Answer the following**

3. Explain the features of the Tanjore Big Temple
4. Highlight the importance of Gangaikondachola temple
5. What do you know about Darasuram Temple?

## **10.4 Impact of Chola Art and Architecture**

The influence of Chola art on other countries, particularly on Indo-China and the Far East is so great. A few temples of 12<sup>th</sup> and 13<sup>th</sup> century A.D in South East Asian countries bear the traits of the Chola architecture. Further, the famous Nataraja figures have also been found in those countries.

The Chola period has witnessed a tremendous progress in the realm of sculpture and iconography. The art of this period may be studied under three different heads: namely Sculpture, Icon and Portraits.

### **10.4.1 Sculpture**

Sculpture was generally a subsidiary to architecture. It was employed as decoration on the walls, pillars, plinths, roofs and other spots in temples. Sculptures appreciated the value of plan spaces on the walls and did not crowd them with too many figures. They worked on hard stones like granite, “Large frescoes in stone” were not produced unlike the Pallava period. The sculptured figures paid more attention on the rich iconography of Siva and Vishnu.



Narrative sculpture in stone are in small panels, sometimes as small as 6 inches by 4 inches as at Nagesvaraswamy temple at Kumbakonam and rarely more than 2 feet by 1 foot. Naturalism was the cream of Chola plastic art. Then spiritualism and dynamism comes.

Decorative sculptures are seen in many forms like architectural motifs, floral and vegetable patterns, friezes of animals, birds, dancing figures with musical attendants and of legendary and puranic stories. Men and women are gracefully chiseled as seen in the Nagesvaraswamy temple at Kumbakonam. They are shown in profile wearing costly jewelers and drapery. They are shown in various actions and poses with different head dress. The effects like light and shade and perceptiveness are vividly portrayed on these figures.

Scenes from Ramayana, Mahabharata and Puranas are vividly chiseled. For example, the lives of the 64 Nayanmars are sculptured in narrative panels on the basement wall of the Darasuram temple. They are subsequently removed to Thanjavur Art Galley. They bear labels also.

One of the Ramayana panels from Tribhuvanam show Ravana with many arms and heads carrying off Sita in his chariot and the bird Jatayu which fought Ravana. There are also small panels-the Agni presenting payusam to Dasaratha, the king distributing the same to his queens, birth of Rama, the fight of Tataka, Hanuman's meet with Ravana are some of the best examples of Chola sculptural art.

Similarly one can notice friezes of alternating elephants, lion and yalis, ganas and birds on the mouldings of the plinth or walls. Yet another piece of Chola art is the dyarapalaka figure. These figures are considered to be door keepers of the abodes of the gods. They are shown on the side of gateways, entrances to temples and shrines. They are shown with either 2 or 4 or 8 arms with different objects and weapons held in the arms. Female's dvarakapalakas (dvarapalikas) are shown in the shrine of goddesses. Their facial features and anatomical details serve as criteria to identify Chola style.

#### **10.4.2 Portraits**

The Cholas excelled the Pallavas even in portraiture. The best specimens are seen adorning walls of Koranganatha temple and Nagesvaraswami temple. They were well preserved

and nearly life size. This art is so unconventional, but original in conception and spirit. Particularly the Chola ladies are gracefully shown. They are realistic human figures, full of feminine grace and the joy of life. This humanism is the principal contribution of the Cholas to South Indian Art. In their free and easy poses, in the divergence of their features and forms, with a pronounced individuality to each figure, in the excellence of their modeling and in the successful treatment of facial expression, particularly of the eyes and lips, these sculptures have no parallel in any other phase of South Indian art. They are not modeled in the round but carved on jewellery of the both men and women reveal much of life the stone and are undetached.

The examples of early portraits have been noticed at Tiruvaduturai. A beautiful bronze of women is now preserved in the Free Art Gallery, Washington, who is identified as Lakshmi or Parvathi. The portraits of Cholamadevi and Kulottunga-III are also noticed at Kalahasti temple.

### **10.4.3 Icons**

Icons of Siva, Vishnu, Nataraj, Lakshmi, Parathi, Subramania were made both in stone and metal (bronze).

#### **(1) Icons in stone**

Siva and his various other forms such as Tripurantaka, Dakshinamurthy, Nataraja Lingodbhava, Gangadhara, were very popular, eight armed Durga is an icon noted for its artistic merit. Icons of Vishnu were less in number than those of Siva. Various Devi's like Lakshmi, Parvathi, Tripurasundari etc., deserve mention.

These figures throw a flood of light on the development of hindu iconography during the period. Sometimes these gods are shown along with their mounts like Bull, peacock, Garuda etc. These icons exhibit the high workmanship as well as the scholarship of the chola sculptors in making these images.

#### **(2) Metal Icons**

Bronze images were cast in large numbers. They were made by the Cire Perdu process. The images were made solid, hollow or semi-hollow with sides. Again there are various forms of bronze icons representing men, women, animal, gods, goddesses etc.

The Nataraja image holds the first place among the Chola bronzes of this type are spread all over the Museums of the world. Some of them are still under worship in temples. The Nataraja figure has been cast in various forms and size. He is shown as a dancing Siva and hence he is known as king of dance. He has four arms with flocks of flying hair and he flown scarf. He holds objects like damaru, fire etc. One of his feet is shown crushing a demon (ignorance). It is described very often as “this dancer is danced upon the bodies of the dead”.

The Natarja icons from Nageswarasamy, Tirvallangadu, Gngaikondacholapuram and Chidambaram are masterpieces of Chola art. Besides, the other forms of Siva, Vishnu, Lakshi, Parvathi and other minor deities are represented in bronze.

Besides icons, there are also copper seals issued which speak of the progress of metal casting during this period. The Karandai copper plates deserved special mention in this connection.

## **10.5 Paintings**

Painting is delicate products of art. The art painting has had a continuous history and made steady progress right through the ages. The Cholas continued the tradition of Pallava paintings. There are few good specimens still preserved in temples like Thanjavur.

The technique of Chola paintings is quite different from that of Ajanta. Here the ground plaster is of course lime mortar below, with a fine coat of lime-wash above it and on which the colour pigment were laid on accordance with the “fresco” or “lime medium” technique, no adhesive was used as gum or glue and it is the important feature that distinguishes the chola paintings from these in Ajanta. The areas of panels vary from 24 squares to 60 squares.

### **10.5.1 Tanjore paintings**

The paintings are found in the walls and ceiling of the pradakshina passage around the sanctum in the Tanjore temple. The theme of the paintings is religious drawn mostly from religious texts. The episode of the life of sundaramurthi forms the theme of a few panels. The Kailasa scene with Siva, rishis and apsara maidens is yet another fascinating panel. Siva is painted red and one of the rishis blue. There are other panels depicting Siva is painted man

and sundaramurthy Nayanar, Nataraja, Tripurantaka and Brahma are also vividly painted. On the western wall of the shrine is depicted Nataraja worshipped by a royal devotee by his queens. The royal figure of Rajaraja-I. and his teacher Kanuvardevar is also portrayed.

There is second circumambulatory over the one in which the paintings have been noticed. The inner wall of this passage also contains traces of chola paintings. There numerous dance poses are painted. The lives are drawn in light red or brown and deepened by black or reddish brown. The other colours used for flesh and drapery are defined by black or reddish brown. The other colours used for flesh and drapery are defined by delicate brush work. The dancing forms are full of action and expression. The hair is done to elaborate coiffures of different styles and decked with high in celestial beings. The eye lids are not pronounced flowers. The eye brows are set low in human forms and but highly expressive. The noses are long, straight and sensitive very rarely curved. The women's dress consists of a sari of muslin tied round the waist covering down to the ankles and thrown into folds decorated by floral geometrical designs. The men are shown with strong body, beard, moustache and knots of hair on the head. Thus the art of painting developed in the chola period.

## **Review Questions- 2**

### **Answer Briefly**

1. Discuss the growth of sculpture under the Cholas
2. Explain the features of icons of the Chola period
3. Narrate about the paintings during the chola period

## **10.6 Summary**

The Cholas were the inheritors and continuers of the pallava traditions in temple architecture. It is a known fact that they have built hundreds of temples throughout their Kingdom- bigger and smaller in proportion. The Cholas continued the tradition of pallava paintings. There are a few good specimens still preserved in temples like Thanjavour.

## 10.7 Answers to Review Questions

### Review Questions – 1

1. See the subsection 10.2.1
2. See the subsection 10.2.4
3. See the subsection 10.3.1
4. See the subsection 10.3.2
5. See the subsection 10.3.3

### Review Questions – 2

1. See the subsection 10.4.1
2. See the subsection 10.4.3
3. See the section 10.5 and subsection 10.5.1

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## **LESSON - 11**

# **ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL CONDITION DURING THE REIGN OF THE PANDYAN EMPIRE**

### **Learning Objectives**

After having gone through this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the agricultural life, agricultural products, land tenure, cultivation system, irrigation methods, inland and foreign trade and merchant guilds during the pandya period.
- ❖ Analyse the land taxes, professional taxes, the Pandyan coins, caste structure, slavery and status of women under the Pandya's rule.
- ❖ Recall the educational institutions such as mutts and temples and Marco Polo's accounts

### **Structure**

#### **11.1 Introduction**

#### **11.2 Economic Life**

##### **11.2.1 Land tenure and Cultivation**

##### **11.2.2 Irrigation and Method of Irrigation**

##### **11.2.3 State Help**

##### **11.2.4 Agricultural Product**

#### **11.3 Industry and Trade**

##### **11.3.1 Foreign Trade**

##### **11.3.2 Foreigners Account**

##### **11.3.3 Inland Trade**

##### **11.3.4 Merchant Guilds**

#### **11.4 State Economy**

##### **11.4.1 Taxes on Land**

##### **11.4.2 Duties on Articles of trade and Excise**

**11.4.3 Professional Tax****11.4.4 The Pandyan coins****11.5 Social Life****11.5.1 Brahmins****11.5.2 Communities other than Brahmins****11.5.3 Women****11.5.4 Slavery****11.5.5 Devadasis****11.6 Education and learning****11.6.1 Service of Mutts****11.6.2 Temple, the Important Social Institution****11.7 Marco Polo's Accounts****11.8 Summary****11.9 Answers to Review Questions****11.1 Introduction**

The 13<sup>th</sup> century was a period of Pandyan revival. Their power reached its zenith with the celebrated reign of Jatavarman Sundara pandaya and Maravarman Kulasekhara Pandya which cover the second part of the 13<sup>th</sup> century. Till 1218, the Pandyas were obliged to take subordinate position and pay tribute to the Cholas. They reasserted their independence to such an extent that the latter half of the 13<sup>th</sup> century has come to be called as "The Age of the Second Pandyan Empire".

For the study of social and economic life of the Pandyas of the Second Empire, we have sources like epigraphy and foreign accounts. Some of the earlier inscriptions are purely historical. Foreign accounts particularly those of Marco Polo are extremely valuable for recapturing the social life of the people.

## **11.2 Economic life**

### **Agriculture**

People settled in the fertile plains of Vaigai and Tamarabarani rivers. These rivers made the land fertile hence most of the people lived on agriculture. They made use of the rivers for their agriculture. Thus the fertile lands of the country were immensely important for the growth of economy. During this period lands were measured properly. After proper measurement boundary stone was laid and regular fencing work was undertaken by the Government. It is mentioned in many copper plates. Moreover the periodic land surveys are indicated by reference to scales like Sundara Pandyanarkoil and Vira Pandyankoil. The yard which was used to measure the land during the time of Maravarman Sundara Pandya-I called "Kuditangi". Boundaries were marked by stones. Kuli, ma and veli were four kinds of lands Viz.,

### **Vellan Vagai**

In this kind the land-owners were called Vellan Vagai. They were brought under the control of the state. They paid the taxes regularly. It is stated that they had to pay an annual tax of 642Kalams of paddy and 40 Kalanju to the Government.

### **Brahmadeyam**

Brahmadeyam lands were given to the learned Brahmins as an honour by the kings and queens. Rich people also donated this kind of lands to the Brahmins. Parantaka Viranarayanan gave a village called Dinachutar Mangalam in the Sinnamannur Copper plates.

### **Devadanam**

The lands offered free of tax were devadana. For Shiva temples, Tiruvidaiyattam to Vishnu temples, Pallichandam to Jains and Buddhist temples.

### **Service Tenures**

This kind of lands was given to the villagers for their meritorious service. Besides the villagers, soldiers were also given such lands for their heroic deeds in battles.



The gifts were written in the documents. If any future boundary disputes arose that should be settled easily by these documents. When the documents had been lost new documents were given. Dalavoypuram copper plates referred to these issues of new document. In Shiva temples the boundary stones were laid with Trisulas engraved, in Vaishnava temples Thiruvazikkal was laid and in Jain temple boundary stones with Mukkudal was laid. The exemptions were noted in the name of the contemporary king and recorded on copper plates.

Lands were classified as Nansey (wet), Punsey (dry) and tottam (garden). All cultivable land was held in one of the 3 broad classes of tenure, which may be distinguished as peasant proprietorship called, "Vellan Vagai" in the inscriptions. The assessment of revenue was fixed with reference to the fertility of the soil and the nature of the crops raised. The revenue was paid in cash or in land.

Broadly stated, only the cultivable land was assessed. The villages sites the quarters occupied by the lower classes and artisans, the courtyard and flower gardens attached to the temples, the threshing floor, the village grazing ground, the saline earth, the land just on the bed of river, the land where breaches had occurred and marshy places excluded. Those that had suffered damage or had failed altogether were excluded.

### **11.2.1 Land Tenure and Cultivation**

The tenant and the land-holder were related by the usual terms of tenure and the land-holder was obliged to pay taxes like land tax, water cess, tank duty etc. The status of the cultivator or the farm labourer was deplorable. The unequal distribution of wealth was a significant feature. Transfers of property were common. The legal acts were recorded on copper or stone, under royal orders if it was of public interest. We have enough information to speak authoritatively about service tenure, military grants etc. The military tenure to soldiers called "Veera Boga". There is an interesting record belonging to the times of Jatavarman Sundara Pandya which gives considerable information about a village called "Vikrama Pandya Chaturvedi Mangalam". Here service-tenure was given to teachers of Sutras, teachers of Vedas, village accountant, Goldsmith, village doctor, carpenter, potters, washer man, barber, village watchman, (Padikappar) and village servant (Vettiyan). The residents of this village were 108 Brahmins. The temples also specialized in service tenure. The charity tenures related to the Brahmins, the temples and the schools. Temple land were given to lessees or tenant for cultivation.

We get enough information in regard to the forms of land tenure to enable us to see that the conditions of tenancy cultivation varied in accordance with the locality. An inscription from Alangudi (Tanjore) gives an unusually detailed account of the rights and duties of landlords and cultivators. Tenancy cultivation particularly in the case of land owned by Brahmins was quite common.

### **11.2.2 Irrigation and Method of Irrigation**

The main sources of irrigation were Vaigai and Tamaraparani rivers. The secondary sources were Vellaru and other canals. River irrigation was in vogue to a greater extent. Several canals were dug in Vaigai River for the purpose of irrigation. Many tanks and canals were constructed by Parantaka Viranarayanan. Among the canals the following were very important: Parakarma Pandyan ground canal, Vasudeva grand canal, Veerapandyan canal and Sri Vallabha ground canal. A dam was constructed during this period. It was called Parakarma Pandya kallanai. Apart from these irrigation works, a canal was dug in River Pennai for the irrigation of the farmers at Tiruvanmalai.

The kings maintained Eri Variyam to look after the lakes. Tanks and lakes were properly maintained by the variyam.

Facilities were made available by the rulers and the aristocracy of the land. The maintenance of their amenity was facilitated by suitable taxes. A very interesting record from Sarkar Periyapalayam (Coimbatore), of a certain Sundara Pandya contains details as to the duties of the person who was appointed a fisherman "Pillaiyan" who had to look after the anai (anicut) and the channel. He had to be given certain income and privileges. He had to see that the water, did not flow above the dam, but was properly directed into the tank. If there are any defects in the tank and dam, then he had to report the villagers and temple authorities. The appointed village servant called "vettiyan" and he would repair the dam. And for this he was given pieces of rent-free land and some payment in grain. Pillaiyan was also to collect the taxes Vayakalpattam (canal tax) and passipattam (fishing tax) from the temple tenants at Suralur.

### **Reclamation of Waste lands:**

Barren lands and uncultivable lands were brought under cultivation in those days. Series of successful steps were undertaken by the Government to remove the sands from the fields

affected by heavy floods. No wonder the Government authorities paid great attention to increase the yield of these lands.

### **11.2.3 State Help**

A record at “Pon Amaravathi” throws light on forbidding the temple authorities to take water from “Idengalikaman” evidently for the purpose of irrigation. Village assemblies maintained the excavation of canals and other facilities. Reclamation of spoil of land and fresh cultivation of virgin soil were both encouraged. Two records of Jatavarman Sundara Pandya mention some lands as having been sold by the village for a certain sum of money, with the exemption of water taxes in compensation for the labour involved in reclaiming them from their waste condition.

During the reign of Jatavarman Sundara Pandya (1251 A.D.) a new flood embankment substantially built on the side of the Coleroon was raised with the aid of funds collected in the form of a special cess from the inhabitants in the neighborhood.

Reference to arid as well as fertile lands is available in the sources indicating variation in the natural fertility of the soil which could be aggravated by failure of the monsoon and or by the practically continuous warfare which raged all ground.

### **11.2.4 Agricultural Products**

Some of the important products were Thina, Varagu, Ellu, Payaru, Kuruva, Karumbu, Kolundu, Karunai, Manjal, Inji, Senkaluneer, Valai, Valuthalai, Poosani, etc. Non-agricultural products were Maa, Pala, Narthai, Elumichchai, Kulaviralli, Nelli, Iluppai etc.,. Among the non-agricultural products, which were valuable as cash crops are cotton, arecanut, coconut, Palmyra etc. The Vadakkadamai tax  $\frac{1}{2}$  panam on every ma levied on gardenland, growing plantain, ginger, turmeric, or betel. Some of these were paid in cash, but most of them in kind.

## **11.3 Industry and Trade**

In the Pandya period, trade played an important role both in the economy and polity of the country. The highways were made use for the development of trade. Many trade guilds

emerged in the Pandyan region. The wide use of coins, weights and measurements by the merchants shows the flourishing trading activities emerged in the Pandyan territory.

General Industry was ancillary to agriculture and largely confined to the manufacture of the iron-wheel, wooden vehicles. Ships and simple carpentry, building construction, spinning, weaving, manufacture of salt and making of religious structures like temples, processions cars and images, were other major industrial efforts. Naturally industries were only domestic based Simple workshops, where the blacksmith made the wheel, or the carpenter his wooden wares could be called factories of a sort.

Weaving was the most important industry. We hear the tax on weavers for their profession called “Tariyiral” levied on looms Cotton textiles manufactured in Madurai were quite famous. The needs of the people being simple the industry could not have been complicated. Rope making manufacture of leather sheaths, making of ornaments, manufacture of baskets and above all the pottery were well known industries from the beginning.

### **11.3.1 Foreign Trade**

The Pandyas being a sea farming people developed the overseas trade to a great extent. From Periplus and Ptolemy, we got information regarding their trade and ports. Foreign trade was one of the planks on which the economic prosperity of the country depended. From the earliest times the Pandya country has been famous for its pearl. There was a group of ports lay in the Pandya Kingdom; Kayal, Vadalai, Devipattinam, Tondi and Passipattinam. Their importance arose in general from their exports of pearls and import of horses. The articles of imports were other kinds of luxuries like pepper, pearls, ivory, textiles and gold ornaments. Trade with Ceylon was continuous and considerable.

### **11.3.2 Foreigners' Account**

The Venician traveler Marco Polo mentions in particular the profitability of the pearl fisheries at Kayal, the chief emporium of Pandya Kingdom. The horse of Kayal had considerable political important and a good part of the revenue of the kingdom was spent on the purchase of horses for the king and the army. Macro Polo was also criticizing on horse trade that the country's wealth was wasted as the climate was unsuited to Arab horses'. According to him,

king was extremely rich. The king possessed many other treasure of great value besides the best of the pearls that were found in the kingdom. The king was also wearing a fine silk thread strung with 104 large pearls and rubies on his neck. Both Marco Polo and Wassof, the Muslim historian agree in saying that the Pandya king had 1200 crores of gold dinars in his treasury. They have also not failed to mention the personal attendants of the king. Who protected the king, and die with him, when the king died. They were king's "Trusty Lieges" or body guards known to epigraphy as "Tennavan Apattuthavigai".

### **11.3.3 Inland Trade**

It was a self-sufficient economy, since the basic requirements of the people were all met by local products. Inland trade was managed by hawkers and the merchants collecting in the periodical or daily markets. Certain commodities like salt had to be transported over long distances i.e. from sea-coast to the interior villages. The few main roads which connected distant parts of the country were important as much for the traders as for the army. These roads were called "Raja Peruvali". Barter was the usual mode of exchange of commodities, while currency was used in capital cities and for foreign trade. The currency of the realm seems to have comprised different varieties of Coins and people had to take care to specify the type of coins to which each transaction had reference like Palam-Soliar kanu, Vira Pandya Kasu. This confusion was because the traditions of a number of rulers simultaneously ruling in different parts of the country. Macro Polo, also mentions this; for these rulers not only did they cause inscriptions to the engraved and endowments to be made each in his own name, but they seem to have even exercised the Right of Coinage.

### **11.3.4 Merchant Guilds**

The merchants organized themselves into groups or guilds. They were Ainnurruvar, the Nanadesis, (foreign trade), Mani-graman, Valangiyar, Nagarattar, Anjuvanam etc. Manigramam means Vanigrammam or association of merchants. We have evidence of many of these merchant associations acting in union in their public activities. The people of 18 provinces Visayam attend (Epigraph of Ramnad district) and came to an agreement that on all articles of merchandise that were measured, spread and folded and on some other specified goods access of one Kasu per achehu should be collected. The corporations that attended the meeting were self-regulating corporations of different classes of merchants.

These merchants guilds were greatly autonomous, which meant that they enjoyed the advantages of freedom from state interference, but also suffered from the disadvantages of lacking state backing. the mercantile community had no elementary banking operations. Lending through houses specializing in monetary transaction and fixation of rates of interest were quite common. But the agency for the horses supplied to the Pandyan kings enjoyed the patronage of the kings. Macro Polo distinctly tells us that the king extended great favour to merchants and foreigners so that they were glad to visit his city.

## **Review Questions-1**

**I Attempt a brief note on the following**

1. Explain the land tenure and cultivation under the pandyas
2. Point out the importance of irrigation methods during the pandya period.
3. Write about the agricultural products under the Pandyas.
4. Highlight the merchant guilds during the Pandya period.

## **11.4 State Economy**

It seems that the 'Pandyan kings maintained carefully revenue and administrative records on Palm leaves, which were later recopied and preserved'(copper plates and stone inscriptions). The kings issued oral orders to their immediate servants and these orders were called "Kelvi". In the case of revenue order the oral "Kelvi" was written in orders or grants by officers called "Variyilar": From inscriptions we come to know about their sources of Taxes. They are namely Land Taxes, Duties on Articles of trade, Excise tax, Professional taxes and miscellaneous item.

### **11.4.1 Taxes on Land**

Land revenue was the main source of income to the government. The taxes on land fall into four main groups:(a)Land revenue proper, (b) Taxes for maintenance of irrigation works, (c)Taxes for the maintenance of village officers,(d)Taxes for the maintenance of temples and Brahmins.Tamil inscriptions mention,"Kadamai, antaraya, viniyogam and vadakkadamai". Antaraya and Viniyogam are grouped under one item viz., "Kudimai".

The assessment of revenue was fixed with reference to the fertility of the soil, and the nature of crops rose. The village assemblies helped in collecting the revenue from the assesses in the village. Lands which became useless due to loss of fertility by the soil procedure that appears to have been usually followed in making gifts to temples of lands freed from all taxes and other assessments. The large number of remission recorded owing to a variety of causes, shows us that such representatives were not without value. Some such cases were scarcity of water, flood, plunder, the ruined condition of the village, desertion of land by peasants, being filled up with sand owing to the vicinity of the sea, and ceremonial occasions like the king's coronation.

Taxes were collected, so that the village police could be remunerated. The administrator, however, was in a sorry state. The assessee had to bribe the tax collectors so that there could be no excess levy. It was possible in the state of affairs prevailed then for a chief to hold a part of the country around the village and demand a ransom of 4,000 gold pieces, and the affected villagers had to sell at their properties to meet their savage demand. There is no record to show that such high handedness was suitably punished by the king. The state, levied heavy taxes. Two inscriptions of 'Maravarman Sundara Pandya', from Ramanad district, seem to contain more direct evidence of heavy and oppressive taxation and thus the village people preferred "Woodland life than village life". But Brahmadeya and Devadana lands were exempted from tax. But sometimes, the Devadana lands and Brahmadeya lands had to pay a nominal tax.

#### **11.4.2 Duties on Articles of Trade and Excise**

The export of special local manufacturing like textiles, pearls etc., earned a lot of foreign exchange for the country and for the royal treasury also. The king took 1/10<sup>th</sup> of the total earnings from pear-driving and sale of pearls as his royalty. Besides this, there was duty known as, 'Sungam' which raised the revenue of the state.

#### **11.4.3 Professional Tax**

One inscription states that a tax of six panams per anum was levied on each Shop-Keeper (a sort of consolidated sales tax) on each weavers, i.e. Kaikolars, and on each oil

monger, the 'saliyar'. Tax on industries was levied; the artisans also had to pay the tax to the state. The tax was often changed on the instruments used by the professional- the washing stone of the washer man, the loom of the weaver, etc. Professional taxes were generally annual, remissions were occasionally granted, specially for the benefit of the artisan classes, in new settlements. The idangai and valangal groups were also taxed as idangai vari and valangai vari. . The potters paid Kusakkanam oil press, the Sekkiraiu, goldsmiths 'tattar-pattam' and the tax of 'virpidi' levied of barbers, carpenters, metal dealers and dyers

#### 11.4.4 The Pandyan Coins

**One of the early coins of the Pandyans showing their emblem of the two fishes.**



A good number of Pandyan coins have been discovered and are found mentioned in inscriptions. A few gold coins throw light on the pandya rulers of this period. On these coins a fish appears sometimes singly, sometimes in pair, along with symbols like a bow, a conch, a discuss etc. The copper coins of the pandyas besides having a fish emblem also have the chola standing figure or the chalukyam devices associated with fish. The intermingling of the symbols of various dynasties on the pandya coins, perhaps indicate their conquests and defeats. On a few of these coins the name Sundara Pandya, Sundra or merely the letter "Su" is found and to which of the sundara pandya they refer, is difficult to say. Some coins bear a boar with legend "Vira-pandya", read doubtfully on one side, the figure of Venugopala on the other side. They are assumed to have been issued by the pandyas but cannot be attributed to any particular king. Then there are some coins which show the title of the rulers'. But only a few of them may be attributed to any particular ruler with the help of the epigraphs. The coins bearing fish symbols are known having the title 'Kondandarman', Kanchivalangam Perumal, Buvanaka



Veeran, Nenmani kail Yugaraman, Sonadu Kondan (Sundara Pandya-1), Ellamthalaianan (Jatavarman Sundara Pandya-1.)

Difficulties regarding genealogy are peculiar and special to pandya history. This is largely because unlike inscriptions elsewhere, the pandya's epigraphs do not openly or clearly help us to formulate the order of successions. The astronomical data occasionally obtained are so confused that as K.A Nilakanta Sastri says, "ignorance at least of astronomy is bliss". This is another difficulty which again is found mostly among the pandyas. The traditions of a number of rulers simultaneously ruling in different parts of the country and many rulers bearing the same names add to the difficulties already enumerated.

## **11.5 Social Life**

The society under the Pandyas was based on the traditional fourfold division, namely the Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaisyas and sutras. There were other communities like Vellalar, Ayar and Idaiyar etc. However the caste system was not rigid. Generally people were respected not on the basis of the caste but on the basis of their profession. Despite caste divisions and political chaos during the Pandyan rule there was a sense of unity among the people. We come to know that the village assemblies carried on many public activities smoothly.

### **11.5.1 Brahmins**

Brahmins were given first preference in the society. They were highly educated and led a simple life. They were respected for scholarship and character. The pandya king gave donation and gifts to them and charity lands for their settlements. They accommodated them in comfortable and separate quarters, settled them exclusively. Brahmin village called Brahmadeyas later it was known as chathurvedi mahgalams, etc., and kings endowed tax –free lands for their benefit. During the time of sundara pandya -1(1261-A.D )many villages were put together and called "Sundara pandya chathurvedi Mangalam "after the name of the king 200 vlis bof lands were given to the 121 vedic Brahmins of the village.Besides this,there were physicians, village accountant, carpenter, blacksmith, potter, barner, vettiyan(village servant), washerman, who were patronized by the state with service tenure lands.

The Brahmins served as priests in the temples, spread vedic knowledge and performed the vedic rites or yajnas. Apart from these traditional and tribal religious functions they were employed in the king's court as Magistrates and ministers. They earned the titles called "Brahmarayan Enade and Veeramangala Perarayan". But in the reign period of Jatavarman-Sundara Pandya we come across the doings of some Brahmins whose profession seems to have been highway robbery; but they were severely punished.

### **11.5.2 Communities other than Brahmins**

Most of them were distinguished from each other by the profession what they pursued. Agriculture was the main profession of the people. Next to agriculture Trade and industry accounted for the second place in the society. The Pariah, beat the Parai, a drum, the Minavan was the fisherman, the Umarar traded in salt and so forth the peasants were the largest rural community. Vaisyas were traders. The artisans like the goldsmith, the cobbler, the blacksmith, the weaver, were all classified as communities. When a new art or craft was developed a new community also came up. Thus the number of communities tended to grow and some of them split into sub-communities. In the middle ages we hear of two communities, the 'Idangai and Valagai'. Their origins are unknown. It is possible that they were particular martial communities. These communities however continued even long after their functions had ceased. We hear of the Idangai and Valagai in the records of the early 19<sup>th</sup> century also.

Next to the Brahmins, the community of cultivators were most important. They were known as "Vellalars"-men of high esteem considered to be the backbone of the State; they took part in the administration of the state as ministers and commanders of the army. The Vellalars, as landlords, quite rich, extended charities to the temples. But the poor gentry of the same group worked in the fields as labourers or tenants.

We see the other and most important section of society was merchants and their occupation was trade. These-merchants made Pandya country extremely rich through their inland and foreign trade. Substantial quantities of pearls were traded by them. They also submitted precious stones, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, to the King and thus in the words of Marco Polo, "what this king wears between gold and gems and pearls is worth more than a city's ransom". Marco Polo's view was also supported by the historian Wasaf also.

Thus without this merchant class, the prosperity of the state was impossible. These merchants were called “Vaishyas”, but in Pandya country they were also known as “Nagarattar and Chettis”. They were extremely rich, also did social services, and earned name and fame among the subjects. Pillayarpatti inscription of 13<sup>th</sup> century, speaks about these merchants. These Nagarattar were also members of “Thisai Iyarirathu Innurruvar”. They protected the temples, and managed the temple festivals. A record of the late 13<sup>th</sup> century narrates dispute between the Chettis and Oil-Mongers (Vaniya-Nagarattar) of Aragalur (Salem district) with regard to the management of temple festivals, and apparently the Chetti’s succeeded in the end.

These communities formed merchants guilds for easy and swift trade (we have already mentioned in economic condition, the various guilds that were formed under them) they stayed in cities and towns and the streets, where they lived were called after their names “Nanadesi perun theru, Innurruvar peru theru”.etc. We also have many epigraphical evidences for their temple patronage. Apart from the communities mentioned above we have fisherman or “paradavas” community which lived along the sea coast of Pandya kingdom. They also looked after the pearl fisheries of kaayal.

### **11.5.3 Women**

In the Pandyan kingdom, women were generally treated on par with men. They took part in public functions along with men. They were allowed to possess property. The women from royal families got more opportunity to educate themselves. The famous Vaishnavite Alvar Andal had lived in the Pandyan territory and attained glory during this period. Generally the married women had concentrated more on the up-keep of their house and their children. They also followed vocations like spinning, pot making, painting, etc. and raised their family income. They had also extended help to men folk in agricultural activities. Women spent their leisure in playing in-door games like dice, chess, etc.

### **Dress and Ornaments**

The people wore clothes made of silk and cotton. The rich were fond of silk garments. Ordinary people wore cotton clothes. The rich people were also fond of decorating themselves

with various jewels and ornaments. The kings and nobles wore costly ornaments studded with pearls, corals and precious stones.

#### **11.5.4 Slavery**

Slavery was not unknown though it was perhaps not very harsh. People often sold themselves into slavery to clear debts. They commuted their debts into slave labour. There was no slave market. Some of the rich people donated slaves to the temples for service.

#### **11.5.5 Devadasis**

In Pandya country, the institution of Devadasis literally mean “Servants of the Lord” and they were dedicated their services to the temple. They were experts in dance and music. Some of them were belonged to aristocratic families, but out of love to Lord, they surrendered themselves to Lord. But some of them were sold to temples. They were honoured by the society: the kings also patronized them. Besides their services in temples, they became exponents of dance and music. Temple trustees had given them charities, besides the rulers.

There were men slaves in the temples. They were sold themselves and some of them were sold by their masters to service in the temples.

### **Review Questions – 2**

#### **Write answers in detail**

1. Discuss the conditions of the Brahmins during the Pandyan period.
2. Explain about the various communities in the Pandyan period

### **11.6 Education and learning**

The village school assembling under the shade of a tree or in the verandahs of temples and mathas was a common institution, and its teachers were among the staff of the employees remunerated from the common land held by the village. Stone masons and copper smiths were to be found everywhere to engrave inscriptions on stone and copper, and the work done often with remarkable accuracy and art. The maintenance of the complex records of the

Government, local and central and the employment for this purpose of considerable staff of officers and clerks might have stimulated them as now to resort to scholastic education as an avenue to public employment.

Popular education in a wide sense was amply provided for by the recitation and exposition in temples and other public places of the national epics like Ramayana and Mahabharatha and the Puranas. Higher education was generally pursued in schools and colleges attached to mathas and temples. The mathas, the palli and vihara were centres of learning which often owned libraries and transmitted on a variety of topics which increased in volume and diversity from generation to generation. The colleges were called **“Ghaikai Vidya Sthanam or Salai”**- we have many references to Pandya country colleges. We have records for **“Sri Vallabha Perunsalai of Kanyakumari”**, **“Parthiba Sekara Puram Salai”**. State patronized Ghatikas by giving lands known as **“Salabhoga”**.

The purposes of education consisted of

- (a) The Brahmin who did their Vedic studies, perhaps other studies as well.
- (b) The students who equipped themselves exclusively in Tamil studies and the allied subjects
- (c) The mechanics and the craftsman learnt their trade hereditary at home.
- (d) The merchants concentrated on arithmetic and book-keeping and calculation of interest rates. Apart from these there was a vast multitude which had no need for any kind of education-formal or informal.

Public discourses on religion and morals and musical recounting for mythological stories for the benefit of the common men provided a popular course of education which was collected through the ear by the illiterate. The rules were very strict in colleges for the maintenance of discipline.

### 11.6.1 Services of Mutts

During the 13<sup>th</sup> century the mutts increased in number due to the patronage from the rulers and scholars. Mutts' service did education next to temples. At “Thiruppathur” many

Saiva Siddhanta scholars lived. There were Saiva mutts at in Sermadevi, Tirunelveli, Aruviyur and courtaleem. The Vaishnavas also maintained mutts at Alagarkovil, Thirukkurungudu and Vanama-malai. They taught here Vedas, Ithihas, Puranas and “Nalayira Divya Prabhandam”. Grammar and composition were taught both in Tamil and Sanskrit.

There were libraries attached with temples and mutts, were known as “Saraswathi Bhandaram”. There was one library at Chidambaram which was started by one “Sami Thevar” and maintained by “Pallavaarayar” an important officer of that period. Here they collected manuscripts and copied them to preserve for future, again an inscription from Sermadevi, mentions about a grant of lands to a library “Saraswathi Bhandaram” in a temple in the locality and records containing endowments for the recitation and study of the vedas and Puranas in temples are frequently met with. Thus we see that the mutts and temples encouraged enriching education and religion in the Pandya country.

### **11.6.2 Temple, the Important Social Institution**

From inscripational evidence we come to know that the temple played a vital role in the villages. We have seen enough to realize that the most fruitful sources of our knowledge of the history of the country are stone inscriptions preserved in temples and copper plate grants. Of these the stone records in temples are more numerous and varied in their interest. In addition to throwing light on matters like land-tenure and revenue administration those records enable us to reconstruct with some confidence the part of the temple in the general social economy of the time. It is clear that in the middle ages, in South India, the temple was much more than a place of common worship. Sir Charles Eliot says, “Temple Worship is not so important for the Hindus and Church service for the Christians. They set more store on home ceremonies and on contemplation”. And yet, every village had its temple, and in every temple was the object of universal attention at the hands of the princes and the people of the land. The temple is historically more important as a “social and economic” entity than as a religious institution. The history of Hinduism, even in South India, is much more than the history of her temples. But the story of the social life of the country, of the common people, centers round the temple in a manner that is perhaps equaled only in Medieval Europe, although with this vital difference that in South India the Villagers held the temple, while in Europe the Church of the Monastery held the village.

The temple was the centre of universe culture. The best architecture and sculpture as such painting, as there was, were lavished on it. Fine arts like music, dancing and jewel-making flourished in the temples and primarily on their account. Several temples contained libraries and were centers of religious and secular learning. The drama, closely allied, to the dance, was promoted by some temples; Above all, the temple was for the village, the most powerful economic support.

A few facts, gleaned from a mass of similar data, anyhow be set down to confirm these statements about the temple and its part in the life of Medieval South India, An inscription of about A.D 1260 from Madambakkam (Chingleput) dated in the 10<sup>th</sup> year of Jatavarman Sundara Pandya, states that the assembly of the village seeing that it was not possible to maintain the lamps, offering and festivals in the temple from the income available for that purpose, assigned the North division. "Vadakuru" with its wet land, garden lands; houses and house sites to the temples, but retained there in 3000 kuli o land with houses, and housesites for their own use. They also decided to pay the dues on them such as "Ponvari" and "Nattuvai" from their own pockets and agreed that "If ever owing to unfortunate circumstances, we are induced to sell this land; we shall do so, for the price at which it then sells, to the sacred treasury of the temple".

An inscription from "Kamarasavalli" (Trichy) of the 10<sup>th</sup> year of Jatavarman Vira Pandya., gives an idea of the manner in which funds were raised by the inhabitants of the "Valanadu" for affecting certain repair to the temple. They agreed to pay to the temple, a small cess on all merchandise sold by the :e.g. 1/2 panam on each bundle of clothes for women, on each "podi" of pepper, and one kasu on each "podi" of paddy. Maravarman Kulasekhara Pandyan records mentions about the local resident's provided provision of the lamps in the temple

Another record from "Mannar kovil" in the 19<sup>th</sup> year of Kulasekhara deva mentions about the acuisition by the king's order (Niyiga) of private houses for a second prakara to the temple being built according to "Sastra".

The villages of Vayaiur (Chengalput) came to an agreement in the 8<sup>th</sup> year of Jatavarman Sundara Pandya (1258 A.D.) by which they released all the lands which belonged to four temples which were probably all situated in Vayalur, and relinquished their previous hold on

them , whether that was by mortgage or by purchase. The king Kulasekhara made certain temple lands rent-free on receipt of a specified sum for the expenses of the journey. An inscription from Sermadevi mentions a grant of a land to a library “Saraswathi Bhandara in a temple in the locality, and record containing endowments for the recitation study of the Vedas and Puranas in the temples. A record from Pattamadai (near Sermadevi) is of more than ordinary interest as it registers a grant to a dancing girls for enacting a drama, on certain festival days.

We see that the temples are furnished numerous occasions for disputes on various matters. A record in the 16<sup>th</sup> year of Maravaraman Sundara pandya state that the authorities of temple of Devanayaka Permal in Tiruvendipuram decided to follow the system of worship practiced in all other temples. But we have no means of knowing the nature of the innovation necessitated this, rather conservative affirmation regarding the manner of worship.

A record of the late 13<sup>th</sup> century, narrates a dispute between the chetties and oil-mongers “Vaniyanagarattar” of Aragalur (Salem District) with regard to the management of temple festivals and apparently the Chetties Succeeded in the end. There were also disputes as to the order of procedure in which the sacred ashes in Siva temples and the prasadam in the Vishnu temples were to be received or the rope of the God’s car “The Ratha” had to be held in drawing it such other matters. A Case of dispute between two Bhattars as to the right of conducting worship in the temples which was settled by the intercession of the village assembly has been mentioned.

## 11.7 Marco Polo’s Accounts

Marco Polo was the prince among the medieval travellers. He presents a spot study of the Pandyan society.

According to Marco Polo new agraharas were created in the Pandya kingdom. During the rule of Maravarman Kulasekhara Pandya many agraharas were established and 18 Brahmins were invited to occupy the place. It was renamed as Chaturvedimangalm. According to Marco Polo Vellalas was called Bhumiputtirar and Nattumakkal. The vaisyas were called as Chettiers or Nagarattar.



Marco Polo has something to say about the common people of the country. The manner of dress seems to have amazed him. He said roundly that there were no tailors at all in the country, nor was there any need for them. "Seeing that everybody goes naked only the decency to wear a scrap of cloth; that the king goes as bare as the rest" The life of common people was very strange to polo, they worshipped as sacred animal and people, "would not eat beef anything in the world".

He also mentions the custom 'sati' as a common practice and the practice of allowing a condemned criminal who was sentenced to death to sacrifice himself to some God or other of his choice.

The following observations of Marco polo deserve quotation:

"Let me tell you the people of this country have a custom of rubbing their houses all over with cow-dug, moreover, all of them great and small, king and baron included to sit upon the ground only... The people of the country go to battle all naked with only a lance and a shield; and they are most wrecked soldiers.... They will kill neither beast nor bird, nor anything that hath life. In their practice that every male and female do wash the whole body twice a day. In eating get use the right hand only and no account touch their food with the left hand. ... And when they drink they do not put the vessel to the lips, but hold it aloft and let the drink spout into the mouth. So also they drink only from drinking vessel and every man has his own.

A reference to Devadasis is also by Marco Polo. "Certain abbeys in which are god and Goddesses to whom many young girls are consecrated"-the nature of the institution of the temple girls, seems, however, to have been hardly understood by the traveler.

Marco Polo refers to the use of the betel leaves, "All the people of the city Kayal have a custom of perpetually keeping in the mouth a certain leaf called, "Tambul". The Lords and gentle folks and the king have these leaves prepared with camphor and other aromatic spices also mix with quicklime. And this practice was said to be very good for the health"

Marco Polo concludes! "The men of this country have their beds made of very light can work, so arranged that, when they have got in and are going to sleep. They are drawn up by

cords nearly to the ceiling and fixed there for the night. Not that everybody does this, but only the nobles and greatfolks, for the other sleep on the streets

Marco Polo has given a clear picture about the trade that was going on during the Pandya period.

There are certain defects in his account. But for such isolated defects (people went naked. There were no tailors) Marco Polo is an authority on medieval social history.

### **Review Questions-3**

1. Assess the role played by temples in developing the education under the Pandyas
2. Explain in detail Marco Polo's accounts about the Pandyan Empire.

## **11.8 Summary**

During the Pandya period many taxes were imposed on the traders by the Pandya rulers. To promote trade sometimes the kings were liberal and exempted some traders from paying taxes. In fact, the Tamils were great traders. Trade flourished due to the increase in the agricultural production and availability of natural resources and minerals in the Pandya kingdom.

Through Marco Polo's account we come to know about the social life of the people of the Pandyan country during the 13<sup>th</sup> century. To conclude we can say that the people in the Pandya kingdom lived in a prosperous manner. Through the temple's services people were educated

## **11.9 Answer to Review Questions**

### **Review Questions-1**

1. See the subsection 11.2.1
2. See the subsection 11.2.2
3. See the subsection 11.2.4
4. See the sub section 11.3.4

**Review Questions-2**

1. See the subsection 11.5.1
2. See the sub section 11.5.2

**Review Questions-3**

1. See the subsection s 11.6.1&11.6.2
- 2 See the section 11.7

## **LESSON - 12**

# **RELIGION, LITERATURE, ART AND ARCHITECTURE UNDER THE PANDYAS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Recall the growth of Saivism and Vaishnavism during the period of the Pandyas
- ❖ Examine the important role played by the mutts and temples in the life of the people and development of Tamil and Sanskrit literature during the rule of the Pandyas.
- ❖ Discuss the architecture of the Pandyas, the growth of cave temples and structural temples under the Pandyas.

### **Structure**

#### **12.1 Introduction**

#### **12.2 Religion under the pandyas**

##### **12.2.1 Saivism**

##### **12.2.2 Vaishnavism**

##### **12.2.3 Hymns by the Alvars**

##### **12.2.4 Jainism**

##### **12.2.5 Buddhism**

#### **12.3 The Role of the Temples**

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#### **12.4 Literature under Pandyas**

##### **12.4.1 Bhakti Literature**

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## **12.5 Art and Architecture under the Pandyas**

### **12.5.1 Early Rocks-cut Caves**

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### **12.5.4 Art and Architecture of the pandyas of the Imperial period**

## **12.6 Summary**

## **12.7 Answers to Review Questions**

## **12.1 Introduction**

The Pandya kings generally followed religious tolerance. They had made liberal donations and gifts to the Jain monks and to their educational institutions. The Pandya rulers patronized Tamil scholars. They gave importance for the development of Art and architecture.

## **12.2 Religion under the Pandyas**

The Pallavas and Pandyas cherished and nourished the Hindu religion during the 6<sup>th</sup> century A.D. It was continued by the later Pandyas in an exemplary manner. The Pandyas patronized Saivism, Vaishnavism and Jainism. The Nayanmars had preached Saivism while the Alvars preached Vaishnavism. They had spread the spirit of Bhakti among the people. The spread of Bhakti cult inculcated religious feelings and service mildness among the people. These qualities had taken deep roots in the Tamil society.

### **12.2.1. Saivism**

The Saivaite saints namely Thirugnana Sambander and Manickavasagar had lived in the Pandya country and propagated Saivism. Ninasir Nedumaran was a Jain at first. He patronizes Jainism. His wife Mangaiyarrkkarasi and his minister Kulachirai were staunch saivites. Both invited Thirugnana Sambander to Pandianadu. It was at the request of Mangaiyarrkkarasi that Thirugnana Sambander went to Madurai and tried to convert the king to Saivism. There was a terrible debate between Thirugnana Sambander and the Jains. His songs firmly withstood against water and fire i.e. he got glorious victory both in Punavatham and Analvatham were completely burnt and were taken away by the river water. Thus they were completely defeated.

Nearly 800 Jains were impaled. Later on the Pandyan ruler became an ardent Saivite. He took keen interest in patronising Saivism with great vigour and rigour.

Manickavasagar was a great mystic, author of Tiruvasakam. He lived during the reign of Varaguna II. Later on he became his minister. He lived his entire life for Saivism. He composed his songs in praise of Lord Shiva. Besides Tiruvasakam, he also composed Tirukkovaiyar.

Kun Pandya is said to have persecuted thousands of Jains.

### **Kings and Queens Contribution to Saivism**

Many Siva temples were constructed by the Pandya rulers. For the purpose of renovation and maintenance Pandya rulers provided endowments. Varaguna II gave 1400 gold coins to Subramanya Swamy temple at Tiruchendur. The coins were utilized for daily pujas. He also gave 290 gold coins to the temple at Ambasamudram.

Sadayavarman Sundara Pandyan provided gold plates for Chidambaram Nataraja temple. The western tower of the temple was constructed by him. The eastern tower of Meenakshi Amman temple at Madurai was also constructed by him.

Kulasekhara Pandyan erected the sanctum sanctorum, Arthamandapam, Manimandapam and Sannadhi Gopuram during his reign.

In addition to this, the Pandya Queens did a lot for the promotion of Saivism and Siva temples. The queen of VikramaPandya constructed Ulagamudayal Sannadhi at Tiruvannamalai.

The queen of Veera Pandya gave gold ornaments and other valuable gifts liberally to the Siva temple of Tiruvorriyur.

### **12.2.2 Vaishnavism**

During the Pandya period Vaishnavism was greatly revived like Saivism in the country. Alvars were highly responsible for such rejuvenation of Vaishnavism. Among the Alvars Madurakavi, Nammalvar, Periyalvar and Andal belonged to Pandya kingdom.

The contest against the heretical sects is carried on the Vaishnava Alvars as much as by Saiva Nayanmars. But the history of the Alvars is even more obscure than that of the Nayanmars and it is not possible to say much of any of them with confidence. We have the intention to fix the age of 'Madurakavi' and his Guru 'Nammalvar' by identifying Madurakavi Alvar, with the minister 'Marangari' who is also called 'Madurakavi' in the Anamalai inscription. Nammalvar was born of a Vellala family at Alwartirunagar (earlier called Kurugur) in Tirunelveli district. His personal name was Maran and he seems to have gained the name 'Sadagopa' on the occasion of his initiation. He renounced the world in his thirty fifth year to practice Yoga. His hymns are rightly regarded as embodying the deepest religious experience and philosophic thought of one of greatest seers of the world.

The same suggestion as in the case of nammalvar, has been made that another Vaishnava saint Periyalvar, who live about the close of eighth century and the beginning of ninth century was the contemporary of 'Jatila Parantaka-I', most probably. Periyalvar does refer to a Pandya king 'Nedumaran' in the lines. All that we can refer is that if this Nedumaran is the same as the contemporary of Gnanasambandar; this Alvar may also be assigned to their age and likewise his daughter Sri Andal. It seems more likely however, that the reference is to 'Sri Mara Srivallabha' (815-2). But this reference can only be tentative and in any case there is no reason to assign periyalvar to the items of Jatila Parantaka-I. But the reference in Periyalvar to the Pandyas and the instance we have already noticed of the creation of two temples to Vishnu in the time of 'Paranataka Nedunjadyan', furnish sufficient evidence of the influence of Vaishnavism in the Pandya country in this period.

The only woman Alvar, Andal or Kodhai, was the real or adopted daughter of Periyalvar. In her intense devotion to Vishnu she dreamt of her marriage with that god and described her experience in her hymns. To about the same period belonged Tiruppanalvar, a minstrel of low caste, who was not permitted to enter the temple of srirangam and tondaradippodialvar, a Brahmin from Thanjavur district whose real name was vipranarayana; and whose intolerance of Buddhism and Jainism was nearly as great as that of Tirumangai Alvar. Kulasekhara, the ruler of Kerala, was the next Alvar who among other shrines of Vishnu, sang of those at Chidambaram and Tiruvali; and lastly came the celebrated Nammalavar and his pupil Madurakavi Alvar, as we have mentioned above. All these Alvars were belonging to Pandya country and enriched the shrines of south by their devotional hymns.

The Pandya country had 17 Tiruppathikal or 'Alvar Mangala Sasana Sthalas'. They were also called 'Divya Desams. Among them 'Nava Tirupathigal' or the nine most important were 'Alvartirunagar, Srivaikunam, Vanamamalai, Tirukkoilur, Alagarkoil, Srivilliputhur, Tirukotiyur, Darbasayanam and tirukkurungudi'.

### 12.2.3 Hymns by the alvars

The Alvars have praised the Gods presiding over the various shrines. But all these have taken up in their works only the temple of Ranganathar at Srirangam and no other places out of the 'Nurrettu tiruppathigai' i.e., 108 the holy Vaishnava shrines have been praised by all. This accounts for the special importance and sacredness of the shrine at this place. The praise of those Alvars about the various shrines are contained in the Tamil work 'Nalayira Divya Prabandam'.

In the middle of the 12<sup>th</sup> century, Nathamuni gave a definite shape to the 'Vaishnava canon. 'Nalayir Divya Prabhandam' and his grandson Alavandar also called "Yamunacharya", was the great acharya of that period. The greatest of the Vaishnava achariyas was undoubtedly Ramanuja.

The thirteenth and fourteenth centuries witnessed the rise of a schism among the followers of Ramanuja; due to a difference in their interpretation of Prapatti (surrender). So there established two schools as a result of schism called 'Vadagalai and Tengalai'. Tengalai School looks upon Pillai Lokachariya (1213) as its founder. The next great teacher and writer in Tengalai school was Manavala Manunigai (1370). The leader of the Northern School or Vedagalai was Vedanta Desika (1268), the poet philosopher and man of affairs

### 12.2.4 Jainism

By the side of Saivism and vaishnavism and the other forms taken by Hinduism to which attention has been drawn, Jainism had a fair following and enjoyed the patronage of the princes, and people though not to the same extent as the orthodox creeds. The ;land of the Jaina Pallis (pallichandham) was a recognized category of tax free land known to the revenue accounts of that time. Tamil literature was greatly enriched by the writings of the Jaina authors.



The Central feature of the development that followed in the succeeding centuries was the determined efforts made by the exponents of Brahmanism in its various forms to suppress the heretical sects of Buddhism and Jainism an effort which was apparently marked by greater success against the Buddhism than against the Jains. In Hiue Tsang's account mentions about the decline of Buddhism in the south and the envied prosperity of the Jains.

Hence we can trace the survival of Jainism even at a later age. The Jaina teacher referred in the work 'Jivaka-Chivadamani' about the Jains conditions in the eight century another inscription in the same period records a grant of land to the Jaina temple. Rajasimha II the last Pandya ruler of this age has said to have endorsed among others, several Jaina temples. A record from Mangadu of Jadavarma Sundarapandia (1251 A.D) contains a gift of land Pallichandham a Jain temple to certain Jain temple. From the above facts we come to know that Jainism was able to survive unlike Buddhism in spite of the rise of Saivism and Vaishnavism

#### **12.2.5. Buddhism**

In the epigraphical sources we are not able to find reference like Jainism about Buddhism. Buddhist writers also contributed for the development of the Tamil literature though not to the same extent as the Jains. Tiruccopuram (South Arcot) records of Jadavarma Sundarapandia mentions about a certain 'sariputra pandita' figures as a donor and there is a reference about 'Sangathar' most probably members of Buddhist Sangha. With the inference of epigraphy and literature we come to know that Buddhism has lost its importance than Jainism in the 12<sup>th</sup> and 13<sup>th</sup> Centuries

### **12.3. The Role of the Temples**

The Temple has been described as a social institution besides being a religious one. The role played by the temples in general life of the people every village has been discussed in the Pandian inscriptions. Temple becomes a center for social activities in the village schools were established and religious discourse were conducted. In its multi-pillared mandapas kings were crowned the temple was a banker. It owned property but it was exempted from the taxes. It employed a large bureaucracy of servants highly officialised in the case of temples like Srirangam. A center of economic activities involved in stone masonry, carpentry, jewellery,

gold smith and so on iron making i.e., sculpture in stone and metal, garland making special textiles and other ancillary industrial activities center around the temple providing employment to variety of people in the village. Every segment of society officials warriors priest merchants and peasants were all involved with the temple activities endowments were made for the temple by both pious people and current and prospective sinners

### **The religious endowments of the kings and the epigraph of the temples:**

The elaborate arrangements made for the management of the affairs of the temple and endowments were carefully recorded in the inscriptions on its walls

The epigraphs of the age furnish numerous instances to private benefactions to temples for the burning of lamps, the maintenance of gardens, etc., and one of these records from Tiruputtur mentions the gift of ten dinars (kasu) by a Brahmin lady for the burning of a lamp.

As inscription from Tiruchendur tells, as the king Varaguna Maharaja distributed among 16 villages, a large endowment he made to the local temple for meeting the cost of service in the temple; throughout the 12 months of the year. The total endowment consisted of 1,400 gold kasus and these kasus were to be a permanent endowment, only the interest being spent for the purpose specified. Again a sum of 290 gold kasus was in the 16th year of same king, placed in the hands of the assembly of 'Ambasamudram' be utilized likewise as a permanent endowment. The 580 kalams of paddy per anum, to be given by the assembly were to be devoted to meet the cost of offerings 'TiruAmudu' to be made for four times a day in the temple of Tiruppottudaiya Bhatarar at Illangokkudi according to a detailed scheduled of offerings given in the inscription.

There are few inscriptions, Which provide for the distribution of the food offered to the daily among Sri Vaishnavas reciting 'Tirupadiyam' during worship, and create the endowment of land for the maintenance for three persons who were to recite 'Tiruvoymoli' regularly in the temple.

Jatavarman Parantaka Pandya dedicated to the Goddess Kumari and called the A'Tennavar Tham Kula Deivam', a whole Nadu as an endowment for the distribution of liberal gifts to all who attended the 'Taipusam' festival on the day succeeding it.

A Suchindrum inscription of 'Maravarman Srivallabha', dated in his 10<sup>th</sup> year, refers to 'Andapillai Bhatte Ariaprayaji' at whose instance the king made a grant of land to Suchindrum temple.

The minister of Maravarman Sundara Pandya, namely, 'Solan Uyya-ninraduvan', built the garbhagraha, the ardha mantapa and mahamantapa of Perumal temple at 'Tirutttangal' and conducted 'Sundara Pandya Sandhi' in the temple, in honour of Maravarman Sundara Pandyan (1216). He also constructed a stone temple for Tangal Isar and his consort Gowri.

Besides a long Sanskrit stone inscription in the Srirangam temple, there are several stanzas in Sanskrit, celebrating the king, Jatavarman Sundara Pandya's (1251 A.D.) martial prowess and political power and recording his splendid gifts to various temples in Tirunelveli, Chidambaram, Tirupputkuli, Kanchipuram and other places.

### **12.3.1 Epigraphical Importance of Srirangam Temple**

The kings of this dynasty mentioned in the Srirangam inscriptions are 'Maravarman Sundara Pandya-I' and 'Jatavarman Sundara Pandya-II'. The former is the contemporary of the Hoysala narasimha-II. His accession has been fixed as 1216 A.D. from his Srirangam record which dated in his ninth year.

Jatavarman alias Sundara Pandya-I was the other king mentioned in the inscription. His date of accession has been fixed as 1250 A.D. from his Jambukeswaram inscription. His Srirangam inscription is two in numbers; the first one describes in Sanskrit verses a large number of gifts he made to the temple.

The other inscription of this king also celebrates his victories over the Cholas, Keralas and Hoysalas from whom he carried a large booty and from which he performed the Tulabhara ceremony and presented the gold to the temple.

Sundara Pandya also gave Tulabhara Dana to Chidambaram temple and offered golden roof to the temple. The western tower of Chidambaram was constructed by him. He also gave three villages as endowments to Tiruvaanaikkal temple on his birth day 'Chitirai Tingal'. At Madurai, he constructed the eastern tower of Meenakshi Amman temple.

Maravarman Kulasekhara (1168-1347) constructed the Swami Sannadhi, the Mandapam, Mani Mandapam and Sannidhi Gopuram of Meenakshi temple. It seems that Maravarman Sundara Pandya (1216-1238) has also been constructed the Amman Koil Mandapam and Tirumadil. Parakrama Pandya (1315-1347) constructed the western power of this great temple of Meenakshi. Vikrama Pandya's wife (1283) gave endowments to Tiruvannamalai temple; and "Ulaga Mulududaiyal Sannadhi" was arranged on her name; In North Arcot Tiruvattiyar temple; she offered precious stones to Lord Nataraja of Chidambaram.

### **(1) The Mathas and Ascetism**

Besides temples, there were mathas representing different sects of Hinduism which were also recipients of several gifts from the king and the people of the country, some of which have been incidentally touched upon.

### **(2) Saiva Mathas**

Some inscription refers to the important Saiva mathas of the Pandyan country in the thirteenth century, which were patronised by Maravarman Sundara Pandya-II

### **(3) Viashnava Mathas**

The two important mathas were vanamamalai, Tirunelveli District and ahobila matha. Ahobila matha had its branches throughout pandya country. from inscriptions we came to know the following mathas namely.

1. Thiruvadudaiyar Matha, Alagarkoil. 2. Kulasekhara matham, Alagarkoil. 3. Tirumangai matha, Tirukkurungudi and 4. Arulalathan Matha, Alwar Tirunagar.

An inscription of maravarman sundara pandya of thirteenth century, says that the arulathan matha of alvar tirunagar was established by Tirukkurungudi Mamunigal.

### **Review Questions-1**

1. Describe the religious condition under the pandyas
2. Write a short note on saivism under the pandyas
3. Discuss the activities of the temples in the pandya society

## 12.4 Literature under pandyas

### Post-Sangam or pandya –pallava period

After giving the oldest body of works now known in tamil language the literature of sangam age , the next great epoch in the annals of Tamil literature extends over a period of there and a half centuries (500-850). This period is known for Tamil literature as Pandya –pallava age, under which it grew rapidly.

In this age ,the inflow of northen Sanskrit influence became even more and marked than before, numerous words and concepts in the domain of ethics, religion and philosophy were freely borrowed and incorporated in tamil. There was a preponderance of jaina writers to start with Jainism and Buddhism were then waxing strong. But the rising tide of Hindu reaction soon produced a great volume of popular devotional literature, which was set to music and ravished the hearts of common folk. Notable developments occurred in Grammar and lexicography, but here the jains and Buddhists continued to hold the palm. Almost all writing was in verse, and there was little prose worth mentioning.

Most of the important didactical works composed in the period have been grouped together under the title. The Eighteen Kilkan-Nakku; (from about the thirteen century, because of their being composed in various short meters, generally types of the venba). Certainly the best known of them all, possibly also among earliest is the kural of Tiruvalluvar, a comprehensive manual of ethics, polity and love. K.A. Nilkanta Sastri, suggests the early centuries of Christian era; 450-550 A.D. May be the best date for the kural .To the same period must assigned the 'kalavali' of Poygaiyar ,and the 'Mudumolikkanji' a short work of 100 stanzas on mutability by kudlurkilar of Madurai.

The age of the remaining works in the collection may be given tentatively and with in broad limits ,as follows ,between 550 and 650 A.D 'Karnapadu' Inno-Narpadu, Aindinai-Aimbadu; Naladi, Nanmanikkadigai and Palamoli; between 650 and 750 A.D. 'Tirukadugam' Aindinai Yelubathu, Tinaimalai Aimbadu, Kainnilai, Eladhi, Tinaimalai-Nurraimbadu, Sirupanchamulam, Iniyavainarpadu and Asarakkovai.

The Kanarpadu is a love poem; as well as Kainilai are also on the theme of love and love belonged to the class of Aham works. Naladi is a Jaina anthology (400) put together by Padumanar, and arranged in forty chapters; the names of the poets whose songs are collected are unknown but the reference to Muttairyar in two of the stanzas give the clue to the date of the collection. Nanmanikkadigai (100 stanzas) by a Vaishanva poet, Vilambi Naganar and Palamoli is a Jaina work of 400 venbas, each citing a proverb and mention some incident or story to illustrate it. The author of Thikadugam was a worshipper of Vishnu, the other works were by Jains. The Asarakkovai is a veritable Tamil Smrithi by a Saiva author based avowedly on Sanskrit originals.

#### **12.4.1. Bhakti Literature**

The wide spread Hindu religion revival for which many Savia Nayanmars and Vaishanava Alvar worked together, furnished a powerful stimulus to the growth of a popular devotional literature. Besides the work of Nayanmars, the 'Tirumandiram of Trimular' is a manual of Saiva mysticism in 3,000 verses.

Among the Saiva saint of this period, who earned themselves an abiding place in the literature and hearts of the Tamils was "Manikkavasagar" whose 'Thirvasagam' forms the eighth book of the Saiva Canon. He was the Minister of Varaguna Pandya-II and renounced the world and become a saint. The transparent sincerity of the passionate outpouring of the saint in the 'Tirunasagam' makes a deep, impression on the reader's mind. The 'Tirukkuvai' is among the earliest of the full-fledged 'Kovais' which treat of love in a schematic poem of 400 stanzas, each depicting a particular situation. His other work 'Tirvempavai' is also noted of merit. 'Manikkavasagar' poem has a double meaning throughout, the main theme being the love of the soul of God. The 'Karikkovai' of 'Kari Nayanmar' and the Muttarajan –Kovai mentioned in the commentary to be Yapparungalam (tenth century) may be earlier than Tirukkuvai and the 'Pandikkovai' also perhaps an earlier poem is available only in numerous citation. It mentions several battles fought by the successors of Pandya kingdom (590-620). Side by side with the Saiva nayanmars, the Vaishnava Alvars also labored along the same lines for the revivals of Hinduism and their devotional songs constitute in their final reduction the four thousand sacred hymns, 'Nalariya Divya Prabandam'.

The celebrated 'Periyalvar' and his daughter Andal, belonged to Pandya country contributed nearly 650 verses to the collection between them. Sri Andal claimed that the Lord of Srirangam was her lover, and her poems are suffused by her passionate longing for companionship with the Lord, her works 'Tiruppavai' (30 songs) and 'Nachiyar Titmozhi' (143 songs), with her father's are placed first in the canon. The hymn of Andal which starts with the words 'Varana Mayiram' telling of her dream-marriage with Vishnu is sung at all vaishnava Brahmin marriage even today.

The notable work for periyalvar is 'Periyalvar Tirumozhi' and Tirupallandu". The next Tondarippotri Alvar has two hymns, 'Tirumalai' and 'tirupallieaucchi'. 'Tirumangai Alvar, Tondaradi Podi Alvar and kulasekara Alvar, were contemporaries. Kulasekara wasa author of devotional poem in Sanskrit mukundhamala' beside the 105 Tamil verses forming the 'Perumal Tirumozhi' in the Tamil canon of the 'Vaishnavas'.

Nammalvar's work is held in the highest respect as it is believed to embody the deepest philosophical truths taught by the Upanishads. The 1,101 shanzas comprising the 'Tiruvoymozhi' hold the place of honor and have been most elaborately commented on by later exposition of the vishistadyaitha system of philosophy. Madurakavi himself was an Alvar wrote one hymn in praise of his acharya.

#### **12.4.2 Pandya Chola Period**

The later period has Muttolayiram', it must have been a work of 900 venbas, made up of 300 verses in praise of the three monarchs of the Tamil Country.

The impulse to produce devotional religious literature with was so active in the last periods, 500-850 A.D. continued with some fore far into his 850-1200 i.e., the work of poet-saints of Pandya-Pallava period was continued in the age of Cholas by a succession a poets and teachers of second rank. Nambi Andar Nambi's work od Saiva Canon become the subject of 'Umapatisivacharyar's Tirumuraikanda Puranam' (fourteenth century) he also wrote 'Sekkizhar Nayanar Puranam'.

The Vaishnava religious literature during the thirteenth and the beginning of fourteenth century was mostly compressed in Sanskrit. Nathamuni's grandson 'Alvanoar' or Yamunacharya

and the great ramanuja himself wrote almost all their works in Sanskrit. Even the commentators on Tiruvoymozhi, Nanjiyar, Nambillai, Periyavacchan and vadakku Tiruveedipillai all others of more elaborate commentaries, developed a quaint style, 'Manipravala' (Lit, crystal and coral) loaded with Sanskrit words not easily understood outside the narrow learned circle, 'Tiruvarangattu Amudanar', the disciple of Ramanuja, wrote, 'The Ramanujanurandadhi' in praise of Ramanuja which become a daily prayer' Jivasambodhanai' of 'Devendra Munivar's is a Jain's work expounding in detail twelve modes of meditation in the form as an address to the soul.

### 12.4.3 Imperial Pandiya Period

The Philosophical literature of Saiva siddhanta had its beginning towards the end of this period 'Tiruvundiyar' by Tirukkadavur Uyyavanda Devar and 'Tirukkalirrupadiyar' by Tirukkadavur Uyyavanda Devar.

In the first half of the thirteenth century meikandar who formulated the tenets of saiva siddhanta in his 'Siva-Nana-Bodam', a short treatise of twelve suthras the next important work on saiva doctrine is 'Siva-Nana-Sittiyar' of Aruthathi Sivacharya

### 12.4.4. Later Pandya Period

At the end of the fourteenth and beginning of fifteenth century 'Svarupananda Desikar' and his student 'Thathuvarayar' authors to anthologies on the philosophy of advaita. The Sivaprakasa Perundirattu, comprising 2,824 verses in the work of the teacher, that of the pupil called 'Kurundirattu'. Tattuvayar's other works are 'Padutarai'. 'Vanavinodan Kalambakam', 'Mohovadai Parani' and 'Anna Vadai Parani',

The philosophical and religious literature of vaishnavism during this period were in Sanskrit. The commentaries adapted the 'Manipravala style'

Vedantha Desika, an eminent writer in Sanskrit was also the author of a number of tamil works like 'umanikkovai Navaratnamalai, Artapnaneakan, Adaikkalapattu'. His son acharyar wrote a poem in praise of his father and guru in twenty verses known as Pillaiyandadi. Tiruvoymozhi Pillai (1307 A.D.) wrote commentaries on the hymns of Priyazhwar



Some prominent works in the puranas are can be mentioned the Koyarpuranam of Umamathy Sivaagharya which among the earliest sthalapurana are narrates and the legends of the celebrated Saiva shrine in Chidambaram. There is also a chidambara Puranam(1508A.D.) by purana thirumalai nadhan who also wrote the Chokkanadha ula in the devotee of Madurai.

In secular literature the Tanjaivanankovai of Poyyamozhi describes the exploits of Vanan a general of the Pandyan king Maravarma Kulasekara I (1268-1308A.D.) The general role in malainadu (Chera country) is an important theme which finds the place in the kovai and that enables us to identify the pandya king whom he served. Regarding the expectation of Maravarma Kulasekara, the poem says useful informations.

Nalavenba of Pugazhendi is narrates about the tragic story of Nala AND Thamayanthi the Bharataham and Villiputhira (1400A.D.) is a poem of great merit which tells the entire story of the great Bharatha war.

#### **12.4.5. Literary works of the Later Pandya kings**

Many of the later Pandyan monarchs and those of some other dynasties were gifted poets. In the same time the Pandyan king Adhiveerama Pandya of Tenkasi wrote Naidadam. Sri Kaviraya wrote four books namely Thirukkalathinthrula, Thiruvannamalaiyar vanna, Seyur Murugan Ula, Rathinagiriula, King Varathungarama Pandya wrote three books namely Kalithurai andhadhi, Venba andahdhi and Pathitruvalu. Mayila nathan wrote commentary on Nanul. Adiyarkkunakkur wrote commentary on Silappadikaram. Senavrayar wrote commentary on Tolkappiyam and Parimelazhagar wrote commentaries on Tirukural. Thus the second Pandyan rulers patronized the literary scholars.

### **Review Questions 2**

#### **Write in detail**

1. Analyse the growth of Bhakti literature during the Pandya rule
2. Examine the literary development under the later Pandyas.

## 12.5 Art and Architecture under the Pandyas

### Aerial view of the Madurai Meenakshi Amman temple



The Pandyas contributed more for the development of architecture. Gopuras, Prakaras, Vimanas and Garbagrahas are the salient features of the Pandya temple architecture. The Pandyas were great patrons of art and architecture. According to A.L. Basham, "Architecture reached its culmination under the Pandyas and marks the transition from the Chola to the exquisite and extravagant products of Vijayanagar". Dr K.V. Raman says that "not only in the quality of outpost but also in the intrinsic qualities of beauty and magnificence, the Pandyan moments stand out as grand landmarks recalling to our minds the long and arduous vicissitudes through which the art tradition and art impulses of the Tamils passed from age to age and reached the fame of glory during the middle of the 13<sup>th</sup> century".

Madurai, Chidambaram, Kumbakonam, Tiruvannamalai, Srirangam temples are good examples for the development of Pandya architecture. The images of horses and other animals are carved on pillars. According to A.L. Basham, "the zeniths of Pandyan architecture are Meenakshi temple at Madurai and Aranganathar temple at Srirangam".

### 12.5.1 Early Rock-cut Caves

The Pandyan period is marked as Renaissance period in the field of rock-cut temple. The early structural monuments in the Pandya country are in sense lineal descendants of

“earlier rock-cut caves”. These caves are distributed throughout the Pandya country and easily to mind similar excavations of the Pallavas, notwithstanding a few varieties in detail. Possibly the earliest of these caves is the one at “Pillayarpatti” containing an archaic inscription in what appears to be Protovatteluttu. More than 50 rockcut temples were excavated from the Pandyan kingdom. More rock cut temples are found in Thirupparankundram, Anaimalai, Karaikudi, Kalugumalai, Malaiyadikurichi and Trichy. These temples were constructed for Lord Shiva and Vishnu.

The cave at Anaimalai contains a foundation inscription in early grantha and vatteluttu, characters citing the kali year 3871 equivalent to 770 A.D. The inscription is that of Maran Jadayan states that the rock-cut temple of Narashima was started by Marankari, a minister of the king, but as he died before the completion hence the work was completed by his brother Maran-Eyinan. who performed the consecration ceremony.

Another cave with an inscription of the lintel of the door way is the one at Thirupparankundram, containing an epigraph mentioning the excavation of a temple for Siva in the kali year 3874 corresponding to 773 A.D. Cave temples are also found at Kalugumalai and Trichy. Unfortunately there is no definite clue to find out the precise date of the excellent monolithic at Vettuvankoil in kalugumalai, which is a precursor to all the later temples in the Pandya region: but its architectural style would suggest that it may be dated somewhere at the beginning of the ninth century.

#### **12.4.2 The Structural Temples**

Structural temples were built on stones. They were simple in style. Each temple consists of Garbhagraha, Arthamandapa and Mahamandapa. Such structural stone temples are found in Kovilpatti, Thirupattur and Madurai. The Pandya kings constructed structural temples at Ukkirankottai, Ambasamudhram, Thirupattur, Mannarkudi, Madurai, Alagarkoil, Enaadi, Srivilliputtur and Sinnamannur, Internal structure of these temples were constructed in a planned manner.

Few famous structural temples of the Second pandyas were at the Vadapadrasayi temple at Srivilliputthur, Siva temple at Ambasamudram, Vijayanarayana temple at Nanguneri and

Lakshmi Narayana temple at Athur. Pandya rulers built big gopurams at the temple entrance. Pandya rulers renovated Alagar kovil and Jambukeswara temples.

### 12.5.3 The Pandya Style of Architecture

From the above mentioned temples we come to know about the superstructure of the temples had both octagonal and square types of Sihara. . The octagonal Sikhara remind us about some of the Pallava monolithic and structural temples. The Pandya monolithic are seen at Kalugumalai. The square Sihara style belongs to the Pandyas.

From the paleography of the inscriptions found in the few Pandya temples we can say that the earliest Pandya temple was at Tirukkurungudi. And the temple must be belonged to the ruler Varaguna I. This temple has an octagonal Sikhara.

Ukkirankkottai temple is in Tirunelveli district. It has two shrines and both the shrines have inscriptions of Sadayvarman. The main shrine of the first temple is a simple sanctum the second has a vestibule over which the superstructure of the sanctum extends

Sri Sowmya Narayana Perumal Temple – Tirukkoshtiyur is a village located near Tirupathur on the way to Sivaganga. This place is very important to Vaishnavites because Sri Sowmya Narayana Perumal temple is one of the 108 Divya desams, the holy shrines for them. It was constructed by the Pandyas. This temple is surrounded by high walls on its four sides; with a Rajagopuram at the entrance is a spectacular one.

Unlike the other temples the inner infrastructure is planned in a such a manner i.e. inside the temple complex the shrine for Vishnu is constructed in 3 stages similar to that of three floors in the building. These stages represent Boologam (earth), Thiruaprakadal and Vaikundam; Narayana appears in three stages in three forms. On the ground floor Narayana appears as Krishna in the dancing posture. In the next floor he is seen as Sayana thirukolam (Sayana-reclining, thirukolam- posture) a posture resting on Adishesha. And at the top level Narayana is seen standing as Sri Sowmya Narayana Perumal. These forms of Narayana has been described by Alvars as Nindran (means standing posture) Kidanthan (means sleeping posture) and Aadinan (Means dancing posture). While the uppermost tala in this square, the first and the second are rectangular. The sikhara is of the octagonal type.

### 12.5.4 Art and Architecture of the Pandyas

The Pandyas of the imperial period added the gateway towers and reduced the central tower over the sanctum to a mere vimana. The prakara lying between the outer towers and the sanctum received greater attention. Outer Mandapas came in. The simplicity of the Pallava style developed into a matured beauty subject to detailed decorative attention and an enlargement of the temple complex at the hands of the Pandyas.

The pillar also underwent a further evolution under the Pandyas the “idol” became more pronounced with a scalloped edge, the corbel was moulded into a pendant or drop, and the palagai increased in width. Some of the architectural pillars of the temple of Nellaiyappar temple at Tirunelveli, when struck, produce a musical sound.

#### **Sculpture:**

Pandyan sculptures are beautiful and ornamental. Some sculptures are engraved on single stone. Pandya period is considered as the renaissance period in the art of sculpture. Sculptures of Somaskanda, Durgai, Ganapathy, Narashima and Nataraja are very good specimens. Sculptures at Kalugumalai, Thiruparankundram and Narthamalai are very famous.

#### **Paintings**

The beauty of the Pandya mural painting can be seen in the Chittannavasal cave temples constructed during the time of Srimara Srivallabha. Pandya, The ceilings and the pillars at Chittannavasal bear the paintings of dancing girls, the kings, the queens, plants and animals. The picture of Lotus, bathing elephants and playing fishes were good at Chittannavasal. Oil painting was also there. They are outstanding examples of Pandya paintings.

#### **Review Questions- 3**

1. Describe the salient features of the Pandyas style of architecture.

### 12.6 Summary

Pandya rulers contributed more for the development of literature, art and architecture. Their contributions created a unique and permanent cultural impact upon the Tamil society.

## 12.7 Answers to Review Questions

### Review Questions -1

1. See the subsection 12.2
2. See the subsection 12.2.1
3. See the section 12.3

### Review Questions -2

1. See the subsection 12.4.1
2. See the subsection 12.4.5

### Review Questions -3

1. See the subsection 12.5.3

## 12.8 Further References

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## **LESSON - 13**

# **MUSLIM INVASIONS IN TAMIL NADU**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Understand the causes for the Muslim invasion
- ❖ Learn about the rule of the Madurai Sultanate and
- ❖ Know the reasons for the decline of the Madurai Sultanate

### **Structure**

#### **13.1 Introduction**

#### **13.2 Causes for the Malik Kafur's Invasion**

#### **13.3 Brief Rule of the Delhi Sultans**

#### **13.4 Origin of the Madurai Sultanate**

##### **13.4.1 Jalaluddin Ahsan Khans**

##### **13.4.2 Ala-ud-Din Udaui and Qutb-ud-Din Firuz**

##### **13.4.3 Ghiyas –Ud- Din Muhammed Damaghani**

##### **13.4.4 Nasir-Ud-Din Muhammed Damghan Shah**

#### **13.5 Decline of the Madurai Sultanate**

#### **13.6 Summary**

#### **13.7 Review Questions**

#### **13.8 Answers to check Review Questions**

#### **13.9 Further References**

### **13.1 Introduction**

The rule of Madurai Sultanate was one of mere wars and expeditions, victories and defeats. Malik Kafur was the important military commander of Alauddin Khilji who invaded Madurai and paved the way for the establishment of the Muslim rule in Tamil Nadu. Their rule

lasted roughly for half a century but they were able to leave a permanent impact in the history of Tamil Nadu. The rule of Madurai Sultanate came to an end with the rise of Vijayanagara rulers.

It was the enmity and dispute over the throne of Madurai Kingdom among the royal family members that brought Malik Kafur to the Pandya kingdom. The Chronicles of Ibn Bhattutta and Madhuravijayam of Gangadevi are the best available sources for the study of the Madurai Sultanate apart from the coins issued by the Madurai Sultanate rulers themselves.

### **13.2 Causes for the Malik Kafur's Invasion**

**The Pandiya king** Maravarman Kulasekhara Pandyan had two sons namely Jatavarman Sundara Pandyan and Jatavarman Veera Pandyan. The elder son, was by the king's wife and the younger, was by a mistress. The king announced Veera Pandyan as his successor contrary to the tradition. As a result Sundara Pandyan killed his father and became the ruler in 1310. With the help of the local chieftains Veera Pandyan started the civil war. In that war Sundara Pandya was defeated and he fled the country. Sundara Pandya sought the help from Delhi sultan Ala-ud-din Khilji. The sultan agreed to his request and sent an army under the leadership of his General Malik Kafur. With his help, Muslim army from the north entered Tamil Nadu in 1311. The army engaged in murder, rape and looting as it passed through Tamil Nadu. Thus the result of the internal quarrel in the Pandyan royal family led to the first invasion of Tamil Nadu from Delhi Sultan. The result of this invasion was devastating to Tamil Nadu.

Malik Kafur fought against Sundara Pandyan also. He fled to southern Tamil Nadu. His main aim was to plunder the wealth of Tamil Nadu after achieving this he went back to Delhi. Only for a brief period of few months his army stayed in Tamil Nadu. During this period he gathered gold, precious stones, horses and elephants. It is said that he had taken over 90,000 sovereigns of Gold, and famed pearls, 612 Elephants and 23,000 horses.

Thus the first invasion of Tamil Nadu from Delhi was a direct result of the internal quarrel in the Pandyan royal family. This was the very first time Tamil Nadu was plundered by a ruler from Delhi. Even though Malik Kafur left Tamil Nadu with the looted wealth in 1311, the Tamil nation laid devastated and demoralized. Tamil Nadu would never recover from it fully and



achieve its past glory. The lost sovereignty was yet to be recovered. Thus he set the stage for the consequent arrival of the Madurai Sultanate.

### 13.3 Brief Rule of the Delhi Sultans

There were few more invasions after Malik Kafur left Tamil Nadu. Roughly from 1327 to 1335 and it was headed by Khusrav Khan and by Ulugh Khan. These invasions shattered the Pandyan Empire beyond revival. While the previous invasion was content with plunder, Ulugh Khan annexed the Pandyan dominions to the Delhi Sultanate. Thus Tamil Nadu became a part of Sultan Mohammad bin Tughlug's Empire of the Delhi sultanate. Then the commanders of the Delhi Sultanate revolted against the sultan and established an independent rule under the name of Madurai Sultanate. Thus the Delhi Sultan rule over Tamil Nadu ended within eight years.

### 13.4 Origin of the Madurai Sultanate

In Tamil Nadu from Madurai they ruled as an independent kingdom for a short period and they were known as Madurai Sultanate. In 1335 then viceroy of Madurai, Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan announced his independence from the Delhi sultanate. Thus he founded the Madurai Sultanate rule in Tamil Nadu. Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan and his descendants ruled Madurai till 1378. The last sultan, Ala-ud-Din Sikandhar Shah was defeated in a battle with the Vijayanagara Empire led by Kumara Kampana. Thus the Madurai Sultanate ruled only for a short period of 43 years, with eight different rulers. This short lived Muslim dynasty at Madurai came into existence following the decline of the Second Pandyan Empire.

#### 13.4.1 Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan

**Coin of Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan**



Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan, the Tughlug Governor of Madurai declared his independence and established the independent Sultanate of Madurai. Thus he was the first Sultan of the Madurai Sultanate and father-in-law of the Historian Ibn Batutah. Immediately Delhi Sultan Mohammad bin Tughlug sent an army to reassert his supremacy. But his army was defeated by Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan. Tughlug took his revenge by killing Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan's son Ibrahim who was the purse-bearer of the Emperor. Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan was killed in 1340 by one of his nobles. Thus he ruled only for a brief period of five years.

#### **13.4.2 Ala-ud-Din Udaui and Qutb-ud-Din Firuz**

After Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan's murder, Ala-ud-Din Udaui Shah came to power in 1340 A.D. In a battle he too was killed soon by the Hindu armies. He was succeeded by his son –in-law Qutb-ud-Din Firuz Shah. After assuming power within 40 days he was also murdered by Ghiyas-Ud-din Dhamagani. He took over as Sultan in 1340.

#### **13.4.3 Ghiyas –Ud- Din Muhammed Damaghani**

Ghiyas–ud-Din Muhammed Damaghani, was defeated by the Hoyosala king Veera Ballala III in the beginning of the battle but later he was able to capture the Hoyosala ruler and murdered him in 1343. He robbed him of his wealth, had him killed and in the walls of Madurai his stuffed body was displayed. In 1334 Ghiyas –ud-Din Muhammed Damaghani died.

#### **Ibn Battuta Chronicles**

During Ghiyas–ud-Din Muhammed Damaghani's rule the Muslim Moroccan explorer famous for his extensive travels through Africa and Asia, visited his court. He married the daughter of Jalaluddin Ahsan Khan. His travel account narrates about Ghiyas–ud-Din Muhammed Damaghani's atrocious behavior towards the local population.

#### **13.4.4 Nasir-Ud-Din Muhammed Damghan Shah**

Ghiyas –ud- Din Muhammed Damaghani was succeeded by his nephew Nasir-ud-Din Muhammed Damghan Shah. He was a soldier from Delhi. After he became the Sultan he realized the threat from the officers and nobles and also from his various political enemies.

Hence he dismissed many and killed them. As a result the decline started in his period and within a short span of time he also was murdered.

### **13.5 Decline of the Madurai Sultanate**

Due to the struggle for power the Madurai sultanate's rule in Madurai declined rapidly. There are no references about the sultanate for some period. There was a lack of any coinage issued during this period. However we are able to get the coins from 1358 to 1378 indicating the ruler's names. They were Shams-ud-Din Adil Shah, Fakhr-Ud-Dim Mubarak Shah and Ala-ud –Din Sikkander Shah. From this we infer that they ruled till 1378.

From Madhuravijayam of Gangadevi we come to know about the defeat of the sultans at the hands of Kumara Kampana, the son of Bukka the Vijayanagar Emperor. The army of Kampana defeated the Sultan's forces at Samayavaram and captured Kannanur- Koppam, a stronghold of the Sultans. In another battle the Sultan was defeated, that took place in between Trichy and Madurai, in which the Sultan was killed. Thus the tyrannical rule of the Sultans at Madura came to an end by the invasion of Kumara Kampana. The southern part of Tamil Nadu came under the rule of Vijayanagar. This tremendous victory made Kumara Kampana as the Viceroy of the Tamil country under Vijayanagar.

Kampana's invasion has been narrated in the Sanskrit poem Madura Vijayam written by Kampana's wife Gangadevi. After this victory they were able to restore Srirangam's temple old glory. During Harihara II's rule in Vijayanagar formally declared in 1378 their possession of Madurai.

### **13.6 Summary**

The struggle among the brothers of the Royal family in the Pandya country led to Malik Kafur's invasion. With this defeat permanently Tamil Country has gone to the foreign rulers namely the Sultans, Vijayanagar, Nayaks, Maharashtrians and Nawabs till our independence. From contemporary historical accounts, we come to know of the rulers of Madurai Sultanate, as tyrants and persecutors of Hindus. Both Ibn Battutta's and Gangadevi's accounts contain graphic descriptions of atrocities committed by the Muslim Sultans on the Hindu population.

### 13.7 Review Questions

1. Narrate the causes for Malik Kafur's invasion to Tamil Nadu
2. Describe about the History of the Madurai Sultanate

### 13.8 Answers to check Review Questions

1. See the section 13.2
2. See the sub sections 13.4.1 to 13.4.4

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## **LESSON – 14**

# **VIJAYA NAGAR AND NAYAK RULERS - SOCIAL AND ECONOMIC CONDITIONS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After having gone through this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Recall the Telugu people settled in Tamilakam in large number and the influence of Brahmas in the society under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
- ❖ Discuss the untouchables lived in a separate places called 'cheris' , the barbars , Potters and washer men who were considered as important classes in the Villages during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
- ❖ .Examine the economic progress through trade and commerce during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

### **Structure**

#### **14.1 Introduction**

#### **14.2 Social conditions**

##### **14.2.1 Valangai and Idangai Groups**

##### **14.2.2 Foreigners**

#### **14.3 Education**

#### **14.4 Family**

##### **14.4.1 Women**

##### **14.4.2 Marriage**

##### **14.4.3 Sati**

#### **14.5 Housing**

##### **14.5.1 Food**

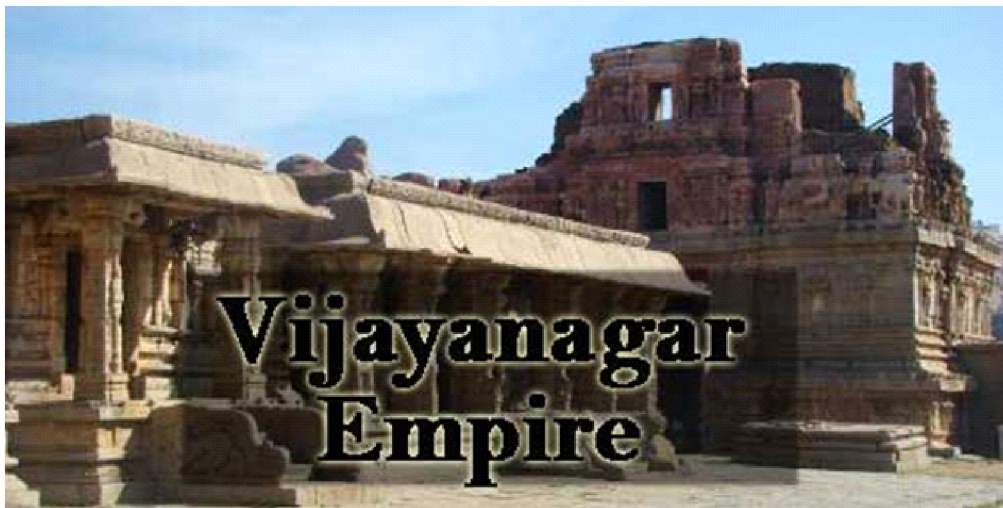
##### **14.5.2 Dress**

##### **14.5.3 Ornaments**

**14.5.4 Fine arts****14.5.5 Festivals****14.6 Economic conditions – Agriculture****14.6.1 Villages****14.6.2 Land****12.6.3 Ownership****14.6.4 Irrigation****14.6.5 Methods of Agriculture****14.7 Industries****14.7.1 Village Industries****14.7.2 Textile****14.7.3 Mining and Metallurgy****14.7.4 Jewelry and Weapons****14.7.5 Carpentry and Fishing****14.8 Trade and Commerce****14.8.1 Exports and Imports****14.8.2 Transport****14.8.3 Ports****14.8.4 Guilds- craft guilds****14.9 Trade Communities****14.10 State Economy-Sources of Income and Expenditure****14.11 Summary****14.12 Answers to Review Questions****14.1 Introduction**

The Vijayanagar Empire was established to save Hindus from the Muslim onslaught and Aggressions. They safeguarded the varnashrama Dharma of Hinduism. The Society during the Vijayanagar-Nayak times was divided into several sections. The Brahmanas and Vellalas

were the two dominant groups in their period. There were other communities like Chettis, Vanniyar and Srigopala's. One of the important features of the Vijayanagar-Nayak society was the adoption of alien communities from the Telugu and Karnataka regions. The Saurahtras and later the Muslims and the Christians formed themselves as separate social groups. The Vijayanagar and Nayak economy was based on land. Many new areas were brought under the plough and agricultural production increased considerably. The king followed a policy of liberal industrialization



## 14.2 Social Conditions

There were many divisions in the society during this period. The establishment of Vijayanagar rule in tamilakam added a new element to the population.

### 1. Brahmanas

A large number of Telugu Brahmins were settled in Tamil Nadu during this period. The Brahmins enjoyed high status in the society. They participated in all the activities of the society. The Brahmanas were learned and functioned as priests in the temple. They also served as ministers and generals in the empire. They have led contingents of army to the battle fields. A few of them owned estates. There were a few traders also among the Bahamians. They led a simple life and spent their time in reading Vedas and shastras. Their dress was a simple two piece cloth, the first worn around loin and the second a long one worn round the shoulder. All Bahamans wore a sacred thread. They were given lands by the rulers for their livelihood.

## **2. Vellalars**

The Vellalas occupied a good position in the society next to that of the Brahmins. They were found in large numbers in Tirunelveli, Coimbatore, Salem and North Arcot. They were the owners of land. Cultivation was dependent on them. They formed the biggest section of the population in the country. In this period they organised themselves into a corporate body called Chitra-melipperi-yanadu. They worshipped the meli (the plough share). The corporate body also looked after the marketing of agricultural products. The srigopalas and manradis lived by rearing cattle. Srigopala tended cows and traded in milk and milk products. The manradis reared sheep. They had close relationship with temples. It was with the manradis the temple sheep were entrusted with. The manradis are to supply a particular amount of ghee for maintaining perpetual lamps in the temple. The Vellalas did not take wine and meat in those days. Widow Remarriage was not allowed in this community.

## **3. Martials communities and Others**

Among the martial communities, the Vanniyar, Tandirmar, Agampadiyar and Marvar may be mentioned. These communities have now settled as land owners and cultivators. The primary occupations of the chettis are komattis was business during the period. They were interested in trade and commerce. The Devaradiyar was another important community attached to the temple. They were the Servants of the temple and performed dances in front of the deity at appointed hours. Their position was degraded into devadasis later. The betel growers and cultivators of oil seeds formed another dominant sub-group. These two communities functioned as traders also. The cultivators of oil seeds were one of the affluent communities in the Tamil country. They extracted oil from the various oil seeds. The betel growers also had a promising trade.

## **4. Artisan Communities**

The artisan communities formed another distinct group. There are five artisan groups namely (1) goldsmith (2) brass-smith (3) black-smiths (4) carpenters and (5) idol makers. The first four communities supplied the household utensils and furniture. Each one of these communities lived in a village and offered their services to the society. Craftsmanship was



usually hereditary. They were collectively named as Panchalar. There seems to have sub-sects among the Panchalas. The inscriptions to Devaraya-1 mention 74 sects among the Pandiyachalas. There was a quarrel among themselves for their privileges. Many instance are known from epigraphs. In one instance Attur, the gold-smith and black-smiths quarreled and finally agreed on a settlement in 1526 A.D. The Panchalas is Kallidaikkurichi disputed among themselves for certain privileges which was later Conferred upon by Virappa Nayak of Madurai.

The Panchalas lived with other communities for securing certain privileges at public festivals in temples. In 1632 the nature of Tiruvamattur agreed that they will not-ill-treat the artisan communities or deprive of their privileges. They further agreed that the rights and privileges enjoyed by the artisans in other areas like Tiruvannamalai, Padaividu Senji and Kanchipuram would be accorded to them. The privileges to Kanmalar were withdrawn in certain other areas like Tirunavalur sirmai, since they were not entitled.

## **5. Kaikolas**

Weaving was the main occupation of the kaikolas of this period, The weavers formed a sizable group in the Tamil country. The Saliya, Niyayattar, Seniyar and Kaikkolars are the different weaving communities. Among them the Kaikkolars occupied a supreme position. They generally lived in separate streets close to the temple in the 16th and 17th centuries separate settlements of weavers were also established with the advent of European traders. The kaikkola weaving settlements were also established near the port cities. The Kaikkolas also fought for certain social privileges. The Kaikkolas of Kanchipuram and Virinchipuram enjoyed the privilege of using dandu (palanquin) and Sangu (conch). In 1485 the same privileges were extended to the kaikkolas of Valudalampattu rajya. The Kaikkolas of Kanchi were also given some privileges. In 1503 the privileges were extended to the Kaikkolas of Tirubhuvanamdevipparru and Nenmalaipparu the kaikolas had the title of: Mudaliar” in those days. The Government collected taxes for their “Taris”.

## **6. Paravas**

The Paravas were a fishing folk lived along the east coast. The paravas on the south pandya region took to pearl fishing also. Some of them were weavers. There are merchants

who traded in the painted cloth known as calico. When the Jesuit missionaries visited the east coast many paravas were converted to Christianity. Their food consisted of meat, fish and rice.

## 7. Other Communities

The paraiyan and Pallan were untouchables. They were the low-caste people. They lived in separate place called as “Cheris”.

. They were the agricultural labourers. They also performed the menial services in the village. They led a miserable life. In many cases the labourers were slaves (adimai) and they were just the property of their masters.. Non-Brahmin and Brahmana land lords owned such slaves. The barbers, potters and washer men were the other communities lived in Villages. From Srivilliputhur inscriptions we come to know that there was a struggle between Devendra Kudumbas and Parayas. After this struggle Parayas were given certain privileges.

## 8. Telugu communities

The establishment of Vijayanagar rule in Tamilakam added a new element to the population. Most of them seem to have migrated along with the viceroys. The important telugu speaking communities in Tamilakam are the Kammavar, Balijas, (Bangle merchant), Uppuliya, Saniya etc,. This rule also witnessed the large scale settlement of the Reddis, an agricultural community from the Telegu area. The reddis were divided into two groups: (1) Pangala Reddis and (2) Panta Reddis. With the Telugu speaking communities the Telugu Brahmanas also came. The Nayaka the militant Telugu community was another influential community that survived in the Tamil country. The Telugu speaking Uppilians (Salt merchants) spinners and dyers, senians (weavers), barbers leather workers, oddans (house buldes) and Dombans (basket plaiters) were the other communities who have settled in parts of Tamil country.

The above Telugu speaking people were distinguished by their own characteristic manners, customs and forms of worship.

## 9. Saurashtras

The saurashtras (Pattunlkarar) were another group who hailed from Saurashtras and settled in parts of Tamil country. They migrated during the Vijayanagar times. They settled in

the Tamil country under royal patronage. An important settlement flourished in Madurai. They assumed Brahmins caste names and spread certain legends that they were originally Brahmins. They had some disputes with Brahmins over certain social rights. During the regency of Mangammal, she established the right to conduct upakarma ceremony by the Saurashtra community by issuing a copper plate to them.

### **14.2.1 Valangai and Idangai Groups**

The different communities in the Tamil country aligned themselves into two main groups as the Valangai (right hand) and Idangai (left hand) groups. About the origin of these two groups many traditions are available. T.W. Ellis mentioned that the agriculturists were Valangai sect and the non-agriculturists like merchants also accepted the theory. However there is no positive and artisans formed into Idangai. M. Srinivasan Iyengar evidences in support of this history. The origin could be traced to the military classifications of the Imperial Cholas. Those who took up arms on the right side of the military formation were the right hand group. Those who formed the left side of the formation were left hand groups. According to tradition each group consisted of 98 sub-sects.

The two groups had frequent conflicts among themselves. The disputes were sometimes on trivial matters like which group the right to wear white or red colour flower has. On some occasions they quarreled for participation in festivals. A similar agreement was also made between the two groups in 1440. These two groups organised themselves into a body at times of distress. Sometimes this proved threat to the government also. The two groups joined together in opposing the introduction of a new measuring rod. They agreed that they shall not submit to any outsider even if the local vijayanagar Governor with Brahman and Vellala land holders oppress them in collusion with government officials. It was an open revolt against the government officials. It was an open revolt against the government that took place in 1429. This peasant revolt was not confined to a small area. Its repercussions can be seen in the whole of the Tamil country.

The occupation of Telugu and Kannada speaking people led to the rise of certain social problems. Since these two groups followed their masters and settled down in the Tamil country with that they commanded a high social status as conquerors of the Tamil people. Probably

this led the earlier inhabitants giving up their original occupation and taking up menial works. The Tamil Semmans, who on the advent of the Madigas (Telugu) and Chakkiliyans (Kannada) had taken up menial service in the village, tailoring lime quarrying and selling. Further these groups undertook some temple services jointly.

### **14.2.2 Foreigners**

There was a considerable foreign population in the Tamil country, The Portuguese, the French and the Danish contributed to the foreign, population. They generally lived in separate quarters. Most of their settlements were created by them. These foreign populations had their own churches and mosques in their settlements. Some Christian missionaries mingled with the Hindu population and attempted conversion to their religion. They had a mixed reception among the native population. The Muslims also made some conversions.

## **14.3 Education**

Only a few communities were able to get education in this period.. The Brahmanas, the Kshatriyas and the Vaisyas were in need of education. Each village had a small educational institution often paid by the local population. The teacher taught the students according to his own Syllabus. The school was normally held in the house of the teacher. Education was generally of gurukula type. Mutts also played an important role in the spread of education. They specialized in the religious philosophy. Much of the Vijayanagar-Nayak educational system was inter-woven with religion. So part of their education was centered round religion and religious philosophies.

The Brahmanas had an educational system of their own. They learnt Vedas and allied literature. Temple premises were utilised for conducting classes. At Adayapalam, Appaya Dikshitar established a school in the Kalakanteswara temple and made provision for the teaching of about 500 students in the Srikantabhasya. In the Arulalaperumal temple at Kanchipuram a school was held to teach Vedas. The teacher appears to have remunerated by assignments of lands. Lands were granted as adhyayana vrutti. King Achutaraya made a grant of village for promoting Vedanta studies. In 1535 a piece of land was granted at Virinchipuram for the teaching of a few sections in the Rig and Yajur Vedas. Madurai was a great centre of learning. According to Robert de nobili. There were about 10,000 students and the Nayaks of Madurai supplied

food and cloth to them. Encouragement was given for the recitation of religious literature in the temples also. In 1523 a gift of land was made for the recitation of Sanskrit Vedas, Dravida Vedas and the exposition of Vedanta.

According to Robert de Nobili four methods of study were followed in schools and they were: The course was divided into four parts the first dealing with evidence, the second with knowledge and the third with authority. Each of these parts was divided into smaller divisions.

Sciences like astrology, astronomy and medicine were also taught. There seems to be no special schools to teach these subjects. Experts in the fields trained the students. They were generally selected among their own communities. The Vaisyas learned the science of mathematics and the art of trade. The kshatriyas learnt the art of administration and warfare.

Temples maintained libraries. They were known as Saraswati Bhamdara. One library is mentioned in the Arulalaperumal temple at Kanchipuram. In 1579 the first Tamil Book was printed with the advent of the Europeans, This book was a summary of Christian doctrines.

## **14.4 Family**

The prosperity of a society rests with the proper running of the family. The family was the smallest unit, and many such units constituted into a society. In the Vijayanagar Empire that basic unit was well organized. The heads of the family unit was undoubtedly the father. Mother was respected as the second important person in the family. There were joint family units as well as individual households. In the joint family unit the property was held by all the eligible members of the family. The property ordinarily descended on the male members. Where male members are absent, the right of property passed on to the female.

### **14.4.1 Women**

The women normally stayed indoors and attended to their household duties. In some communities women went outside and earned their livelihood. Among the cultivators the women helped men in their agricultural pursuits. The women in some communities possessed enormous wealth of jewels. They also inherited property on certain occasions. Many women were reputed authors. The authoress of Raghunathabyudayan mentions that there were in the court of

Rahunatha of Thanjavur many accomplished women proficient in composing four kinds of poetry, some women were capable of explaining works written in various languages. They were able to sing very sweetly and play on the Veena and other musical instruments.

Temple dancers form a separate group. They were entrusted with the duty of performing dance in front of the deity on specified hours of a day. They are also singers who sang devotional songs in front of the deity on festival occasions. They lived near the temple quarters and received remuneration from the temple. Their services were hereditary. These dancers also danced in the car procession also. A performance of about 30 dancers in the car festival at Thiruvaiyaru was witnessed by a Jesuit missionary.

#### **14.4.2 Marriage**

An important institution in the social life was marriage. Marriages were generally arranged by elders. Love marriages were also known. Normally a marriage was arranged between parties who have attained majority. Child marriage was popular in certain communities. Polygamy was a popular system in this day. The king's nobles and the public married more than one wife. The system of giving dowry was prevalent in the period. Land and gold were granted as dowry. Bride money or giving *sradhana* to bride was also popular. However it was opposed by the people. The Brahmanas of various subsets in the *padaividu rajya* during the times of Devaraya-II they signed an agreement that they shall not perform marriage after receiving gold from the bride's party. The marriage shall be in the form of *kanyandan* and those who conclude the marriage after receiving gold shall be liable for punishment by the king and shall be excommunicated. The agreement was also binding on all the communities like *kannadgas*, Tamils and Telugus.

#### **14.4.3 Sati**

The customs of *sati* was practiced. The foreign travelers Barbosa, Caesar Frederic, Nuniz, Baradas, Pietra Della Valle and Linschoten give evidence for the prevalence of *sati* in South India. There seems to be some preference with regard to the following of *sati* among various communities. The customs also differ from place to place. The women seem to have either burnt along with her husband. The foreign travelers give graphic descriptions of the ceremonies

attached with sati. The performance of sati, could not be considered universal. It was probably popular among the nobility. Sati was not compelled but voluntarily performed. The performance of sati was commemorated by the erection of sati stones. One these stones were sculptured the representations of the widow who committed sati on the death of her husband. They are generally sculptured with a pointed pillar or pose from which projects a woman's right arm bent upwards at the elbow. The hand is raised with fingers stretched and a lime fruit is usually shown placed between the thumb and four fingers. Such sati stones are very few in Tamil country but in Karnataka they are numerous. One of the famous performers of sati was the queen of Vijayanagar chokkanatha. Another famous performance was by the wives of Tirumalai Nayak.

## 14.5 Housing

The people lived in different types of houses. The nobility lived in fully palaces. These palaces had many big rooms enclosed with spacious yards. The Nayak chiefs also lived in big palaces. These residences of Nayaks were ordinarily situated on plains. Palaces were also constructed at the hill tops and places of strategic importance. These palaces were surrounded by a big fort. Madurai and Thanjavur had Nayk Palaces. At Shehji the palace was situated on the top of hill. At vellore was a palace situated within a fort which served as the residence of Bommi Nayaks. These palaces are self contained big houses. They contained provisions for keeping a big army contingent.

The rich people also lived in big houses. These houses were built of burnt bricks and the walls coated with lime plaster and polished. Big pillars and massive walls are the characteristics of these buildings. Sometimes painting was executed. Wood, coconut, and Palmyra tree rafters were employed in the constructions. Doors and windows were out of wood. The middle class lived in small houses. Some of these houses had upper storey with balconies. The floor of these houses were normally made of the floor consisted of fine lime mortar laid over a rammed rubble mixer. The poorer sections lived in small doors. Up to a certain height mud walls were used in small thatched houses. They had small doors. Up to a certain height mud walls were raised and over which the roof was laid out. The floor was laid up with rammed earth.

Houses in the villages were arranged on the two sides of a long street. The villages ordinary consisted of more than one street. Each street was assigned to particular community. The communities who were in charge of the temple lived adjacent to the temple.

### **14.5.1 Food**

Rice was the staple food of the people. With rice the people took a good amount of cereals. Kambu was a common food among the common folk. Vegetables supplemented the food. Meat and fish were consumed by a section of people. The Brahmanas, Vaisyas and Jains took vegetarian food. Food was eaten in plantain leaves also. There seem to have regular feeding houses for travelers also. These choultries were established on highways by kings and philanthropists. Proper grants were given for the maintenance of these choultries. In many temples, Brahmanas were fed with different items of food.

Chewing of betel leaf was an important custom followed in this period. The king and nobles chewed a good amount of betel. The Vijayanagar and Nayak court accorded certain special privileges to the betel page. The poorer sections also followed this custom. Women also chewed betel leaves. Chewing betel leaf after the food was the common custom adopted among the different communities. Betel was also offered to god and in many temples provisions were made to the offer of betel to the deity after the sacred food offerings. Provisions were also made for the supply of betel to the persons who were fed in the temples and choultries.

### **14.5.2 Dress**

The people wore different types of dress. Cotton was the common material used by the masses for making their dress. The kings and nobility used silk for their dress. Satin was also in use. Wool and linen were also used for making costume. The dresses of the nobles were embroidered with many designs. The designers were executed with gold threads, the nobles and rich wore a cap of gold brocade covered a piece of fine silk stuff. A long silk cloth was used as a turban. People wore different types of turbans. The well to do people wore the lower garment with many folds, which are gathered in between their thighs. The common people went quite naked excepting a piece of cloth in their middle. The courtesans wore white garments of very thin cloth or silk or bright colours. One part of their dress was tucked on to the girdle and



the other end was thrown over the shoulders. The common folk used one of cloth worn around the girdle and used another piece of cloth to cover their upper parts of the body.

Rich people wore foot wear. There are a few types of chapels usually worn by wealthy persons. However the majority walked barefooted.

Women wore a head dress. Caps embroidered with flower designs were used by them. Women decked their head with flowers. On festival occasions men also wore flowers.

### **14.5.3 Ornaments**

Ornaments were worn by all sections of the society. Gold ornaments of various sizes and shapes were worn Necklaces, ear rings and armlets were commonly used. The gold ornaments were sometimes inlaid with precious stones and pearls. Strings of pearls formed a kind of necklace. Finger rings and girdles, bracelets, and head ornaments of different sizes were also worn by them. Diamonds, neck rings, double neck rings and nose ornaments are the other ornaments worn in this period.

The people use perfumes also. They smeared the paste made up of with musk, sandal wood, saffron and rose water. The women used to apply saffron musk to their body.

## **Games**

One of the largely participated games by all sections of the society was wrestling, these matches were periodically hold in the headquarters of the Nayaks, kings and nobles also witnessed the animal hunt as a pastime. Sometimes they enjoyed the fight between man and animal. Cock fights and bull fights were also witnessed by nobles and kings. Raghunathabyudayam mentions the existence of a Gymnasium to witness these matches. Hunting elephants or witnessing elephants hunts. Horse riding was another pastime. Among other pastimes chess may be mentioned.

### **14.5.4 Fine Arts**

Dance and Music provided great relief to the people. Dramas were also performed. These entertainments relieved the people from their stress. Puppet shows were also popular in this

period. Dance was greatly encouraged by the people. The Devaradiyals of temple dancers performed dances in public places also. They danced in front of the deity on festival occasions. Ragunatha Nayak, the Thanjavur Nayak king designed a new type of dance in this period. Kolattam another play performed dance in small circles striking the sticks in their hands of the beat of music. Music reached new heights in the Tamil country. The instruments Vina, Mattala, Kottu and Nadaswaram were used to produce melodious music.

#### **14.5.5 Festivals**

Maharasankaranithi, Sri Rama Navami, Ugadi, Deepavali, karthigai and Holi were some of the festivals they celebrated. These festivals in a way refreshed the minds of people. There were public and religious festivals. One of the important public festivals celebrated was Deepavali. The harvest in the villages could have celebrated by cultivators. There were many religious festivals. The Makara Sankaranthi and Ugadi were other important festivals. In temples also they celebrated festivals. For example the marriage of the deities called for a festival in some big temples. Other festivals are Festival of Floats, Hunting festivals, spring festival and Masi Makam festival. Apart from all these they have celebrated the king's birthday with the usual splendor in the temple.

### **14.6. Economic Condition -Agriculture**

Agriculture was the backbone of economy. The centre of agricultural economy was the village. There were three major groups of villages. They are Donative Villages, Royal villages and Villages of Cultivator.

A village donated to a temple, mutt or a Brahmana may be included in the first category. The devadana, Brahmadeya, Thiruvudaiyattam and Madapura are the village donated to temples and Brahmanas. In the second category the Pandaramadai and Amaram villages may be included. These villages were fully owned by the state. The Military chiefs granted to the officers of the army and Nayaks are also to be included in this category. The amaram villages also come under this group. The lands in the last category of villages were owned by individual cultivators separately.

### **14.6.1 Villages**

Villages were not planned properly and constructed. A village consisted of a living quarter, cultivable lands, streets and waste lands. Different sections of the village population lived in different quarters. The landlords lived in big houses and occupied the village's prestigious place. The agricultural labourers and merchants occupied other parts of the village generally located adjacent to the main settlement. Other members of the communities occupied different places within a village. The untouchables have a separate quarter. The houses were mostly built of mud walls supporting a thatched roof. The wealthy people lived in big houses built with burnt bricks. Roofs-tiles were also been used. The walls of big houses were plastered with lime mortar and sometimes decorated with paintings. The floor was made up of rammed earth plastered with cow dung. The wealthy people had used a fine variety of lime mortar for their floors. Wood was also used in the construction of houses. There was poor sanitary condition in those villages.

### **14.6.2 Land**

The village lands were divided into three categories. These 3 categories were divided on the basis of the crop cultivated in the field. The land cultivating paddy was identified as nancey (wetland) while the land produced non-paddy crops was categorized puncey (drt land). Land which produced crops like plantain, coconut, jack fruit, palms and flower-bearing plants was classified as thottailam (garden land). The lands were further sub-divided into different categories on the basis of their fertility. There were various types of waste lands. Wooden ploughs were used by the farmers to plough the lands.

### **14.6.3 Ownership**

The king was theoretically the lord of all land but he was not the actual proprietor of the soil. The king also recognized the right of the people for the proprietor of the soil. Apart from the royal villages the absolute enjoyment of land was vested with the owner of the land. The property of the father was usually inherited by the son. The ownership of the land contained the following eight-fold rights of possession. Nidhi, Nkisepe, Jala, Pasana, Aksini, Agami, Siddha and Sadhya. (deposits, buried treasure, water, stones, akshini future income, past income and probable income.)

Land granted to officers' form a separate group. The service tenures were given to officers to remunerate their services to the village communities or state or agencies like temple or mutt. They will hold right of enjoyment till they are in service. The right of enjoyment is normally hereditary since the service is inherited. Such service tenures were granted in the villages to goldsmiths, potters, barbers, physicians, village watchman and other village servants. A few pieces of lands were held by village assembly as common lands. The royal estates formed a separate group. The state had absolute right over these lands.

#### **14.6.4 Irrigation**

Irrigation system was very excellent in those days. Agriculture was given encouragement by the rulers. Rivers Wells and canals were utilized for irrigation. The kings dug new canals. In using the river water for cultivation the individual land owners paid a small amount as water cess. Where there were no rivers, lands were cultivated with tank water. In drawing water from tanks turn-system was adapted. This system envisaged a fair use of available water by all the cultivators. Lands were irrigated by private wells also.

##### **(a) Maintenance of sources of irrigation**

The people, public bodies and the state undertook the construction and maintenance of tanks and irrigation canals. The local temple at Tiruvamattur purchased a piece of lands in 1486 A.D, for digging a canal from the river leading to the irrigation tank of the village. The public bodies also made provisions for the maintenance of village tanks.

##### **(b) Maintenance by State**

The state helped in the repair and maintenance of tanks. In 1402 the silted up channel in the village valuvur led to the abandonment of lands by cultivators. The state soon repaired the tank. The state encouraged individual;ls by making certain grants to undertook the maintenance work of sources for irrigation. In another instance, the Dalavy set apart the income from the lease of fishery from the tank at Kodungalur for deepening it. The state also encouraged the people to maintain tanks by remitting certain taxes since the cultivators could not cultivate their lands owing to the silted condition of the tank.

Distribution of water to the lands from the village times settled amicably among villagers. In certain other tanks often created problems. One instance of dispute over the distribution of water from the local tank among the villages of Alattur and Attipattu is reported in 1406 A.D. Government solved the irrigational conflicts in a smooth manner.

#### **14.6.5. Methods of Agriculture**

Lands were ploughed with wooden ploughshares. To strengthen the wooden tip a piece of iron plate was attached at the point. The ploughshare was held by the cultivator. It was drawn by Buffaloes. The crops were cultivated in two seasons. They are Kar and Pasanam. A third crop (Kadaippu ) was cultivated in some fertile areas. Cultivation was also carried out in the parts of lands in the river and tank-beds on certain periods of the year. On the dry lands one crop was harvested for the year.

#### **Crops**

Rice was an important production. It was the main crop cultivated on a large scale. The inscriptions refer to the Kuruvai variety of rice. Among the cereals , Varagu and Tinai were cultivated in great quantities. Among pulses, the green gram, black gram, horse gram and beans were cultivated. Sugarcane and oil seeds were grown. Pepper was cultivated among the spices. Chinamon cloves and ginger were the other important items of spices produced in the Tamil country, Cardamom and mustard were also produced.

The Vijayanagar and Nayak age produced garden crops like Mango, jack-fruit, orange, lime, grape, plantain, tamarind and coconut. Apart from the above garden crops brinjal, garlic, onion, pumpkin and turmeric were produced in some places. Cotton and sugarcane cultivators were restricted to certain areas in the Tamil country.

The condition of farmers was not satisfactory. They lived on debts. The debtors were treated as slaves. Most of the agriculturists were very poor. They had to pay heavy taxes to the Government.

#### **14.7 Industries**

During the rule of Vijayanagar and nayak many industries were started. Small scale industries were well developed but it was restricted to a limited area due to raw materials

availability. However there were few industries existed like oil pressing, sugar industry and textile industry.

### **14.7.1 Village Industries**

There were Augar factories in the country. Jaggery, palm-jaggery, sugar were produced in those factories. Coconut trees were cultivated largely during this period. The byproducts like rope, mat and toddy were obtained from these trees. These products received a good market in both rural and urban areas though these products were manufactured in the country side. Oil Pressing was another important industry. The oil pressers are famous in South Arcot, Chengalpattu and Trichy. More oil seeds were cultivated in these areas hence it was easy for them to sell their products in these places. The sekku vaniyar (oil monger) paid comparatively a high percentage of tax to the state than other communities.

Pottery was another important rural industry. It was mostly a local industry catering to the needs of the locality. People used fine variety of pottery in their houses. The temple also utilized the services of potter. Fishing industry was also in existence near the village tank and other water reservoirs. They sold fish in the nearby markets. Fishing boats and nets were employed.

### **14.7.2 Textile**

Generally Textile Industry plays an important role in the country. In Coimbatore and Ramanathapuram cotton was produced. Cotton was manufactured in kan-pa-mei and it was a famous place in Coimbatore. Apart from Coimbatore, Madurai also manufactured cotton in some areas. Raw silk was manufactured in the western parts of the Tamil country. However they used to import raw silk from Karnataka.

First raw silk was processed, dyed and woven into fine pieces of 4 to 5 feet in width and 12 to 13 feet in length. Kaikkolars, Saliyars and occasionally the Paruaiah were engaged in this industry. The Padmasalis and Saurashtrians later occupied parts of the Tamil country under the royal patronage and monopolized silk weaving.

The state encouraged the weaveres on many occasions. Sometimes the state used to reduce or exempt their taxes when they were burdened with tax. Due to the Government

support at the correct time the industry is able to survive. During the Nayak rule Saurashtrians were given concessions and they were able to settle in many parts of the country. Finally Madurai became one of the chief centre of their activity.

## **Dyeing**

Dyeing was another important industry. In Kanchipuram and in Madurai Dyeing of yarn by weavers were performed. Indigo was abundantly available and hence they used for dyeing textiles. Myrabolan was also used as a dye stuff in Tamil country.

### **14.7.3 Mining and Metallurgy**

Mining was another important industry which fetched good revenue to the state. Main centers of mineral collection were North Arcot and Coimbatore districts. From different parts of the Tamil country semi- precious stones were collected. Diamonds were obtained from the mines of Kurnool (Vajrakarur ). Skill workers were done the cutting and polishing of precious stones.

The main revenue to the Government came from the Gold and Silver mining industry. In Tamil Nadu from Dharamapuri and North Arcot districts they have collected Gold from gold mines. Iron and copper mines were also located in parts of Tamil country. Iron and copper mines were also located in parts of tamil country. The manufacture of metals i were entrusted to small units. In remote areas these units functioned.

### **14.7.4 Jewelry and Weapons**

Manufacturing jewelry was a subsidiary industry of gold mining. For minting coins gold was used. Various types of gold ornaments were manufactured by craftsman. Temples were also supplied with Gold jewelry. With the iron , weapons of war were manufactured. Household articles were also manufactured and were in use. Every village possessed a goldsmith, a blacksmith and coppersmith.

### **14.7.5 Carpentry and Fishing**

Carpentry was another profession of utility value, found an important place in the country. Besides manufacturing chariots, palanquins, carriages by guilds of carpenters many household

objects were manufactured. The skilled workers constructed ships and boats. In the construction of houses also the services of a carpenter were utilized. The cart, wheel and a few related object were manufactured by some specialized craftsman. From foreign traveler's accounts we come to know that they manufactured leather goods like shoes.

### **Pearl fishing**

Pearl fishing was another important industry which yielded good revenue to the state. Fishing was the monopoly of the state. Through pearl fishing the state received huge money. The fishermen with special training were employed as dives and pearl catches were sold to highest bidders. Kayal was the centre of pearl-fishing in Tamil Nadu. Portuguese showed keen interest in purchasing the pearls Manufacture of salt was under the control of the state.

### **Labour**

The chettis, Senaikkadaiyar, Kaikkolar and Vaniyar were considered industrial group. They were given a common name Pattadai. The industrial class seems to have occupied a position of greatness among other classes. This impact produced some changes in the economic condition of the country.

The craftsmen produced articles in their place and brought them to the market centers for sale. The output of articles was limited since each craftsman was entrusted with the work of completing one product from raw materials. The women folk helped in the manufacture of certain articles. The state patronage played a vital role for their development.

## **14.8 Trade and commerce-inland trade**

Trade and commerce both inland and foreign were carried by Chettis or Komatis, Brisk trade was going on between Tamilaham and neighbouring countries. The articles of Trade were many Rice, Millets, Wheat, Vegetables, Salt and spices were brought to market centres or weekly markets (sandai) and were sold. The coconut, oil jiggery, betel, areca nut and fruit were also brought to the marketing centres. Cows, oxen and horses were sold in fairs. Fairs were organized weekly in those days. For example the Friday shandy (Fair) of Senji was a popular one. Raw cotton, cotton thread and raw silk were included in the trade articles.



### 14.8.1 Exports and Imports

The Tamil country traded with foreign countries. Rice, Kandala's sugar etc., were exported to Aden, Ormuz and Ceylon. It exported a good deal of articles it seems rice was the most important food item exported to foreign countries. Another important item exported from Tamil country was powered sugar (yellow sugar). Wheat and millets were also exported. Coconut was another chief item of export. The Indian pepper was in great demand in the foreign market. The Black pepper was exported in large quantities. Green and dried varieties of ginger were exported to foreign countries. Besides these food articles, dye stuffs were also in great demand. The indigo, myrabolan, two important dye stuffs were imported in large quantities. Cinnabar and henna were also exported. Among the metals exported into western countries iron had a lion's share. Some of the precious stones were exported. They include some varieties of diamonds, rubies, sapphires, amethysts and topazes. Most of these precious goods were shipped to Arabia. The cotton and silk clothes were other items of goods that had a great demand in the western markets. Many varieties of cotton cloth were shipped to foreign markets. The calico and painted cloths were also exported from the country.

### Imports

The Vijayanagar Kingdom imported many articles. Gold, silver, Tin, Lead, Copper and Opium were imported from Aden and China. Some precious stones were imported from Ceylon. Akil, camphor, Spices etc., were imported from Sumatra, Java and Malaccas islands. The imports, included pearls from Ceylon and Ormuz,. Ceylon supplied rubies, sapphires, garnets and cat's eyes. Among other imports may be included spices like Cloves, Cardamom and cinnamon, which came from Sumatra, Malaccas Islands and Ceylon. One of the pried articles of trade was Camphor was imported sandalwood were also imported from Java. From China opium was imported, saffron, rose water and musk was also imported. Elephants and horses were also imported from Ceylon and Arabia respectively.

### 14.8.2 Transport

Trunk Roads were constructed for the purpose of trade and commerce. For inland trade, highways were used. River and channels were used for the movement of goods. Bullock-carts

were utilized for transporting goods from one place to another. The cart was the dependent system of road transport. For transporting big bundles to a long distance cart was employed. Pack horses were also employed for transporting goods on a limited scale. Sometimes articles were carried on head-loaded. Gunny bags and baskets were used in the transporting of goods. For crossing rivers and carrying heavier objects over waterways ferry boats were employed.

Boats, Catamarans, ships and small boats were utilized for transporting goods through water. Small boats and rafts were sometimes used. Parisal was kind of basket boat used in the Tamil country. The Parisal was built of wicker rafts. Catamarans were also employed for transporting at times. For going into seas ship were employed.

### **14.8.3 Ports**

The overseas trade was controlled by a good amount of ports situated on the east coast of the Tamil Country. Nagapattinam was an important port. The other ports on the Tamil coast were Tirumalairayanpattinam, Tharangambadi (Tranqubar), Parangipettai (Porto Novo), Thevanampattinam, Sadurangapattinam (Sadras) pazhaverkkadu (pulicat) and Mylapore. Many ships sailed from Malabar anchored at this ancient port to take rice. At Devanampattinam all kinds of cotton cloth, printed and woven, were ex[ported Some of the articles imported into this port included pepper, nutmeg, cloves, sandalwood, alum and raw silk, kunimedu was another important port city. Chaturangapattinam and Mylapore ports were also important. Palaverkadu (Pulicat) was another port city situated on northern end of the Tamil country. Ships anchored at these ports sailed to Pegu, Malccca and Sumatra. Cloth was an important item exported in this port.

### **Trade routes**

Owing to a brisk inland trade, it can be expected that there were a good number of well guarded trade routes in the country. These trade routes were maintained by to have connected. Vijayanagara amd Mylapore, running the state between merchantile centres. A road appears through Chandragiri, Tirupati and Pulicat. Another road connected Kalahasti, Tirupati and Kanchi and Tiruttani was considered as resting place. Another road connected Tiruvannamalai, Chidambaram, Madurai, Rameswaram and Dhanuskodi, Another trade route connected Vijayanagara with Pulicat the port city.

#### **14.8.4 Guilds- Craft guilds**

Guilds were organised locally but functioned as extra territorial organisation. There were two types of guilds (a) the craft guilds and (b) merchant guilds. The craft guild was a territorial association organised to supervise the production of goods. They followed hereditary occupations. Barbosa also remarks about the hereditary nature of their progressive inscriptions speaks about different functions of 18 craft guilds in which were included the smiths, potters, oil pressers, weavers, washer men and barbers. The most important and the best organised seems to be the guild of the panchalas or smiths (five chases). They formed themselves into a corporate body. They claimed their descent from visvakarma, the son of Brahma, as their progenitor. The members of the guild lived in specified localities in the urban areas. The guilds acquired some privileges from the king from time to time. The kammalar of kanchipuram received some social recognition from the king. The weavers of Kanchipuram and Virinchipuram enjoyed certain rights. The agricultural community formed themselves into a corporate body called Chitrameli-Periyannadu. It seems that this body had control over the production and distribution of the produce from the land.

##### **(a) Merchants guilds**

Merchant's guilds formed a separate group, which is primarily a corporation of merchants. The merchant guilds were many. Some of the guilds were named banajigas, nanadesis, Vaniyanagarathar, Vaisyas, Mummuridandas, Chettis, Ayyavole and Manigramam. There were Brahmana and muslim merchants also. The horse traders (kudirai chettis) constituted themselves into a guild. They are said to have come from the north of the Tamil country. Another important guild was that of the saliva weavers. Manigramam, an old corporate body also existed in this period. This body consisted of merchants of this guild had certain privileges.

#### **14.9 Trade Communities - Chettis**

Trade was carried out by various communities. The chettis were enterprising businessmen. They traded with foreigners also. They sold pepper for precious stones and costly wares. One cinnama chetti was an influential merchant who helped the Dutch to carry over trade with Indian traders and weavers. One of his dependants was Sesadri Chetti at Porto Novo who rose

to the position of a chief Indian merchant at Madraspatnam. The Chettis settled in the eastern countries also

The Malabars were another enterprising community that carried on a part of the trade in the country. They traded mostly in spices, coconut, palm sugar, in return for coarse rice and iron.

### **(a) Muslims**

The Muslims dominated the trade between the fourteenth and seventeenth centuries. Then was a substantial Muslim population even as early as the 13<sup>th</sup> century. They brought goods from China, Malacca and Bengal. The coastal trade was largely controlled by them. However on the west coast, the Muslims were humbled by the Portuguese.

### **(b) Portuguese**

The 16<sup>th</sup> Century witnessed the arrival of the Portuguese in the Tamil country. The first settled on the west coast and from there, they traded with the Tamil merchants frequently they established their settlements in the Tamil Country. One such settler they located at Santhome, Mylapore. It continued to be a flourishing trade centre.. For the cloth manufactured in the Tamil Country and Coromandal coast there was a great demand in Portugal after the debacle at Talikota of the Vijayanagar Kingdom, the Portuguese trade received a setback in the whole of south India However, in the beginning of the 17<sup>th</sup> century they established several settlements in the Tamil country. A settlement at Nagapattinam was a flourishing trade centre they lost some of the centres like Vellore and Chandragiri to the other western merchants.

### **(c) The Dutch**

In the sixteenth century, the Dutch, the Danes and the English made their appearance on the east coast. The Dutch in 1608 established a factory at Devanampattinam near, Cuddalore with the permission of the Nayak of Gingee. The rivalry of the dutch worked havoc to the Portuguese ships in the sea. The Portuguese obstructed the Dutch in getting a hold in South India. The Portuguese, through the Vijayanagara king stopped the establishment of a factory at Devanampattinam. Later the Dutch were expelled completely. The Dutch established a fort

at Pulicat but was razed to the ground by the Portuguese. Later the Dutch, with the English jointly established a factory there, which however, failed to function due to mutual mistrust.

#### **(d) The Danes**

The Nayaks of Thanjavur encouraged the establishment of factories by the Danes at Tranquebar. A small fort was built and soon their trade prospered. They established some factories in the inland centers also.

#### **(e) The English**

In the beginning of the 17<sup>th</sup> Century, the English tried to settle in Pulicat with the help of the Dutch. However, this attempt was failed by the mutual mistrust. In 1622 on the invitation of the Nayaks of Thanjavur, the British sought permission from him. However the Danes manipulated the events and the king refused permission. The British returned to their factory at Masulipattinam. In 1637 another attempt was made by the British. This time Francis Day was able to secure a factory site at Madarasapatnam near Santhome (Mylapore) from the local Nayak, Venkatadri Nayak. A Fort was built at this place and gradually the settlement became a strong one. They manufactured long cloth, painted cloth and many kinds of stuff. Later the Vijayanagar ruler also confirmed the Nayak's permission. The English received some privileges from the king and their trade prospered.

### **14.10 State Economy – Sources of Income and Expenditure**

Since No Government can be run without finance and since Government finance is got mostly through taxation Tamil Governments from very early times levied many kinds of Taxes. The Vijayanagar rule in Tamil nadu was not an exception to this. Many kinds of Taxes were imposed and collected during this period.

The most important item of state source was land tax. Tax was levied on all types of cultivated land. Tax was assessed on the basis of a systematic survey. Wet and dry lands were assessed. On the dry lands the assessment was received much less than the wet land assessment. The land tax included some cases are assessment valakkai and nikuli (water case). On wetland the tax was collected in Paddy and on dry land it was, collected in panam.

On garden crops like banana and coconut the tax was collected in the respected crops. On some categories of land, tax was exempted. When the crops failed, tax exemption was granted. There were state-owned villages in the kingdom. They were Bhandharavadai villages. The lands in these villages were leased out to the highest bidder in this way the state received a lump sum from the leaseholder.

Income was derived from other resources. The weavers, the fishermen, shipperents and oil mongers paid tax to the state. The Barbers, potters and washer men also paid their share of tax to the state. From the merchants the State collected tax. The tolls and customs collected at various points on the highway amounted to a good part of the state income at the port the goods were paid a duty. Excise duty was levied on the manufacture of salt and on drawing toddy. The shops in the market centers also paid a duty. The income from the fairs contributed a good share in the state income. Taxes were also levied on various articles of trade.

Military contributions supplemented the revenue of the state. The Nayaks and the Military chiefs paid a lump sum every year. Contributions from the conquered territories also increased the income of the state. Customary payments were also demanded from the subjects. Benevolences formed another important feature of the state income. The judicial fines were also considered as a form of the Royal income. Confiscated property also contributed to the state's revenue.

## **Expenditure**

The state spent large sums of money on various development activities. The state took active part in the construction of temples. Large sums of money were spent on the construction and repairs of temples. Endowments were instituted by kings and queens in several temples and portion of the state revenue were set apart for this purpose. A good portion of the state income was spent on military organisation numerous military expeditions undertaken both by the Vijayanagara and Nayak rulers sliced a part of the state income. A percentage of the state's resources were spent on excavations of irrigation tanks and canals. Another portion of the income was spent on maintenance of roads and construction of rest houses. Though the officers were remunerated with a grant of land, one portion was set apart to the salaries and expenses of the royal officers. Another good portion was spent on the royal household.

### **(a) Currency**

In the early years of the Vijayanagara rule the use of a standard currency was limited to certain transactions. A good part of the commercial transaction was carried by barter system in some areas of then Tamil country. The use of the currency was increased gradually in both the state and commercial transactions. A well regulated currency system of the Vijayanagara Empire was adopted in Tamil country and the Nayaks followed it. A uniform weight standard was also followed. The currency system was based on a unit of gold weighing about 50 or 52 grains. In the Vijayanagara Empire this gold coin was called by various names as follows: Pon, Varaha, Pagoda and Gadyana. In the Tamil country all the above names were used but the Tamil from Pon was popular. In the Nayak period Varaha and Pagoda became popular terms. The Pagoda appears to be a half of a varaha. The Katti was one-fourth of a Varaha Panam, another popular currency was one-tenth of a Pon. The tar was the only silver coin. Kasu was the copper coin popular in the Tamil country. Irefai, guligai, cakkaram and madai were the other names applied to coin in the Tamil country.

### **The coins**

The medium of exchange in all commercial transactions was gold. Gold coins called "Ramadunga" are available in plenty. The people used "pagoda" as medium of exchange (one Pagoda is equal to three rupees). Panam and Kasu were in use during this period. Frier has mentioned that one pagoda is equal to eight Shilling.

Figures were inscribed on both sides of the coin. Figures like Uma Maheswari, Hanuman, Lakshmi and Narayanan were inscribed on one side of the coins. Figures of Ox, pig and elephant were inscribed on the other side of the coins. In the Ramadanga kasu figures of rama and Sita were inscribed on one side and the figures of Hanuman on the other side. Generally the coins were round (circular) in shape. The name of the king who issued the coin was also inscribed on the face of the coin. The coin system of the Nayaks was similar to that of the Vijayanagara kings.

### **(b) Mints**

There was a central mint at the capital for minting coins. The provincial governors were permitted to issue their own coins. The Tamil provinces also issued coins from their own mints.

During the Nayak rule mints were established at gingee, Thanjavur, Tiruchirapalli and Vellore. There were some smaller mints also in the country in these mints moulded metal was poured into the terracotta moulds and coins were extracted by the process of cooling.

### **(c) Weights and Measures**

For conducting trade various units of measures are needed in the Vijayanagara days, various units were popular. The regional units of measurements then in current were also adopted. However a few broad units were common to the whole country.

The popular unit of weight was a maund. Twenty maunds consisted of baram, which was the heaviest. The maund was sub-divided into lesser units of visa, paam, seer and talas. The capacity measures adopted in the country were units. pilavu, kanam, ulakku etc. the popular unit of capacity measures was kalam, One-twelfth of a kalam, was a marakkal another popular capacity measure.

The land was measured by ancient units of measure like veli, ma and kuli, veli, was the popular unit of measurement. Twenty ma consisted of a veli and a ma consisted of 100 kulis. The Kuli-ma ratio varied from area to area was no uniformity among the land measures of the Tamil country. Land was measured by different lengths of measuring rods. The most important measuring rod which was used in the Tamil country was Rajavibhadan kol equivalent to about 9.5feet. There are other measuring rods, whose lengths are equal to 19 and 21.5 feet.

### **(d) Famines and flood relief**

The economy of the state was distributed on many occasions by famines. The state undertook famine relief measures. Failure of monsoon was one of the most important reasons for the famine. Unprecedented floods resulted in the spreading of epidemics and loss of precious property and grains. One famine is referred to in 1381.A.D. in an inscription at kuttalam. At another time in 1402 the thanjavur area experienced a famine. In 1412 another famine occurred. The state took various other measures and helped the affected by providing shelter and food.



## 14.11 Summary

There were different communities lived in this period. For the first Christians and Muslims were able to convert the Hindus to their faith. Printing press entered into the country mainly to print their religious works.

Their rule witnessed the rapid urbanizations in the country. Commercial activity increased and merchants from distant places thronged the cities of Tamil country. It is in this period Europeans took a keen interest in the South Indian trade. All these factors induced a remarkable change in the economy of the Tamil country in this period. This period paved the way for the East India Company to govern our country later.

## 14.12 Review Questions

1. Write about the Telugu and Saurashtra Communities under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
2. Analyse the Right hand and left hand groups during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
3. Explain about the education system under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
4. Analyze the status of women during the Vijayanagar and Nayak period.
5. Describe the fine arts and festivals of the Vijayanagar and Nayak period.
6. Explain about the irrigation system under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
7. Discuss the village industries under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
8. Write a note on the inland trade under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
9. Write about the transport system during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
10. Describe the trade communities under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

## 14.13 Answers to Review Questions

1. See the subsections 14.2(8) and (9)
2. See the subsection 14.2.1

- |     |                      |                       |
|-----|----------------------|-----------------------|
| 3.  | See the section      | 14.3                  |
| 4.  | See the subsection   | 14.4.1                |
| 5.  | See the subsections  | 14.5.4 & 14.5.5       |
| 6.  | See the subsection   | 14.6.4                |
| 7.  | See the subsection   | 14.7.1                |
| 8.  | See the section      | 14-8                  |
| 9.  | See the subsection   | 14.8.2                |
| 10. | See the sub sections | 14.9 & 14.9(a) to (e) |

## **LESSON – 15**

# **VIJAYANAGARA AND NAYAK RULERS- RELIGION AND LITERATURE**

### **15.1 Learning Objectives**

After having gone through this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the growth of savism and vaishnavism and development of temple architecture with a new dimension during the period of vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
- ❖ Growth of Tamil and Sanskrit literatures during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

### **Structure**

#### **15.1 Introduction**

#### **15.2 Hinduism – Saivism**

##### **15.2.1 Vaishnavism**

##### **14.2.2 King's Patronage to Religion**

##### **15.2.3 Mutts**

##### **15.2.4 Philosophy**

##### **15.2.5 Jainism**

##### **15.2.6 Buddhism**

##### **15.2.7 Islam**

##### **15.2.8 Christianity**

#### **15.3 Literature**

##### **15.3.1 Tamil**

#### **15.4 Contribution of Foreigners**

#### **15.5 Sanskrit**

#### **15.6 Summary**

#### **15.7 Answers to Review Questions**

## 15.1 Introduction

The Vijaya nagar rulers encouraged all religious faiths. Hinduism was their favourable religion Hindu temples were repaired and rebuilt in their period; some of the temples were enlarged with additional gopurams and praharas. New temples were built Vellore, Kanchipuram and Kumbakonam. They have also patronized Tamil scholars.

## 15.2 Hinduism – Saivism

The saivites constituted a large majority among the Hindu religious group in the Vijayanagar Empire. Siva's various forms were also worshipped. Gangadhara, Dhakshinamurthi and Umamahesvara forms of Siva were popular. Siva's consort parvati was also worshipped in her benign form. Ferocious forms like Kali, Durga and Mahisasuramardhini were also popular. Separate shrine was constructed for the consort of Siva near the central shrine in the temple complex.

The Saivites were classified into three small groups, namely Advaitins, Pasupathas and Vira Saivism. The Vijayanagar rulers, from the sangama brothers up to the commencement of Virupaksha's rule followed Pasupatha Saivism and patronized Advaitism.

The Advaitins were the followers of the philosophy of Sri Sankara who advocated the theory of non-dualism. Sri Sankara established two monasteries, one at Sringeri and the other at Kanchipuram. In 1546, the Sangama brothers of Vijayanagar made grants to monasteries.

The Pasupathas paid great attention to the Saiva Agamas and the famous saint of the sect of Saivism was Kaivilas Kriyasakthi. Harihara I and Bukka I were the disciples of Kriya sakti. Under this sect, Lord Virupaksha was the royal family deity.

The Vira Saivas constituted the influential religious sect in Vijayanagar Empire. It was made popular by Basava, a minister. The Virasaivas were the staunch saivas and they carried Lingam always with them. They rejected the authority of the Vedas: disbelieved in the doctrine of rebirth, objected to child marriage, approved the marriage of widows and cherished an intense aversion to Brahmins.

Temples for Siva were built many parts of the Tamil Country. In some big temple centres the existing temples complexes were enlarged by the addition of mandapas and prakars. Big and tall gopuras were built in a few other temple complexes. Tiruvannamalai, Madurai, Kanchipuram, Thanjavur, Tiruchirapalli, Srivilliputtur became big religious centres.

### **15.2.1 Vaishnavism**

The Vijayanagar days were very favourable for the spread of Vaishnavism in South India. The Vijayanagara king's patronised Vaishnavism. Vaishnavism had a large following in the Tamil country. Vishnu was worshipped in his various forms. The avatars of Vishnu were worshipped. Sridevi and Bhudevi were also worshipped. Separate shrines were now established for the concords of Vishnu within the temple complex. The Alvars and Archariyars were now elevated to godhood and were worshipped.

Since the days of Ramanuja the great Vaishnava philosopher, the Vaishnava creed was gaining a large number of followers. After the death of Ramanuja the followers of Vishnu were divided into two sections. Namely Vadakalai and Tenkalai. The origins of these sections may be traced to the 14<sup>th</sup> century. They were divided on various aspects from their caste marks to the doctrines.

Vadakalais preferred Vedas as their basic scriptures while the followers of tenkalai adopted Tamil scriptures as basic to their religion. The Vadakalai wore a cast mark (nanam) resembling 'U' on their forehead, different from the Tankalais who were with a stem attached at the bottom of 'U' the caste mark.

The Vadakalais thought that salvation could be achieved by one's own self effort even without surrender. They held that Lakshmi is one with the Lord Vishnu. The Vadakalai followed strict caste system.

The tenkalais on the other hand believed in Saranagadhi (self surrender to God) and awarded a lower position to Lakshmi than Vishnu. They were liberal enough to admit other members of lower caste into Vaishnavism.

### 15.2.2 Kings' Patronage to Religion

The early Vijayanagar kings were Saivites. The later kings changed their faith to Vaishnavism. So both Saivism and Vaishnavism flourished during this period. The Saluvas were Vaishnavas, devoted to Narashima of Ahobalm and Venkatesa of Tirupathi. They patronised saivism also.

Under Krishnadevaraya, and Sadasivaraya, Vaishnavism gained a large number of followers. Krishnadevaraya built a temple for Lord Krishna which he carried to his capital with great renovation from the fort of Udayagiri. He encouraged the vaishnava literary scholars namely Venkata Tatarya and Vysa Tirtha. Coins issued by them proclaim their conviction towards Vaishnavism.

Krishnadevaraya remitted 10,000 varahans in favour of Saiva and Vaishnava temples in the Chola mandalam. The Northern gopura of Chidambaram temple was built by him. He made substantial additions to Siva temple at Tiruvannamalai. He also made substantial improvements to the Varadarajaperumal temple at Kanchipuram.

The Nayaks had their individual preferences, some were followers of Siva and others patronised vaishnavism. However the king practised religious toleration.

Achyutaraya granted a village to the temple of Varadaraja, and Ekambaramatha at Kanchipuram. He built the image of Lord Thillai Govindaraja in the temple of Nataraja at Chidambaram. Achyutaraya also made a grant of 82 villages to the temple of Nataraja at Chidambaram.

The Nayaks built many new temples and provided additions to old temples. The Madurai temple (Meenakshisundareswarrar) temple complex was enlarged by the construction of mandapas. The pudumandapam was constructed by the Nayaks of Madurai. The Subramanya shrine in this temple of Brihadisvara at Thanjavur was built by a Nayak King. The Nartanmandapa of the Perur temple was constructed by a Nayaka. A few Mandapas were built by the Nayaks in the Ranganatha temple at Srirangam and Jambukesvara temple at Thiruvanaikkaval.

Vaishnavism received still greater support at the hands of the rulers of the Aravidu dynasty.

At every stage the saivas opposed the spread of Vaishnavism.

### 15.2.3 Mutts

During the Vijayanagara period the Mutts assumed greater importance. Their main aim was to propagate religion and philosophy. There were many Mutts in the Tamil country. One of the famous Mutt existed in Kanchipuram was the kamakottipeda. It is believed that the Mutt was founded by Adi Sankaracharya in honour of Goddess Kamakshi. The Mutt was patronised by Krishnadevaraya who made a gift of two villages to the Mutt.

A branch of kamakotipitha was established at Tiruvanaikovil. The Nayaks of Madhura made a gift of land for feeding Brahmanas in the Mutt. Another Mutt which had substantial following was the Golaki Mutt'. This mutt had centres in Andhrapradesh, Karnataka and Tamil country. In the Tamil Country the centres were located in Devikapuram. Tirupparankunram, Tiruppattur and Piranmalai..

The Dharmapuram Mutt appears to have been founded in the 16<sup>th</sup> century by Kumara Gurupara. The Tiruvavaduthrai Mutt was established by Namasivaya Desikar in the sixteenth century. Another Mutt that deserves mention is the Tiruppanandal Mutt. Among the other Mutts located in Tamil country mention may be made to the Triuvenkatanatha Mutt (Puliyankulam), Jnanaprakasawamigal Mutt (Kanchipuram), Angaravan Mutt (Tiruvorriyur) and Periyadeva Nayinar Mutt (Chidanbaram).

The Mutt was administered by a head (pontiff) of Mutt. The head of a Mutt was also the administrator of temples attached to the Mutt. Many of the heads of Mutt were great scholars. Sadasiva Brahmendra and Chansrasekara Saraswati are two pontiffs who have established their philosophical lore in the Tamil country during the 16<sup>th</sup> century. Isana sivacharya, KumaraGuruparar, Ambalavanaswami and Namasivaya Desikar were the other heads who have extensive knowledge in the Saiva Siddhanta Philosophy.

### 15.2.4 Philosophy

The Saiva Siddhanta Philosophy received great impetus during the Vijayanagara period. The earlier doctrines of Adi Sankara were also being followed. Generally the followers of the advaita philosophy of Adi Sankara were known as Smartas. Meykandadeva, another philosopher made Saivism a popular religion among the masses. The Saiva Siddhanta philosophy is largely

based on the Agamas. It seeks to determine the relation between God, Matter and Soul. The philosophy advocated Bhakti in preference to rituals and ceremonies. The other great exponents of Saiva Philosophy were Arulnadi Sivacharya and Umapati Sivacharya.

The 16<sup>th</sup> and 17<sup>th</sup> century Tamil country saw the rise of mystics (Siddhars) who propagated Saivism in their own way. These Siddhars were a kind of distinguished philosophers who raised above all religious and communal barriers. There were eighteen Siddhars in the 'Tamil country'. Among them about a half could belong to the Vijayanagar period. Mention may be to the Siddhars, Sivavakkiyar, Sivaprakasar and Tathuvarayar. The Siddhar Sivavakkiyar ridiculed the worship of idols without sincere devotion. He emphatically expressed that there is no use decking idols with flowers and performing ceremonies. Another Siddhar Sivaprakasa, had disputations with Christians. Thathyvarayar was another Siddhar who was against the idol worship.

On the Vaishnava side, the Ramanuja's Visistadvaita philosophy was favoured. There is a slight variation in the Vaishnava philosophy since there appeared Vadagalai and tengalai groups. However to attain salvation bhakthi and surrender (saranagati) were considered important. Vedanta Desika, (14<sup>th</sup> century) followed some of the doctrines of Ramanuja. However he emphasised varnashrama dharma system. The followers were the vadakalai sect. Pillai Lodacharya and Manavala Mamuni headed the tenkalai sect who opposed the conservative ideas and fought for equality among the followers of Vishnu.

The philosophy of Vittoba, Vallabhacharya and Madhava were followed in philosophies during the Vijayanagar period. During the Nayaks rule these philosophies could have gained some more support among the masses.

### **15.2.5 Jainism**

Jainism also received patronage in the Vijayanagar period. The Jains were minority in Number. The kings patronized Jain Pallis. There was a Jain Palli at Thirunanurgondai in those days. A large number of Jains lived at Tirupparuttikkunaram, Salukkai and Vijayamangalam. The Minister of Harivhara-II built a mandapa in the Jain Palli. Krishnadevaraya gave liberal donations to the Jain Palli at Tirupparuttikkunaram. Even the Jain Pallis at Kavanthai and Nagarkovil also received gifts from Krishnadevaraya.



### **15.2.6 Buddhism**

During the Vijayanagar period, Kanchi and Nagapattinam were the centres of Buddhism. Buddhism flourished in Tiruvalarkoil, Kumbakonam and Tiruvalanjuli. In those places Buddhist Viharas were established to spread Buddhism. Buddhism followers were limited during this period.

### **15.2.7 Islam**

Islam reached India before the establishment of the Vijayanagar Empire. The Muslims traded with the Tamil country in a small group. After the invasion of the Malik Kafur the Muslims established a Sultanate in Tamil country. Conversions were made in large numbers. In the initial stages the Muslims destroyed temples and plundered the wealth. They spread havoc in many villages. But Devaraya II entertained Muslims in his court, allotted them lands and erected a mosque. He placed a copy of Koran before his throne to command the loyalty of the Muslims. Krishnadevaraya and Ramaraya also followed the same policy. On the eastern coast many settlements were established to house the followers of Islam. The Nayak queen Mangammal made a gift of villages to the Durga. The Durga at Nagur gained importance from the Vijayanagar period. Conversions to Islam were forced. Some of the Hindu temples were also modified as Durgas. However, these conversions were more during the 18<sup>th</sup> century in the Tamil country.

### **15.2.8 Christianity**

Christianity began to spread in South India with the coming of the Portuguese. In 1533 the Paravas of the coastal region in the land were the first to convert to Christianity. The paravas had monopoly over the fisheries. According to father Heras, at least 20,000 were converted to Christianity. In the Nayak court of Madurai Jesuit missionary, Robert-de-Nobili began a campaign of conversion of the Hindus of the Tamil country. He has learnt the vernacular languages to attract the masses. But he failed in his attempt. The Vijayanagar rulers followed the policy of tolerance towards Christianity. They permitted them to construct churches in many places like Chandragiri, Santhome etc., But Ramaraya did not approve his earlier ruler's permission. However with the rise of commercial establishments, the westerners were allowed to build churches. These churches were constructed within their commercial establishments.

### 15.3 Literature

The Vijayanagar kings appointed regional governors to rule over various territories of their territory in Tamil Nadu and was subsequently ruled by the Madurai Nayaks, Thanjavur Nayaks and Gingee Nayaks. Hence this period was referred as the “Vijayanagar and Nayak age” in Tamil literature. This period witnessed an enormous output of philosophical works, commentaries, epics and devotional verses.

The Vijayanagar and Nayak rule in the Tamil Country saw a great deal of literary activity. Tamil, Sanskrit and Telugu works contributed to the richness of the literary movement in this period. Many of the Vijayanagar and Nayak kings patronised scholars. They have also composed several works and contributed to the flowering of the literature in this period.

#### 15.3.1 Tamil

The Puranas, Ulas, Andhadi and Kovai literature flourished during this period. There were religious and secular works also. A good number of works were devoted to the philosophy of the age. Many commentaries were written in this period. A few translations into Tamil were made. One of the important contributions of this age was the prose writing initiated by the foreigners. Another important change in the style of writing was the adoption of Manipravala from prose by some authors in their works.

#### 1. General works

One of the scholarly contributions of the age was Bharatam by villuputturar. It renders the story of Mahabharata in Tamil in 4350 verses. Adiviarama Pandya's Naidadam was another great work of this age. It portrays the life of Nala, the ruler of Nishada country. The poems of Kalamegam fall into a separate group as 'Taniapdai'. They were composed in simple style. He is famous for his instant compositions (asu kavi) on any subject. Murkkudarp-pallu (17<sup>th</sup> century A.D) was one of the greatest pally works by an anonymous author from Thirunelveli region. The peasant life of that reign is vividly portrayed in this work. Another important work of this period was Kudralak Kuravanji by Tirikudarasappa Kavirayar. It was written in simple and appealing language. The work was in praise of Kudralanthar, the presiding deity at Kudralam. Supradipakkavirayar, composed Virali-vidu-thudhu and kulapanayakanthal. The first work was

written in the form of a message sent by the dancer musician Virali. The second work is a love story of a Nayaka and a courtesan. A historical ballad 'Ramappayan Ammanai' was composed in this age. It deals with the wars of a general of Tirumalai Nayak.

## 2. Puranas

The Jains also contributed to the enrichment of Tamil literature in this period. The work Merumandirapuram by Vamana Muni narrates the story relating to Meru and mahendra, two Gandharvas of the tirthankara of jaina kanchi. Mandalapurada's sripuranam was an adaptation of the Sanskrit Adipuram. Maraijnambandar's work. Ongugoyil puranam is in praise of the presiding deity of Ongukoyil in Tirupattur. He also wrote kamalalaya puranam and Arunagiri puranam. The Chidambaram puranam, a Tamil translation from the Sanskrit work, was by Tirumalainatha of Chidambaram. The Bhagavatta Puranam by Sevvaichchuduvār and Achandir puranam by virakavirayar may be mentioned. The last mentioned work was written in 12 sections. Tirumaluvadi puranam, kamalai Jnnanaprakasa Panditar, Linga puranam and kurmapuranam of Ativirarama Pandiya, may be mentioned as important contributions of the age. The Tiruvilaiyadal puranam by Paranjodi Munivar and Kanda puranam by kachiyapa sivachariyar are an excellent work. The Tiruvilaiyadal puranams have taken their themes from Saiva traditions. The 64 sports (Tiruvilaiyadal) of Siva at Madurai are narrated in these works. The Kandha puranam is a great work on the birth and achievements of kanda (Muruga) written 10,000 verses.

## 3. Sthala Puranas

In this period many sthala puranams were composed. They speak in elaborate details the traditional history of a temple and their neighbourhood. These temple histories were written in simple style devoid of any literary excellence. Among the many sthala puranams, the following may be mentioned: Tiruvorriyur puranams by Gnanaprakasar Thiruppattisvarapuram and Thiruvallanjulipuram by Revana, Siddhar, and Viruddhachala puranams by Gnanakkuttar.

## 4. Minor works

The Ula literature received a patronage in the hands of many poets. The irattaippulavar (Mudusuri and Ilamsuriyar) wrote an Ula, Ekambaranatha-ula in praise of the deity

Ekambaranatha at Kanchipuram. The great poet Kalamegam wrote the Tiruvanaikkaval ula in praise of the deity at Tiruvanaikkaval Madurai-chokkanathar ula was composed in praise of the presiding deity at Madurai by Tirumalainatha. Seria Kavirajapillai wrote a ula on Tirukkalainatha. His other ulas are cheyyur Muragan ula and Ratnagiri ula.

The Andadi was another form of literary composition popular in this period. Among the many andadhis mention may be made to Ramanujanurrandadi by Manavalamamuni and Tirukkaruvai padirrupattu and adadi by Varatungarama pandya. Among the other literary pieces composed in this period mention may be made to Mummanikkovai, Naaratnamalai (by Vedanta Desika), Sukulagamasarum (by Maraijina sambandari), Annamalaikkovai (by Jnanaprakasa Panditar), Kandarkavilivenba, Maduraik-Kalambakam, Muthukumarasamy pillaitamil and sakala-kala-vallimalai (all by Kumara Guruparar)

## 5. Devotional Literature

Works in praise of deities were also composed in this age. The most important contribution in this period is undoubtedly that of Arunagirinathar's Tirupugal. It consists of 1360 verses on Muruga. Jhanaprakasa Desikar's Kachikkalambakam praise the greatness of the deities in Kanchipuram. In praise of god at Alvar Tirunagiri two works were composed by perumal Kavirayar. They are Tirukkurukamanmiyan and Marankilavimuninalai. Kumara Guruparar's works Sakala-kalavalli-malai at was in praise of saraswathi Muthukumaraswamy pillaitamil by the same author was in praises of the deity Muthukumaraswamy at Vaidhisvaran Kovil.

## 6. Works on Philosophy

A good portion of the works produced in this age was devoted to religious philosophy. Swarupananda Desikar's Sivaprakasa Peruntirattu was a work of 2,824 verses in the Saiva Siddhanta. Another small Kuruntirattu was an anthology by Tattuvarayar. It deals with the Advaita philosophy. Another work on Saiva philosophy was Tattuvaprakasam by Tattuvarayar or Tiruvarur. The Advaita Siddhanta is explained elaborately in the Kaivlyanavanitam by Tandavarayaswamigal. It consists of two parts. The first part entitled Tattuvavilakkappadalam deals with the advait Siddhanta. The second part entitled Sandekam-telidapadalam is devoted to the explanation of certain philosophical ideas. Irusamaya Vilakkam by the Vaishnavite Harudasar was another good work which explains the merits and demerits of the two religions Saivism and Vaishnavism.

However the superiority of Vaishnavism is established. Maraijanasambandar of Chidambaram wrote pari- pasupasap-panuval, Sankarpa- nira- karanam paramopadesam Saiva Samayaneri. All these works explain the philosophy of Saivism..Siva Gnanandabodam was another good work on Saiva Philosophy written by Kamalai Jnanaprakasa panditar. Gurujnasambandar's Sivalogasagram was another work also explains Saiva philosophy. Pramodachandrodaya

## **7. Works on Grammar**

Works on poetics and grammar also contributed to the richness of the Tamil literature in this period, Paranjoti's Chidam-barappattiyal is a work on poetics. Another. work on poetic composed in this period was Navanitappattiyal Ilakkanavikkam was a work on Tamil Grammer by Vaidyanatha Desikar of Tiruvarur. Maranalankaram was a work on rhetoric composed by pillaipperumal Kavirayar Kumara-gurupara's Chidambaracheyyutkkovai was a work on Tamil prosody.

One of the greatest nigandus produced during the Vijayanagar rule was by Mandalapurudar. His early work on Tamil lexicography entitled Chodamani-nigandu explains the meanings of words in 10 sections. Sivapparakasar's Tarukkapari-bhasu was a work on tarka (debta).

## **8. Commentaries**

This period witnessed a large number of commentaries were written. Adiyarkunallar had written a commentary on Silappadikkaram. Senavaraiyar wrote a commentary for Tolkappiyam. Then arrived the legend Parimelalagar, whose commentary on Tirukural is still considered as the best one . Other celebrated commentators such as Perasiriyar and Naccinarikiniyar who had composed commentaries in the various works of sangam Tamil literature.

## **9. Translations**

Tamil translations to various Sanskrit works appear in this age. The Bhagavatham was translated into Tamil by Arulaldasar. It deals with the ten incarnations or Vishnu. Another Tamil version on Bhagavatam was made by Vadiraja Aiyangar. Another important work translated

into Tamil was Soundaryalahri by Kaviraja Panditar. Varatunga rama pandya translated kokkokam, a work on erotices.

## 15.4 Contribution of Foreigners

The Christian missionaries also enriched the Tamil literature by their contributions. Robert de Nobili wrote many works in Tamil. On them mention may be made to the following works: Nanaopadesam. Mandiramalai, Athumanimayam, Sattiya-veda-lakshnam, Kadavul-nirunayam, he prepared a Tamil-Portuguese dictionary. Another missionary who made significant contributions to the Tamil literature was Beshi (Viramamunivar). He wrote the famous epic Tembavani, which narrates the life story of Christ. His other works are Tirukkovalur-kalambakkaam and kitteri-anumanal. He wrote a few prose works namely, Vedyar Olukkam. Vedavilakkam and Parmarrttaguru-kadai may be mentioned. He started the art of lexicography in Tamil country by preparing Sadurakardhi. He has translated a part of Tirukkural into Latin.

## 15.5 Sanskrit

Many Sanskrit works were produced in the Tamil country during their period and they patronized the Sanskrit poets. Several kings of the Vijayanagar and Nayak dynasties were great authors. Raghunatha Nayaka of Thanjavur, himself a great poet, also patronised poets. Ramabhadramba lived in his court. In the court of Sevappa Nayak of Thanjavur flourished the illustrious author Govinda Dikshita. Srinivas Dikshita was patronised by Sevappa Nayak of Ginijee.

### 1. Madhuravijayam

Madhuravijam by Gangadevi, wife of kumarakampana, the second son of Bukka-1, was an important work of this period. Though this work written in the court of Vijanagar, it can be considered here since it speaks about the conquest of Madurai in the Tamil country. This work describes in excellent literary style.

### 2. Works of Vedanta Desika

The contributions of Vedanta Desika, to the Sanskrit literature in this period are noteworthy. He was a prolific writer both in Sanskrit and Tamil and has written about 90 works of which very

few are available works, the Yadavabyudaya was an important work. It is a long mahakavya describing the life of lord Krishna in 21 canots. The padukashasara is a poem of 1,000 verses on the paduka of Rama. In the Sankalpa-suryodhya he presents a drama in 10 acts. The work was written to explain the system of Visistadvaita. In it he personified evil and good dispositions of men. Taking the model from kalidasa's from kalidasa's Meghaduta, he wrote Hamsa-sandeha. He wrote a didactic work the subasita-nivi in 144 stanzas. He was the author of a commentary on Sirbhasya of Ramanuja. He has composed many stotras like Hayagrivastotra, Astabhya-stotra, Tudarasana stotra and a few prabhandas.

### 3. Works of Appaya Dikshita

Yet another contribution to the Sanskrit literature was made by Appaya dikshita who lived in the 16<sup>th</sup> century. He is credited with the authorship of 14 works. The kuvalayandha is a work on figures of speech and the Vrittivartika was a treatise on the significance of words in their poetic use. His works chitramimamsa and Lakshana-vali were on literature criticism and the appreciation of poetry. In his Anandhalahari he attempted to synthesise all the four philosophies (Advaita, Visishtadvaita, Sivadvaita and Dvaita) and bringing them on to a progressive line of thought culminating in Advaita. He wrote a commentary on culminating in Advaita. He wrote a commentary on Yadavabhyudaya of Vedanta Desika and another commentary on Srikantha's Shaiva-bhasya. In the commentary on Saiva-bhasya he has tried to establish Sivadvaita in preference to Advaita.

### 4. Others

Raghunatha Nayaka, the Nayak king of Thanjavur also contributed to the enrichment of the Sanskrit literature. His works on music entitled sangita-sudha and harata-sudha. These two works incorporate the newly discovered ragas and talas by him. His other contributions are Nalacartia Partijatapaharana, Valmiki-carita, Gajendramoksha. These works are based on Tradition and Religion. His Arjuntarayabhyudaya was a work on the life of his father Arjuna. On the life and achievements of Raghunatha, the work Raghunanda abhyudaya was written by Ramabhadra, who lived in his court.

Nilakanta Dikshita (great-nephew of Appaya Dikshita) wrote the Mahakavya: The Sivalilarnava in 22 canons and the Gangavvataranga. He also wrote Nilakantavijaya-campu,

Vairagyasataka, Anyapadosasataka, anandasagarastava and Sivo-ka-rasamanjari. The last two works were of brilliant devotionally lyrics addressed respectively to the beloved Mother and Father of the Universe. He wrote a drama Nalacarita-nataka and a commentary on kaiyata's Mahashashyarpradipa Ragavendra tirtha contributed about 42 works. Among then his commentaries on four Vedas may be considered significant. Parimala Nyayamuktavali-bahva-Sangraha and Tattva-Manjari are his other works. He wrote Sathiya-sudha and commented on Jaimini's Sutra and Kaumarila's Darsana.

Srinivasa Dikshita of Satyamangalam was patronised by the Gingee Nayak. He wrote 18 plays and about 60 poetical works, most of which are now lost. The poetical work Bhavanapurushotama composed at the instance of the Ginee king, was an allegorical poem. Bhaishmiparinaya-champu was a small work on the marriage of Krishna and Rukmani.

## 5. Telugu

The Nayaks of Madura and Thanjaur patronised telugu in the 16-17 centuries. The Prabhandha and Desi type of literature became popular. In Thanjaur court Yagshagana, Kuravanjis Kuravanji and Jakkinis were the literary styles adopted. These works contain dialogues and songs resembling dramas. The Yakshagana, is a king of literary piece, borrowed probably from the kannada and telugu country. Music formed an important piece in this. The Jakkini is also a king of drama Ragunatha Nayaka wrote a few telugu works. The Parijatapaharangam deals with the life of Krishna. The Valmiki caritam, Ramayana-Yakshangana, Rukmani-Parinaya-yakshagana, were the other works.

Cemakuri venkatakavi patronised by Viyarabhava Nayak wrote two works. The Sarangadhara-caritan and the vijayavilasa. Krishnadhvari's sleskavya called Naisadha-parijatiya as another important work. Vijayaraghava Nayaka wrote many dreams like the kaliyamardhana, putanaharna, prahaladanataka and the Rajagopalavilasa Rangarajamma (queen of vijayaraghava) was a great poet. She wrote a biographical work mannarudasivilsa inthe Yakshagana, style, Kadiriipati's Sukasupati was another good work composed in this age.



## 15.6 Summary

The early Vijayanagar rulers were saivites while the later rulers were Vaishnavites. Hence both Saivism and Vaishnavism flourished during this period.. On the other side, new religious started to have a foothold in parts of the country. Islam and Christianity became recognised and started spreading vigorously. Mosques and churches were built and large conversions to new religions were made. In the midst of these religions Buddhism and Jainism also thrived.. There was a tremendous growth in both Tamil and Sanskrit literature during this period.

## 15.7 Review Questions

1. Describe the growth of Saivism and Vaishnavism Under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
2. Examine the Condition of other religions under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
3. Analyse the growth of Tamil general works during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
4. Describe the development of Sanskrit literature during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

## 15.8 Answers to Review Questions

1. See the subsections 15.2 to 15.2.1 and 15.2.2
2. See the subsections 15.2.5 to 15.2.8
3. See the subsections 15.3 to 15.3.1 (1)
4. See the subsections 15.5 and 15.5. (1) to (4)

## **LESSON – 16**

# **ART AND ARCHITECTURE OF THE VIJAYANAGAR RULERS**

### **Learning Objectives**

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Discuss the features of 100 and 1000 pillared kalyanamandapas and sculptures of the temples under the vijayanagar rulers.
- ❖ Recall the features of the palace and temple of the city of Hampi and the residential places of the officials and rich people during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
- ❖ Analyse the decorative beauty of the sculptures with hybrid animals and birds placed in the temples and palaces under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

### **Structure**

#### **16.1 Introduction**

#### **16.2 Secular and Civil architecture**

##### **16.2.1 Hampi ruins**

##### **16.2.2 Audience hall**

##### **16.2.3 Throne platform**

##### **16.2.4 Town planning**

#### **16.3 Defence Architecture**

##### **16.3.1 Gopuras**

##### **16.3.2 Mandapas**

##### **16.3.3 Tanks and Gardens**

#### **16.4 Vijayanagar Temples in Tamil Nadu**

#### **16.5 Indo Islamic Architecture**

#### **16.6 Sculpture**

##### **16.6.1 Portrait sculpture**

##### **16.6.2 Decorative sculpture**

#### **16.7 Summary**

#### **16.8 Answers to Review Questions**

## 16.1 Introduction

Under the patronage of Vijayanagar rulers' temple architecture received a new impetus and reached to new heights According to Professor S.K.Saraswathy "The most frequent design is one which the shaft becomes either a central core or background for a group of statuary, of substantial proportion and carved practically on the ground". Important features of Vijayanagar style were Monolithic pillars, ornate brackets, decoration on exterior side of the walls, etc.

During the period of Vijayanagar Rulers, Temples became very elaborate both structure and organisation. Old temples were amplified, modified and altered. Pillared mandapas were added to the existing temples are the most important fact to be noted. The most important of all the mandapas, is the one called kalyanamandapa. It is generally located on the southern side of the entrance to the temple i.e. to south of the mahamandapa of front mandapa. This is very ornate pillared mandpa with a raised platform at its entire. It was meant to conduct the annual celebration of the marriage of the deity and hos consort. Second thing is that the Amman shrine was becomes a common feature the beginning of which has been noticed in the later Chola period. Third factor is the construction of 1,000 pillared mandapas of which give access to the temple proper.

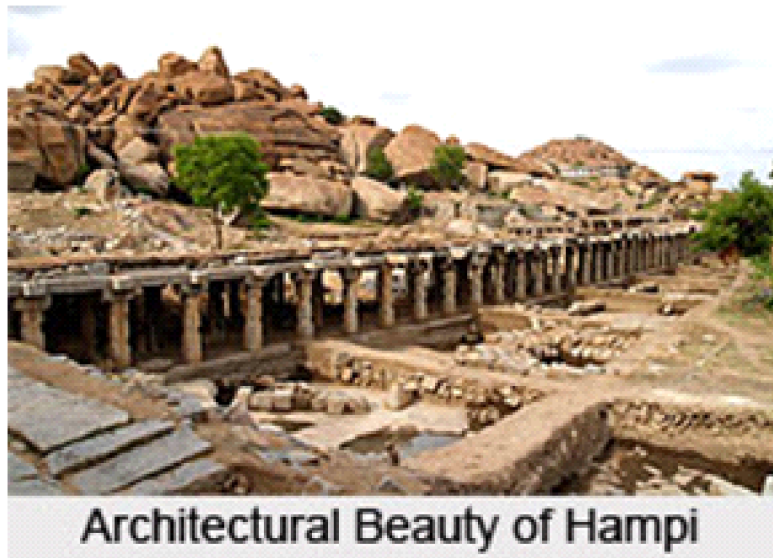


**A Temple built during  
Vijaynagar Dynasty**

## 16. 2 Secular and Civil architecture

The secular architecture may further be divided into civil and defence architecture. Under civil architecture may be included town planning, palaces, houses etc. The defence architecture includes structures like fortress etc. The vijayanagara rulers had to fight against the Muslims and the Bhamini Sultanas who has a powerful army and ammunition. Therefore their first and foremost duty was to protect their capital and other centres of political authority and cultural importance by way of construction strong and durable, palaces, moats around them, long and whole roads and highways etc. Further, the emperors were leading a luxurious life for which they had to raise palatial buildings with proper town planning. The accounts of the foreign travellers who visited the Vijayanagara country contain vivid descriptions about the town planning and buildings activities of the period. Further, there are a new structural remains still extent in places like Hampi which once served the great capital of the dynasty. Unfortunately most of the Vijayanagar is now in ruins, represented by the well known site Hampi which is dotted with little hills of granite.

### 16.2.1 Hampi Ruins



The palace was the most impressive building in Vijayanagar. There were halls of public and private audience. The halls were decorated with beautiful painted pictures. Usually the walls and pillars were ornamented with sculptures made of stone or wood. Among the civil buildings that still exist at Hampi/ two of the impressive basements stand out above many others. They are (1) the king's Audience Hall (2) the Throne platform.

### **16.2.2 Audience Hall**

The basement is nothing but a terraced platform. It seems to have been originally surmounted by pillared pavillions with pyramical roof, with several storeys. The audience Hall is a hall of hundred pillars, arranged in ten rows. The pillars have square bases cylindrical shafts and bracket capitals. The basement is divided into three spacious diminishing stages one above the other with flights of stumps and sides. It is decorated by broad hold mouldings and string sources. On the whole the Hall presents magnificent appearances and exhibits the architectural grandeur of the age.

### **16.2.3 Throne platform**

The base of this platform is also divided into three spacious diminishing stages. It is square in plan. The lowest storey has sides measuring 132 feet and the highest tier 78 feet. The top most tiers are lavishly embellished by means of beautiful mouldings. The lower two tiers left plain. However they bear a series of figures and animals in low relief. These carvings enhance the beauty of the monuments.

### **16.2.4 Town Planning**

Town planning of this period drew attention of the contemporary writers and travellers. Numerous cities with palatial buildings were created. Lengthy highways and cross roads were laid in order to facilitate smooth flow of inland trade activities. Coastal areas were linked with inland routes by a chain of roads and cross roads.

The palace was the seat of royal activities. It had numerous apartments like durbar hall, bed rooms, kitchen, store rooms, guest houses within a massive defence wall. It was surrounded by a deep moat. Beautiful gardens were also provided. The houses of the ministers, Army chiefs, and other high officials and wealthy people had many storeys and apartments with playgrounds and gardens for purposes of outdoor games and entertainment. The walls of the palaces and buildings were whitewashed and painted pictures were hung on the walls. Wooden figures of animals and birds were hung in the walls.

Bridges were constructed across the rivers and canals. The remnants of such bridges have been recently brought to surface.

Dams were built at important places to store water for purposes of irrigation.

## 16.3 Defence Architecture

Massive fortresses were built with stone, clay and bricks. They were built around the important cities and the residential quarters of the royal families. This fortress understood the onslaughts of the Muslim invaders. They gave protection not only to the rulers but also to the public at times of wars and natural calamities like inundation. There fortress tell us the fall of the wards between the Vijayanagars and the Bahminis.

### 16.3.1 Gopuras

The Vijayanagara rulers paid special attention to the construction of gopuras. The rectangular basement of the gopura was enlarged and divided into two zones- upper and lower. It was built of granite stones. These zones bear numerous niches with several of Siva and Vishnu besides flora and fauna of the times. The super structure of the gopura was generally built of bricks and was adorned with numerous stucco figures of both religious and secular scenes. Contemporary socio-economic life has been vividly portrayed in the various storeys of the tapering gopura. The scenes like bazaars, shopping, procession, marriages etc. deserve special mention.

On account of increase in the number of outer enclosures, the gopuras also grew in large numbers to adorn gateway. The ruined or incomplete super structure of the gopura of the earlier period was also build of bricks during their period. This is evident from the extent of gopuras in a few temples of the Chola and Pandya period in Tamil country.

The gopura constructions received greater attention during this period and it is one of the major contributions of the Vijayanagar dynasty to South Indian temple complex.

### 16.3.2 Mandapas

More pillared mandapas were built in front of the sanctum in the same axial line. Further, the front mandapa deserves special mention as it has a peculiar arrangement of pillars i.e., 12 pillars in 3 or 4 rows so as to have 9 equal squares. This type of mandapa is known as Navarang mandapa. The construction of this has become a permanent feature in the Vijayanagara temple complex. Wherever they made additions to the old temple, this mandapa was added. 100

pillared and 1,000 pillared mandapas were also built. They were built either in front of the Navranga Mandapa or in the southern or northern corner of the outer prakaras. Particularly, the 100 pillared mandapas were built in the south east corner of the outer prakara of the main temple. The mandapa has ornate pillars and a raised platform at the centre. It is known as Kalyanamandapa or Natyamandapa. The annual celebrations of the marriage of the main deity are being conducted in this mandapa.

The pillars are of different varieties. Most of them bear horses or mythical animals with riders or soldiers in fighting mood. These figures suggest that the age of the Vijayanagar is one of the chivalry. The riders and even the galloping animals are highly dressed. The roof of the architrave and other parts of the mandapa are stamped with minute and delicate carving. The best examples of Kalyanamandapa may be seen in the Vardaraja Perumal temple at Kanchipuram, Vellore Temple and the horse mandapa at Srirangam. This mandapa is another noteworthy contribution of the Vijayanagar Rulers.

### **16.3.3 Tanks and Gardens**

The outer prakaras were often provided with sacred tanks and gardens. The tanks were dug to bathe the deity on certain festive occasions and the abhiseka water from the sanctum will be let out into this tank to sanctify it.

The garden was cultivated to grow flora for the deity. Sometimes medicinal herbs were cultivated in such gardens. Besides, kitchen, store room, staircase to the upper storeys in the prakara wall was also built in the outer prakara complex. Thus the temple complex drew both horizontally and vertically not only to cater to the needs of the devotees but also to the public general. Therefore the temple became a centre of not only religious activities but also served as an institution of public welfare. This is the major contribution of the Vijayanagar rulers to South Indian culture and History.

## **16.4 Vijayanagar Temples in Tamil Nadu**

When Tamil country was brought under the Vijayanagar rule a few temple cities received special attention and patronage under the vijayanagara rulers. These centres are; Kanchipuram Vellore Chidambaram Kumbakonam .Srirangam Madurai and Viruchipuram.

## 1. Kanchipuram

The Ekamabara natha temple at kanchi possesses one of the largest towers in South India, measuring 188 feet and it has ten storeys. It was built by Krishnadevaraya. The Rajagopura of the temple contains a large number of sculptures with beautiful decorations. There are many mandapas in the temple.

## 2. Vellore

The Jalakandesvara temple within the fort of Vellore received additions and alterations during this period. The Kalyana mandapa of this temple is celebrated for its sculptural wealth and elegant carvings. The horsemen on the pillars present varieties of dress and jewellery. It is one of the best specimens of the Dravidian architecture.

## 3. Chidambaram

Krishnadevaraya built a good part of the modern tower (north Gopuram) of Chidambaram temple. The height of the tower is 140 feet. Stones were used in the temple up to first floor: but bricks were used in the later portions. The noteworthy feature of the temple is the “Thousand Pillared Halls”. Each pillar is remarkable for its monolithic construction and perfection.

There are also shrines for Sivakamasundari and Subrahmanya within the temple prakara. The square pillars in these shrines are remarkable for their carvings.

## 4. Kumbakonam

The late Chola temples at Kumbakonam received additions of pillared mandapas and gopuras during this period. The ceilings of the mandapas have been richly painted with designs depicting stories from Ramayana and Mahabharata besides geometrical and floral designs. The Sarangapani temple deserves mention as it has a fine gopura.

## 5. Srirangam

The ‘house court’ or Seshgiri mandapam at Srirangam temple belongs to this period. It contains a ‘colonade’ of furiously fighting steeds each rearing up to a height of nearly nine feet, the whole executed in a technique so emphatic as to be not like stone but hardened steel observes Percy Brown.

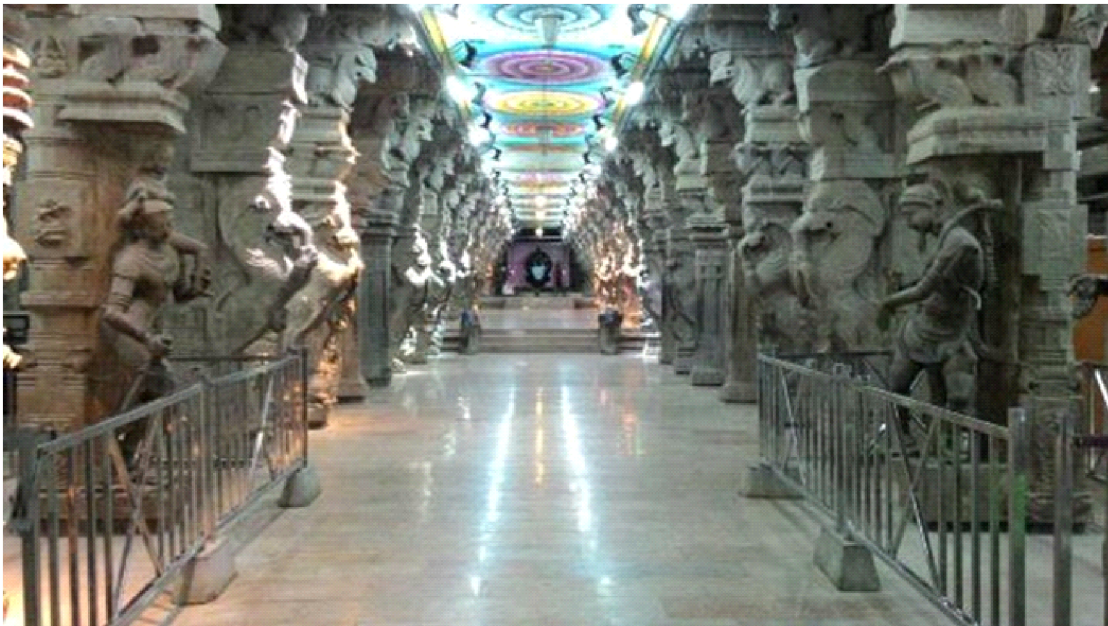


## 6. Virinchipuram (North Arcot)

The Margasakesvara temple at this place has a Navaranga mandapa of the Vijayanagaras. It exhibits beautiful carvings and paintings.

## 7. Madurai

### Thousand pillared hall at Madurai Meenakshi temple



The most wonderful contribution of the Vijayanagar kings is the Meenakshi temple at Madurai. It is considered as a monument of very fine workmanship. The Mandapas and the thousand pillared hall were constructed in a beautiful manner.

## 8. Jain Temples

Though the Vijayanagara rulers were mostly followers of Vaishnavism, they did not hate other religions. Hence we could see temples were built during this period at places like Geniyitti and Kanchipuram etc. The Geniyitti temple is a jaina temple wherein seen jaina sculptures. A Jaina Tirthankara is portrayed on the main door way.

The Varadhamana temple at Tiruppruttikkunram (Jina Kanchi) is another Jain temple of this period. It has a circular sanctum and sikhara representing Vesara style of architecture. A

pillared mandapa is built in front of the sanctum. It measures 62 feet by 26 feet. There are paintings on the ceilings and pillars. It is by dedicated to one of the Tirthankaras.

## 16.5 Indo Islamic Architecture

The impact of Islamic architecture style we can see in Vijayanagara architecture. Received too certain structural motifs like half dome shape, stalactite, honey combining portal etc., were borrowed and blended with Hindu architecture. As a result, the style has been termed as 'Indo aracenic' or Indo Islamic'.

The Lotus Mahal in the zenaha is an example. The Mahal has a pavilion with an upper storey. While the pillars and niches are in the Islamic style, the stucco work represents Hindu style. It is an interesting blending of the two different styles.

The Chandragiri palace is yet another example. The palace has three storeys and arcades and a pyramidal tower.

## 16.6 Sculpture

The Vijayanagara sculpture, as usual, includes portraits, decorative sculpture and icons. However, the portrait sculpture saw a tremendous progress during this period. There was a setback in the progress after the fall of the Cholas. But Vijayanagara rulers paid greater attention to this aspect of sculpture and revived the art to the extent possible.

### 16.6.1 Portrait sculpture

The portraits were made both in stone and metal. Most of them are life size and represent colossal figures of the kings, queens, ministers and Vijayanagara rulers, especially Krishnadeva Raya followed a policy of erecting new temples as and when he won battles. Similarly gopurams pillared mandapas were added to the already existing temples. the Vijayanagara rulers, especially Krishnadeva Raya followed a policy of erecting new temples. These were done to commemorate such historic events. With this, portrait figures of the king were also installed within the temple mandapas or niches on the tower etc. Sometimes the donor figures were installed in the front mandapas in temples or they were attached to the bases of the pillars in the mandapas. The custom became very popular during the late Vijayanagara and Nayaka period. This is one of the reasons why portrait sculpture grew in this period.

### 16.6.2 Decorative Sculpture

This period witnessed a tremendous progress in the field of religion, particularly Vaishnavism had received greater patronage and it served as a main theme for decorative and narrative sculptures. Vishnu and his avatars form the main subject. These figures are found scratched on the ceiling and on the pillars. Further the stories from Ramayana and Mahabharata also find place in many of the sculptured panels.

Secular scenes like wars, procession, games and amusements are portrayed. However, war scenes dominate the panels. These are generally scratched on the basement of the Kalyanamandapas. These sculptures throw a flood of light on the dress and decoration of the times besides the method of warfare, weapons of offence and defense. The men wear coats, bush shirts, trousers, boot etc. They also wear cap or turban. Therefore, they are considered to be an important source for writing the history of the Vijayanagars. Palaces, houses, street etc are vividly portrayed. Animals and birds of various kinds have been portrayed. Hybrid animals, birds and animal with human head, divine and mythical animals and birds are being represented as decorative motifs on the balustrade, steps etc.

Marriage scenes, shopping and bazaar activities etc. have been also included. These aspects are peculiar to Vijayanagar sculpture.

#### 1. Icons

The Siva and Vaishnava iconography made a steady progress and numerous icons of Siva and his various forms, Vishnu and his avatars. Lakshmi and Parvathi and of other minor deities were made in large number and installed in the niches on the walls, Vimana, gopuras, basements etc. the enlargement of temple complexes had provided space for installing these icons. They were made of stone, bronze and copper.

#### 2. Paintings

During this period, painting took a fine shape; considerable progress was made in this field. The art of paintings had made of steady progress. The palaces, houses and temple mandapas, walls, ceilings etc. were lavishly painted. The remnants of their paintings have

been noticed in a number of temples in South India. Besides, the accounts of foreign visitors like Paes bear testimony to the flourishing state of this art.

### 3. Tanjore Temple

In this temple, the Vijayanagara paintings are found super imposed over the early group of Chola paintings. The passage around the sanctum contains these paintings may be classified as follows;

1. Scenes from Tanjore Sthalapuranas.
2. Scenes from the life of Siva saints like Kannappar and Chandisvara.
3. Scenes from Hindu mythology such as churning of the ocean of milk, Siva drinking poison, Ravana lifting kailasa.
4. Representations of Siva, Vishnu, Brahma, Natraja, Dakshinamurthi, Lakshmi Devi, Sri Devi, Bhudevi, Ganapathi, Subramanya.
5. King, sages, saints, hunters, soldiers, attendants etc. These paintings depict the dress and jewels of 17<sup>th</sup> century A.D.

### 4. Kanchipuram

The Vardhamana temple at Jina-kanchi bears a groups Jaina paintings belonging to the time of Harihara 11(1378 -1404)

A careful study of these paintings reveals the following facts; the painters had an excellent knowledge of human anatomy, of figures to produce good compositions, good colour sense to paint pleasing and handsome pictures. The lines are drawn in bold strokes and the curves suggest facile way. The colours used are quite simple. They consisted of red, blue, and yellow, green, black and white.

## 16.7 Summary

The varied and complication treatment of the pillar is the most fascinating feature of the Vijayanagar temple complex or style. It serves as a criterion to identify Vijayanagara temples.

The shaft of the pillar stands alone or as a core while it is surrounded by a group of statuary in great size. They are sculptures in the round, having as its most conspicuous element—furiously rearing horse, rampant hippogryph or upraised animal of a supernatural kind. The pillar and the figures are carved out of a single block of stone. This is one type of pillar. There is another type wherein shown a cluster of miniature pillars encircling the central pillar. It should also be mentioned that the animal sculptures bear riders on their back. The brackets of the pillars are elaborately embellished which form part of the capital. It cannot be considered as a separate item as was seen in the earlier period. The pendant, which was carved below the capital, was further elaborated into an inverted lotus bud (pummunia).

Therefore the ornate pillars which are located in the huge mandapas just in front of the entrance to the temple add colour to the temple style or complex. These pillared mandapas are the outstanding contributions of the Vijayanagar to the temple architecture.

They have also continued the Pandiyan tradition of building tall gopuras. Another feature is, the ceilings of the mandapas, wall surfaces and pillars were painted in multicolour. These paintings are extant even today in most of the Vijayanagara temples or mandapas. Thus art, architecture and painting witnessed a considerable progress during the Vijayanagar period.

## 16.8 Review Questions

1. Write a short note on defence architecture under the Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
2. Describe the features of the temples of the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
3. Discuss the features of the paintings taken place during the period of Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.

## 16.9 Answers to Review Questions

1. See the section 16.3
2. See the Subsections 16.4 and 16.4(1) to (8)
3. See the Subsections 16.6.2(2) to (4).

## 16.10 Further References

1. George Michell & John M Fritz : Hampi Vijayanagara
2. Mahalingam T.V. : Economic Life of Vijayanagara Empire
3. Robert Sewell : A Forgotten Empire (Vijayanagara) Hampi
4. Sastri K.A.N. : A History of South India: From Prehistoric times to the Fall of Vijayanagar
5. Subramanian N : Social and Cultural History of Tamil Nadu
6. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hindu\\_temple#South\\_Indian\\_temples](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hindu_temple#South_Indian_temples)
7. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dravidian\\_architecture](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dravidian_architecture)
8. [www.wikipedia.com](http://www.wikipedia.com)

**M.A DEGREE EXAMINATION**  
**HISTORY**  
**MODEL QUESTION PAPER**  
**PAPER – II**  
**SOCIAL AND CULTURAL HISTORY OF**  
**TAMIL NADU UPTO A.D. 1565**

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Time: 3 Hours

Maximum: 80 marks

**SECTION A**

**(10 X 2 = 20 Marks )**

**Answer any TEN questions.**

**Each answer should not exceed 30 words**

1. Thirukkural
2. Arikamedu
3. Avanthi Sundari kathasara
4. Marudham
5. Kalabhras
6. Ghatikas
7. Karaikkal Ammaiyar
8. Devadasis
9. Marco Polo's Accounts
10. Ibn Battuta Chronicles
11. Ramadunga
12. Hampi Ruins

**SECTION B****(5X 6 - 30 Marks)****Answer any FIVE questions.****Each answer should not exceed 200 words**

13. Explain about the Geographical features of Tamil Nadu
14. Write about the caste system of the Sangam Age.
15. Describe about the Industries in the Pallava period.
16. Analyse the development of Literature during the Chola period
17. Assess the role played by Temples in developing the education under the Second Pandyas.
18. Bring out the impact of Malikkafur's invasion on Tamil Nadu
19. Write about the Indo-Islamic architecture under the Vijayanagar and the Nayaks period.

**SECTION C****(3X 10- 30 Marks)****Answer any THREE questions.****Each answer should not exceed 500 words**

20. Explain the status of the women in the Sangam Age
  21. Describe about the four fold divisions in the society under the Pallavas
  22. Bring out the contribution of the Imperial Cholas to art and architecture
  23. Elucidate the social structure during the Pandya Period
  24. Describe the socio-economic conditions of Tamil Nadu under Vijayanagar and Nayak rulers.
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